



鈴森鉄工

りん
誕生日おめでとう!

王の言葉

KING'S WORD

The King's Word

王の言霊

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Book One

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Chapter 1 – The Plan

It started on a Tuesday morning on the Rail Loop, four days before Ryn's birthday, when a train pass fell out of a salaryman's bag.

I caught it without meaning to – plastic, still warm from his pocket – held it out to him and said, "Sorry," which made no sense, because I hadn't done anything wrong. He blinked at me the way you blink at a vending machine that talks. Heat was already coming up off the platform tiles in visible ripples. My phone buzzed twice against my thigh – the war app the government would not let anyone uninstall, two ugly tones that meant somewhere east a place with a name was becoming a place with a casualty count. Haiga again, probably. I turned the screen face-down against my leg without reading it.

"You apologized to him," said a voice behind me. "For catching the thing he dropped."

"I apologized to the situation."

"You apologized to a rectangle." Kurosawa Kaito dropped onto the bench beside me before I had even turned around – taller than me, wider at the shoulders, built like someone who ran into trouble and won more often than he should. Scraped knuckles, a thin white nick through his left eyebrow that only showed when he grinned, which was always, and yesterday's dark jacket over today's uniform. He was already too loud for the hour. "One day you're going to apologize to a guy mid-swing and he'll be so confused he just leaves."

"That's the plan."

"It's a personality disorder, Haru."

"It's manners."

"Same disease." He knocked his knee into mine. "Train's here. Unless you want to apologize to that too."

The doors chimed and we got on ahead of the crowd. That was the thing about Kaito that nobody ever managed to explain: people made room for him without

deciding to. Two women across the car glanced up at his volume, bristled, and then softened in that odd way people did, like he'd already won an argument nobody had started. A third-year two seats down moved his bag off the seat without being asked. Kaito didn't notice any of it.

Through the window the city unrolled the way it did every morning. The river. The elevated highway. The Daigo Building's giant screen, which was supposed to show weather and increasingly showed the war instead: FRONT STABLE. EASTERN WARDS: CONTAINED. Under the reassurance, in smaller font, the names of the newly missing scrolled past, and everyone in the car looked at their knees until the screen was behind us.

Halfway around the Loop, two men started up near the middle doors – a shoulder bumped, a briefcase clipped, voices climbing over each other in that dry-season way where the argument isn't about the argument. People began studying their phones very hard.

"Sorry—" I was up before I'd decided to be, doing the thing my body does. "Sorry, he didn't see you, the car braked, it's – everyone's tired." Nothing clever. Nothing anyone would remember. Both men looked at me, and then the anger just – went out of them, all at once, like a radio changing stations. The taller one actually apologized to the other one. They found separate poles and studied separate windows.

I sat back down. Kaito was watching me with his head tipped.

"See, that," he said. "That's not manners. That's a superpower for boring people."

"Somebody has to do it."

"Nobody has to do it. They'd have shouted for two stops and gotten off angry, same as every day." He stretched, and his sleeve rode up, and I caught a bruise on his forearm – greenish, days old, the shape of a grip. "Anyway. Ryn's off today. Pickle stall with her grandmother."

"She hates the pickle stall."

"She loves the pickle stall. She just hates that she loves it." He grinned at the window. "You bringing your mom's thing Saturday?"

"Her thing is a homemade cake," I said, "and you will show it respect."

"I will show it reverence." He put a hand over his heart like he was

swearing into court. "Candles?"

"I have candles."

"Good. Because if you forget candles I'm stealing some from the shrine, and then you'll have to apologize to a god, and we'll be there all week."

We came up the school hill late enough that the track already smelled baked. The rooftop chain hung on its broken padlock the way it had all year – a formality everyone climbed past and nobody reported, because the roof was the only place in the building where the air moved.

First period, Doi-sensei shoved through the door – mid-forties, soft in the middle, thinning hair combed forward against the odds, tie already loosened – with a stack of handouts clutched to his chest and his wire glasses losing the war with his nose. "Sit down, sit down – I have exactly enough copies, which means if any of you multiplied over the weekend, we have a problem."

Kaito was still standing in the aisle, because the aisle had a problem in it. A third-year had followed him in from the hallway to finish an argument about Sunday's match – a big kid, half a head taller, the kind who wanted the room watching while he won. He'd planted himself between the desks with his arms crossed and no intention of leaving.

"You cost us the match," he said. "That tackle was a red and the ref swallowed his whistle. Everyone on the hill is saying it."

"Then everyone on the hill watched your striker trip over his own feet," Kaito said, grinning, far too loud for a room with a teacher in it. "I barely touched him. He went down like laundry."

"He's out two weeks."

"From falling? Tell him to practice landing."

Doi looked up from his handouts. "You. Third-year. This is not your classroom."

"One minute, sensei." The kid didn't even turn his head. That's who this was – someone who could ignore a teacher comfortably, in a room that wasn't his, with forty people watching. He came a step closer, into the space where these things stop being words. "Behind the gym after school. Or apologize now, where

they can all hear you.”

I was half out of my seat with a “sorry” already loaded – the useless kind, aimed at the situation, my whole trick. I never got it out.

“Hey,” Kaito said. Not loud anymore. Just final. “Back off. Go back to your class.”

And the third-year went.

Everyone else saw a stare-down end the way stare-downs end: the big kid weighed it, thought better of it and walked. What I saw was the order it happened in. He turned for the door before anything in his face gave up the fight – body first, decision after – and he was three steps gone while his expression was still catching up, confused, like his legs had made the call without him. Nobody hands out an ultimatum in front of forty people and then just leaves. He didn’t even take a parting line with him for the hallway.

Kaito sat down. Under the noise of the class exhaling, he pressed two fingers under his nose and checked them. A pinprick of red. He wiped it on the dark jacket, where it wouldn’t show, and I looked away before he could catch me looking.

Dry air, I told myself. Summer AC. Nosebleeds happen.

“Kurosawa,” Doi said. “Sit down.”

“I am down.”

“Be more down.”

The class laughed, the day started, and everything was ordinary again.

After last bell we pushed into Fullmoon Mart for the air conditioning, which was a lie the fried-chicken heat lamp told, and for Ryn, Amano Ryn, who was behind the register with her sleeves shoved up and price-tag ink on her fingers. Dark brown hair clipped back for the shift with one cowlick the clip never held, and sharp amber-brown eyes that had clocked us before the door finished opening.

“Don’t,” Ryn said, before the door chime finished.

“We haven’t said anything,” Kaito said.

"You're both wearing the face." She rang up a canned coffee for a customer without looking at either of them. "The 'we're planning something' face. Kaito wears it because he's Kaito. You wear it because you'll agree to whatever he wants and then feel responsible when it goes wrong. It's my birthday Saturday. That's what the face is about."

"It's your birthday," Kaito said, delighted, planting his elbows on the counter directly under the NO LEANING sign. "You can't plan your own surprise."

"I plan everything. This store would burn down without me. Elbows."

"I'm a guest."

"You're a problem with a jacket. Elbows."

He lifted them maybe a centimeter. She let it go, which was as close to affection as the two of them came in public, and turned to me. "Tell me it isn't karaoke. The 'K' died on the tower sign and the whole street smells like—"

The door chimed. A kid in a too-big hoodie went past the register toward the drinks wall with an egg sandwich already half up the front of his shirt, and Ryn's body changed before either of us had finished turning our heads. Retail instinct, or whatever the thing underneath retail instinct is.

"Hey."

He ran. She was over the counter before the word had finished – one hand flat on it, pivot clean, the gum display skittering – and out the door while the welcome chime was still being cheerful about it. By the time we caught up half a block later, the sandwich was crushed on the corner and the kid was gone. Ryn stood over it, bent double, furious and laughing at the same time.

"An egg sandwich," she wheezed. "A criminal record. For a crushed egg sandwich. Did you see his face? He didn't even want it, he just panicked—" The laugh stopped like a tap being shut. Something older moved behind her eyes. "He had the dust on his shoes. The gray stuff. Haiga dust – it doesn't wash out. Grandma says you can tell how long they've been walking by how far up the laces it's gone."

All three of our phones buzzed at once – the two tones, the ones we were all pretending not to count. Nobody reached for a pocket.

Kaito picked the sandwich up off the pavement, inspected the damage, and ate it in two bites.

"That was evidence, you animal—"

"Gone now. Very thorough cleanup."

She shoved him a full step, and he let her, and I looked at the pavement because looking at the two of them properly was too much for a Tuesday.

"Saturday," Ryn said, taking the sidewalk like she owned it, which on that street she basically did. "Since you're both incapable of surprising me, you might as well tell me the plan and let me fix it."

"Sakaba-dōri," Kaito said. "The arcade, then ramen—"

"We do that every week. It's my eighteenth, not a Tuesday."

"The dead 'K' is tradition—"

"The rooftop," I said.

They both looked at me. Ryn's eyebrows went up. Kaito's grin paused halfway, which for him was a full stop.

"The school roof," I said. "At midnight. The chain's been broken all year — nobody checks, nobody cares. You can see the whole city from up there. The Loop, the river, all of Sakaba-dōri at once. We bring the cake up and you turn eighteen where you can see every light in the city at the same time."

"That's trespassing," Ryn said.

"Mildly."

"No — listen." She stopped walking, under the pachinko neon, so we had to stop too. "If a patrol picks up two boys after curfew, it's a story you get to tell at lunch on Monday. If they pick up me, they walk me back to Grandma. She won't yell. She'll just rearrange the stall schedule until I never have a free evening again, and she'll do it without once mentioning why. That's the price, and you two aren't the ones who'd pay it."

Kaito opened his mouth. She pointed at him without looking at him, and he closed it.

"So don't sell me the view," she said to me. "Tell me why it's worth that."

I didn't have anything clever, so I gave her the true thing instead.

"Because you plan everything. The store, the stall, Saturday, us. Somebody should hand you one night you didn't have to build yourself. And if it goes wrong, I'll stand in front of Sugi and tell her the roof was my idea and you argued against it, which will even be true."

"You'd last four seconds in front of Grandma."

"Then I'll apologize for four seconds. It's my best event."

She was quiet for a moment, neon from the pachinko hall sliding across the silver stud in her ear, and I watched her decide. Then she smiled – not the counter smile, the rare one, the one she gave you when you'd accidentally gotten something exactly right.

"Yeah. Okay. Let's do the roof."

Beside me Kaito had gone still, which I felt before I saw. No joke loaded, no volume ready. Just looking at her like the smile had knocked the wind out of him and he'd rather die than admit it. Then he caught me noticing, laughed too loud at nothing, and hooked an arm around each of our necks so we had to walk the rest of the block bent over like conspirators.

"Midnight on the roof, then," he said. "All three of us and Haruki's homemade cake. I'm telling you right now – nothing is going to ruin it. Nothing."

Chapter 2 – Day Before

My mother came off a twelve-hour shift on Friday morning and baked a cake before she would let herself sleep.

I'd told her I could do it alone. I had the recipe card, I had the eggs, I'd watched her do it every year since I was six. She stood in the doorway of our kitchen in yesterday's scrubs, dark hair escaping its hurried clip, the same warm brown eyes she'd handed down to me sitting in a face worn thin by night shifts, and looked at me the way she looked at patients who said they could walk unassisted.

"You'll overbeat it," she said.

"I won't overbeat it."

"You overbeat everything. You think if you keep going it gets better. That's true of homework and untrue of eggs." She pushed off the doorframe and took the whisk out of my hand. "I'll beat. You measure. Talk to me so I don't fall asleep standing up."

So we made Ryn's cake the way we always made it, in the too-small kitchen with the window open to the sound of the Loop, and my mother stayed upright by asking questions with her eyes half closed. She asked about Kaito; I said loud. School was fine. Was the Amano girl really eighteen already – she remembered her at eight, biting a boy who stole my hat.

"She'd bite him again," I said.

"Good girl." Mom slid the pan into the oven and set the timer, and then she was asleep on the couch before the smell started, still in her scrubs, one shoe on, her hospital badge clipped crooked to the pocket – AOYAMA MIKA, NURSING – like the hospital had followed her home. I put a blanket over her and did the dishes quietly. On the fridge, under a magnet from a hospital pharmaceutical rep, was the note she'd left herself: Sat = R's bday. Buy nothing, H has it handled.

I stood there longer than I needed to, reading my own name in her handwriting.

Sugi's pickle stall sat in the alley mouth off Sakaba-dōri, between a shuttered camera shop and a pachinko hall, and it had been there so long the pachinko hall's neon had a pickle-shaped burn shadow on its lowest sign. Two crates, one plank, jars in rows, and a folding stool nobody had ever seen her sit on.

Friday after school, Ryn was behind the plank with her grandmother, weighing out plum for a line of old women who all knew each other's business. We got in line like customers because getting out of line was not permitted.

"You'll wait like everyone waits," Amano Sugi said, without looking up from her scale. Small, wiry, sun-dark hands stained to the wrist with vinegar, white hair pinned in a bun that permitted no argument, a faded indigo apron older than any of us. Ryn's eyes, fifty years on. "Royalty waits too. I've seen it."

"When have you seen royalty," Kaito said.

"I've seen boys who thought they were. Same manners. Worse shoes." She jerked her chin at his sneakers, which were held together on one side with a strip of black tape. The old women found this very funny. Kaito took it the way he took everything from Sugi, which was on the chin and grinning, because Sugi was the only person alive he never argued with. I had a theory about that. The theory was that nobody had ever fed him regularly without being required to, and he didn't know what to do with it except keep showing up.

So we waited, and the line talked, because that was what the line was for. Ahead of us a woman in a sun visor was buying plum for a daughter-in-law she clearly didn't like, and telling the woman behind her about a nephew out east who had stopped writing in May. "Not stopped," she corrected herself, counting coins out of a purse that snapped. "Slowed. The post is slow out there, with everything." The other woman said "with everything" back in the exact same voice, and they both looked at the jars, and neither of them said the word for what everything was.

Then the visor woman reached the plank and found somewhere better to put it. "You're lucky, Sugi-san. A granddaughter. They don't take the girls."

Sugi weighed out the plum and tipped in one extra with her thumb, the way she did for people she'd decided deserved it that day. "Nobody's lucky this year," she said. "Some people are just still here. Tell your sister to come before Thursday – the barrels turn over." The visor woman went pink like she'd been caught at something, paid, and didn't mention anyone's nephew again.

When the line thinned she filled two paper cones with broken pickle ends – the ones she couldn't sell – and put them in our hands like it was a transaction we'd paid for.

"Eat. You're both the wrong color." She looked at me a second longer than the sentence needed. "Your mother working nights again?"

"Mostly."

"Then you're the house now. Eat two."

Ryn came around the plank untying her apron. Off shift, hair down, the silver stud catching the alley light. "Grandma. I'm taking my break."

"You've been on break since two."

"I've been helping since two. There's a difference, legally." She stole a pickle end out of Kaito's cone as she passed, which he allowed with the long-suffering face of a man taxed by his government. "Ten minutes. I have to show Haruki a thing."

Sugi waved us off and turned to the next customer, already reaching for the plum jar before the woman had said a word.

The thing Ryn had to show me was a letter.

She walked us to the mouth of the alley first, out of her grandmother's sightline, which told me what it was before I saw the envelope. Her brother wrote on Federation Defense stationery because it was the only paper they gave him. Tōru's handwriting used to fill pages – dumb jokes, complaints about boots, a running story about a sergeant who collected beetles. The envelope she pulled out of her apron pocket was light enough to float.

"Three weeks since the last one," she said. "This came Tuesday. I didn't open it till yesterday."

One page. I read it standing between a pachinko hall and a camera shop while

Kaito read over my shoulder and, for once in his life, said nothing.

Ryn. All fine here. Eating enough. Tell Grandma the east isn't what the news says – tell her it's better, she'll believe that from me. Don't let the boys eat my share Saturday. – T.

Six lines. Tōru wrote six lines the way other people wrote nothing at all.

"It's better, she'll believe that from me," Ryn repeated. Her voice did a thing I'd never heard it do, a small flat skip, like a stone going over ice. "He picked those words so I'd know. It's not better. He knows I know. We're just – agreeing to say it to Grandma together." She took the letter back and squared its edges and put it away. "So. That's the thing. I just needed somebody else to have read it."

"Ryn—" Kaito started.

"Don't." Not sharp. Just done. "If you're kind to me right now I'll lose the whole afternoon. Tell me something stupid instead."

Kaito, to his infinite credit, did not miss the step. "Haru apologized to two grown men on the Loop on Tuesday and they stopped fighting so fast one of them apologized back."

"He does that." The corner of her mouth came up. "It's creepy."

"It's useful," I said.

"It's creepy and useful. Like Grandma." She breathed out, and the flat skip was gone. "Okay. Break's over. Both of you go home and sleep, because if either of you yawns on my birthday I'm pushing you off the roof."

She meant it as a joke.

Kaito didn't go home. He came to mine.

He did that some weeks – showed up at the door around nine with his uniform in a plastic bag and a story he'd tell the walls before he'd tell me. My mother had left for her shift. We ate rice with an egg on it and watched half a soccer match with the sound low, and at some point I looked over and he was asleep sitting up, jacket still on, one fist closed around nothing.

His forearm had slid out of the sleeve. The bruise I'd seen on the train had

gone yellow at the edges, and above it there was an older one, and I stopped looking because he had never once asked me to see them. His uncle's apartment was a fifteen-minute walk from ours. In two years I had never been inside it, and Kaito had slept on our floor maybe sixty nights, and both of us left that unsaid, because he had decided it wasn't a thing that was happening and I had decided that being where he could reach was more useful than being right.

He would have denied all of it if I'd asked. So I never asked.

I put the spare futon down next to the couch. He woke up enough to move to it, muttered something about candles, and was gone again. I lay in my own room with the window open, listening to the Loop run its last circuits, and went through the same names I went through every night that June – Mom at the hospital, Ryn above the stall, Kaito on my floor, everyone I had, all inside one train line, all fine. The war app buzzed once, far off in the kitchen where I'd left it on purpose. I didn't get up to read it. In the next room Kaito turned over, said a whole sentence with no words in it, and went still again, and I fell asleep naming Loop stops until the list ran out.

Saturday morning he was gone before I woke – the futon folded wrong, the way he always folded it, and a note in his terrible handwriting on the back of a receipt: getting the plan ready. meet at the dead K at six. don't be a butler.

The cake sat in its box on the counter with eighteen candles taped to the lid in a sandwich bag. Mom had drawn a cat on the box before she left for her Saturday shift. It looked deranged. It was perfect.

I texted Ryn: Tonight. Bring nothing. It's handled.

She sent back a photo of the fare gate at the bottom of her street, where somebody from the ward office was pasting a new poster over the old ones. CIVIL PREPAREDNESS IS EVERYONE'S DUTY. KNOW YOUR WESTBOUND ROUTES. She'd written one line under it:

handled, huh. don't drop my cake.

Out east, if you'd climbed our school roof that morning and known where to look, they say you could already see it – the orange sitting low on the horizon. I didn't climb. I had a cake to carry.

Chapter 3 – Let Her Go

I met Kaito under the dead 'K' at six with the cake box held level in both hands.

He looked me over and said, "I told you not to look like a butler," and I said, "You look like you slept in a batting cage," and we were both right. My fringe was in my eyes. His hair had dried into a shape with opinions. We were both still in uniform, because neither of us owned anything nicer that wasn't wrinkled, and we had privately agreed without ever saying it that Ryn should not spend her birthday flanked by two boys in wrinkles.

"Where is she?"

"Closing the register early. She said if we're late she starts without us."

"She wouldn't."

"She would. That's why we're early."

We went to eat ramen first, at the good place – six seats and a cook who hadn't spoken since the Occupation as far as anyone knew, broth hot enough to enforce silence. We claimed the end stools and watched the curtain for her like idiots who'd never eaten with her before.

She came in with her hair down and no apron, still smelling faintly of the Mart's fried-chicken lamp, and dropped onto the middle stool like it had been reserved for her since birth.

"You're early," she said. "I hate that. It means I can't complain."

"We can leave and come back late," Kaito offered.

"Don't you dare." She pointed her chopsticks at the cake box on my lap before we'd even ordered. "Is that the one with the deranged cat?"

"Mom drew it."

"Then it's perfect. Don't open it yet. I want to be surprised by the frosting like a normal person."

The cook waited with his ladle and his silence. Ryn ordered the spicy one without looking at the board. Kaito ordered the same thing louder. I ordered miso, and both of them looked at me like I'd brought a note from home.

"On her birthday," Kaito said.

"I like miso."

"He likes miso," Ryn told the cook, solemn, as if translating. "He's our responsibility."

When the bowls landed she stole half of Kaito's chashu before he'd finished guarding it.

"It's my birthday," she said. "Theft is legal until midnight."

"That is not how law works," I said.

"It is tonight."

She laughed – the real one, the one that made the cook glance over once and then go back to pretending we didn't exist – and passed me the garlic before I asked. We ate the way we always ate there: too loud for the room, too slow for Kaito's patience, Ryn narrating every customer who came in like she was writing a report for Sugi. The salaryman who ordered miso and looked personally betrayed by it. The couple who shared one bowl and somehow still fought over the last egg.

Kaito tried to teach me how to drink the broth without making a sound and failed so completely that Ryn wiped my chin with a napkin and called me a liability to the brand.

"What brand," I said.

"Ours. The three of us. We have standards. Low ones, but standards." She bumped her shoulder into mine. "Thank you for the cake. Thank you for not making it karaoke. Thank you for—" She stopped, looked at both of us, and something soft moved through her face too fast to name. "Just thank you. Don't make it weird."

"I'm going to make it weird," Kaito said immediately.

"I will push you into the broth."

"Worth it."

"You're not eighteen till midnight," he added, fishing the last piece of pork out from under her chopsticks. "Until then you're a regular criminal."

"Then at midnight it becomes retroactively legal." She stood, slapped money on the counter before either of us could, and was already at the door. "Eat faster next year. I want to win things."

The arcade was loud and half empty, which was the best version of it. Neon on wet tile. A claw machine singing the same four notes it had sung since we were twelve. Ryn made for the light-gun cabinet like she was collecting a debt.

"Birthday rules," she said, loading tokens. "I go first. You both die. I narrate."

Kaito lasted eleven seconds. I lasted eight. She lasted the whole stage, calling our deaths into the plastic mic like a sports broadcast that hated us personally.

"And Kurosawa goes down in the doorway – tragic, avoidable, he opened his mouth instead of aiming – Aoyama behind the crate, apologizing to the crate – and Amano clears the floor alone, as prophesied–"

"The crate moved," I said.

"The crate was plastic. You're worse than Kaito."

"Hey," Kaito said.

"You're right. He's worse than the crate."

A college kid with a jacket too clean for the room drifted over while her name was still blinking in the high-score slot. "One more," he said. "Loser buys."

Ryn looked him up and down once. "You're on."

He was better than us. He was not better than her. When his last life went in a spray of pixels she didn't cheer – she just nodded and walked him to the drink machine.

"What do you want?"

"I was supposed to buy," he said, still catching up to having lost.

"You were. I'm in a good mood. Pick something with sugar before I change my

mind.”

He picked a canned coffee. She paid, put it in his hand, and came back to us wiping her palms on her jeans.

“Don’t look at me like that,” she said.

“Like what,” I said.

“Like I did a kindness. I robbed him first. Order of operations.”

Kaito was already at the claw machine, burning yen on a hideous cat plush with one milky eye. Nine hundred later the cat was still behind glass and his ears were red. I put in one more try because somebody had to end it, won on the second grab entirely by accident, and had to pretend I’d only been warming the machine up for him.

“You let me lose,” he said, betrayed.

“I let you warm it up.”

“Let me try again—”

“Absolutely not,” Ryn said, lifting the cat out of the chute. “I’m keeping the evidence.”

“It’s my yen—”

“It’s my birthday. The cat is mine. The humiliation is yours. Everybody wins.” She tucked the plush under her arm like a sack of rice and was already walking. “Come on. We have a roof to get to, and Haru’s holding that cake like it might testify against him.”

“Let her have it,” I told him.

“I am letting her have it. Under protest.”

“Let it go,” she called back, without turning. “Both of you. Before I win something else.”

The war app buzzed twice on the walk to the Loop. Both times I turned my phone face-down without reading it, because I had decided that tonight nothing was allowed to be wrong. On the Daigo screen the big font said EASTERN LINE HOLDING and the small font underneath scrolled the names of the missing, and for once I let them go past unread.

The evening car up the school hill was nearly empty. That's why I noticed the man.

He stood by the far doors, and he did not belong to the evening. Everyone else in the car was going somewhere – home, a shift, a dinner – and wore it on their bodies. He was not going anywhere. He was at somewhere, and the somewhere was us. Mid-thirties, maybe forties. Short hair with nothing to say. A plain dark coat too warm for June. A face that my memory kept refusing to hold even while I was looking directly at it.

Kaito laughed too loud at something Ryn said – the whole car did its usual thing, the small soft leaning-in that rooms did around him – and the man did not soften. He watched Kaito laugh without smiling once. Then his eyes moved to me, and I felt it, physically, the way you feel a draft. He took out a phone, held it up, and for one second turned the screen toward us across the car. Not filming. Showing. Text on it, too far away to read.

The doors opened at the hill station. Ryn pulled us out by two sleeves at once, into the warm dark, laughing about something I didn't catch, and by the top of the school stairs I had forgotten the man completely.

The chain on the rooftop door hung off its broken padlock, same as all year. We climbed through into open air.

From up there the city was worth every rule we were breaking. The Rail Loop drew its ring of light around us. Sakaba-dōri was a smear of pink and gold with one dead letter in it. Planes of rooftops stepped down toward the river, and past all of it, east, where the bright ended, a low uneven orange sat against the horizon line. We all knew what it was. Nobody named it. It had sat there for weeks, and we had all stopped seeing it.

I set the cake on an upturned crate. Kaito produced a lighter from somewhere, because Kaito could always produce a lighter from somewhere, and cupped the flame against the warm wind while I planted eighteen candles.

Ryn stood over her cake with the plush cat under her arm and the candlelight moving on her face, and she looked – I didn't have the word then. Unguarded. Like someone had told her she was allowed to have all of it, and she was still deciding whether to believe them.

"Make a wish," Kaito said.

"I know how birthdays work, idiot."

"Then make one before Haru's fringe catches fire."

"Don't say it out loud," I said, "or it won't—"

"I wish," Ryn said, eyes shut, the flames leaning, "that it stays exactly like this. The three of us. I wish nothing ever—"

She never finished the sentence.

The sky over the eastern wards turned white.

Not orange. White — hard, total, a photographer's flash the size of a horizon. It printed the whole rooftop in black and silver: Ryn's shut eyes, Kaito's open mouth, eighteen little flames gone suddenly pointless. No sound. Light first, and the space where sound should be, long enough for your body to lean into the wrongness of it. Then the air arrived — not a noise so much as a shove, through the chest, through the water tanks, through every window below us, and the city went off all at once like a struck hive. Car alarms. The Loop's horns. Dogs.

Then our phones. All three at once, and not the two tones. A third tone under them, low, felt in the back teeth, a sound I had never heard the app make. Every screen on every pole and every building went the same flat red, and on the red, in the calm government font that had lied to us every single morning:

LINE BROKEN. RUN WEST.

East, where the white was fading, something was rising into the space it left. Not smoke. Smoke moves like it's escaping. This moved like it was arriving — vast, wrong, unhurried, the shape the news called Anomalous Materiel and the refugees with gray shoes called things they wouldn't say twice. I looked at it and my legs understood before I did.

"Okay," Ryn said.

That's what she said. Okay. Calm the way she went calm when a shoplifter bolted — fear routed straight into motion, no stop in between. She blew the candles out in one breath and started assigning the world jobs. "Down the stairs. West exit. Grandma's stall — Grandma first, then the station. My

brother said west is—" Her voice caught on brother, one syllable of ice, then came back. "West. Now. Both of you with me."

We turned for the door. Her hand had already found my sleeve.

The rooftop door banged open, and the doorway was full of soldiers.

They came through in a fanned spread that took the roof apart into zones before we'd finished a step – gray-green, rifles up, gunlights cutting white circles across the cake, the crate, our faces. Federation Defense Command. Six of them. Eight. Boots on concrete that had been ours five seconds ago. The air smelled like oil and dust and the sweet leftover of birthday candles.

Behind them came a man who did not hurry.

He stopped three paces onto the roof, in the middle of the ending of the world, and checked his watch. Tall, lean, early thirties. Black hair parted with a ruler. Uniform without one wrong crease on the night the east died. He lowered his wrist, looked at Kaito, then at me, and his eyes didn't blink enough.

"There you are," he said, mild as someone finding coats in a closet. "We have been looking for you two for a very long time."

The sentence hit wrong. Looking for us. On a birthday roof. While the eastern wards were still turning themselves inside out. My mouth opened on something useless – you've got the wrong people, we're nobody, the screens say run – and nothing came out that could stand up to rifles.

"On the ground!" another one shouted. "Hands where I can see them!"

"We're just kids," Kaito said.

He'd stepped in front of us without my seeing him move – between Ryn and the guns, hands open, chin up, loud the way he got loud when a room needed rearranging. His voice shook once and then didn't. "We're leaving. Look at the sky. East is burning. We're going west with everybody else—"

"Last time," the officer said, still mild. Still not raising his voice over the alarms. "On the ground. All three of you."

Ryn's fingers locked in my sleeve so hard I felt the cloth strain. She didn't look at the guns. She looked at the west service door, fifteen meters

of open roof away, and then she looked at Kaito and me the way she looked when a shoplifter bolted – decision already made.

She went.

We went with her.

Two steps. Three. Someone shouted stop. A hand caught my jacket and I tore out of the sleeve so hard I heard stitching go. Kaito hit someone – I heard the grunt of an elbow landing in ribs – and for one stupid second I thought we were going to make it, birthday kids running for a door we'd climbed through a hundred times, cake abandoned on a crate behind us like evidence.

We had crossed maybe five meters when they stopped asking.

A soldier peeled off the line, cut behind the crate with the dead candles, and took Ryn by the wrist. Clean. Practiced. She yelled – not a scream, an angry sound, furious that anyone would put a hand on her on her own night – and kicked him hard enough that I heard the boot land. He didn't argue. He walked her backward like luggage, boots set, and held her out over the open air.

One fist in her collar. One hand locked on her wrist. His body on the roof. Hers not.

Her sneakers pedaled once and found nothing. Wind pulled her hair across her face. Below her was every light in the city – the Loop, the river, Sakaba-dōri with its dead letter – exactly the view I'd promised her when I said midnight on the roof. My stomach dropped so hard I thought I'd be sick on the concrete.

"Enough," the soldier called across the roof. Not even loud. Bored, almost. "You two. Stop. Hands up and come quiet – or I drop her."

The world narrowed to that.

Alarms still going. Sky still wrong. Phones still screaming red in our pockets. None of it reached me. There was only her collar in his fist and the black air under her shoes and six meters of roof I was never going to cross in time.

"Ryn–!"

I didn't know if I said her name or only thought it. I turned back toward her anyway. One step. That was all I got. Arms locked around my chest from

behind, a knee took the back of my leg, and the roof came up and hit me in the face. Blood flooded my mouth. Grit in my eye. Someone's weight on my spine, grinding my cheek into concrete that still smelled faintly of cake.

From down there I could see her – out over the lights, sneakers hanging, the milky-eyed cat plush still crushed under her free arm like she refused to drop it. She had gone perfectly still. Not calm. Calculating. The stillness of someone who had understood exactly what struggling would cost.

"Haru," she said, from over the edge of the world. Quiet. Reasonable. The voice she used on panicking shoplifters. Her eyes found mine and held them. "Don't. Don't make him–"

Kaito had made it further. Always further. Two soldiers on his arms, a third across his shoulders, dragging him back with his knees scraping concrete, and he was fighting all three like refusing hard enough might change it. Blood on his lip. Jacket half off. He looked at her, then at the drop, then at the soldier's hand, and I watched the knowing land in his face – he couldn't touch them, couldn't cross, couldn't do the one thing his whole life had been built to do, which was get between her and the hurt.

His mouth opened. His voice cracked in the middle, so loud it tore something in my chest just hearing it:

"LET HER GO!"

I'd heard those three words in kitchens and arcades my whole life. Let it go, Haru. Let her win. Let me try again. The smallest words in the language.

The soldier's hand opened.

It wasn't a throw, and it wasn't a decision. His fingers uncurled all at once, evenly, mechanically, the way a hand opens when the nerve is cut – and his face hadn't changed yet, he was still wearing the threat, because no part of him had chosen it. The command went in his ears and came out his fingers and skipped every part of the man in between.

He let her go.

The cat hit the concrete beside the crate and stayed. Her free hand caught the lip. Fingernails on concrete – a sound like chalk snapping. Her eyes were still on mine, and her mouth moved, and I have spent every night since deciding what the shape of it was. The kindest reading is okay. I don't always

have the strength for the kindest reading.

Then the lip of the roof held nothing, and the space where she'd been was just city lights.

What came next didn't stay in order.

I was screaming – I only knew it was me by the tearing in my throat. Two soldiers dragged me back from the lip and I fought them with everything I didn't have and it accomplished nothing at all.

Kaito had gone silent. Both arms held, on his knees, mouth open, no sound coming out. The soldiers around him had gone strange – the one who'd held her was kneeling on the roof staring into his own open hand, turning it over, like it belonged to someone else and had been mailed to him by mistake.

And I know the officer walked to the lip, looked down at the street for exactly as long as a man checks a delivery, and then turned – not to me, not to his soldier – to Kaito.

"Confirmed," he said, to the radio on his collar. "It's the Word. Both flagged, the loud one is active." A pause while the radio talked. He glanced at the kneeling soldier the way you glance at a spent tool. "One casualty. Civilian. Yes – it was instructive." He stood there, in the middle of all of it, and checked his watch again. "Bring both. Alive is the entire point. And if the loud one opens his mouth – hands over your ears, and you do not listen to one word he says. That order stands until I revoke it."

Seventeen years old, face-down on a rooftop, Ryn gone, the east ending, and a man in a pressed uniform talking about my best friend's mouth like it was the reason they'd climbed the stairs. I understood nothing.

Then the east stairwell exploded.

Pressure first – my ears went to ringing, and the municipal screen across the street became light and then wasn't there. Half the roof stumbled. The concrete under us jumped like a struck drum, dust boiled out of the stairwell door, and every gunlight swung at once toward the noise, and the arms holding me loosened by exactly one boy's worth.

Kaito moved first. He tore an arm free, put his forehead into the nearest soldier's nose – I heard it break – and then his hand was in my collar, hauling me up off the concrete, and we were running for the west service door through smoke that tasted like scorched wiring.

Boots behind us. A shout. A shot that hit plaster instead of us. The stairwell was dark and full of grit and I knew it blind – twenty years of my mother's hospital shifts had taught me every cut-through on this hill, and the school's service stairs came out by the gym, and the gym backed onto the supply alley, and the supply alley ran west. We fell down three flights more than we ran down them, crossed the gym floor in the dark, and went out the loading door into a city that was one long westbound scream.

Two blocks on, a vending bank had collapsed into the mouth of a underpass, leaving a gap just wide enough for two boys who no longer counted as people with somewhere to be. We wedged into it and stopped being visible, and for a while the world was boots and sirens and the app's third tone going off in dead men's pockets somewhere.

In the dark beside me, close enough that I could feel him shaking, Kaito's breathing had a wet catch in it. Nosebleed. In that light the blood on his wrist looked black.

"Haru." His voice was wrong – cracked through the middle, half of it missing, like something had been spent out of it. "Haru. I told him to let her go. He was going to drop her. He said – I just wanted him to stop. I said let her go and he – his hand just–" He stopped. The next thing came out smaller than any sound I'd ever heard him make. "Why did his hand open?"

The right thing to say was there. It wasn't your fault. Six syllables. I had them. I opened my mouth and they were right there – and I had seen the hand open. I had seen how it opened. All at once. Evenly. Nobody home. And I could not make the six syllables come out with the weight he needed them to have, because some careful, cowardly part of me had already decided what the open hand meant, and wouldn't lie about it.

So I held onto his jacket in the dark and said nothing, and he felt the nothing arrive. Half an inch of space appeared between us that had never been there in two years, and I couldn't see his face when it happened.

"Okay," he said finally. Flat. Emptied of every decibel I'd ever known him

by. He wiped his nose on the back of his hand and looked at the smear like a stranger's signature. "Okay. We have to go west."

Chapter 4 – Low Tide

We went west because she said west, and because every road still open pointed that way.

Kōgetsu emptied behind us quietly, which was somehow the worst part. No panic in the streets we walked – just lines. Lines at the station gates, lines at the bus stops, lines of tail lights on the elevated highway pointing west like iron filings. People stood in them holding suitcases that wouldn't close and pets that wouldn't stop shaking, and everybody kept their voice down, as if the thing rising over the eastern wards could be kept from noticing us if the whole city agreed to whisper.

The trains were finished by midnight – not stopped, taken, requisitioned for the wards closer to the line – so we walked. Out through the west gates of the city with the crowd, then along the coast road when the crowd thinned into the ones who had nowhere particular to be walking to. Ash came down for a while around two in the morning, fine and gray, like the beginning of snow that had changed its mind. It got into our socks. It got into everything.

The arcade cat was jammed under my arm. I never decided to carry it. It had been under Ryn's arm on the roof, and then it was beside the crate, and then it was mine, and at some point in the night I understood that I would fight anyone who tried to take it, which frightened me more than the sky had.

Kaito walked half a step ahead the whole way and barely spoke. When he did, his voice came out scraped, like the shout on the roof had taken the finish off it. Around four we stopped at a vending machine that still had power – one machine, humming alone on the edge of a dark town, stupidly cheerful. He bent to drink from the bottle I bought, and his hair fell away from the side of his face, and I saw it.

Behind his left ear. A pale mark, the size and shape of a pressed thumbnail, with a shallow notch in one edge. I had the same mark behind mine. Exactly the same, notch and all. My mother called it a stork bite when I was small, and I

had stopped thinking about it around the same age I stopped thinking about my own elbows.

The same mark. The same ear. On two boys born in different cities to different families.

I reached up and touched mine, the way you check your pocket after seeing someone robbed. Then I put my hand down, and I didn't say anything. It wasn't tact. It was that a soldier had already looked at us that night and said both of them, and I wasn't ready to follow that thought to where it went.

We walked on. Dawn came up gray at our backs. A two-car branch train was running from the junction town – some railway man had decided on his own authority that it would run, and stood on the platform waving people aboard like it was any Sunday – and it carried us over the coastal hills with a load of quiet strangers, down to where the land folded into a cove and the sea finally stopped looking like something on fire.

Nagihama was boats under blue tarps and one main street, with a plum tree hanging over a tile-roofed row at the end of the harbor lane.

Ryn had talked about this town every summer of her life. It was exactly the size of her stories, and she was not in it, and I hated it on sight for that.

Sugi opened her door before we knocked.

She had gotten out on the last Saturday train with the other stall-keepers – I learned that later. What I knew in that moment was only what her face did. She looked at the two of us on her step, gray to the knees with ash. Then at the cat under my arm, birthday sticker still on it. Then behind us, down the lane, at the space where a third person was not standing.

I watched her understand.

"Inside," she said. "Both of you. Shoes off."

Sugi's kitchen smells like pickled plum and charcoal. The arcade cat sits on the shelf by the window where she set it, birthday sticker still stuck to the plastic, one milky eye watching the lane. Kaito is in the back room, on a futon that still smells like sun, asleep or pretending so well it counts. His breathing is too even.

Over tea, I tell her all of it, straight through – the train pass, the roof, the road, her door. She doesn't ask a single question while I talk; she has been feeding people through bad news longer than I have been alive, and she knows the rest comes out on its own if you leave a person alone with a hot cup. When I finish, she glances toward the doorway once, and whatever she thinks stays behind her teeth.

"You told it straight," she says. "Most people dress it up."

"I don't know how to dress that up."

"Good. Don't learn." She pushes the fresh cup at me. "Tomorrow we do what the widows do when the sea doesn't give a body back. It isn't much. It's what there is. Tonight you eat, and you sleep, and you don't apologize to my floor for existing."

"I wasn't going to—"

"You were. I can hear it loading." She stands, joints cracking, and points at the bowl she already set in front of me. "Eat. He eats too, when he wakes. Even if he argues. Especially if he argues."

The girl from down the lane shows up the next afternoon with a sack of rice under one arm and a stack of folded towels under the other.

She is seventeen, maybe – short for it, sturdy through the shoulders, built for market crates and long walks up the lane. Dark hair cut blunt at the jaw, a little uneven at one side like she'd done it herself over a sink. Warm brown skin from a life spent outdoors and clear dark eyes that take in the entryway, the shoes and me.

"Saeki Mira," she says, and bows with the rice still under her arm, careful not to tip it. "My aunt's house is the one with the blue gate. Sugi-san helped her through last winter, so – this is late, but. Towels. Rice. People always remember the hard things and forget the boring ones."

Sugi is already taking the sack out of her hands. "Come in before you fall over the threshold being useful."

Mira steps in, leaves her sandals neat, and sets the towels on the low table like she's done it in this house before. Kaito has come as far as the

back-room doorway and stopped – one hand on the frame, checking the room the way he checks every room now. She looks at him once. Not long. Not soft. Just a look that says I see you standing there, and then she is talking to Sugi about whether the co-op still has miso left for households that don't have ration cards yet, and which tide tomorrow is low enough to dig for clams if anyone has the legs for it.

Nobody asks us where we came from. She never once looks at the empty third place at the table.

When Sugi puts a cup in front of her, Mira drinks it standing, the way people do when they know better than to settle into someone else's grief. Before she goes she glances at our ruined shoes by the door.

"My aunt keeps spare boots in the shed," she says. "I'll bring a pair tomorrow. Two, if they fit." She tips her chin at Kaito without making him answer. "You look like you walk. Walking's easier when your feet aren't bleeding."

Then she is gone – rice on the counter, towels stacked, blue-gate girl already halfway down the lane whistling something with no tune.

When the door shuts, Sugi watches it for a moment.

"Good kid," she says. "The lane's full of them, if you look."

The send-off, when it comes, is three days later – low tide, out on the flats past the sea wall.

No body. There was never going to be a body; Kōgetsu is a sealed word on the radio now, a place with a number instead of a population. So the widows do what this coast has always done for the sea's unreturned. A square of white cloth. A flower. Something that can stand in for a person the water already took, carried to the tide line and given back, so the water can do the carrying from here.

Sugi sets the arcade cat on the cloth.

It should be ridiculous – a plastic game prize with one milky eye standing in for a girl who vaulted counters and stole chashu and said okay when the sky went white. It is ridiculous. My throat closes anyway. The birthday sticker is

still on its side. Nine hundred yen of Kaito's pride and my accidental win and her arm around it on a roof that doesn't exist anymore. Sugi doesn't explain. She has buried more people than we have met, and she doesn't waste words on the ones still standing.

The widows begin a song I don't know. Low. Almost not a song – more like breath passed from chest to chest along the line of them. The eastern horizon still carries its wrong glow, faint from here, there every time I check. Wind off the flats finds every gap in my borrowed jacket. Sugi's hand locks around my wrist, hard enough to hurt, and I understand she is holding me up. I cry without making any sound. Beside me Kaito does not cry. His face has gone blank in a way that frightens me more than tears would have.

One of the widows steps forward and says the old words over the cloth. She means them the way this coast has always meant them. She does not know what those three words did to us five nights ago. She cannot know. The phrase is older than our ruin:

"Now we let her go. Now we let her go home to the water."

Kaito flinches like he's been hit in the mouth. The flinch travels into me a half-second late, the way everything does – and for a moment I am back on concrete, blood in my teeth, her sneakers over black air, his voice cracking open the world. Then I am on the flats again, and a kind old woman is offering those same words as mercy, and there is nowhere to put either version of them.

The rite is simple. You wade out to the tide line. You set the cloth on the water. You open your hands.

We carry it out together, one corner each. The water finds us at the ankles, then the calves, cold through the boots Mira's aunt sent, colder than June has any right to be. My hands are shaking so hard the cloth trembles. His are worse. The square settles on the surface as if it always belonged there.

I look at him.

He looks at the cat. At the water. At nothing. His knuckles have gone white on his corner. For a long breath I think he won't do it – that we will stand here until the tide decides for us – and I almost want that, because opening my hands feels like agreeing she is gone, and I have not agreed, I have only survived.

"Together," I say. It comes out ruined. "Kaito. Together."

His eyes find mine. Something in them breaks, or finishes breaking. He nods once – not agreement, not peace, just the smallest possible yes a person can make and still mean it.

I open my hands.

He opens his.

The tide takes the cloth the way it takes everything on this coast – patient, without ceremony, without asking if we are ready. The flower turns. The cat rides a little farther, sticker catching the light once, and then the black water has them, and there is only the empty square of sea where a girl used to be a weight in my arms.

Neither of us moves. Cold climbs our legs. Behind us the widows' song thins and stops. Sugi does not call us in. She lets the quiet have us for as long as it needs.

When we finally turn, the sea wall above us holds a thin line of neighbors who came to pay respects from a distance. Mira is among them, arms folded against the wind, face bare of anything useful. She watches us walk out of the water with empty hands. She does not smile. She does not look away.

Inside, the shelf by the window is empty where the cat was. Kaito sits against the wall with his wet boots still on and his hands open on his knees, as if he hasn't figured out what to do with them now that they've done the one thing they didn't want to do. Last light goes gray-gold through the glass. Down the lane somebody laughs at something that has nothing to do with us – the sound carrying the way sound does in a town built low.

"Futon or my room," Sugi says. "Pick one and stop staring at my floor like it owes you an answer."

"Futon," Kaito says. Scraped. Barely a word, but a word.

"Futon," I say.

She nods once and goes to put rice on.

I'd promised myself I'd say it when he could hear it. It wasn't your fault. On my first night under Sugi's roof I lie awake with the sentence ready,

listening to his breathing stay too even across the room, and I don't say it then either.

Chapter 5 – Two Weeks

Sugi wakes us by setting bowls down hard – rice and pickles, tea still too hot to drink. The kitchen smells like charcoal and plum, and outside the lane is already moving – boats, shutters, somebody arguing with a bicycle.

“Sit,” she says, tying her apron. “And listen, because I am only saying this once. You are not guests. Guests smile, eat, leave. Boys who sleep under my roof make themselves useful, or they start packing.”

Kaito is already standing. He has been, every morning since we got here – up before the kettle, boots on, one look through the doorway before he commits to the room. Mira’s aunt’s boots, still a half-size too big. He takes the bowl standing up anyway and starts eating before she finishes.

“I can haul,” he says, around the rice. “Co-op’s got ice coming in. I heard them yelling about it from the lane.”

“Of course you can haul. You have been looking for something heavy enough to hold still since you walked through my door.” She tips her chin at me. “You. Not the co-op. Orihara’s books have been lying to her for a week and she won’t admit it. Go down there, tell her Sugi sent you, and find the mistake before she takes it out on the widows.”

“What if she doesn’t want help?”

“Then you sit on her stool until she does. She hates an empty stool more than she hates being wrong.” Sugi pours the tea she already knows we won’t drink hot. “Eat. Both of you. I did not cook for the air.”

“Yes, Sugi-san,” I say.

Kaito just nods, finishes the bowl, and is gone before the tea has a chance.

The co-op yard smells like ice and diesel and wet wood. I cut through on the way to Orihara’s and find him with a crate on his shoulder, frost on his

cheek, already two hours into the morning. The other boys are talking over each other by the scale. He isn't. When he sees me he stops at the gate a second too long – eyes on the opening, then through it – before he comes out.

"You're early for the shop," he says. "She throw you out?"

"She sent me to catch Orihara's books cheating. You look frozen."

"Ice detail. Foreman asked if I had a problem with cold and I said no, which was a lie, but he stopped asking about papers after that, so." He shifts the crate against his shoulder and tips his head at the talking boys. "They keep trying to put me on the lunch pool. I told them I eat at Sugi's. Tell her that, or she'll pack me two lunches and pretend she didn't."

"She'll pack you two anyway."

"Then eat the second one on the way home and don't get caught." The almost-grin shows for a second – real this time, thin, but his – and then he glances past me toward the lane again, automatic. "Orihara's going to test you. She tested the last three boys and sent them home. Don't apologize when she does it. She hates that more than the wrong numbers."

"I wasn't going to apologize."

"You were. You always are." He bumps the crate against the gatepost, already turning back toward the ice house. "Two o'clock. If you're not at the table she starts inventing reasons. Go on. And Haru–"

"Yeah?"

"Don't let her put you on the high shelves. Last boy broke his wrist, and I am not carrying you home."

Orihara's dry-goods shop is dim between pickle jars and ball string, and the woman behind the counter looks like she has been arguing with the same pencil for forty years. Gray bob tucked behind both ears. Gold-rimmed glasses on a cord. Fingers stained with ink and dried plum. She does not look up when the bell goes.

"If you're here for rice, there isn't any until the afternoon boat," she says. "If you're here for charity, the shrine's that way, and if you're here to sell me something I already refused last week, the door works in both

directions.”

“Sugi sent me. She says your ration numbers are wrong.”

That gets her eyes. She looks me over the way she looks over a jar with a cracked lid – keep it, or throw it out.

“Sugi says a lot of things. Mostly about other people’s business.” She sets the pencil down. “You’re one of the Kōgetsu boys. The quiet one.”

“Aoyama Haruki.”

“Orihara Fumie. And I don’t need a boy. I need a week that adds up.” She pulls a stool out with her foot anyway and drops a newspaper on the counter – yesterday’s, the margins already dense with her handwriting. “Sit. Find where I went wrong. If you can’t, you can tell Sugi I said she is welcome to come do it herself, and I will enjoy watching her try.”

I sit. The column is a mess of refugee households, half-names, doubled entries, a five that wants to be an eight. I find the doubled line in a minute and the wrong carry in two. When I turn the paper toward her she follows my finger, grunts once, and does not say thank you.

“Lucky,” she says.

“I can do the rest of the week.”

“Can you.” Not a question. She slides the pencil across. “Then do it. After that the miso wants shelving where my knees won’t reach, and if you fall I am not writing to your mother.” She watches me start on the next page. Softer, almost as an afterthought: “Your people. Still east?”

“My mother’s a nurse. West of the line, last I knew. The hospitals moved first.”

“Good. Nurses know how to wait in lines.” A widow comes in for thread; Orihara is already reaching for the right spool without looking. “Boy. Tuesday’s five is wrong again. If you make me find it a second time, the stool goes back under the counter.”

By the end of the first week I am there most afternoons. She pays me in vegetables. The lane pays me by knowing my name. After that, other households start bringing their ration books too – not because I am special, because I will sit still and add things up when nobody else wants to.

Mira comes by most days, because Mira comes by everywhere most days.

Seventeen, aunt with the blue gate and a bad hip, an errand network that covers the whole lane. She's the one who knows which family has extra futons and which grandmother stopped cooking for herself. When the shrine gym flooded its corner last week she had four boys with buckets there before the priest finished noticing. Nobody organized her. She's just how errands get done on this lane. With us she doesn't do the refugee voice – she argues with Kaito about whether the co-op scale is honest, she borrows a kilo weight to prove him right, she brings her aunt's spare radio for Sugi and stays through the marine forecast like it's entertainment.

One afternoon she turns up while Sugi's washing is still dripping in the tubs and says, "Those will mildew if you leave them," as if the sheets had personally offended her. Ten minutes later we are in the yard with the line strung between the plum tree and the eaves, pegs in a tin bowl, wet cotton heavy in our hands. Kaito is down the lane carrying a new shelf for Orihara like it weighs nothing. From here he is just a dark shape and a piece of wood.

Mira has a peg in her mouth. She pins a corner, takes another peg, and talks around it like people who hang laundry for a living.

"Can I ask you something without you getting weird about it?"

"Probably not," I say.

"I'll ask anyway. Your friend. He carries half the lane's furniture and never says where he's from. You at least mention your mother. He doesn't even do that."

"He doesn't like talking about it."

"I noticed." She shakes out the next sheet; it snaps once in the wind off the cove. "Is he always like this, or is this the new version?"

"There's an old version. Louder. This is—" I look down the lane at him, shelf on his shoulder, already halfway to Orihara's. "This is after."

She waits. Not pushing. Just holding the sheet up so I have to take the other end. I take it.

"He was closer to what happened than I was," I say. "That's all I know how to tell you."

"All right." She pins her side. I pin mine. For a few pegs neither of us says anything, and I can feel the question she is not asking sitting between us like a wet sock. Then she says, lighter: "My cousin came back from Haiga the same way. Barely talked. Ate standing up. Drove my aunt mad. Got better when somebody put work in his hands and stopped asking him to explain himself." She nods toward Kaito's shrinking back. "So. Furniture. I'm not complaining."

"Neither is Orihara. That's her third shelf this month."

"Fourth. She told me she was done buying them, which means she'll buy another by Friday." Mira grins, quick, then softens. "I'm not digging, Haruki. I just don't like watching people go quiet alone. Bad habit of the coast."

"I know," I say. "Thanks for not pushing."

We finish the line. I like her. She shows up, she hangs sheets, she leaves people their silence when they ask for it. That afternoon, that is enough.

The truck comes on a Thursday.

One truck, gray-green, Federation Defense Command stenciled on the door, and it parks in front of the harbor office at ten in the morning like it has always parked there. Two soldiers and a lieutenant with a clipboard. No rifles out. Rifles racked inside, visible through the open back – visible on purpose, I think. A display of not-needing-them.

The whole market goes half a step quieter. Not silent – silent would be a confession. The town does something I recognize from my own body: it keeps moving, but every motion becomes slightly performed, fish being iced a little too attentively, change counted a little too well.

They post a notice on the harbor office board. NEW ARRIVALS SINCE 6/1 – REGISTRY VERIFICATION. All persons arrived since June first to present at the harbor office with identification over the coming weeks. Households sheltering arrivals to declare them. It's phrased like paperwork. Everything they do is phrased like paperwork.

I read it twice and go home the long way, past the co-op. Kaito is stacking crates with his back to the street, too fast and too neat – the way he works when he has already seen something and decided not to look at it again.

"You saw the truck," I say.

"Hard to miss a gray-green thing that big." He takes the next crate without turning. "What's on the board?"

"They want names. Anyone arrived since June first – and the households sheltering them have to declare it."

That gets him to stop. He sets the crate down and wipes his hands on his thighs, once each.

"Sheltering," he says. "That's a stupid word for what she's doing."

"It's their word."

"Then we give them a better one. We're family. Visiting. Her sister's side, whatever – Haru, listen to me." He faces me properly now, and for a second he sounds like the boy from before the roof, loud enough that a man two stacks over glances over. He drops his voice. "They wrote us down that night. The officer with the watch. He knew our faces. If our names go up on a coast list as arrivals from Kōgetsu, that is not a refugee list. That is them finishing a job."

"I know."

"Do you? Because if Sugi puts her name next to ours and they come asking, she goes on the list too." He picks the crate back up, like his hands need something legal to hold. "Talk to her tonight. She knows how this town does its paper. I don't. I just know I am not handing her to them because we were too polite to lie."

That night Sugi listens all the way through before she answers. She has already set three bowls. She always sets three bowls.

"Nephews," she says, finally. "My sister's grandsons, out of Kōgetsu. You came west with the stall-keepers. You are staying until the mail finds your mother." She looks at me, then at Kaito. "Half this lane is suddenly cousins with somebody. The clerk at the harbor office grew up two doors down from me. He stamps what keeps his neighbors fed. It will hold for a registry week."

"And after that?" Kaito says.

"After that we are careful." She does not soften it. "It will not hold if

either of you gives them a reason to look twice. No shouting in the market. No disappearing when a truck parks. No clever stories that do not match the one I just gave you." Her eyes stay on him a beat longer. "Especially you."

He nods once. Takes his bowl to the sink when he is done, washes it, and washes it again, as if the second pass might rinse the day.

After dinner I find him on the sea wall.

He is sitting at the bend where you can see the whole cove, heels against the stone, dusk coming in off the water. I climb up next to him. For a while neither of us talks. The tide does the work.

"Foreman chewed me out today," he says. "Says I lift angry. Says I'll wreck my back by thirty if I keep doing it like I'm mad at the ice."

"Are you mad at the ice?"

"I'm mad at everything. Ice is just what's in my hands." He almost smiles. The nick in his eyebrow shows for a second, then goes. "I told him I'd lift quieter. He laughed."

A gull crosses the cove and vanishes into the dark over the boats. Kaito's thumbs rub the pads of his fingers, back and forth.

"Haru." Still not looking at me. "Can I ask you something? About that night."

My mouth goes dry. "Yeah."

"Not all of it. Just – my voice. I keep hearing the three words. Over and over. Like a song I can't shut off." He swallows. "You were on the ground. I know that. But you were looking. You saw his hand."

"I saw it."

"Did it look like he chose to let go?" He says it flat, like he has been practicing the question all day and still hates the sound of it. "Or did it look like something else?"

It wasn't your fault. The sentence is right there. It has been right there since the underpass. All I have to do is say it.

I remember the fingers. Uncurling all at once. Evenly. Nobody home.

"It looked fast," I say. "It was dark, and everyone was screaming, and it happened fast. That's what I saw."

He is quiet long enough that I hear my own pulse in my ears. Then he nods once, small.

"Yeah," he says. "Fast."

He knows what I did not say. I can feel him knowing it, sitting there with the gray-green truck parked up by the harbor office and the east still glowing wrong over the hills. He asked for one thing and I gave him a weather report.

He does not ask again. He drops off the wall and lands light, like the conversation never happened.

"Come on," he says. "Sugi holds rice hostage after eight, and I already washed my bowl twice. She'll invent a third crime if we're late."

I slide off the wall after him. Six syllables. Why couldn't I say them?

Chapter 6 – The Pier

"You're doing that with your anger instead of your thumb."

That's the first thing Jun ever says to me, leaning over my shoulder at the mending frames, and it's about a knot, and also isn't. Amano Jun, twenty-three, big and unhurried, forearms like dock rope, a wide sunburnt face that settles naturally into cheerfulness, born two lanes over and never once wanted to be anywhere else. He runs the frames on the north pier. The co-op put me on ice my first week and moved me to nets my second, and the nets are where he finds me.

He fixes my thumb. Then my elbow. Then, over two weeks of mornings, most of my netting, because I'm bad at it and he's patient the way big calm men are patient, like there's no clock anywhere in his body. He splits his lunch without asking – his mother Hanae packs it, always too much, always with the pickled radish cut in careful little fans – and he talks enough for both of us, which suits me, because my voice comes out scraped these days and I've got reasons to be careful with it.

"You'll get winter work if you learn splices," he says. "Co-op always needs splices. You planning to be here for winter?"

"Not planning anything."

"Smart. Plans are how the sea gets you." He says the grim ones cheerfully. "My little cousin planned. Wrote it out – Haiga, boat mechanic school, whole thing. You know where Haiga is now."

I know where Haiga is now. Everyone knows where Haiga is now.

"He get out?" I ask.

"He got out." Jun ties off, bites the tag end, spits it. "Papers didn't. So now he's twenty and he exists because my mother swears he does. You want the second rice ball? You're looking at it like it insulted you."

That's Jun: a big slow kindness with too much lunch, teaching a refugee kid

splices so he'll have winter work in a town he isn't planning to stay in.

The too-much lunch has a source. Amano Hanae comes down to the pier around ten – half Jun's size, gray threading her bun, sleeves rolled like she's mid-task even when she isn't – with the cloth bundle and a running list of everything Jun has done wrong since breakfast. He left the gate unlatched. He promised the Moriyamas a hand with their engine and forgot. He's sitting on damp stone again like a boy who's never heard of kidneys. Jun takes it the way the pier takes weather. He calls her boss without any joke in it.

The second morning she catches me sharing his lunch. She looks me over hard – height, wrists, the scrape in my voice – and the next day the bundle is bigger and the radish fans come in two rows.

"You'll say thank you once," Jun advises, quiet, "and then never again. She treats thank-yous like arguing."

"What does she want instead?"

"Eating all of it." He hands me the second rice ball without checking whether I want it. "She fed half of Haiga's boats when the harbors closed. Feeding is just what her worry looks like. You're on the list now. There's no getting off."

I eat all of it. Both mornings. For a couple of weeks a woman I barely know decides my lunch is her business, and it is the closest thing to ordinary I've felt since the roof.

The verification line runs on the harbor office pier all week, and by Friday it's Jun's turn, and I'm the one who walks down with him. That's the whole accident of it. Hanae asked him to go early, get it stamped, come back for the afternoon tide. I'm carrying the frame hooks back to the shed anyway. Company for the boring part, he says. I say yes with half a mouth of rice, the way you say yes to anything Jun asks.

The line is fishermen and mainland families, mixed. Two soldiers work the tables, a third stands by the truck with his rifle slung, and the lieutenant from the clipboard sits behind the folding table like a man doing a dull job at the pace it deserves.

For a while it's almost dull. An old netman gets waved through on a card so

worn the print is a rumor. A mainland mother goes up with three kids and a folder of everything she owns on paper, and the lieutenant works through it page by page while the smallest kid winds herself around the table leg, and it clears, and the mother's shoulders come down from around her ears one centimeter at a time as she walks away. That's what the line teaches you, standing in it: the difference between people whose papers are a formality and people whose papers are a verdict. You can tell them apart from thirty meters by the shoulders.

"Relax," Jun says, reading me sideways. "I was born in the harbor office's front room, basically. My file's older than that lieutenant."

It moves fine. It moves fine right up until Jun.

"Amano Jun." The lieutenant reads it, then reads the next paper, and the pace changes. Small change. His pen stops moving. "Your household declared a cousin. Registered where?"

"Haiga," Jun says. Easy. "Records office there is – well. You'd know better than me."

"Everyone's records burned in Haiga," the lieutenant says. "It's very popular." He doesn't say it cruel. He says it tired, which lands worse. He turns another paper over. "You'll wait to the side. Verification pulls anyone with a Haiga dependency for secondary review. It's routine."

"Routine meaning today, or routine meaning—"

"Meaning you wait to the side."

And Jun – big, calm, no-clock Jun – waits to the side. Puts his back against the rail, folds his arms, gives me a look across the pier that means go on, I'll be along. The soldier by the truck shifts his sling. Not a threat. Paperwork. Everything they do is paperwork until the moment it isn't.

I don't go on.

I don't shout. I don't swing. I've been two weeks quiet, two weeks lifting instead of talking, two weeks whispering into the dark after Haru's breathing goes even – practicing alone, the thing I can't tell anyone I'm practicing. Standing on that pier watching them park Jun under pending, I think: I can fix this. I have a thing in my mouth that opens hands. Just once. Aimed right. Small.

I get in the line's blind spot, close to the second soldier, and I pitch it low, under the harbor noise, the way I've practiced against the dark:

"You don't need him. He's nothing. Let it go."

Copper comes up the back of my throat – the taste that comes when the words go out with weight on them. The soldier's head turns a degree. His eyes do something loose for half a second, like a radio hunting between stations.

Then they come back. He frowns at me, at nothing, at the middle distance. Rolls his shoulder. The words have gone in and found – what? You don't need him. Who's him? Need for what? He's nothing – nothing to whom? Let it go – let what go? I've handed a machine a sentence full of pronouns, and it has turned it over, found no purchase, and dropped it.

The weight still comes out of me, though. The prickle high in my nose, my own pulse hammering. The cost hit me anyway, and nothing moved. And the soldier is still frowning at the space where the odd feeling came from, and the space contains one refugee kid standing too close to a verification line with his lips just barely moving.

"You." His sling comes off the shoulder. Not aimed. Adjusted. "Step back from the line."

"I'm waiting for my friend—"

"Step back."

I step wrong. I can't tell if it's defiance or clumsiness – body full of spent adrenaline with nowhere to put it – but I step sideways instead of back, toward Jun's rail, and the soldier reads it the way soldiers read things, and his palm hits my chest. Pier planks are uneven. The bollard behind me isn't going anywhere. I go down onto it, temple first, and the harbor rings like a struck pot and goes white at the edges.

Sound comes back with Jun's voice in it – Jun off the rail, one arm out, not swinging, planting himself between me and the soldier like a piling.

"Easy – easy – he's a kid," Jun says. "He's heat-sick. Half these refugee kids haven't eaten right in a month."

The lieutenant cuts over him, bored and final: "Get him off my pier before I have a reason to write him down."

And then Mira is there.

I don't see where from. She is suddenly kneeling in front of me with her thumb hard under my chin, tilting my head, loud enough for exactly the audience that matters.

"There it is – look at his eyes, that's heatstroke. My aunt had it twice this month. Up. Up. You don't make the bathhouse boil water all morning and then stand in the sun with no hat, I told you–"

She scolds me like a cousin and marches me by the sleeve through a pier full of soldiers who want nothing to do with a girl managing a fainting relative. Paperwork resumes behind us. The line moves.

She walks me two lanes on rubber legs before she lets the act drop. Sits me on the bathhouse step. Looks at my temple, which I can feel now, hot and wet at the hairline.

"Press this." A cloth, out of nowhere, like the towels on the first day. Then she is quiet a moment.

"You said something to that soldier," she says. "Before he pushed you. I was watching the line. His face went strange for a second – like he'd lost the next thought."

"I asked him to leave Jun alone."

"Asked him." She takes the cloth back, refolds it clean side out, presses it to my head again. She doesn't call me a liar. She doesn't ask twice. "Jun will clear. Half the town owes Hanae dinner. The clerk will lose that file by Tuesday if he knows what's good for him." She checks the bleeding. "Your head is harder than the bollard. Go home before Sugi hears the pier version. By tonight you'll have fought four men and won."

"Why the cousin act?"

"Because it worked." She stands, brushes her knees, and looks down at me for a second with something careful in her face – worry, maybe, or the start of a question she isn't ready to ask. "Because you looked like a boy about to throw away something he couldn't get back. Go home, Kaito."

Sugi's table that night is its own kind of checkpoint.

The pier version of the story beats me home, the way everything in this town beats everyone home. By the time I slide the door she has the disinfectant out on the table, not asking, just out, and Haru is sitting over Orihara's account books doing an extremely bad impression of a boy interested in account books.

"Heatstroke," Sugi says. "That's the story the lane's telling. Saeki girl walked you off the pier scolding you about hats."

"Crate edge caught me first," I say. "Then the heat."

"Mm." She dabs the split at my hairline like she's cleaning a fish, efficient, no sympathy to slow her down. "A crate edge, at a verification line, on the day they pulled Hanae's boy to the side. Busy pier."

I don't answer that. She doesn't need me to; she just wants me to know it's been worked out in this house too. Across the table Haru's pen has stopped. He doesn't look up, and he doesn't ask a single question, and that's how I know how many he has – my best friend interrogates by not asking, the way other people do it with lamps and chairs.

"Jun's people have been getting boys off that pier for a hundred years," Sugi says, pressing the plaster down with her thumb. "He'll clear. What you'll do, since you're suddenly so interested in lines, is stay off them. Boys who go looking for the Federation's elbow generally find it." She packs the kit shut. "Eat. Both of you. The rice won't apologize for itself."

Later, on the futons, in the dark, Haru finally asks one question. He picks the smallest one he can find.

"Does it hurt?"

"No," I say.

Both of us lie there listening to how much I didn't answer.

Jun clears by Tuesday, like she said. He comes up the lane himself to tell me, with a lunch his mother packed for two, and we eat it on the sea wall like nothing happened.

So no harm, right? Nobody hurt but my own head.

I don't tell Haru this part. On the pier, in the half second when that soldier's eyes went loose and hunting – before the sentence failed, before the

shove, before any of it – something in my chest lifted. Like a hand finding a grip. It didn't work, and I still walked away knowing why it didn't work: too many pronouns. No name. No clear thing to do. The machine needs it clean.

I'm not practicing against the dark anymore to make it stop.

I'm practicing to make it clean.

Chapter 7 – Practice

The gulls are the first thing I try, because gulls can't tell anyone.

North end of the sea wall, an hour before the boats go out, nobody but me and forty birds fighting over the co-op's gut bucket. I pick the big one on the piling, get my voice down into the register where the weight lives – I can feel it now, the way you feel a lifted crate settle onto your spine – and tell it: "Fly away."

Nothing. It looks at me with one flat yellow eye and goes back to screaming at the other gulls.

I try again, closer, cleaner. Fly away. Leave. Go. A faint prickle high in my nose each time, weight going out of me – and nothing coming back. Forty gulls, and not one of them cares what I say, and on the walk to work it comes together like a splice under Jun's thumb: the soldier on the roof heard me and knew what the words meant. The one on the pier heard me and couldn't find the meaning – pronouns, no handles – and it slid off.

It's not a shout. It's not volume at all. It's a sentence going into a mind that understands it, and the understanding is the door the weight walks through.

Which means it only works on people.

I stand on the sea wall with the gut bucket screaming behind me and let it arrive properly. The only thing in the world my mouth works on is people. There's no practicing on cans off a fence.

I go to work and tie splices and don't say anything with weight on it for three days.

The nights are different. Most nights I end up on the north wall again.

Practice looks like this: a boy on cold stone past midnight, building sentences out loud with no weight on them, the way you dry-fire a rifle. I pick a job – make a man put down a knife, make a man step out of a doorway,

make a man forget he saw me – and then I draft the sentence and attack my own draft. Put the knife down – which knife, what if he's holding two things, does down mean drop or set. Step aside – aside which way, what if aside is off a pier. Every sentence has exits, and everything I love about how I've talked my whole life – fast, hot, first thing out of my mouth – is exactly what leaves the exits open. So I sand them. Shorter. Fewer doors. Say it, hear the gap, close the gap, say it again. Some nights I get one sentence smooth in two hours, and my throat aches like I've been shouting even though nothing I said all night was louder than the tide.

Twice I put a hair of weight on one, aimed at nothing and nobody, just to feel it catch – and even that takes something with it. I can feel it go: a faint pressure behind the eyes, gone by morning, but real.

The second time, a lantern comes up the wall path. Old Harada, checking his skiff lines the way he does when his hips won't let him sleep. I sit still and let him find me being a boy staring at the sea, which is a thing this town's boys are allowed to be at night, and he grunts something about the swell and goes back down. I tell myself he saw nothing.

The town notices things too. That comes clear on Friday.

I know what the gulls proved. Every real test has to be a person. I start creating tests, and I know exactly what I am doing – the version where I stumble into it is a comfort I haven't earned.

I build them the way Haru would. That is the part that makes my skin crawl – I can hear the shape of his thinking in mine, careful, step by step: a real test needs a result you can't explain away. Telling a co-op man "take the other end" proves nothing; he would have taken the other end anyway. For a week I do those anyway – little deniable nothings, "hand me the hook," "mind the ice" – and get nothing but maybes, hurting myself to learn nothing.

A real test needs someone doing a thing they would never otherwise do.

Wednesday, on the mending frames, Jun is fighting the co-op's worst net – the one everybody hates, the one with the tar-stiff panel that takes two men and a grudge – and doing it alone, because the other netman is out and Jun is constitutionally incapable of leaving a job for the tide. His hands are torn up. He has waved off my help twice, cheerful, you've got your own frame, boss

counts my blisters not yours. And the sentence assembles itself behind my teeth before I've asked it to. Clean. Perfect. Four words, no exits: Let me help you.

It would work. That's the thing. It isn't a test I might fail – I can feel the shape of it, feel that it is smooth all the way around, and it would go into the kindest man on this pier and move him out of the way like furniture, and he would never know anything had happened. He would just – change his mind. People change their minds all the time.

I stand there with it loaded and look at him – at the radish fans in the lunch cloth, at the thumb he taught mine to be smarter than – and I swallow it. Physically. It goes down like a stone.

Not because it is cruel. Because it isn't. Because it is help, and it is still me reaching into my friend's head and rearranging the furniture, and if I let myself start with the kind ones I already know exactly where that ends. Every rep is a person. Jun doesn't get to be a rep.

I help him anyway, the ordinary way, by ignoring his waving-off and grabbing the tar panel, and he calls me a mule and splits the lunch, and I sit there eating Hanae's rice with the unspent sentence still dissolving on my tongue.

I have already drawn the line: nobody I love. Nobody kind. It doesn't occur to me yet that a line like that has another edge to it, and the other edge is a permission.

So I look for someone who isn't either.

The buyer from the city comes Thursdays. Suit trousers and rubber boots, drives down from the prefecture road, and the whole co-op hates him the same way you hate weather – he shorts the posted price, every week, and every week the foreman argues and loses, because the buyer's truck is the only truck, and everyone's crates rot the same speed. Nobody loves him. Nobody calls him kind. He is perfect for a test.

Thursday, he's mid-shortchange – foreman's neck going red, Jun's mouth doing its flat patient line – and I'm stacking behind the scale, close enough. Low, under the argument, aimed at the back of his head like a thrown hook:

"Pay the posted price. Don't argue."

The copper comes up hard this time, and my nose prickles high up behind the

bridge, and the buyer stops mid-sentence.

Stops. Blinks at the chalkboard. And pays the posted price – counts it out flat, no argument, while the foreman stands there with his rebuttal dying in his mouth and the whole shed goes quiet at the miracle. The buyer looks confused doing it. That is the detail that sticks. He watches his own hands count the money like a man watching rain fall out of a clear sky, mutters something about fixing the numbers next week, and drives off.

I know what it was before anyone else does. It was clean. Name the act, close the exits. Pay the posted price. Don't argue. No pronouns, no gaps, nothing for the machine to turn over and drop. Two weeks of whispering in the dark and I have finally played a whole note, and it has gone through a grown man like current through wire.

I make it to the ice room before the nosebleed properly starts.

The co-op talks about it for two days after that. Miracle, they say. Even misers wake up human once.

Here is what it costs, since I'm the only one who knows.

The blood, first – not a trickle, this time. I sit on a crate in the ice room with my head forward, pinching, and it runs through my fingers for longer than it should, bright on the wet floor, and when it finally stops, my throat feels the way it felt after the roof: scraped, paid out, like the voice is a rope and something heavy just went down it too fast.

Then the pulse in the skull – behind the eyes, a slow flat drumbeat that lasts till evening.

Then the part with no name. That night, lying in the dark across from Haru's breathing, I keep my mouth shut on purpose. Not practicing. Not even dry-firing. Just listening to my own throat scrape when I swallow, and wondering what the weight is taking out of me when it leaves – because it goes into people, and I am also a person, and I don't know what talking is doing to whoever's left in here after I use it.

And underneath all of it – under the blood and the drum and the fear, holding them up like a piling – the true cost, the one I would never say at Sugi's table:

I feel good.

When the buyer's hands start counting. When the shed goes quiet. Two weeks of being a scraped-out refugee kid who checks doorways, and for one second on that dock I am the reason the world goes right instead of wrong – the miser pays, the foreman wins, Jun's crates make money – and something in my chest lifts like a gull getting the wind, and it has not fully come down since, and I hate it, and I go looking for it again every time I practice.

That's the truth, both halves of it: it works when it's clean, and part of me is glad, and I can't tell anymore which of those is the dangerous one.

Mira knows something. I keep turning it over and I can't find who told her – which means nobody did, which means she is just watching that closely.

Friday she is at Sugi's gate when I come back from the wall crew. She falls in step. For one lane's length she says nothing. Then:

"Third nosebleed this week. Ice room Monday. The wall yesterday. And don't bother lying – Harada saw you, and Harada tells my aunt everything. It's her whole retirement."

"Dry summer," I say.

"It's the wettest June in nine years." Mild. Watching the lane ahead. "The buyer paid the posted price on Thursday. First time in two years. Jun says a saint did it. The foreman is telling people his arguing finally landed."

"Maybe it did."

"Maybe." We walk. Her voice stays the same size the whole way, which is somehow worse than an accusation. "My aunt gets deliveries from three towns up the coast. Drivers talk when they think nobody's listening. There's a story going around from Kōgetsu – about the night it fell. A checkpoint sergeant walked away from his own post in the middle of the evacuation, rifle and all, because somebody told him to go home. The way they tell it, he did. Three days' walk. Turned up at his mother's door still holding the rifle."

She stops at the bathhouse corner, where her road splits off mine.

"It's probably nothing," she says. "Evacuations grow stories. But the Federation doesn't think it's nothing. There's a man at the harbor office this

week who isn't there for the registry. He doesn't stamp anything. He just listens."

The lane is very quiet. Down at Sugi's end, the plum tree moves.

"Why tell me?"

"Because you get nosebleeds. Because you're terrible at looking innocent. And because Sugi's floor has enough grief on it already." She shifts her aunt's parcels up her hip – ordinary as anything, seventeen years old, talking about rising water like tide charts. "Whatever you're doing at night on the north wall – Harada, remember – do it where the town can't see you. Or better: stop."

She goes her road. I stand at the corner a while.

I don't stop.

Not because of the lift in the chest, whatever else that lift is doing to me. Because that night I finally write the sentence out – the one I've been circling since the roof, the reason I whisper into the dark until my nose bleeds. On the roof I had one throw and I made it with a dirty sentence. Let her go – words we'd been tossing around the arcade all night, worn so smooth they could mean anything, and the machine took the meaning I didn't want.

Clean, I know the sentence now. Built the careful way, Haru's way, no gaps, no exits.

Bring her onto the roof and set her down.

Not let her go – that opens a hand over empty air. This names the place, the act, the end of it. That's all it needed. One clean sentence and Ryn would have been alive.

Chapter 8 – Drop It

Orihara's shop backs onto a drying yard, and the drying yard backs onto a net shed, and the net shed is where the lane keeps the things it doesn't explain to visitors.

I find out by accident, the way I find out everything – by staring at paper too long. Three weeks of doing Orihara's books and the numbers keep having a shadow: rice that sold without selling, small payments marked only with single characters, money in and out that balances perfectly and connects to nothing. Good books hide things badly from people who like books. When I finally ask, Orihara looks at me for a long moment over her glasses and then, instead of answering, introduces me to Sato.

Sato Kimi is fifty, built like a bollard, and spent thirty years as the harbor office's records clerk before her knees retired her. What she does now, in the net shed, with a locked tin box and a beautiful old hand-stamp collection, is keep the town's second set of paper. A boy from Haiga whose records burned gets a work chit that says he's somebody's cousin. A family the registry would split across two shelters becomes one household with one address. Nothing sold, nothing forged from air – mostly real stamps applied with merciful timing, and a quiet list of who owes whom dinner. The clerk who replaced her at the harbor office grew up two doors down. It is not a resistance. It is a lane taking care of its paper the way it takes care of its nets.

"You can carry for me," Sato says, that first day, sizing me up like a crate. "You look honest and boring. That's the whole uniform."

So Tuesdays and Fridays I carry – envelopes between the shed and the shop, the numbers in my head where no soldier can read them. I tell Sugi. She grunts like I've told her the tide is in. I do not tell Kaito, and I am honest about why: he has enough to carry, and I like having one thing that is mine – one small brave thing I am doing with my honest face while he lifts ice and gets quieter. Pride, dressed up as protection.

Friday afternoon I am on a carry run – shed to shop, envelope under my arm – when it goes wrong.

The drying yard sits between Orihara's back door and Sato's net shed: gravel, three walls, net frames down the middle. Gate opens to the seaward lane. Shed door is open at the far end. Sato is inside at the bench with the tin box open, stamps in their rows, her book beside them. I am on the shed threshold, about to take the envelope from her, when Kaito comes through the gate the other way.

Orihara has bought another shelf. She keeps buying them. Kaito is hauling this one across the yard for her, halfway between the gate and the shed, when two soldiers walk up the lane on foot.

Not the pier detail. Younger. Unfamiliar. The kind the registry week has been rotating through town in pairs, poking gates for something worth writing down.

They stop at the open gate and look in – and see the shed, the open box, the stamps.

"Yard check," the taller one calls. Bored for half a second. Then not.

"Step away from the bench." His rifle comes off the shoulder. His partner's too, a half-beat late. "Hands where I can see them. Away from the box."

Sato does something I curse her for and admire her for in the same breath: she steps in front of the box. Thirty years a records clerk. She knows exactly what a tin of loose stamps means at a registry verification, and exactly which names are in the ledger, and she puts her body where the paper is like it is the most natural thing in the world.

"This is net-mending storage," she says. "You're holding rifles in a widow's drying yard."

"On the ground, all of it—" and he moves toward her, rifle first. It's aimed at a fifty-year-old woman's chest from four steps. His finger is inside the guard. He is twenty-two, maybe, and hunting a commendation, and his voice has gone tight and high because nothing about a granny in a net shed was in this morning's briefing.

I am at the threshold, holding an envelope of the exact thing he's looking for.

I do the thing I do. I open my mouth to apologize to the situation – some blur of sorry, she's my aunt, we're mending nets – and I get one word into it when the shelf hits the gravel.

Kaito, setting it down. Freeing his hands. And walking – not running – into the space between the rifle and Sato, wide of the net frames, angling so the muzzle has to choose between them, and his voice, when it comes, isn't loud at all.

"Drop it."

Two words. Aimed like a thrown hook.

I see it happen four steps away in good afternoon light. The soldier's fingers open. All of them, at once, evenly – the rifle just leaves his hands, like the ground has asked for it back – and his face hasn't changed yet, he is still wearing the shout, because no part of him has chosen it. The rifle hits the gravel. And for one held breath, nobody in the yard knows whether that has happened.

The partner decides first. The young one, the half-beat one – he sees his sergeant's weapon fall for no reason in the middle of a stand-off, and his body does the thing scared bodies do around a trigger.

"Step back," Kaito says, at the first one – second command, out before I finish blinking – and the disarmed soldier obeys, instantly, the machine walking him backward, and backward is where his partner is standing. Eighty kilos of commanded man steps into the younger one's rifle arm.

The shot goes into the yard like the end of the world.

Wild – up and sideways, wrenched by the collision – and it would have hit nothing, it should have hit nothing, the yard is three walls and open sky. Sato is mid-turn, reaching to close the tin box. The round takes her through the upper arm and slaps her against the shed frame, and her blood hits the stamps, and the sound she makes is not a scream, it is a huge affronted oh – a records clerk's disbelief that the world could get a page this wrong.

Then nobody moves for a second.

The younger soldier stares at what his rifle has done, holding it away from his body like it bit him. The older one is on the gravel where the second command left him, eyes coming back, empty hands open the way I saw on a

rooftop. Blood starts down Kaito's upper lip. He is already moving to Sato. I get both hands on her arm and press the way my mother taught me – kitchen towel, nine years old, keep pressure until someone who knows better takes over.

Through the gate: Mira at a dead run, her aunt's first-aid kit under her arm.

She takes over the arm like she's done it before. She doesn't ask what happened. She looks once at the rifle on the gravel, once at the older soldier still on his knees in the wrong part of the yard, once at Kaito's bleeding nose – a triangle, three points, I watch her eyes draw it – and then she says, in her tide-chart voice: "You two were never here. Go through the shop. Sato fell on a net hook. Everyone in this yard likes that story better than any other story. Go."

The soldiers don't stop us – because the older one can't explain his empty hands without a story he doesn't have, and the younger one has just shot a widow in a drying yard. They have more to bury than we do. By evening the lane's official truth is a discharge accident during a routine check, apologies conveyed, the box and its stamps long gone into some other shed by hands I don't see. The lane protects its own.

Kaito comes and finds me on the sea wall after, past the bend, where the stone still holds the day's heat. For a while we sit in the dark and listen to the tide work, and I set what I actually saw against everything I've spent a summer refusing to look at, and it finally comes together whether I like it or not.

"You saw," Kaito says.

"I saw."

"Then say it. Out loud. What you saw." Not a challenge. He needs a witness. His voice is scraped raw and there is dried blood he missed at his jaw.

"You said drop it and his hands opened before his face knew. You said step back and his legs did it. The same as—" I make myself finish it. He deserves at least one honest sentence. "—the same as the roof."

He breathes out like something has been cut off him. And then it comes, all

of it, quiet and fast – the practicing in the dark, the gulls, the pier and why the pier failed, the buyer, the nosebleeds, the taste it leaves, the clean sentences and how he builds them. He talks for longer than I have heard him talk since Kōgetsu. I don't interrupt. I listen. Some of it is terrifying. Some of it is just my best friend describing, in his own scraped voice, the loneliest month of work anyone I know has ever done.

"It's getting cleaner," he says finally. "That's what today was. Two commands in ten seconds and they both landed. A month ago that soldier's hand wouldn't have opened all the way." His thumb runs across his fingertips, back and forth. "And Sato's arm still happened. Clean isn't the same as safe. I aimed everything right and the yard still broke sideways, because it isn't only me in the yard." He puts his hand flat on the stone. Then, smaller: "Help me."

"Kaito – we can fix–"

"I don't need you to fix it. I need somebody outside my own head. You notice the order things happen in. You just proved it. You gave me the roof back straight and it didn't kill me to hear it." He looks at me properly. "Help me figure out the rules. What it needs. What it costs. Where the edges are. Because I'm going to keep ending up in yards, Haru. This summer isn't going to stop putting me in them, and the next wild shot lands somewhere worse than an arm."

The tide works on the stones. He is not asking for it wasn't your fault. He has not asked since the wall. He is asking for something I can actually give, and I understand, sitting there, that this is mercy for me as much as for him.

"I saw the hand open on the roof," I say. It is the closest I have ever come. "I've been seeing it all summer. I couldn't make it mean anything that didn't terrify me, so I called it dry air and I let you carry it alone. That's what I did." My throat hurts. "I'll help. I don't know what help looks like yet. But I'm done pretending, and I'm not leaving you alone with it – the rules, the costs, any of it. We figure out your mouth the way we'd have studied for finals. Properly. Both of us."

Kaito looks at the black water for a while.

"She'd laugh," he says. "Study group."

"She'd run it," I say, and it is the first time either of us has touched the

subject of her lightly, and it holds – barely, but it holds.

We walk back up the lane past Orihara's dark shop. In her front room a lamp is still burning where Mira is sitting up with Sato. Neither of us says much. She got there first with a kit, and she invented the story that let us walk away.

Chapter 9 – Kill Yourself

The trucks come back on a Tuesday, and this time there are three of them.

I'm on the nets with Jun when the first one crosses the bridge – engine note wrong for a fish town, too even, no rattle – and by the time it parks at the harbor office the second is coming down the prefecture road and the third is already at the shrine. Jun's hands stop on the mesh. Big, calm Jun, who never hurries at anything, goes still, and that scares me worse than the trucks.

"That's not a registry pace," he says.

Loudhailers by nine. All residents and registered arrivals to the shrine grounds for a flow assessment. Assessment – everything they do wears a clerk's word. Soldiers walk the lanes in pairs, knocking, polite, and the politeness has a floor under it you can feel through your boots. The lieutenant with the clipboard sets up his folding table under the camphor tree at the shrine steps, and beside the table, on a stool nobody brought for him because he brought it himself, sits a man I've seen once before, through Mira's warning, without ever seeing him: harbor office, doesn't stamp, listens. Gray suit, no uniform. He doesn't hold paper. Everyone else at that table is doing a job. He's doing a different one.

The whole town fits in a shrine yard, it turns out. Fishermen, widows, mainland families, Sugi with her spine straight, Orihara, Hanae with her lunch cloth still knotted in her hand because they knocked mid-packing. Haru is across the crowd with Sato's side of the lane – I find him first, the way I find him anywhere, and he finds me, and we do the thing we've done since the roof: mark each other's positions like men counting exits.

They read names. That's the assessment. A soldier reads from the clipboard and people step to the table and answer questions, and it goes fine, it goes boring, it goes almost gentle – until the fourth name.

"Amano Jun."

Jun leaves my side, ambles up, easy, twenty-three years of nothing-to-hide in his walk. The lieutenant flips a page. And the man in the gray suit leans forward, elbow to knee, and looks at Jun the way a scale looks at a crate.

"Your household filed a dependent cousin. Haiga registration." The lieutenant's pen taps the file. "That verification cleared last month. It's been reopened."

"Cleared is cleared," Jun says. "Your own office—"

"The office has been advised that its coastal files show irregularities." He doesn't look at the gray suit when he says advised. He looks at his pen, which tells me everything about who advised whom. "The dependent isn't present at your registered address. Where is he?"

"He's twenty," Jun says. "He does day work up the coast. He's a mechanic's hand, not a—"

"Where."

"I don't keep his boots by my door."

It builds from there, slow. The lieutenant asks the same question four different ways. Jun answers wide four different ways – cheerful going flat, flat going careful – because the cousin's papers are the lane's paper – Sato's shed, the tin box, the merciful stamps – and every soul in the yard knows it, and knows that Jun knows. Jun, being Jun, has decided with no clock in his body that the FDC gets to stand in his town but not inside his family.

Then Hanae starts forward – mother's instinct, the lunch cloth twisting – and a soldier puts an arm across her path, and Jun's voice changes register for the first time.

"She stays out of it." He steps sideways, putting himself between the table and his mother's line to it. "You're talking to me."

"Face the table—"

"You're talking to me—"

The shove comes from the flank soldier, two hands, center of Jun's chest, and Jun – dock-rope forearms, hauling since he was eight – absorbs it without moving his feet, which reads as strength, which reads as resistance, and everything after runs on that misreading. The soldier's rifle comes level.

Young. Not the drying-yard boy – this one's older and worse, calm in a way that has practiced being calm.

"Hands behind your head. Last warning."

The yard has gone tide-flat silent. I'm thirty meters back in the crowd with words already gathering in my throat, and Haru's eyes find me from across the yard with a message in them as clear as a shout: don't – not with a hundred people watching and the gray suit at the table. And I am obeying him. I stand there with my mouth shut, being counseled by my best friend's terrified face across a shrine yard, both of us betting the day will grind through and land everyone home by supper.

"Last chance," the soldier says. "Hands."

Jun, twenty-three, with his mother behind him and his cousin's forged life sitting in his silence, does not put up his hands. He does something worse. He half-turns his head toward Hanae – checking her, only checking her, the way he checked my thumb on the nets – and his weight shifts with the turn.

The rifle takes him through the chest.

No warning past the two he'd had. No aiming beat you could point to. One crack, flat off the shrine wall, and the biggest gentlest man I've met since the world ended goes down onto the stones of the yard he was baptized in, and the sound Hanae makes bypasses every human word ever made, and the crowd folds inward and outward at once – toward him, away from the rifles – and Jun coughs twice at the sky, at the camphor leaves, and stops.

He was checking on his mother. That is the movement they shoot him for.

"NO--"

My voice. Already too loud, tearing out of thirty meters of stunned crowd. I don't remember choosing it. I remember the yard rearranging – soldiers pivoting, the lieutenant standing, gray suit rising off his stool with his head cocked like a listening dog – and the shooter's rifle swinging across the crowd toward the noise, toward me, faces scattering out of the line between us until there is nothing in it but him and me and Jun on the ground.

"Shut up," the soldier says, muzzle steadying on my chest. "One more sound out of you and--"

He faces me. He hears me and understands me, and I hear and understand him –

a month of whispering in the dark, a month of clean sentences ready – Jun's blood still finding the gaps between the stones – and what I say, I say with every gram of weight my ruined voice can put under it:

"Why don't you shut up. Or better – why don't you just kill yourself."

The words go out of me like a spine being pulled. My knees go. Blood comes down over my lip, the copper fills my mouth, the yard tips sideways –

– and the soldier turns the rifle under his own jaw and fires.

I look away before it finishes. It doesn't help.

The yard breaks. Screaming, the crowd going in every direction at once, soldiers shouting cover and contact and pointing rifles at a threat that isn't there, that is me, that they can't see – because who fired? The man fired at himself. Nobody knows what they've witnessed. Except: at the table, the man in the gray suit stands very still in the middle of the smashing wave, hands over his ears – over his ears, in a yard where the shooting is finished – and his eyes go through the crowd like a hook through water, hunting, and what they are hunting is a mouth.

Somebody's hand closes on my arm. Sugi – I don't know how she crosses that yard at her age at that speed – Sugi, hauling me up off my knees with vinegar-stained fingers, shoving me lane-ward through the crush, and her face says run before her voice does.

My body runs the town like it has been rehearsing the route all summer – down the lane past Orihara's, through the drying-yard cut, out the gap in the wall fence Jun showed me my first week so we could beat the lunch line. Behind me the shrine keeps screaming. My nose pours. Twice the world goes gray at the edges and I run through the gray.

Haru catches me at Sugi's gate.

He must have run the parallel lane – he is there first, chest heaving, arm out, and I stop, because it is him. One breath. The two of us in the gateway where we have stood every evening of this salvaged summer.

"Kaito—" His hand gets my sleeve. His face is working faster than I have ever watched it go, and losing. "It wasn't—"

And it stops. Half a beat early. His mouth open around the rest of it – your fault – the sentence he has owed me since the dark outside Kōgetsu – and it will not come. Even now. Even with Jun's blood on the stones and a man dead by his own hand with my words in his ears. My best friend is too honest to finish it, because he just watched a soldier put a rifle under his own jaw because I told him to, and no true sentence starting with it wasn't survives that.

"It was," I say. "You saw it. It was."

I pull my sleeve out of his hand. Gently. That is the one mercy I have left – I do it gently.

Mira is at the lane mouth. Kit on her shoulder, a cloth sack already packed, her aunt's bicycle leaned against the wall. No expression on her face at all. Just readiness. I understand in one look that she packed that sack before the shrine yard – days before – the way you pack for weather you have watched coming up the coast.

"Not the coast road," she says. "They'll rope that first. There's a foot track over the ridge the herring carts used before the tunnel. I know it." And then, when I don't move: "Kaito. The man in the gray suit is why I know. Come now, or sit down and wait for him."

One more look back. Sugi's plum tree over the wall. The empty stretch of shelf through the window where the cat used to sit. Haru in the gateway, hand still open where my sleeve was, mouth still open around the sentence he couldn't close, and behind him up the lane the sound of a town learning what the day is.

I turn and follow her at a run.

We take the ridge track in the dark, over roots and herring-cart stones, Mira's shape ahead of me, until the cove drops away behind us and Nagihama is just a handful of lit grains at the sea's edge with three gray-green trucks parked in it.

She lets us stop at the top. Two minutes. She hands me water from the sack – she packed enough for both of us – and I drink while Nagihama stays lit below the ridge.

"We have to keep moving," Mira says from the dark ahead. Gentle. "If we stop

here, they close the ridge by morning.”

“I left him in the gateway,” I say.

“I know.” She starts walking. “The man in the gray suit had his hands over his ears before the yard finished screaming. He was hunting for a mouth. He will not stop at Nagihama. Walk.”

Chapter 10 – Toward Kuroishi

The town spends the next day being questioned, and I spend it giving nobody a reason to look at me twice, and I learn something about myself in the process that I'd rather not have learned.

They rope the coast road by midnight and post pairs at the bridge and the prefecture road by dawn. The official account congeals fast, the way official accounts do: an armed incident during a flow assessment, one civilian casualty, one member of the detail dead by – the phrase they land on is discharge under review. Nobody in Nagihama corrects them. The whole town watched a soldier turn his rifle under his own jaw for no reason the eye could find, and the whole town has, without one meeting being held, decided it saw confusion, smoke, an angle blocked by the camphor tree.

The man in the gray suit conducts interviews in the harbor office all day. Not everyone. He picks. He works through everyone who stood near the shooter, name by name.

My turn comes mid-afternoon. A soldier walks me up – polite, tired – and the gray suit sits across the clerk's table with no clipboard, no pen, nothing to do but listen. That is the most frightening way a man can sit.

"You knew the deceased." Flat. He doesn't say which one. He wants to hear which name I reach for.

"Jun taught my friend net splices. Everyone knew Jun."

"Your friend." He lets it sit. "The one who shouted. The one who ran."

"Half the yard ran. There was shooting."

"Mm. He shouted no. And the soldier turned his weapon from the crowd, addressed him – and then." Nothing on his face. Water has more expression. "You were across the yard. Between the well and the cistern shed. You see well from there?"

He has me placed to the meter, a day later, out of a crowd of six hundred,

and that should be the moment I come apart. Instead – and this is the part I'd rather not admit – the room settles onto rails I know. A frightened man across a table, needing a believable shape for a bad day. I've been doing that since I was ten. I drop my shoulders and let my voice go soft and steady, the one that works, the one that has been working all summer at gates and lines and counters, and I give him a seventeen-year-old's honest confusion – the tree was in the way, the crowd surged, I heard two shots and hit the ground with everyone, my friend ran because I was screaming at everyone to run, I don't know where he went, his uncle's people were mainland, maybe–

He believes me faster than the lie deserves. I watch it land. He thanks me and has me walked out, and standing in the sun outside the harbor office I finally shake, not from fear but from the other thing.

It isn't charm. Charm doesn't work on men like that. Something in my voice makes people stop looking. It has happened all my life – the train men, the gates, the checkpoint smiles – and now a gray suit, and I no longer believe the word for what I do is polite.

Kaito's mouth makes people move. Whatever I carry makes them quiet. That is as far as I let the thought run. There is too much else from the yard still in my head.

I don't sleep. The room has his futon in it, folded wrong, and the shelf is still empty.

At the gate I got two words out. It wasn't– and the rest jammed in my throat, and he took the broken sentence as a verdict and pulled his sleeve out of my hand gently, and that gentleness is the thing I cannot lie down in the same room with.

So I stop pretending, somewhere before morning, and pack.

Hanae comes to Sugi's at first light, wearing yesterday's clothes, moving like the air has gotten heavier overnight. She sits where Sugi puts her, holds the tea she doesn't drink, and asks me one question.

Not about Jun. She's past questions about Jun; there's nothing about Jun anyone can tell her that the stones of the yard didn't.

"Your friend," she says. "The loud one. Jun fed him all summer." Her thumb moves on the cup rim, once, twice. "He shouted when they – everyone else held still, and he shouted. And then the man who did it pointed his rifle at your friend and said something, and then the man was dead of his own hand." She looks up at me. "You were there. Tell me what I saw."

Sugi's kitchen is absolutely silent. The kettle isn't on. She chose for it not to be.

And I do the thing. My shoulders drop. The words come out quiet and even.

"You saw a frightened man break," I say. "Soldiers who shoot into a crowd sometimes can't live in the next minute. Your son's death cracked him. The shouting boy was only a boy shouting. None of that is yours to carry."

She believes me. That is the horror. She is not a gray suit; she wants a shape she can live holding, and my voice hands her one, and I watch a little of the weight leave her shoulders – a mercy, a real one, built out of a lie so deep the whole roof of her grief now rests on it. She holds my hand at the door with both of hers and thanks me.

I stand in the entryway a long time after she's gone. I just handed a grieving mother a lie, and she thanked me for it with both of her hands. Jun checked on his mother and they shot him for the angle of his shoulders. The paper that would have saved him was mercy, and mercy is what they came to punish. The man with the listening face puts boys on maps by the meter, and the only tools that have bent anything this summer toward kindness are a boy's mouth that kills and a boy's voice that lies.

Nobody is coming to fix any of this.

Sato receives me in Orihara's back room, arm strapped, gray from a fever she's decided not to have, and she has the tin box out on the table like the day never happened.

"You came for paper." Records-clerk voice. "Good. You'd be dead in a week without it."

She works one-handed while she talks, and what she builds me is a boy who exists: a transit chit with real stamps in a merciful order, a work reference from a co-op that will swear to me, a family errand – locating a cousin's

household, displaced, last known inland – that gives my walking a clerk-shaped reason. “Don’t embroider it,” she says. “You’re a boring boy on a family errand. Boring is the whole uniform, I told you that the day I met you.”

“Come with me as far as the junction,” I say. “You can’t stamp with that arm. Orihara can hide the box better than–”

“I can’t.” Flat. Then – because she is Sato, and she does not give easy answers when true ones are owed – she gives me the true one. “Not with this arm. Not after that yard. My nerve’s cracked, boy. I heard that shot in the yard yesterday and I was on the floor of this shop before I knew I’d moved. A woman who drops when the world bangs is a danger to whoever she’s walking beside.” She squares the chit’s edges, slides it across. “So I stay, and I stamp, and that’s my share. Yours is the road. They went inland – the ridge track drops to the old herring road, and the herring road has one town with water on it, and that’s Kuroishi. A day, day and a half, if that girl walks him hard, and she will. She strikes me as someone who’s planned a route before.”

She says it perfectly level. I meet her eyes, and neither of us puts anything more on the table than that – just two people looking at the same handful of maybes and declining to say any of them out loud.

“Bring him back a person,” Sato says, which is the closest she comes to goodbye. “Paper I can fix. That, I can’t.”

Sugi doesn’t try to stop me. That’s the last thing Nagihama gave me, and the biggest.

She watches me pack the onigiri she made without being asked – the paper of stamps going inside my jacket where rain can’t argue with it, food on top – and she stands in the entryway with her arms folded, and what she says is:

“You know what you’re walking toward isn’t the boy who left.”

“I know.”

“You don’t,” she says, without heat. “You know it in your head. You’ll learn it the other way on the road, and it’ll cost you, and you’ll keep walking anyway, because that’s the animal you are. I’ve fed enough people to know the ones who come back from things and the ones who go toward them.” She looks at

me for a long moment, and whatever she's checking for, she finds enough of it. "Both of you got made wrong for surviving. It's the one thing I'd change about either of you, and it's the only reason I'm letting you through this door."

She fixes my collar like a grandmother, one pull, done.

"That shelf stays empty," she says. "I am not filling it. So one of you has to come back and look at it eventually. That's not sentiment and you'll tell him so."

"I will."

"Go, then. Before I invent a reason to feed you again."

The plum tree over the wall. The lane, gray-gold, going about its morning with soldiers in it. At the edge of town the pairs are checking paper, and I hand mine over with my shoulders down and the family errand ready in my mouth, and the soldier stamps me through while he's still reading and then the town is behind me and the herring road is under my feet, dust instead of salt, running inland between dry hills toward a water tower I can't see yet.

I spend the first hour composing what I'll say when I catch him, and throw all of it away by the second. Every draft is a speech, and speeches are what I do instead of the thing. I have owed him one sentence since a vending-machine light outside Kōgetsu – six syllables – and it has only gotten heavier, and I am done offering substitutes.

He told me it was his fault, and I let the town burn the last bridge before I argued.

So: Kuroishi. Then wherever the road goes after Kuroishi. However far west there is, however long it takes – until I am in front of Kurosawa Kaito, and the sentence is finished.

Chapter 11 – Inland

The salt smell is gone by morning.

The ridge has given us dust instead – dry hills, scrub, a herring road that used to mean carts and now means two people walking west with one sack between them. Mira sets the pace – not hard, not soft, the pace of someone who has already decided how far today goes and is waiting for my feet to catch up.

I don't talk. She doesn't make me. Twice she hands me water without asking, and twice I take it, and both times my throat still feels like something heavy went down it the night before and never finished landing. Jun is not a thought I can hold all at once. He arrives in pieces – the radish fans, the thumb on the splice, the half-turn toward his mother – and I keep walking through them the way she told me to.

By noon the road tips into a long main street with a blackened shrine gate at one end and a bus depot at the other – hot asphalt, croquette oil, the copy-paper smell of an open office door. Kuroishi. The town has FDC the way a dog has fleas: pairs at the depot, a clipboard man under a shade cloth, nobody running, nobody smiling much.

"Not the depot," Mira says, quiet. "Not yet. We need a roof first."

"You know somebody?"

"I know a shop that used to take coast people overnight when the herring road still meant something." She glances at me once. "If she's still there, she won't ask questions. If she asks questions, we leave."

Orii's dried-goods sits halfway down the street between a shuttered tool shop and a place selling secondhand boots – a bell on the door, dust in the light, shelves of rice, tea, string, and soap, the boring things that keep a town standing.

The woman behind the counter does not look up for the bell – middle-aged,

hair pinned flat, wearing an apron the color of old paper. She finishes counting a stack of tea boxes, sets the last one straight, and only then lifts her eyes.

"We're closed for lodging," she says.

"We're not lodging," Mira says. "We're cousins from the coast. Looking for evening work, and a floor if you still have the upstairs."

Orii's gaze goes over Mira, then over me – scraped voice, dust to the knees, a boy who looks like he walked out of something and hasn't decided what to call it. She does not ask which coast. She does not ask why.

She points upstairs without smiling.

"One night. Maybe two. You haul stock in the morning. You don't talk about the war in my shop. I don't stock it."

"Understood," Mira says.

"Payment's the hauling. There's a mat and a washbasin. Don't leave the water running." She looks at me again, longer. "And keep your mouth quiet if anyone with a clipboard comes in. This town has ears."

I almost laugh. It comes out wrong. She has already turned back to her tea boxes.

The room above the shop is one mat, one window onto the alley, a washbasin with a crack down the side. Mira unpacks like she has done this before – water, a cloth, a small tin of rice she bought at the counter without me noticing the price. I sit on the mat with my back to the wall and listen to the street – diesel, a radio somewhere playing a cheerful jingle over a war bulletin. Nobody screams. Nobody here knows Jun's name.

"Eat," Mira says.

"Not hungry."

"I didn't ask if you were hungry." She puts the rice in my hand. "You walk better with something in you. That's not kindness. That's logistics."

I eat. It tastes like nothing. It stays down, which is the whole job.

She watches me finish and doesn't pretend she isn't measuring whether I can

walk tomorrow.

"You're going to keep seeing him," she says. Not gentle. Accurate. "In every quiet room. That's what it does. You don't have to talk about it with me. You just have to keep your feet moving when it hits."

"You packed the sack before the trucks came."

"Yes."

"How long before?"

A small pause. She folds the cloth once. "Long enough. The gray suit had been circling the harbor office for a week. My aunt's drivers talk and I listen." She meets my eyes. "I didn't know it would be Jun. If that matters."

It matters. It also doesn't change anything. I nod once, because that is what I have left that isn't a sentence with weight on it.

In the evening Mira goes down to ask Orii about the bus toward Ishibashi. I go out the back for air and find the alley opens onto a square with a stone well at the center – low wall, iron crank, a line of travelers filling bottles before the next walk. A man in a gray-green shirt with no rank tabs stands beside it with a folding stool and a notebook, checking bags as people come up. It isn't a full checkpoint, just the town's clipboard habit without the trucks.

I should go back upstairs, but I don't. My bottle is empty, and my throat is still wrong, and the well is right there.

I get in the short line behind an old woman with a market bag and a boy my age with a satchel. The gray-green man opens the satchel, thumbs through it, stamps a slip, and waves the boy on like he has done this a hundred times today and expects nothing from the hundred-and-first.

Then it's my turn.

"Bag," he says.

I hold it out. Empty. He looks at the empty and then at my face, and something in his eyes shifts – not recognition, interest. The interest of a man who has been told to watch for coast dust and scraped voices and boys who arrived without a bus.

"Where from?"

"Nagihama road."

"Papers."

I don't have papers. Mira is downstairs. Orii's ceiling is not a stamp.

"I lost them on the ridge," I say.

He doesn't buy it. His hand goes to the radio on his belt – not lifting it yet, just resting there – and he says, mild as a clerk, "You'll wait by the shade cloth. Secondary. Routine."

Same word they used on Jun at the pier. Same waiting to the side until somebody with a better clipboard decides.

Something rises in me before I have chosen anything. I am so tired of being parked.

Under the well's crank noise, aimed at the man with the notebook:

"Look the other way. You never saw me."

The copper comes up hard. My nose prickles. The man's eyes go loose for half a second – radio hunting stations – and then he turns his head toward the depot, exactly as told, and his hand leaves the radio, and I walk past the well with my empty bottle and my bleeding lip and nobody stops me.

Behind me I hear him say to the next person, a little confused, "Bag. Come on, I haven't got all evening."

I don't look back. I fill the bottle from the public tap on the alley wall instead, hands shaking, and go upstairs the long way so Mira won't see the blood until I've wiped it.

She sees it anyway. Cloth out, thumb under my chin, the same move as the pier.

"Who," she says. Not what. She already knows what.

"The well. He was checking bags, and he wanted me for secondary."

"And you told him to look away."

"I told him he never saw me."

She holds the cloth there a second longer than the blood needs. Her face

stays level – reading weather that hasn't arrived yet.

"That leaves a mark," she says. "Not on paper. On people. Someone at that well is going to tell a story about a boy whose mouth made a clipboard man forget his job." She lowers the cloth. "We leave at first light for Ishibashi. Before the story grows legs."

"Oarii said one night. Maybe two."

"One night. Then we go." Mira packs the sack while she talks – already deciding for both of us. "You used it in a town that still has buses. That's different from a shed. Different from a shrine yard with six hundred witnesses who will swear they saw smoke. Here it's quiet enough to remember."

I sit on the mat and try to feel sorry. The sorry is there. Under it, smaller, is the same lift I felt on the pier when the soldier's eyes went loose – a hand finding a grip – and I hate that it is still there after Jun, after the soldier under his own jaw, after Haru's open mouth in the gateway.

Mira ties the sack shut.

"Sleep," she says. "Tomorrow we walk again. And Kaito – next time a clipboard asks for paper, you let me talk first. Your mouth is what they're hunting. Mine is just a girl's."

She says it like logistics. I nod like logistics. Outside the window the well square is still busy – bottles, crank, somebody laughing at a joke I can't hear. I lie down and make myself stop listening to it.

Chapter 12 – Bus Fare

Orii is already at the counter when we come down. She points at a stack of rice sacks by the door without looking up from her pencil.

"Haul those to the back before you leave. Then you're paid up."

We haul. Mira takes the rhythm of it; I take the weight. My nose has stopped bleeding. My throat still feels scraped. When the last sack is stacked Orii sets two onigiri on the counter and a folded paper with a bus time written on it in the same blunt hand as her inventory.

"Ishibashi run leaves at nine from the depot if it hasn't been requisitioned," she says. "If it has, you walk – same road, only dustier." She looks at Mira, not me. "Your cousin should keep his head down at the ticket window. Clipboards have been asking about mouths since yesterday."

Mira bows like a coast girl who knows how to leave a debt clean. "Thank you."

Orii has already gone back to her pencil. We take the onigiri and go.

The bus is still there. Gray, rattling, half full of people who look like they have been moving west for weeks. Mira buys two tickets with money from the bottom of the sack – I see how thin the fold is when she opens it – and we sit near the back with our bags at our feet.

Nobody asks where we are from. The war app buzzes once in somebody's pocket and everybody pretends not to hear it. Through the window Kuroishi slides away: blackened shrine gate, well square, Orii's awning.

Mira leans her head against the glass and closes her eyes – resting, not sleeping. I watch the road go by and keep my mouth shut.

An hour in, a pair of soldiers works the aisle from the front, checking tickets and faces. The woman across from us hands hers over with a smile that

costs her. When they get to us Mira has both tickets ready and a story about cousins and a family errand already shaped in her mouth.

"Ishibashi," she says. "Our aunt's people are expecting us."

The taller one takes the tickets and does not stamp them. He looks at me longer than he looked at her – at the dust on my knees, at a boy who doesn't smile when smiled at. Then back to Mira.

"Your aunt's people. Which house?"

It is a small question. It is exactly the size of question that sinks people.

"Off the bridge square. The Moris – they take in mending." She says it with the mild boredom of a girl who has answered for her family a hundred times. "If they're not at the house, they're at the stall."

"There's a mending stall on the bridge square?" He says it half to the bus, almost friendly. Behind us a seat creaks, and an old man's voice arrives, helpful, terrible: "Square's all fish these days. Mending would be new."

The soldier's eyes come back to Mira. The whole bus is very interested in its windows.

"New since spring," Mira says, unhurried. "Half of everything is new since spring – that's why they need hands." She lets one breath of annoyance show, exactly one. "You're welcome to walk us there off the bus. My aunt will feed you for the trouble, but she'll also tell you about her knees, and that costs an afternoon."

It is good. It might even have been enough. But he is still holding the tickets, and now he tips his chin at me.

"You," he says, mild. "Say something."

Mira's shoulder touches mine – not a shove, a reminder that she talks first. Except he asked me, in front of the whole bus, and he's shy only works on a man who hasn't dug in.

The sentence is already there, assembled before I ask for it – Stamp the tickets and move on – four words, clean, no exits. I make my mouth do the harder thing instead.

"We're going for the work," I say. My voice comes out the way it comes out

these days. His eyebrows move at the scrape of it. "Sir."

"What happened to your voice?"

"Fever in the spring." The lie Mira built for me, ordinary in my own mouth for the first time. "It never came back right."

He looks at me for a long beat with the bus jolting under all of us. Then he stamps both tickets and moves on, and the old man behind us tells his window that mending is a good trade after all, as if he had been on our side the whole time.

Mira does not let her breath out until the pair reaches the front. She doesn't say anything either. She just passes me the water like it's about the heat, and I drink, and my pulse comes down slow off the sentence I didn't say.

I keep my mouth shut the rest of the way to Ishibashi.

Ishibashi is a stone bridge over a nearly dry riverbed and a market tucked under the arches – squid oil, hot stone, diesel from a truck idling where the bus lets us off. The FDC presence is thin paper theater: a desk under a tarp, a woman stamping day-passes, nobody with a rifle in a hurry.

Mira counts the money left in the sack while we stand in the shade of the bridge.

"Enough for food today," she says. "Not enough for the Takamatsu bus and a roof."

"How far is Takamatsu on foot?"

"Two days if we push. Three if we don't." She looks at the market. "Or we earn the fare here and ride tomorrow."

"Earn how?"

"Same way coast people always earn." She tips her chin at the stalls under the arches – crates, ice, a man shouting for hands to unload a truck. "You have a back. I have a face people trust. We don't use anything else."

The anything else sits between us. She is not asking. She is drawing a line I already know and making sure I hear it in daylight.

"I talk first," I say.

"You haul first. Talking is my job until your voice stops sounding like a wanted poster."

The truck man is thick through the middle and red from the sun. I haul crates for him until sundown and he pays in cash – not much, but enough to put the Takamatsu fare back in the sack. My shoulders burn the useful way. Once he asks where I'm from. I say west, and he laughs like that counts as an answer, then goes back to his count.

Mira spent the afternoon on trays at a squid stall. She comes back with grease on her wrists and the one thing worth knowing: a boy who runs errands for the depot says the Takamatsu bus still leaves at dawn if nobody has requisitioned it overnight. She starts to tell me who else she talked to – a stall woman, a clerk near the stamps – and stops when she sees I'm only listening for the bus.

At the edge of the market she buys two bowls of something hot with the truck money, and we eat under the bridge where the arches keep the wind off. While we eat she counts what is left in the sack against the fare and the stamps.

"So we sleep near the arches," Mira says. "Cheaper than a room, but cold. Up before the bus if we want seats."

"How long to Takamatsu from here?"

"Half a day if the bus isn't stopped. Longer if they hold the road." She taps the sack. "We've got fare and almost nothing else. Once we're there we need work the first afternoon, or we're eating stamps."

"What kind of work?"

"Yards. Markets. Whatever doesn't ask for a family register." She looks at me over the bowl. "And you keep your head down at the window. If they ask you to talk, I talk. Same as the bus today."

A man from the ice truck walks past with a crate, recognizes me from the unload, and slows. "You heading out already? We could use you again tomorrow – same rate, maybe better if the squid boat comes in."

I almost say something ordinary. In Nagihama I would have. Here I just nod once and look at my bowl until he shrugs and moves on.

Mira watches him go. "He was offering money."

"We've got enough for the tickets."

"Enough for tickets isn't the same as enough for a week." She says it without heat, then softer: "You used to learn people's names by supper. That one had a face you could have used tomorrow if the bus got canceled."

"If the bus gets canceled, we walk."

"We walk," she agrees, and does not push the name. She finishes her bowl, wipes her wrists on her skirt, and stands. "We sleep under the arches tonight and get to the depot before first light. If they stamp us through, Takamatsu by afternoon – and then we find a roof that doesn't care where west is."

"And if they don't stamp us?"

"Then we find another road." She tips her chin at the sack. "Come on. Cold's easier if we claim a dry spot before the market empties."

We claim a dry strip under the arches before the market empties and sleep with the sack between us. Cold comes up through the stone. Nobody asks our names.

Before first light Mira shakes my shoulder. Yesterday's pay is still counted into two tickets' worth and a little food. The dawn bus is on the board. At the window she buys both seats to Takamatsu, the clerk stamps the slips without looking up twice, and we climb on. No aisle soldiers this time. Just market people, a radio playing something bright, and the road starting to climb.

For the first hour we don't talk. Then Mira does, quiet enough that the seat ahead can't use it.

"Once we're in, the aunt story dies," she says. "It nearly died yesterday over a mending stall. Cities ask for addresses. If we give them one that isn't real, somebody checks it by supper."

"So what do we say?"

"As little as possible. We don't go through Station Plaza if we can help it – that place is full of gray-greens. We get off with the yard workers and walk east. East Yards hire by the day and don't care whose cousin you are as long as you can lift."

"You've been there?"

"I've heard enough to not get us arrested the first afternoon." She tips the sack with her foot. "We've got almost nothing left after the tickets. Work before dark, or we're sleeping in a ditch with bigger rats than Ishibashi's."

I watch the hills go by. "And if they ask me to talk?"

"Then you talk like a boy who wants a wage, not a boy who wants an argument." She glances at my mouth, then away. "Ordinary words. Nothing under them. Same rule as the crates."

"I know the rule."

"Knowing it and keeping it when a clipboard leans in are different jobs." She says it without heat. "You're getting better at being quiet. Don't get clever with the other thing because the quiet feels small."

I almost tell her the quiet is the only thing that has felt like mine since the shrine yard. I don't. The bus hits a patch of bad road and the whole cabin rattles, and when it settles she is looking at the window again.

"Why Takamatsu?" I ask. "Not the next town. Not farther west."

"Because it's big enough to get lost in and still find work." She is quiet a moment. "And because the road west of it gets thinner, and thin roads have fewer places to put a boy who can't go home."

That is as much answer as she gives and I let it stand.

Late afternoon the land opens. Takamatsu comes up under us – harbor cranes, smokestacks, streets running until they blur, wet neon even in daylight, fry oil and pine and brake-squeal. Nobody on the bus looks impressed. They have been moving toward this for weeks.

We get off with the yard shift at a stop before Station Plaza – Mira's hand on my sleeve once, already steering. Behind us the main depot is a mess of cones and waiting people. Ahead, East Yards: chain-link, diesel, men shouting for hands before the afternoon load leaves.

"There," Mira says. "Ask for day work. I'll find us a roof that takes cash and doesn't keep a register book."

"Split up?"

"For an hour. Meet back at that water tower when the whistle blows." She

nods at a rusted tower over the yards. "If I'm late, wait. If you're late, I come looking – and I don't want to come looking because your mouth got bored."

"It won't."

"Good." She almost smiles. It doesn't reach her eyes. "Water tower when the whistle blows. Go."

A foreman at the gate is already shouting for hands that can lift without asking questions. I put my name nowhere and take a place in the line before someone else takes it first.

Chapter 13 – One Day Behind

Kuroishi is supposed to be where I catch him.

I know it isn't before I clear the last bend – no bus idling at the depot end, no cart dust hanging over the road, nobody walking ahead of me. Dust and scrub for hours behind me, a water tower rising and falling until I stop believing in it, then a town at the bottom of the tip – blackened shrine gate at one end, bus depot at the other, the smell of hot asphalt and croquette oil and copy paper from an open office door. Sato's transit chit rides dry inside my jacket. Sugi's last onigiri is gone by noon. The sentence I have been carrying since a vending-machine light outside Kōgetsu is still unfinished in my mouth, and every kilometer since Nagihama has been the same argument: I am late, and late is how I lose him.

At the edge of town a pair stops me under a shade cloth – polite, tired, already halfway through the next stamp. The older one holds out a hand for papers without looking up from the previous boy.

"Purpose," he says.

"Family errand. Locating a cousin's household inland. Displaced since the coast registration week." I hand over Sato's chit with my shoulders down, and he stamps me through while he is still reading the work reference. His partner glances at my boots, then at the road behind me, and waves me on before I have finished thanking them.

I walk into Kuroishi with the stamp still wet and go in through the shrine end so I don't hit the depot first. Nobody runs. Nobody smiles much. A boy my age wheels a cart of empty bottles past me – the town has already decided I am ordinary, which is useful at a shade cloth and useless for catching anyone.

I ask at the first open door that looks like it feeds people – a dried-goods shop between a shuttered tool place and secondhand boots, a bell over the

door, dust hanging in the light. The woman behind the counter does not look up until she has finished counting a stack of tea boxes.

She is middle-aged, hair pinned flat, in an apron the color of old paper, and she lifts her eyes the way Orihara used to lift them when a customer cut into her counting: as if the interruption were the rude part, not the war.

"We're closed for lodging," she says.

"I'm not lodging." I keep the same quiet I used at the shade cloth – the uniform Sato gave me, the ordinary tone. "I'm looking for my cousin. He came through yesterday, maybe the day before – tall, dust on him from the road, voice that sounds scraped. There was a girl with him. She probably did most of the talking."

She looks at me for a long time, measuring.

"You're late," she says.

The words land harder than they should. "How late?"

She doesn't answer that. She looks at the stack of tea boxes, then at the storeroom door, then back at me, and names a price without calling it one.

"There's stock in the back that wants moving and a back here that doesn't. You're built like your cousin. Haul it, and I'll tell you what I remember while you work."

So I haul – tea, then rice, then a crate of soap that has no business weighing what it weighs – and she counts boxes and talks, to the shelves as much as to me.

"They hauled stock this morning, same as you're doing now, and took the Ishibashi bus at nine, if it ran. If it didn't, same road, only dustier. Either way they're ahead of you."

"Did he look all right?"

"He looked like a boy who had walked out of something and hadn't decided what to call it." She says it flat, not unkind. "The girl paid in work. He kept his mouth shut in my shop, which I appreciated." She goes back to her tea boxes. Then, without looking up: "Your cousin should keep his head down. Clipboards have been asking about mouths since the night before last."

"What do you mean, mouths?"

"Ask at the well if you want gossip. I sell rice."

"What did the clipboards ask, exactly?"

She snorts once. "Whether anyone had heard a boy talk strangely. Whether anyone had paid posted price without arguing. Whether a coast voice had made someone do a thing they wouldn't have done. The kind of questions that make shopkeepers close early." She taps the pencil against the counter. "I told them the same thing I'm telling you: I sell rice. Now can I get back to my boxes?"

"Can I buy water first?"

She points at a jug by the door without charging me. I fill my bottle. I thank her. She does not give me her name. I do not ask. On the way out I try once more: "The girl who paid in work – did she say where they were headed after Ishibashi?"

"Takamatsu, if the bus kept its schedule. That is all I know, and it is more than I should have said." The bell rings behind me. The street heat hits like a second stamp.

The well sits in a square off the main street – low stone wall, iron crank, a folding stool empty beside it. An old woman filling a bottle from the public tap on the alley wall watches me stop and decides I look harmless enough to talk to.

"You're looking for the stool man," she says. Not a question.

"I'm looking for whoever was here yesterday."

"Then you're looking for the stool man." She corks the bottle and makes no move to leave. "And I'm an old woman who hauls water twice a day on wrists that are done being brave about it. Take the crank a while and I'll talk."

I take the crank. She sits on the well wall and pays me in the town's favorite story.

"He's at the depot today. Won't come back to the well. Something went wrong with his head. One minute he's checking bags like always. Next minute he's staring at the depot like somebody moved the town, and a boy walks past with an empty bottle and blood on his lip, and the stool man doesn't see him. Then

he asks the next person for their bag as if nothing happened. He's been telling that story to anyone who'll listen. Half of them think heat. Half of them think the boy said something."

"What kind of something?"

She shrugs. "The kind that makes a clipboard forget his job. We've had coast boys through here before. None of them did that." She looks at my face, then at the dust on my boots. "You related to him?"

"Yes."

"Then walk faster. Stories grow legs in this town, and the depot has ears."

A younger man waiting for the crank has been listening. He adds, helpful and wrong at least once: "I heard the boy told him to go home. Or look away. Something like that. The stool man won't say the words – says he can't remember them clean. And my brother-in-law swears the same boy bought two tickets east the next morning. Coast people always go back east. Can't help themselves."

East is a burned coast and a sealed word on the radio. Either his brother-in-law saw a different boy, or the shop woman watched a ghost haul her stock and board west. One of these people counted a morning's work at arm's length; the other one has a brother-in-law.

"Did anyone see a girl with him?" I ask.

The old woman shakes her head. "Not at the well. He came alone with an empty bottle. If there was a girl, she wasn't in the square." She picks up her bottle. "If you're going to the depot, don't ask the stool man to repeat it. He's had enough faces leaning in."

I fill my bottle at the tap. My hands stay steady while a stranger describes my best friend's mouth like weather. That steadiness frightens me more than shaking would have.

I walk toward the depot as far as the shade cloth, close enough to see the buses and the pairs and the stool man from the well now sitting under a different awning with his notebook shut in his lap. He looks ordinary. Tired. A man who lost half a minute and cannot get it back. A soldier asks a woman

with a crate to open it; she does; he stamps her; the line moves. Ordinary paper theater, and still my stomach turns at the thought of standing in it with Sato's chit after what I just heard.

I could buy a ticket. Sato's paper would get me one. A ticket would put me on a bus where soldiers ask you to say something, and I have just spent an hour learning that Kaito's trail is a trail of people who heard him and went strange.

I turn around before anyone at the depot looks at me twice.

At the croquette cart by the shrine gate I spend the last of Sugi's vegetable money. The woman wraps it in paper and asks if I want the bus schedule; I tell her I'm walking, and she looks at me like that is a stupid choice and a free one, which is fair. A delivery boy on a bicycle slows and asks if I need the depot; I tell him I already know where it is, and he pedals on.

I eat standing under the gate, looking west along the road the shop woman pointed at, and count what I still have: Sato's chit, half a bottle, and enough afternoon light to put kilometers behind me before dark. If the crank man's brother-in-law is right, I am about to spend two days walking the wrong way. But nobody hauls rice all morning to buy a ticket back into the fire, and the shop woman counted their work with her own eyes. I believe the woman who charged me.

I put the croquette paper in a bin. I check Sato's chit once, inside the jacket, and start walking west before the afternoon heat finishes climbing. The first kilometer out of town is still asphalt. The second breaks at the edges. A truck headed coast-bound lifts two fingers off the wheel without slowing; I lift mine back.

A woman selling water from a roadside cooler calls out the price. I have almost nothing left after the croquette, so I shake my head. She shrugs and goes back to her shade.

The board at the last fork says Ishibashi – fourteen kilometers. Fourteen more between me and the last people who saw him. I take the first step and keep taking them.

Chapter 14 – Soft Boy

The road between Kuroishi and Ishibashi runs straight through open hills, and the sun has owned every step of it since morning.

By mid-afternoon my shirt sticks to my back and Sato's paper feels like a second skin under the jacket. Hills on both sides, scrub, a dry ditch running parallel to the asphalt. Two trucks have passed me all day. Neither stopped. I walk on the shoulder and keep my eyes on the heat shimmer where the road disappears, because looking down makes the distance worse.

A roadside board says Ishibashi 14 km in paint that has half peeled off. Fourteen kilometers between me and the next chance of catching them. I am still walking that off when I hear boots on gravel behind the ditch.

Three of them. Not gray-green. Local jackets, work boots, the kind of thin that has decided the road owes them a living. The tallest has a length of pipe. The middle one a knife he is not hiding well. The third hangs back with his hands in his pockets, watching the road both ways.

I stop. Hands open. Politeness comes up before I have decided to use it – the uniform, the thing that has been working on gates and gray suits and grieving mothers.

"I don't have much," I say. "You're welcome to the food money. I'm just walking through."

The tall one grins. "He's polite. I like polite."

"Take what's in the pocket and I'll keep walking. Nobody has to get hurt over a coast boy with empty hands."

The watcher laughs from the ditch bank. "Empty hands still have stamps, polite boy."

"I mean it," I say, quieter. "Take the yen. Leave the paper. I need the paper to—"

The pipe man steps in and hits me in the ribs before the sentence finishes.

Geography, then, because manners do not rearrange this.

Road on my left. Ditch on my right, knee-deep, dry weeds. Hills too far to run for. The knife man is between me and Ishibashi. The watcher owns the way back to Kuroishi. The pipe man is in my face, close enough that I smell onions on his breath and the cheap metal of the pipe where it scraped my side.

I go down on one knee. Air gone. I try the polite line again anyway – “You don’t want to do this, there’s nothing on me worth–” – and the knife man laughs and kicks my shoulder, not hard, just enough to put me in the dust.

“Empty the jacket,” the pipe man says.

I empty it. Sato’s chit comes out with the yen. The pipe man takes both. He looks at the stamps the way hungry people look at stamps – as if paper might turn into rice if you stare hard enough – and then he puts the chit in his own pocket and the yen in the knife man’s hand.

“That’s my transit–” My voice cracks on it, stupid and necessary in equal parts. “I need that to get through the next desk. You can keep the money. Give me the chit back and I walk away and forget your faces.”

The pipe man considers it for half a second, which is almost hope, and then he shakes his head. “Paper’s worth more than your manners.”

The pipe comes up again. I get an arm up. The blow turns my forearm numb and knocks me sideways into the ditch weeds. Dust in my mouth. The watcher calls something about a truck coming and the knife man glances west, and that half-second is the only door I get, so I take it – scramble up the ditch bank, shoulder into the pipe man’s stomach, and we go down together on the asphalt.

He is heavier. He rolls me. Fist in my ear. The world rings. I get a knee up between us and shove; he grunts and loses the pipe for a second; I grab for it and miss; the knife man is coming in from the side, blade low, and I am still trying to find a sentence that will make three grown men put their hands down when a fourth set of boots hits the road from the scrub above the ditch.

The new one is seventeen, maybe – lean-hard, messy dark hair tied back with a

scrap of cloth, cheap work jacket, boots that have walked more than they have been cleaned. He does not announce himself. He takes the knife man's wrist, turns it until the blade drops, and puts an elbow into the man's throat hard enough that the sound cuts off mid-curse.

The pipe man scrambles up off me. Swings. The new boy ducks under it, steps inside, and hits him twice in the body – short, ugly, the kind of hits that are for ending things, not for looking brave. The pipe clatters. The watcher starts forward, sees the knife on the asphalt and the pipe man on his knees, and decides the road has nothing for him today. He runs east. The knife man follows, coughing. The pipe man gets up slower, looks at the new boy once, and goes after them without the pipe and without my chit.

I am still on the asphalt with dust in my teeth and Sato's paper half a kilometer gone in a stranger's pocket.

The new boy picks up the pipe, weighs it, and tosses it into the ditch. Then he looks down at me. Crooked front tooth when he grins. Scraped knuckles as default. He clicks his tongue once, the way some people check a tool before they use it.

"Soft boy," he says. "You walk like the road owes you manners."

I sit up, ribs complaining, one ear still ringing. "Thank you. I – they took my paper. My transit chit. I need–"

"I saw." He offers a hand. I take it. He hauls me up by the collar as much as by the arm, sets me on my feet, and steadies me with one finger on my chest until I stop swaying. "You tried to talk them out of a pipe. That's a skill – wrong skill, wrong audience."

"I don't fight."

"I noticed." He glances west, then east, then at my face. "Nakahara Riku. You can pay me back by not dying on my stretch of road before sundown. What's your name?"

"Aoyama Haruki." The full name comes out because he gave me his, and because manners are the only weapon I have left that still works on people who aren't holding pipes. "I'm going to Ishibashi."

"Everybody's going to Ishibashi until they aren't." He tips his chin at my ribs. "Can you walk?"

"Yes."

"Prove it."

I walk. It hurts. It works. He falls in beside me without asking if I want company, hands in his jacket pockets, eyes on the hills the way Kaito used to watch rooms – exits first, conversation second.

We make a kilometer before he talks again.

"Those three work the ditch after the second bend," Riku says. "I usually clear them on Tuesdays. Today is not Tuesday. You're welcome."

"I can pay you when I–"

"You can't. They took your yen and your stamps." He says it without heat. "So you owe me a favor instead. I hate favors less than I hate watching polite boys get their ribs rearranged for free."

"What kind of favor?"

"Haven't decided. Something useful. Or funny. Or both." He glances sideways. "You always apologize to people holding pipes, or was today special?"

"I apologize to situations."

He laughs with his whole face – short, bright, gone. "Yeah. That tracks."

The heat shimmer ahead resolves into the first low roofs of something that might be Ishibashi if we keep walking. My ear has stopped ringing. My forearm is going to bruise the color of the pipe. Sato's chit is gone, and with it the clerk-shaped reason for my walking.

"How do I get through a desk without stamps?" I ask.

Riku shrugs. "You don't, if the desk is hungry. You go around, or you work for someone who already has paper, or you look like you belong under a bridge until the hungry desks go home." He kicks a stone off the asphalt. "Ishibashi has arches that don't ask. Takamatsu's worse. Bigger desks."

"You've been to Takamatsu?"

"I've been through Takamatsu. Being to a place means you had a reason to stay." He looks at me properly for the first time since the fight – not the ribs, the face. "Why help, you're about to ask. Bored, mostly. Spite covers

the rest. You looked like someone who might survive a Tuesday if somebody shoved him upright first. Also you didn't cry. Soft boys who don't cry after a pipe are either stupid or walking toward something. I stick with the second kind. They're rarer."

"I'm walking toward a person."

"Even better. People are harder to catch than towns." He tips his chin west. "Ishibashi by dark if your ribs behave. I know a place under the arches that doesn't ask for stamps. You can tell me about your person when you're not bleeding on my jacket."

"I'm not bleeding on your jacket."

"Yet." He grins the crooked tooth at me again. "Cousin, brother, or a debt?"

"Cousin," I say, because that is the story the road already knows, and because the true word is heavier than my ribs can carry right now. "Tall. Scraped voice. There was a girl doing the talking. They took the bus from Kuroishi this morning, if it ran."

Riku clicks his tongue. "Then you're a day behind a bus, and you just lost the paper that would have put you on the next one. Lucky I like hopeless errands." He nods at the roofs. "We'll get under the arches before full dark. The market's still open at that hour – ask there tonight. Markets remember food money better than faces."

"And the favor."

"I'll invent it when I need it. Walk, Aoyama. Your ribs are slowing the schedule."

I walk. West again, with Nakahara Riku half a step ahead, already picking the dry side of the ditch.

We reach Ishibashi at dusk and Riku moves through it like a man checking his own house: a nod to a boy stacking crates, a wide berth around the tarp desk where a woman is closing her stamp box for the night. Nobody stops us. Nobody asks me to say anything.

He parks me at the busiest food stall – squid on skewers, a woman with grease to her elbows shouting an order back into the smoke – and says,

quietly, "Her. She sees every face that eats here twice."

I wait until she hands off her skewers. "I'm looking for my cousin. He came through yesterday heading west, with a girl who'd have offered to work for the food instead of paying for it. Anyone like that eat here?"

Her face turns it over before she answers. "The quiet one and the girl who worked my trays. You know them?"

"I'm trying to catch up."

"Then you're chasing the wrong end of the day." She wipes her hands and points her chin at the depot end of the arches. "She carried for me all yesterday afternoon, good worker, and this morning the two of them were at the dawn window for Takamatsu. The boy didn't talk. She talked enough for both of them." She looks at my dusty knees, at the bruise coming up my forearm. "Bus left at first light. You want a skewer or not."

First light. While I was still on the Kuroishi road, they were already at the ticket window. Half a day. I have no chit and no yen, and the depot at the end of the arches is closing its stamp box for the night.

Riku buys two skewers without asking the price out loud – the woman just marks something on a scrap by the grill – and shoves one into my hand.

"Eat while it's hot. Cold squid is an insult."

I eat – grease and salt and too much chili – and my ribs complain when I breathe in.

"Takamatsu's a day by truck if the driver's in a hurry," Riku says. "I know a man who runs ice west twice a week. He takes hands instead of papers when he's short. He'll be short tomorrow if I lean on him."

"What do I owe you for that?"

"The favor you already owe me. Don't stack a second one until you've paid the first." He licks chili off his thumb. "We sleep under the arches. Before dawn we walk to the ice yard behind the depot. You keep your mouth useful for thanking the driver and nothing else. Clear?"

"Clear."

"Good." He tips his chin at a dry strip of stone under the bridge where someone's already laid out cardboard. "Claim a spot before the market boys

take the dry ones. I'm not sharing a puddle with you on principle."

I claim one. Above us the arches are black stone, older than any desk in this town, and somewhere past them sits the shuttered window that sold two dawn tickets to Takamatsu. One day behind. I put my back against the stone and stay facing west.

Chapter 15 – Hands, Not Papers

Riku shakes me off the cardboard while the arches are still black, and we walk the length of the market with our breath showing, past shuttered stalls and a cat that owns the whole street at this hour. Behind the depot there's a gravel lot with a corrugated shed, two trucks, and a man in a rubber apron sliding blocks of ice down a wooden ramp like he's angry at each one personally.

Riku lifts a hand. "Boss. You're short today."

The driver doesn't stop working. "Who told you that?"

"You did, last week, when you were complaining about it." Riku hooks a thumb at me. "There's two of us. We load here, we ride quiet and we unload in Takamatsu."

The driver straightens up and looks at me the way men look at secondhand tools. He takes in the bruise on my forearm, the road on my boots, and the fact that I'm standing still instead of explaining myself.

"Is he broken?"

"Bruised," Riku says. "Bruised lifts fine. You pay him the coins. Me you owe a beer, because I'm the one who found you two hands on a short day."

"Then start lifting."

That's the whole interview. No name asked, no paper wanted. I get my hands under a block and my spine understands immediately why the driver is built like a door. The blocks ride in sawdust, stacked in a wooden crib down the middle of the bed, and by the time the sky has gone from black to gray, my shirt is soaked through on a cold morning and I've stopped feeling my fingertips.

The driver checks the load, throws two folded tarps at us, and says, "You ride with the ice. Anybody looks in, you're crew. Crew doesn't wave, crew doesn't smile, crew looks bored. Do you think you can look bored?"

"He's a natural at it," Riku says.

We pull out of Ishibashi as the first light comes over the arches, and I watch the bridge and the dry river and the squid stall's cold grill slide away behind the tailgate. Kaito left this town at dawn yesterday. I'm leaving it at dawn today. A day behind then. Still a day behind now.

The bed of an ice truck is its own kind of country. Cold comes off the blocks in a flat, patient wall, the sawdust gets into everything, and the road plays the tailgate chain like an instrument with one note. Riku and I sit wedged between the crib and the side rail with the tarps over our knees, and for the first hour neither of us says anything, because the cold does the talking.

Then Riku digs a strip of dried squid out of his jacket – I don't ask where from – tears it in half, and hands me the bigger piece.

"So," he says. "Takamatsu. Have you been to a real city before?"

"Once, on a school trip. Two days – we saw a castle and a museum, and a boy in my class got lost buying melon bread."

"That's not a city, that's a postcard." He chews, watching the hills go by through the gap in the tarp. "A city is a machine for not knowing people. Nobody in Takamatsu is going to remember your face, your cousin's face, or the face of the man who robbed them last Tuesday. That's the bad news."

"What's the good news?"

"It's the same sentence." He grins, the crooked tooth showing. "Nobody's going to remember your face either. A boy with no papers can live a long time in a place like that if he's useful and quiet. You're quiet. We'll work on useful."

The truck drops into a lower gear for a climb. Somewhere under us the ice shifts and settles, and meltwater finds a seam in the boards and starts drawing a thin line toward the tailgate.

"Say you catch him," Riku says.

"Who?"

"Your cousin. Say tomorrow you turn a corner and there he is. What happens then? You grab his sleeve, and then what – you walk him home? He left on

purpose, from the sound of it. People who leave on purpose don't come back because somebody chased them well."

The dried squid goes to sawdust in my mouth. It's the exact question I have been walking around since Nagihama, the way you walk around a hole in a dark room because you know the floor stops there. Bring him back. The plan has three words and I have never once finished it past the second.

"I have something to say to him," I say. "I started saying it in a gateway and didn't get to finish. That's all I know. When it's finished, I'll find out what happens then."

Riku looks at me for a while. Whatever he's weighing, he doesn't say it. He clicks his tongue once and pulls the tarp higher.

"Long way to ride for a sentence," he says. "Better be a good one."

The city announces itself before we can see it – the road widens, gets honest asphalt again, grows painted lines. Traffic thickens around us: carts, two buses, a convoy of gray-green trucks that Riku watches without moving his head. Then the ridge opens and Takamatsu is just there, the way the sea is just there, too big to have edges – harbor cranes, smokestacks, an elevated rail line stitching across the rooftops, streets running back into haze in every direction I look.

At the city edge there are cones, a swing barrier, and soldiers with a lamp even though it's daylight.

The truck slows. I hear the driver's window crank down, hear a bored voice ask for the load sheet. Boots crunch down the length of the bed. The tarp lifts at the tailgate and a young soldier looks in at two boys gray with sawdust sitting against a crib of ice.

"How many hands?" he says, to the driver, not to us.

"Two, plus me. It's on the sheet." The driver's voice comes back flat as his ramp. "And that ice was cut yesterday, so unless the army's buying it melted, we can count faster."

The soldier looks at me a beat longer than I'd like. I look at the ice the way crew looks at ice – bored, put-upon, a boy who has done this run all

season and would rather be asleep. The tarp drops. The barrier swings open.

Riku exhales through his nose, not quite a laugh. "Congratulations," he says quietly. "You're an ice man. Ice men are invisible."

North Market takes the truck in whole.

I have never seen anything like it – a roofed street and then another roofed street crossing it, stalls three deep, fish on shaved ice that we are apparently here to replace, a noise that isn't one noise but a thousand negotiations happening at once. We unload into cellar hatches and cold boxes for two hours, and men take delivery of the blocks without ever really seeing us, and I begin to understand what Riku meant about the machine.

The driver pays me in coins, counting them twice into my palm so we both see the number, and tells Riku he runs again Friday. Then he's gone, and I'm standing in the middle of the largest crowd of my life with wet boots and money I earned with my back.

I try asking if someone has seen him once, because not trying isn't in me. There's a tea seller at the mouth of the roofed street, old enough to have seen everything twice, with a queue that never quite dies. I buy a cup with the driver's coins and drink it standing at the end of her boards, and when the queue thins I ask whether two people off the coast buses came through yesterday – a tall quiet one, and a girl who worked trays for food in Ishibashi.

"Came through doing what – buying tea?" She doesn't pause her pour. "Half the coast has walked through this market in the last month. Burned out, registered out, walked out. Faces don't keep here."

"They'd have been hungry. Somebody sold them a first meal."

"Somebody sells everyone their first meal. That's the whole city." She hands a customer his change and takes my empty cup back, which means we're done. Then, because I have paid and I am still standing there and the queue has died properly: "You want to find one person in Takamatsu, stop asking markets. Find what he has to keep going back to – work, food, sleep – and stand near it. Now move along, you're blocking a paying man's elbow."

It lands like the shop woman in Kuroishi and the squid woman in Ishibashi,

except in those towns the trail was a day old and warm. Here it walked into eight hundred streets of strangers. I put the coins away and find Riku leaning on a pillar, watching me learn it.

"Cold trail?" he says.

"Ice cold."

"Then we do it the way the tea lady said, which is the way I was going to say. You get work, you get fed, you get a roof, and you let the city bring the faces past you instead of chasing them down eight hundred streets." He pushes off the pillar. "Which brings us to tonight. Come on. There's a place."

The place is two wards back from the market, down a street where the shops get narrower and more honest – a tool sharpener, a mender, a public bath exhaling steam. At the end of it hangs a rope curtain and a wooden sign with one word burned into it: MINATO. Riku pulls me inside with him.

Inside is one long counter, a shelf of bottles, steam, and a radio talking quietly to itself in the corner. An old man sits at the far end with a beer he doesn't seem to be drinking. Behind the counter stands a broad-shouldered woman, fifty-something, bun speared with a chopstick, forearms like she has carried heavier things than kegs. She looks up when the curtain moves, and her eyes go over Riku, then me.

She doesn't say welcome. She ladles two bowls of oden and sets them on the counter before either of us has touched a stool.

Riku raises an eyebrow at her. "We haven't ordered yet."

"Trouble eats standing up," she says. "That's how I know. Sit down before you fall down."

We sit. The broth is hot all the way down, the first food since Ishibashi that didn't come off a skewer, and I have to concentrate on not making a sound about it. The woman goes back to her pots without another word, and it's the old man at the end of the counter who speaks next.

"Road-bruised, the pair of them, and thin with it," he says to nobody, or to the beer. Then, to us: "Where are you guys from?"

"East," Riku says.

"That's a report, not an answer." The old man turns on his stool with a creak that might be the stool and might be him. Ginger-root hands, a cardigan despite the steam. "Forty years I drove trams in this city. I can tell a ward by how a man says its name. You two aren't from any ward. So: east." He lets the word sit there, unimpressed.

"Rules of the house," the woman says from the pots, without turning. "Nobody in here is from anywhere. Everybody in here is from before. Gorō knows the rule, he just likes hearing himself lay the trap."

"Gorō," the old man agrees, pointing at his own chest, as if the introduction had been on his schedule all along. "And since the mama has spoiled the game, I'll give you something instead of taking it. You unloaded ice at North Market – I can smell the sawdust. The casual line there dies at sundown. Anyone who tells you there's evening work at the market is selling you a walk. Evening work in this city is the docks and the rail sheds, and the rail sheds check papers." He taps the counter once. "One fact. That's the toll for sitting near me. Next one costs you a fact back."

"He's also the best map in Takamatsu," Riku says, "as long as you pay the toll. And he'll tell you about the flood of '02 if you don't watch your feet."

"The flood of '02 is worth telling," Gorō says with dignity, and turns back to his beer.

The woman – Machi, Riku calls her – refills my bowl without asking, which is its own kind of sentence. When the counter empties toward closing, she jerks her chin at a doorway behind the shelf.

"There's a back room with mats. Working boys sleep there sometimes, when they've worked. Did you two work today?"

"Since before dawn," Riku says.

"Then it's yours tonight. Wash the bowls first. Both of you – I've seen his hands, now I want to see yours."

We wash the bowls. The water is hot and my fingers come back to life in it, aching. Through the doorway the back room is narrow and smells of dry rice and clean straw – the first proper roof over me since Sugi's.

Riku claims the mat by the wall on the grounds that he found the place, then lies there with his hands behind his head, looking at the ceiling.

"Tomorrow," he says, "that favor you owe me. I'm calling it."

I stop with my jacket half folded. "Calling it how?"

"There's a man two wards over who needs hands and hates new faces. I vouch for you, you work like you worked today, and you don't make me regret the vouch. You do that, we're square." He yawns. "After that, anything I do for you, I do because I feel like it. Which is worse for you, because I'm moody."

"That's the whole favor? Just work?"

"That's the whole favor. You were expecting a kidney?" He rolls over, away from the lamp. "Sleep, Aoyama. The city starts loud."

"Then call it," I say. "Tomorrow. Vouch me."

He doesn't turn back. "Already did. Don't make me look stupid at dawn."

Chapter 16 – The City That Works

The man who hates new faces is called Tanabe, and he hates mine on sight.

He runs a wholesale cellar off North Market – dry goods, oil, salt in sacks the size of children – and a handcart route that feeds shops in six wards. When Riku brings me in, Tanabe is doing sums at a standing desk, and he looks at me over his glasses the way the ice driver looked at me, except the ice driver decided in one second and Tanabe enjoys taking ten.

“I don’t take boys off the road,” he says. “Boys off the road drop a cart once and vanish owing me a ward’s groceries.”

“He unloaded ice all yesterday morning and washed bowls at Minato last night,” Riku says. “Machi let him sleep in the back. You know what that costs her to allow.”

“Machi feeds strays. I run a business.” Tanabe sets down his pencil. “Give me one reason that isn’t this one vouching for you.”

I could build something. Sato’s careful voice is still in me. But I’m tired of that uniform, and something in me decides that this man with his sums deserves the plain thing.

“I can’t drop the cart and vanish,” I say. “I’m looking for somebody in this city, and the only way I can afford to keep looking is to be worth keeping. You’d be paying me to stay findable.”

Tanabe blinks. Whatever he was lining up to say next doesn’t get said. He looks at me a moment longer, and then the no I could see him building just isn’t there anymore.

“Be here at six sharp,” he says, and goes back to his sums. “Late once and you’re done.”

Outside, Riku gives me a sideways look, half a step longer than it needs to be. “Huh,” he says. “You could sell a wet umbrella.” And that’s all he says about it.

The days find a shape.

Six sharp at the cellar, load by weight so the cart doesn't fight the camber. North Market first while the fish trucks still own the streets, then the long fan outward – the mender's ward, the bath-house street, a noodle row where three shops take the same oil and pretend not to know each other's order. Tanabe pays daily, in coins counted twice, like a man who has been shorted before.

The route teaches me the city faster than a year of wandering would have, and where the route stops, Gorō starts.

He's at Minato most nights, the one beer standing sentry in front of him, and he trades company for geography. He draws me the city on the counter with a wet finger: the wards like wedges around the harbor, the elevated line and where it actually stops rather than where the map says, the three bridges and which one floods, which streets a handcart can take at noon and which ones will get you cursed at in two dialects.

"Forty years on the trams," he says. "I know this city the way you know a person. And like a person, it's been getting sicker. My line got shortened twice – materiel priority, they said, everything up the hill gets the steel first." He says up the hill the way other men say a name they're not speaking. "You'll see. Everything in this city that stops working, stops working from the hill down."

"What's on the hill?"

"Offices," Gorō says, and drinks, which is how I learn that even the free map has one district he won't name.

Work, food, sleep – I stand near all three, the way the tea seller said. On the route I listen at every shop door for a scraped voice. At the market I watch the day-labor lines forming at dawn, rows of backs and caps, and learn how many tall, thin, dark-haired boys one city can hold. There's a registry office two streets off Station Plaza where new arrivals are supposed to declare lodging, and a bus depot with a board listing every arrival from the east, and I don't go inside either one, because desks keep lists, and a boy asking after a boy gets both names written on the same desk. Kaito's trail being cold hurts less than it did in Ishibashi. Cold means no yard has broken sideways with him standing in the middle of it. I tell myself cold is what

careful looks like from the outside, and most days I believe it.

Once, a fish man on the noodle row mentions a coast boy working evening loads at the docks – young, keeps to himself, voice like he gargled the harbor. I take the cart back early and stand where the shift lets out. The boy comes through with the crowd, twenty-five if he's a day, throat wrecked from tar fumes, and the girl who meets him has a baby on her hip.

I walk the long way home with my stomach sitting somewhere under the cobbles. Wrong boy. Next time I hear about a coast voice, I'll go look again.

Thursday, I learn, is a ceremony.

Thursday nights Machi feeds working boys whether they can pay or not – one bowl, one refill, no discussion. The counter fills with dock hands and market boys and a tram conductor who knew Gorō when they were both young enough to be handsome, according to Gorō. Machi runs it like a harbor master, and I watch her read every new face at the curtain the way she read mine, and I never once see her get it wrong.

The door to her back room drags. It has dragged since I first slept behind it – you have to lift the handle and shoulder it, and everyone does, and nobody fixes it, because a bar full of working men is somehow never working. The second Thursday I borrow a plane and a screwdriver from the tool sharpener up the street, take the door off its hinges before the evening rush, and rehang it square.

Machi watches me do it from the pots. She doesn't say thank you. When I sit down she puts an egg in my oden that I didn't ask for and charges me for a bowl without one. At the end of the counter Gorō taps his glass. "That door's been dragging since the flood of '02," he says. "I was there. Want to hear about it?" Somebody groans. He tells it anyway. It's a good story, and it's better the third time.

Riku, for his part, teaches me the city's other language.

He catches two dock boys sizing us up on the walk home one night – nothing in it yet, just two pairs of eyes weighing us from a doorway – and after they've moved on he stops me under the rail line.

"You walk wrong," he says. "Same as the day I met you. You walk like you're

following something, head down, all your weight going forward. To a certain kind of eye that says nobody's expecting this one anywhere. That's what got you the ditch outside Kuroishi." He squares me up with two hands like I'm furniture. "Keep your chin level and put your shoulders back where they live. You walk like somebody's holding your seat at a counter, because somebody is. Doorway boys count that stuff better than clerks count stamps. Make them pick someone else."

"That's the whole trick? Pretend I'm expected?"

"You are expected, idiot. Machi holds the mats. Tanabe holds the route. It stopped being pretending two Thursdays ago." He clicks his tongue and walks on. "Keep up."

I stand under the rail line for a second with that landing on me, and then a tram goes over and shakes the whole street like a pan, and I catch him up.

He's right, is the thing. Some evening while I was watching for it the city stopped being a place I was passing through. The coins I keep in three knots of cloth prove it: one knot for food, one knot for Tanabe-day mornings when the cart needs a wheel or I need gloves – and one knot, the heaviest, that I don't spend. Two bus fares east, and a bit over. I count it some nights, back-room lamp low, and I can never decide if it's a plan or a prayer. As long as that knot holds two fares, I'm still going to find him, and we're still going home.

Then, on a morning like the other mornings, I get to the cellar at six sharp and Tanabe isn't doing sums. He's standing in the cellar mouth looking up the roofed street, where three gray-greens with clipboards are moving stall to stall in the dawn rush – not searching, not stopping anyone. Counting. One writes while two look, and they look at hands and backs, at the boys hauling crates, at the casual line forming by the fish trucks, and the market noise around them is a note lower than any dawn I've heard here.

"They did the docks yesterday," Tanabe says, quiet, not to me exactly. "They counted the evening shift out the gate. A man I know says they were counting the difference – book crew against real hands."

At the top of the street, where the notices go – bus schedules, boil warnings, the mayor's blessings – a fourth soldier is pasting up a fresh

sheet, white as a bone against the old weathered paper. People are already drifting toward it in the way people do, wanting to know and not wanting to be seen wanting to know.

Riku appears at my shoulder, drawn up the street by the same lowered noise as everyone else, and we read it together over a fishmonger's head.

LABOR REGISTRATION – ALL CASUAL AND DAY-HIRE WORKERS. By order of the Federation Defense Command, all unregistered laborers must present themselves at their ward office within seven days. Employers of unregistered labor after this period are subject to penalty. Registration requires proof of residence and origin documentation.

Origin documentation. Two words for everything I don't have, at the bottom of a page with a seal on it, seven days wide.

Riku reads it twice. He clicks his tongue, once, and it doesn't mean help this time.

"That's aimed at us," he says.

Chapter 17 – The Squeeze

The notice stays up seven days. On the third, Tanabe starts counting differently.

He still pays me at sundown, but he doesn't look at me while he does it. Before noon the casual line at North Market is almost gone – the boys who used to wait by the fish trucks for overflow work have cleared out, and the few who stay keep paper in their jackets and flash it at each other like they're not sure whether to laugh.

On the fourth day a gray-green pair walks the roofed street with a notebook and stops at every cellar mouth. They don't take anyone; they write names and move on. Tanabe watches them pass his doorway with his pencil held so tight the wood creaks, and when they're gone he says, without looking at me, "Finish the mender's ward and come back. Don't take the noodle row today."

"Why not?"

"Because the noodle row has a clerk who likes being useful to soldiers." He goes back to his sums. "And because I said so."

The mender's ward nearly finishes me anyway.

I'm unloading oil at the seamstress's shop when a pair comes up the street with a third man half a step behind – civilian jacket, board under his arm, the one who writes. They work the doorways one by one, and the street does the thing streets do now: keeps moving, a little too attentively. When they reach the seamstress's she comes out to meet them on the step, scissors still in her apron pocket, and plants herself like a woman with nothing in the back room.

"Day-hire," the list man says. Not a greeting. "Who carries for you?"

"My sister's boy, when his knees work." She says it in the flat sing-song of a woman answering a question she has answered four doors' worth of times. "And the wholesaler sends deliveries. I don't hire the street."

"The wholesaler." His pencil is already moving. "Which one?"

Her eyes don't go to me. They go over the pair's shoulders, down the street, anywhere ordinary – but I am standing next to a handcart with the man's oil in my arms, and there is no version of this where I am not part of what he is writing down. The soldier turns and looks at me the way men with lists look at boys with carts.

"Whose cart?"

"Tanabe's, off North Market." My shoulders are already down, my voice level. It is the true answer and the legal one – three more days of legal. "Dry goods and oil, six wards."

"Tanabe." The list man writes it. One word, one line, my mouth to his board. The pencil sounds louder than it has any right to. "Registered employer?"

"Registered premises," the soldier answers for me, bored, already moving to the next door. "The hands are what we're counting."

They go. The seamstress takes her oil out of my arms without a word, and her look, before her door shuts, is not unkind and is not reassuring: the look of a woman deciding what helping me just cost her.

I finish the mender's ward. I don't take the noodle row. All the way back the pencil keeps writing Tanabe's name in my ear.

At sundown he pays me and holds the last coin a second longer than usual.

"You've worked clean," he says. "That matters. But after tomorrow I can't have hands I can't put on a form. You understand what I'm saying?"

"You're saying I'm done."

"I'm saying the form is going to ask for origin documentation, and you don't have any, and I don't forge for boys I like." He puts the coin in my palm and closes my fingers over it. "Take what you've got. Don't come at six. If they ask me about a coast boy on a cart, I never had one."

He doesn't say that a pair wrote his name onto a board this afternoon because a boy holding his oil answered honestly. He doesn't have to. It has been in the room the whole conversation.

Riku is waiting outside with his hands in his jacket. He heard enough through the doorway. He doesn't make a speech about it. He just tips his head toward the bath-house street and we walk.

"Tanabe's not wrong," he says after a block. "A form that asks for origin is a form that asks for a trail. You don't have one you want."

"I know."

"Knowing doesn't put dinner on the counter." He clicks his tongue once. "We'll find something that still pays in cash and doesn't ask. Docks are getting checked. Rail sheds were always paper. That leaves the alleys behind Station Plaza – scrap, night hauls, the kind of work that doesn't put your name anywhere because it doesn't want its own name known either."

"And if those dry up?"

"Then we get thinner for a while." He glances at me. "You've been thinner. You lived."

Minato is quieter that night. Thursday ceremony feels like a smaller room. Machi still feeds whoever comes, but fewer come, and the ones who do keep their eyes on the curtain. Gorō's beer is in its usual place. He isn't drinking it any more than usual, but he's talking more – low, for the counter, about the counting pairs and the hill and how every time this city tightens, it starts with a clipboard.

"They counted the docks," he says. "They counted the market. Next they count the bars that feed the hands they just made illegal." He taps the counter once, the old toll gesture with nothing to trade for. "I drove trams for forty years. This isn't about labor. This is about finding out who doesn't belong on a page."

"Keep your voice down," Machi says from the pots, not unkind. "I like this stool occupied."

"You like this stool occupied because I pay for the beer I don't finish." He turns on the stool and looks at me. "Boy. You've been asking about a scraped voice since the week you walked in here. You still looking?"

"Yes."

"Then listen to an old man for free, because the toll is closed tonight. If your person is in this city and he has no papers either, the registration is going to push him somewhere. Men without paper don't vanish. They gather –

scrap yards, night markets, the backs of places that already look the other way." He points a ginger-root finger at the beer. "Or they get stupid and walk into a ward office thinking a polite story will save them. Don't be the second kind. And don't let him be."

"I don't know where he is."

"Then stop standing near work and food and sleep like the tea lady told you, and start standing near the places that hide." He says it flat, then softens half a degree. "I'm not telling you to get yourself taken. I'm telling you the map just changed, and the old streets don't lead where they used to."

Riku, beside me, has gone very still. "You shouldn't talk like that with the curtain open."

"I shouldn't do a lot of things," Gorō says. "I also shouldn't have let them shorten my line twice and called it materiel priority. At some point an old man gets to say the word hill out loud."

Machi sets a bowl in front of him that he didn't order. "Eat and shut up. Both of you – eat. The boy looks like a notice ate him."

I eat. The broth is the same as every other night, but It doesn't help as much as it used to.

On the sixth morning the pairs are at North Market before the fish trucks. They go cellar to cellar with the notebook and a second man who asks employers for their day-hire lists. Tanabe's doorway has a soldier in it when I walk past on the far side of the street, pretending I have somewhere else to be. I don't stop. I don't look long enough to see whether Tanabe is answering.

Riku finds me an hour's scrap work behind Station Plaza – sorting metal from a collapsed shed for a man who pays in the afternoon and doesn't ask where anyone slept. My hands come away gray. The two-fares knot stays in my cloth, untouched.

That evening Gorō's stool is empty – pushed in, no beer standing sentry – and Machi is wiping the same stretch of counter in a circle that doesn't need wiping.

"Where is he?" Riku asks, before I can.

Machi doesn't look up. "Two men in gray-green came at midafternoon. Not the counting kind. The kind that already know which door. They asked for the tram driver who talks too much about the hill." She wrings the cloth out harder than cloth needs. "He went with them. He told me to keep his seat. He told me to tell anyone who asked that he walked."

"Walked where?"

"He didn't say." She finally looks at us. Her eyes are dry and furious. "If he walked, he walked. If he didn't, there's nothing two boys can do at a desk that takes old men for talking. Sit down, eat, and stay away from the ward offices. Clear?"

"Clear," Riku says.

I sit. I don't eat much. The counter has a Gorō-shaped gap in it, and every time somebody new comes through the curtain they glance at the empty stool and don't ask, which means the ward already knows.

After closing I wash bowls I didn't use and lie on the mat in the back room with my eyes open. Riku is awake too. I can tell by how carefully he isn't moving.

"He'll turn up," Riku says to the ceiling. "Men like that know alleys. He drove every ward in this city. If anyone can walk out of a truck, it's him."

"And if he can't?"

Riku doesn't answer for a long time. Then: "Then the hill took him, and the hill takes people, and we don't get to go get them back with a handcart and a good attitude." He rolls onto his side, facing the wall. "Sleep anyway. Tomorrow we still need coins."

I don't sleep. The notice and the closed cellar and the pushed-in stool keep turning over, and that morning in Nagihama comes back without me asking for it – the morning the world stopped failing and went wrong. I try to build the other version, the one where somebody is coming, somebody has to be – and it won't stand up. It wouldn't stand in Sugi's entryway and it won't stand here.

In the morning Machi puts breakfast in front of us without asking. "His coat's gone from the hook. The good shoes too. So either they let him dress for a long ride, or he got a minute alone and took what he needed." She fills my cup. "I choose the second. You two choose whatever keeps you eating."

Riku finishes his rice and tips his chin at the curtain. "Scrap today. Tonight we ask the night market if anyone's seen a cardigan walking north. Quietly."

"And if the pairs are there?"

"Then we ask quieter."

"And if they took him for talking," I say, "what does quieter get us?"

Riku looks at the empty stool the way Machi looked at us – dry, furious, done pretending. "It keeps us off their list. That's tonight's whole job."

Chapter 18 – Reshaped by Whom

The night market gives us nothing useful.

We ask quietly, the way Riku said – a cardigan, an old tram driver, walking north. One man swears he saw a gray-green truck take someone toward the hill. A woman selling roasted corn says an old man slipped that same truck at the pine road and kept going. Neither story has a name on it. Neither brings Gorō back to his stool.

By the second evening the ask has gone cold, and we are back at Minato eating like the work still matters, when a man sits in the corner and does not drink.

I notice him the way you notice a chair that wasn't there yesterday – not because he's loud, because the room has rearranged around a stillness. Mid-thirties, maybe older. Short hair with nothing to say. A plain dark coat too warm for the season. He has a cup of tea going cold in front of him and both hands around it like the tea is the point, and he watches the counter the way Gorō used to watch the beer: as if the glass were a window.

Machi serves him once and doesn't chat. Riku glances over, dismisses him, goes back to arguing with a dock hand about scrap prices. I keep half an eye on the coat because something about the face won't stay put even while I'm looking at it, and that bothers me more than a staring man should.

Later, when the dock hand leaves and the counter is quieter, Riku knocks my bowl with a knuckle. "You're somewhere else."

"Gorō isn't coming back," I say, low, for him. "And nobody is coming after him to make it right. The world isn't failing, Riku. It's wrong."

Riku looks at me a second. "Eat anyway." He doesn't argue. He doesn't make a speech. That is as much answer as I get, and I take it.

The coat man doesn't speak all evening. He is still there when the counter thins. When Machi starts wiping down, he stands, leaves exact change for the

tea, and goes out through the curtain without nodding at anyone.

Riku watches the curtain settle. "That one give you a feeling?"

"I don't know."

"Then leave it. Feelings about quiet men in warm coats are how boys get walked to desks." He tips his chin at the back room. "Just go to sleep. We have scrap work at dawn."

I almost do, but then I remember Gorō's voice – start standing near the places that hide – and I think about a man who sat through a whole evening of working boys talking about registration and an empty stool and never once asked a question, and I push through the curtain after him.

The street outside is damp from a short rain. The bath house has closed. The tool sharpener's shutter is down. The coat man is halfway to the corner, not hurrying, and when I call out – "Wait" – he stops as if he had been waiting for exactly that word.

He turns. Up close the face is ordinary in a way that feels deliberate. Warm enough to trust. Easy to sit beside. I still can't hold it; my eyes keep sliding off toward the collar, the buttons, the wet street behind him.

"You left without finishing your tea," I say, which is a stupid opening and I know it.

"Tea goes cold. What gets said over it doesn't." His voice is pleasant, unhurried. "You were the one talking about the world being wrong. At the counter. To the boy with the scraped knuckles."

I said that – quiet, to Riku, not for the room – and I thought the coat was far enough away. Apparently not.

"I was talking to my friend."

"You were talking where ears reach." He smiles without showing teeth. "I have a soft spot for boys who notice the shape of the damage. Most people only notice the part that hits them." He tips his head toward the alley beside the bath house, out of the streetlamp. "Walk with me a minute. I don't bite, and I don't carry a clipboard."

Riku would tell me to go back inside. Gorō's empty stool tells me sitting

still hasn't fixed anything. I join him.

The alley smells of steam and old soap. He stops under the overhang where the light gives up and leans his shoulder to the wall like a man with all night.

"So," he says. "The world is wrong. What would you do about it, if you could?"

"Find my friend, finish something I started saying to him, and go home."

"That's a personal repair. I asked about the world." He looks genuinely curious, not mocking. "You've seen enough to know polite stories don't hold – registration sheets, old men taken for talking, a coast that burns and calls it verification. If the whole arrangement is crooked – not broken, crooked – who puts it right?"

"I don't know."

"Good. The ones who know too fast are selling something." He laughs then – head back, loud enough that it bounces off the alley wall, a jolly sound that doesn't match the coat. "Keep your ideals, though. Follow them. Never let anyone talk you down into being useful and quiet while they take the people who drew you maps up the hill." He wipes his eye with a knuckle, still grinning. "You want the world reshaped. I can hear it on you. Every boy who sits at that counter long enough starts wanting it."

"I didn't say reshaped."

"You didn't have to." He leans in a fraction. "Reshaped by whom, boy?"

The question lands harder than the laugh. I open my mouth and find the same empty place I found on the ice truck when Riku asked what happens after I catch Kaito.

"I don't know yet," I say.

He laughs again, delighted, as if that were the prize answer. "Honest. I like honest. The world only ever answers one mouth, Aoyama – remember that when somebody invites you into a chorus." He says my surname like he has been holding it ready, and I go cold because I never gave it to him.

"How do you know my name?"

"Your friend uses it when he tells you to sleep. People are loud about small

things." He pushes off the wall. "Go back inside and eat. Don't follow quiet coats into alleys as a hobby – tonight was educational; tomorrow it might not be."

At the mouth of the alley two figures in dark coats are waiting where the streetlamp fails. They don't speak. They don't greet him. They just fold in behind him as he walks, and the three of them turn the corner toward the elevated line, and by the time I take two steps after them the street is empty in a way that feels practiced.

I stand under the overhang until the damp works through my sleeves. His face is already sliding out of my head. The question – reshaped by whom – stays.

When I push back through Minato's curtain, Riku is on his feet and angry in the quiet way.

"You followed him."

"He heard me talking. I wanted to know why he cared."

"And?"

"He asked me who reshapes the world. I said I didn't know. Then he left with two men who don't talk." I sit. My hands are steadier than they feel. "He knew my name because he heard you say it. That's all."

Riku stares at me a second longer, then curses under his breath and drops back onto his stool. "Next time a warm coat wants a walk, you take me. Or you don't go. Those are the options."

"Those are the options," I agree.

Machi sets a cup in front of me hard enough to click. "I didn't like him either. Tea drinkers who don't drink are worse than beer drinkers who don't drink." She jerks her chin at the door. "There's a dock runner in here with a mouth full of news. He's been waiting to tell anyone who'll listen. You two look like you need a different problem."

The dock runner is a man I half-know from Thursday bowls – thick wrists, a burn on one forearm from a line. He's already telling it to Gorō's empty stool, as if the stool might still argue.

"Old hospital stack," he says, when we lean in. "The logistics wing on the

north hill – not the ward that still takes fever kids. The quiet floors. Break-in before dawn, and there wasn't an alarm or a smashed latch. Night clerk on the service door swears he opened it himself and waved people through, then sat down on the loading step and cried because he can't remember why. He says he never saw their faces – says he never saw them at all, except he must have, because the door was open and a room upstairs is empty that was not empty at shift change." He shakes his head. "Captain's calling it heat and shame. The boys who haul linen are calling it something else: a door that opens because a mouth asked."

Riku snorts. "Dock stories. Every week somebody's aunt saw a ghost."

"Ask the clerk," the runner says. "He's still on the step. He'll tell you the same thing three times and none of it will have a smashed lock in it."

I hear the rest of the room move on – another beer, another complaint about registration, Machi telling someone the back room is full. I don't move on. A door that opened because a mouth asked is the same wrong shape as a stool man at a well who forgot a boy with blood on his lip, and the same wrong shape as a soldier's hands opening in a drying yard. I would know that shape in any city.

Riku is watching me. "You've gone the color of leftover rice. What?"

"I need to see that hospital," I say. "Tonight, or at first light – before they move the clerk or tidy the story."

"Because a dock runner told a ghost story?"

"Because I've seen that story before, and it wasn't a ghost." I stand up. "Are you coming, or am I walking alone?"

Riku looks at Machi. Machi looks at me, weighs whatever she sees, and turns back to her pots.

"North hill, service road behind the laundry chimneys," she says. "Don't walk the main hospital gate after dark unless you want your name on a board. Pairs like the front."

Riku clicks his tongue once – help, this time – and pulls his jacket on.

"You set the pace. If this turns out to be heat and shame, you owe me breakfast for a week."

"If it turns out to be what I think," I say, and I don't finish it, because finishing it would mean saying Kaito's name in a bar that still has ears.

Machi's voice carries from the pots without her turning. "Whatever you two just decided – don't bring it back through my curtain tonight. I already lost one stool."

Chapter 19 – Clean Rooms

Morning finds the apartment the way it always does now – latch clicking when Mira turns it, tatami that still smells like the sun someone aired it in, a window on a bath-house alley instead of diesel. I know which floorboard complains. The ceiling stain over the sink looks like a river I've already walked.

First week in Takamatsu was the tool sharpener's roof – oil, dry rice, cash paid by the night. Then her contact found this: a false name on a landlord's book, two rooms above a closed stationery shop, rent from the pile Mira never explains. The price was staying useful. I understood that without being told the rest.

Mira is at the low table with a paper map and yesterday's pay already sorted. Food. Rent. The third pile. She looks up when I come out of the wash corner.

"You're early."

"Couldn't sleep." My voice scrapes the way it always does now. The fever lie has become ordinary in her mouth – spring fever, never came back right – and clerks stop looking at my throat when she says it. I have said it enough that part of me almost believes the lie is kinder than the truth. "Foreman wants the east run. I should go."

"Not today." She taps the map once. "Sit."

I sit. My shoulders are still set for the east run – crates, diesel, a foreman who likes that I don't ask questions. Pulling me off it means she needs the mouth, or she needs me not at the yards when something happens. Either way my hands want work they aren't getting.

Mira watches me the way she watched the pier soldier's face, once – checking for the tell before she says anything she can't take back.

"Last night the contact came upstairs," she says. "You were asleep. I let

you stay that way.”

“What did she want?”

“She brought a window.” Mira turns the map so I can see the north hill marked in pencil – hospital stack, laundry chimneys, a service court behind the logistics wing. “There’s an old woman on the quiet floors. Not a fever ward. The part they don’t put on the visitor board. They’ve been holding her as an asset with no name worth stamping. Transfer east locks tonight – truck to the rail spur before dawn. After that she goes somewhere we can’t reach.”

“You know her?”

“I knew her.” Mira’s voice stays level. “She kept things for people my aunt’s road owed. Names. Routes. The kind of remembering lists don’t like. If the east truck takes her, the people who hold clipboards get to keep one more person who shouldn’t belong to them.” She looks at me. “I am getting her out tonight. I need a door opened that paper won’t open.”

There it is. The thing under the rent. The reason the contact found us a clean room instead of another rail-shed floor. I feel the sentence shape itself behind my teeth the way it has been doing all summer – clean, ready, hungry – and I hate how glad the hunger is.

“You said no talking under anything in this city,” I say. “Not for a shortcut. Not because I’m angry.”

“I said that.” She doesn’t flinch. “I’m asking you to break it once, on purpose, for someone who will be gone by morning if we don’t. After that we move. This room won’t stay clean once the quiet floors notice a hole.”

“And if I say no?”

“Then I still go, and I fail, and she rides east, and we keep stacking crates until the gray suit sits at Minato and points at your mouth.” She says it without drama, level as a timetable. “I’m not threatening you with that. I’m telling you the road. You’ve been angry for weeks, Kaito. You sleep like you’re waiting for a fight. Something is going to give – I’d rather it be a door we choose.”

I want to argue. The argument comes out smaller than I mean it to.

“I’m not your tool.”

"I'm asking you to choose," Mira says. "That's different. Tonight you can be a boy who opens one door for an old woman I refuse to leave, or you can be a boy who stays useful and quiet while they keep hurting others. I know which one I'd pick. I'm not picking for you."

The bath-house steam lifts past the window. Somewhere a whistle starts the first yard shift without me. I think of Jun checking on his mother. I think of the buyer counting money with empty eyes. I think of Haru's hand on my sleeve in a gateway, and how this city has taught me to walk past kindness without stopping.

"What's her name?" I ask.

"Suzumori. You don't need more than that to open a door."

"When?"

"After the second night shift changes. Service court behind the laundry. Contact waits two streets down with a cart and a story about linen. I talk. You keep your mouth the wage length until I say otherwise. If a latch won't move and paper can't move it – then you." She folds the map. "If it goes wrong, you run with me. You don't stay to finish an argument with a rifle."

"And after?"

"After, she goes inland with people who can hide her. We don't sleep here again. We don't sit where the yard hands talk – not the counters, not the bars that feed the east line. Tonight makes us famous whether we want it or not." She stands, already packing the sack lighter – water, cloth, the small knife she uses for twine. "You can still walk to the yards and pretend this conversation was heat."

I look at the latch on our door. At the third pile on the table. At Mira's hands, steady.

"I'm not walking to the yards," I say.

Something in her shoulders drops a fraction – not relief exactly. Readiness. "Then we go over the route until you can walk it with your eyes shut. And Kaito –"

"I know. Ordinary words until you say. Nothing under them for anger."

"For anger, for fear, for a boy who looks at you wrong in a corridor." She

meets my eyes. "You open one door with a plain ask, and then we leave. The part of you that likes it when it works – leave that part outside the fence. I need the part that gets an old woman down a stair."

I nod. The liking is already in the room with us. I don't pretend otherwise. I just put my boots on and take the map when she holds it out.

We spend the day like people who still belong to the city.

Mira buys rice and vinegar like any aunt's errand. I walk the service road behind the hospital once, alone, a wage boy looking for a shortcut – laundry chimneys, chain-link with a cut wire near the drain, loading dock with a folding chair for a night clerk, stairwell door painted the same green as every municipal building that wants to be ignored. I count the cameras that work and the ones that don't. I count how many steps from the court to the quiet-floor landing if the contact's pencil is honest.

At midday I almost open my mouth at a pair of gray-greens who stop a cart boy for papers he doesn't have. The words come up ready – then I crush them by putting my hands in my pockets and taking the long way around the block. The cart boy gets a shove and a warning instead of a cell. That is the city's kindness. I walk until my pulse settles.

Mira finds me at the water tower we used the first afternoon. She doesn't ask where I went. She hands me a rice ball and says, "Clerk changes at eleven. Transfer truck is staged for three. We go in the gap."

"You've done this before?"

"I've watched people do this before." She looks at the hospital stack on the hill – ordinary windows below, blank ones higher up. "Watching isn't the same. Neither is asking you."

"Then don't make it a speech."

"I'm not." She almost smiles. It still doesn't reach her eyes. "I'm making sure you know the exits."

We go back to the apartment. I sleep two hours because she tells me to, and wake with the scrape in my throat worse, and eat without tasting it. Mira oils the latch so it won't speak when we leave. She puts the false-name rent book

under the sink like a joke we won't need again.

"When we walk out," she says, "we don't look like people saying goodbye to a room."

"I'm not good at that."

"You're getting better at not looking like anything." She says it soft, not proud. "Ready."

I stand. I keep my mouth shut the way I've been keeping it shut for weeks – jaw locked, nothing under the ordinary air. My hands still want a crate to lift. What I want under that, I don't give a name. I put my boots on the complaining floorboard and leave it there.

Mira locks up and leaves the key under the stationery shop's broken shutter, where the contact said to leave it. The metal makes a small sound against the wood – too small for a goodbye, which is the point.

"Service court," she says. "If I stop, you listen. If I run, you run. Clear?"

"Clear."

"Good." She tips her chin at the north hill. "Once we start, we don't have a room to come back to. Say it so I hear you know."

"We don't have a room," I say.

Chapter 20 – Quiet Floors

We reach the laundry alleys a little after eleven.

The walk up from the stationery streets took twenty minutes if you don't cut through Station Plaza, longer if you do and hit a pair with a clipboard. We took the long way on purpose. Mira checked the hill road once from a side street – two gray-greens at the main hospital gate, bored, smoking – and pulled us back into the alleys behind the bath house.

The second night shift has already taken the dock. From the corner of the bath-house wall I can see the folding chair under the single bulb, and the clerk on it – municipal jacket, soft middle, stamp box closed on his knees. He drinks from a thermos, sets it down, checks his watch. The transfer truck is not here yet. Mira said three. The gap is what we came for.

We wait. Not long – long enough for a tram to pass twice on the hill road, long enough for my shoulder to remember it is still whole and my mouth to go dry. A loader crosses the court with a bag of dirty sheets, nods at the clerk, and goes in through a side door that is not our door. The clerk does not look up.

Chain-link fences the three open sides of the service court. A drain runs under the cut wire her contact showed us on the map. Above the green service door, the quiet-floor windows stay blank. No visitor board. No ward noise. Only laundry steam and the tram.

Mira has the empty linen cart. She stops us in the shadow of the stacked carts against the fence and checks the court once more.

"I talk to him first," she says. "If he won't open, then you do."

"How long do we have?"

"Until someone comes looking for why the court door is open, or until the truck crew shows early. Don't make up a third deadline – court or truck, that's it." She adjusts the sack on her shoulder. "Stay here until I call you

forward.”

I nod. My mouth is dry. My hands open and close on nothing.

She walks into the bulb light like a girl on an errand – shoulders down, voice the polite size that gets clerks to look at clocks instead of faces.

“Linen pull for the upper floors,” she says. “We’re late. Supervisor said use the service stair – the ward lift’s down again.”

The clerk blinks at her, then past her toward the shadow where I am, then at the empty cart. “Upper floors don’t take linen after ten. Quiet floors take nothing without a chit from the desk.”

“Desk said the chit’s coming with the transfer truck. They want the room cleared before the east load.” She holds out a folded paper that looks enough like a schedule to waste ten seconds of a tired man’s eyes. “I’m not arguing with a truck. Open up and we’ll be gone before your tea cools.”

He almost does it. His hand lifts toward the latch. Then his eyes find me when I step out of the shadow, and they snag on my scraped voice before I’ve said a word.

“Nobody I don’t know goes up tonight,” he says. “Transfer or not. Sit on the step if you want. Wait for the desk.”

Mira’s weight shifts. Not enough for him to call it a fight. Enough for me.

I walk into the bulb. I keep my voice low, under the chimney steam, under the distant tram.

“Open the door. You never saw us or our faces.”

It lands.

His hand finds the latch without asking his face first. The green door swings. His eyes go empty – a held breath of nothing – and then he is staring past us at the court as if he has forgotten why he stood up. The weight goes out of me hard enough that the dock tilts for a second. Blood reaches my lip. I wipe it on my wrist and don’t look at Mira.

“Inside,” she says.

We push the cart through. Behind us the clerk sits back down on the folding chair with the door still open and puts his face in his hands.

The service stair is concrete and old paint. It smells like bleach that never quite covered something older. Mira takes the steps fast without letting her boots slap. I leave the cart on the first landing – the wheels would carry through the quiet floors – and follow.

First landing: a narrow window on the laundry roof, steam moving past the glass. Second: a locked door marked STAFF ONLY with a paper notice curled at the edge. Third: the fire door with a strip of glass. Mira stops there and looks through before she opens it.

The corridor beyond is the color of boiled rice. Doors without names. A camera at the far end with a dead red light. The floor is mopped too clean for a place that is supposed to be empty at this hour.

Mira counts doors under her breath and stops at the fourth on the left. No number. A paper sleeve where a chart should hang, empty.

From the stairwell below us – boots on concrete. Not running. Checking.

"Clerk?" a man's voice calls. "Why is the court door open?"

Mira knocks twice on the fourth door, soft. A pattern.

The handle turns from inside.

The room is small. One bed. One chair. A window that does not open, with a view of another blank wall. An old woman is already on her feet, slippers on, a thin blanket folded once on the mattress as if she has been waiting sitting up. There is a paper cup of water on the floor by the bed and nothing else that looks like it belongs to a person – no bag, no coat on the hook, no shoes but the slippers.

Suzumori is smaller than I expected. White hair pinned with a wooden stick. Eyes that take Mira in first, then me, then the blood drying on my wrist. She does not look surprised.

"Saeki," she says. Not loud. "You took your time."

"We have minutes," Mira says. "Can you walk?"

"I can walk." She already has the slippers tied. "East truck was due before dawn. I heard them oiling the gate an hour ago."

"Then we're early enough." Mira tips her chin at me. "He's with me. He doesn't talk unless he has to."

Suzumori's gaze returns to my mouth. "That voice is loud even when it whispers. Careful where you point it, boy. It cuts both ways."

Boots again – closer. Second flight now.

"We go," Mira says.

Suzumori nods at the corridor and steps past me without asking my name. Mira takes her elbow. I take the rear and pull the door shut behind us, soft as I can.

We are halfway to the stair when a gray-green turns the corner from the far end – young, rifle sling loose, the look of a night post that has been boring until this second. He sees three people where there should be none. His hand goes to the sling.

"Stop–"

He is close enough that if he gets the rifle up, the stair is finished. Mira and Suzumori are between me and the fire door. The only cover is a linen cart left against the wall by someone else's shift.

"Drop the rifle. Face the wall. Count to one hundred before you turn."

He drops it. The sling catches and the rifle hits the floor hard enough to wake people two floors down. He turns to the wall with empty eyes and starts counting out loud – wrong numbers, a child's count. My knees go. Gray climbs the edges of the corridor. Mira's hand finds my sleeve and pulls.

"Stairs."

We take them. Suzumori is faster than her size. Behind us the counting goes on, thin and obedient, and a second voice shouts for the clerk from the court. On the loading dock the first clerk is still on the chair with his face in his hands. He does not look up as we pass. The bulb swings a little in the draft from the open door.

Mira goes through the cut in the wire first, then Suzumori. My shirt catches on the cut end and tears. The fence takes a strip of skin off my shoulder. I swear once – ordinary, no weight under it – and drop into the alley behind the chimneys.

The contact is already there with the cart pointed toward the pine road. Dark jacket. Hair pinned flat. She looks at Suzumori, then at my mouth, then

at Mira.

"Truck's two bends down," she says. "She rides under the linen. You two take the long cut. Don't go back to that room."

Suzumori pauses with one hand on the cart rail.

"You used a boy's throat for a latch," she says to Mira, quiet.

She heard it on the quiet floor – me telling the soldier to drop the rifle, him facing the wall and counting. Mira doesn't pretend otherwise.

"He opened what paper wouldn't," Mira says. "You'll get your argument about that later. Right now we need to get out of here."

Suzumori's eyes find me – not kind, not cruel.

"Two mouths like that in one world," she says. "What a terrifying thought."

She climbs into the cart without waiting for an answer. The contact covers her with a sheet that smells like bleach and starts walking. By the time I wipe my shoulder on my sleeve, the cart has turned the corner toward the pine road, and from the service court someone is shouting for the clerk by name.

We take the long cut: bath-house alleys first, then the back streets under the elevated line. Every few minutes a train shakes dust out of the shop signs. We stay off the main hill road. My legs want to stop. Mira's shoulder is under my arm because the second command took more out of me than the first, and my scraped voice is thinner than walking wants.

A clock over a closed pharmacy says 11:40. The streets here are mostly shutters and cats. A drunk argues with a vending machine two doors down and does not look at us. The sirens have not started.

We cross behind a noodle shop that is still lit – one cook scraping a pan, radio low – and cut through to the stationery street. We pass the closed shop without slowing. Our window is dark. I do not look up at it longer than a step.

"She goes inland on that truck," Mira says. "We don't. Can you keep walking?"

"Yes." Then, before I can hold it: "Haru—"

Mira's step hitches once. "What about him?"

"Nothing. Forget it."

"I'm not forgetting a name you say with blood still on your mouth." She doesn't slow down. "If he's in Takamatsu and he hears about a door that opened for no reason, he'll come looking. So we aren't here when he does. Drainage cut to the pine edge before they rope the hill road. After that you keep quiet until I say otherwise."

"What did she mean, two mouths?"

"I don't know. She's under linen on a cart – if I get an answer, it won't be tonight." She looks at me sideways. "You opened two doors for me. Next time something needs your mouth, I ask first. You can still say no. I'm not –"

"Using me."

"I was going to say I'm not deciding alone. But yes. That too."

A siren starts on the hill – hospital side.

"This way," Mira says, and takes the narrow service path behind the yards, the one that runs wet along the fence toward the pines. We stay off the lit road. Water soaks through my boots in the low places. A second siren joins the first, closer to Station Plaza.

Chapter 21 – Pine Edge

The service path ends where the pines start to lean over the fence.

We stop in the first dark that is not street dark. Water finds every hole in my boots. Mira listens with her whole body – head tilted, one hand on the fence rail – and does not move until a third siren joins the first two and then fades toward Station Plaza instead of climbing the hill after us.

“Down,” she says.

There is a drainage cut under the pines, shallow enough that a cart could clear it if someone knew to look, deep enough that two people can sit with their backs to wet clay and not be seen from the lit road. We take it. My shoulder burns where the fence tore it and I put my fist against the clay so I don’t put it against my mouth.

Sirens thin. A tram crosses somewhere below the hill and shakes pine needles onto my sleeves. Mira unwraps a strip of cloth from the sack, presses it to the tear, and ties it without asking if I want help.

“Don’t talk,” she says. “Sound carries differently once the road gets quiet.”

I nod. Haru’s name is still half-shaped behind my teeth. Mira saw it. She will not let me pretend she didn’t.

We wait. My shoulder finds a new way to hurt every time I shift against the clay.

Dawn comes gray through the needles.

Mira leaves me in the cut and goes up to the fence line alone. She comes back with pine needles in her hair and a face that says the lit road is awake.

“Pairs on the hill road,” she says. “Not sweeping yet. Standing. Looking like they expect someone stupid to walk back the way they came.”

"Contact?"

"Signal is noon at the second bend if the truck cleared. If it didn't, we don't go looking for her on the open stretch." She sits, shoulders against the clay. "We stay put until the sun is high enough that shadows stop looking like people. Then we move inland along the fringe, not the road."

"And if someone comes up this path?"

"Then we're cousins who got lost looking for a laundry shortcut, and I do the talking." She looks at my bandage. "You look like you lost a fight with a fence. That much is obvious."

"I can talk."

"You can. I'm asking you not to invent a better story than mine while we're still in earshot of the hill." She tips her chin at the clay. "Sit. Sleep if you can. I'll take the first hour."

Mira sleeps sitting up for an hour. I do not. A bird argues with another bird. Far down the hill a loader shouts. Once, footsteps pass on the lit road – two pairs, boots in time – and Mira's eyes open before I can decide whether to wake her.

They do not turn down our path. They keep going toward the hospital stack.

"Not him yet," Mira says, quiet. "But the hill is getting the kind of quiet that makes people check their stories twice."

"You've seen him here?"

"I've seen what happens when he sits somewhere and listens. That quiet is coming whether we watch it or not." She stands, brushes clay off her knees. "Water. Half. Then we move before noon makes us visible."

I take the half. Flat. Warm from the bottle. Mira checks the fence line once more, then the inland track.

"When we catch up to her," I say, "what's she going to want from me?"

"An answer she already has." Mira does not soften it. "Whether last night was me using you, or you choosing. She'll ask it ugly. I'd rather you be standing there when she does."

"And if I walk off before she starts?"

"Then I still owe her, and you still owe the hill a scraped voice it hasn't finished hunting." She tips the water back. "I'm not dragging you into that shed by the collar. I'm telling you I'd rather not lie to her about where you went."

The fringe inland is not a road. It is a track deer use, and people who do not want their names on boards. Roots. Wet patches. A view, sometimes, of the hospital chimneys through a break in the trees – laundry steam still rising, gray-greens like ants on the main gate.

We do not look long.

At the second bend there is a stump with three chalk marks on the bark, fresh enough that Mira's thumb comes away white when she touches them.

"Truck cleared," she says. "She's ahead. We follow the marks, not the road. Contact will leave the next one past the water tower cut."

"How far?"

"Far enough that we don't get there before dark if we stay careful." She looks back the way we came – toward the service path, the cut, the city. "Someone is going to walk that laundry court today and ask the wrong questions. We aren't there for the answers."

I almost say his name again. Mira's eyes flick to my face and away.

"If you're about to ask whether we go back for him," she says, "the answer is no."

"I wasn't."

"Good." She starts walking. "Because if he's in this city and he knows that shape, he'll come to the hill on his own. We need to be somewhere else when he does."

We walk. My shoulder stiffens. The bandage darkens and then stops. The fringe opens once onto a scrap of scrub where someone dumped broken tiles, and closes again into wet dark that smells like sap and old smoke. Mira checks every chalk mark twice – once with her eyes, once with her thumb – as if the marks might lie to her the way paper lies to clerks.

Around midday we stop in a scrape of dry ground under pines that still hold

last night's wet. Mira digs two rice balls out of the sack – stationery-shop morning rice, cold, the seaweed gone limp – and I do not ask where she hid them. We eat with our backs to different trees. Mine faces the way we came. Hers faces the chalk marks ahead.

"You keep looking back," Mira says.

"Someone might be on that path."

"Someone's always walking." She picks a grain of rice off her thumb with her teeth. "You mean him."

I don't deny it. The scrape in my throat makes denial sound like theater anyway.

"If he's coming," I say, "the marks are the only thing that don't make him guess. We leave them, he finds the shed. We burn them and cut south, he walks the open road into whoever is listening for a scraped voice."

"Or he walks the open road into us, and then we have a reunion with gray-greens for an audience." She doesn't raise her voice. She doesn't have to. "I didn't pull Suzumori out of a hospital so you could sit on a hill waiting for the boy who has been walking toward your mouth since Kuroishi."

"He's walking toward a hospital story. Not me."

"Same road, if you leave him a trail of chalk." She wraps the empty seaweed and stuffs it in the sack like evidence. "Listen to me. If the hill gets loud – pairs, sirens, that man who covers his ears – we cut south and burn half a day. We lose the marks on purpose. If it stays quiet, we keep them and we move. Quiet is what worries me. Quiet means someone is taking their time."

"And if quiet is him?"

"Then he can take his time too." For a second something almost soft moves in her face, and then it is gone. "We have a shed to reach before dark. Eat. Then we walk. Looking back doesn't get us there."

I finish the rice. It tastes like a room we already locked.

"Marks," I say. "For now."

"For now," she agrees, and she makes me say the inland signal once under my breath before she lets us stand – two notes, not a tune – so I remember what we are walking toward instead of what we left.

Afternoon brings the gray suit.

Not on our track. On the lit road below a rise where the pines thin. Mira pulls me flat behind a fallen trunk before I see him properly – same suit as the shrine yard, no rifle, hands empty, standing with a pair of gray-greens who look like they would rather be anywhere else. He is not looking at maps. He is looking at mouths. Even from here I can tell: the way his attention sits on the younger soldier when the boy answers a question, the way he tips his head as if sound itself were a trail.

Mira's fingers dig into my sleeve.

My mouth wants a clean order – make them walk past, make the track empty – the same ready shape as last night's latch. I shut it. Jaw locked. Hands flat in the needles so they do not make a fist that looks like choosing.

Mira feels my arm go hard under her grip, then ease. She does not let go.

"Down," she breathes. "He's the one who covered his ears on the pier."

Below us he asks something we cannot hear. The younger gray-green points toward the hospital service court. The older one points toward the pine road. He does not point. He turns once, slow, and for a second his face is aimed uphill in our direction – not seeing us, not missing us either. Just listening for too many stories on one hill.

Then he walks back toward the chimneys with the pairs, and the lit road is empty again.

We do not move until the steam from the laundry has shifted twice.

"Inland," Mira says. "Before he decides the fringe is interesting."

Dusk finds us past the water tower cut.

The next chalk mark is on a stone, not bark – three lines, then a fourth half-scraped as if someone changed their mind. Mira swears once, and crouches.

"Contact got interrupted," she says. "Or she wanted us to wait. Either way we don't sleep on the open track."

There is a shallow bowl under pines where someone has built a fire ring of stones and then kicked it cold. We take it. Mira sets no fire. She sets her

back to a tree that covers two approaches and tells me to watch the third.

The city is a smear of light through the trees now. Sirens have stopped. That is worse than sirens. Quiet means someone has decided what story to tell about last night, and quiet means the gray suit has somewhere to sit.

I hear them before I see anything – boots on wet ground, not in time with gray-green pairs. Two people. Careful. Coming up the service path we left before dawn, the long way from the laundry court, voices low enough that words do not carry, only the shape of talking.

Mira is already on her feet. She pulls me deeper into the pines, off the track, into needles that stick to the bandage and smell like rain that never finished.

We freeze.

The boots stop at the drainage cut. A light clicks on – small, cupped – and jumps once across the clay where we sat. A boy's voice says something I almost catch. Another voice answers – impatient, the kind of answer that comes with a tongue-click.

They are not gray-greens. They are not the man from the lit road. They are two people who walked a hospital story to a wet path and found our prints already cold.

Mira's hand finds the back of my neck and holds me still. Not kind. Necessary.

I know that voice the way I know a door latch in the dark.

The light goes off. The boots move again – not toward us. Toward the pine road proper, the open stretch where chalk marks lead inland. They are going the right way for the wrong reason, or the wrong way for the right one. I cannot tell from here. I can only tell that if we step out now, the night becomes a conversation I am not ready to have with blood still dried in the crease of my wrist.

Mira waits until the boots are gone. Then she waits longer.

"The cut was my call," she says, quiet. "Wet clay holds prints. We should have moved at dusk and I kept us sitting in it half a day. I gave them a place to start." It is the first time I have heard her hand herself a mistake, and she does it the way she does everything – once, level, and without asking

anything back for it. "We don't follow them."

"They're on our marks."

"Then the marks are burned and we cut wider." She is already moving, south of the track, into thicker dark. "Contact's next signal is the shed past the pine fork – not the road those two just chose. We get there first or we don't get there at all."

"Mira–"

"If you say what I think you're about to say, we lose the shed and the truck and her." She does not look back. "Those two can burn the open road. We cut wider. Walk."

"That was him."

"I know." Her voice stays level. "Walk anyway."

"If we get to the shed first," I say, "and he's already on the marks–"

"Then he's burning decoys for us whether he means to or not." She does not look back. "We get to the shed first. If you need a sentence to hold until dawn, hold that one."

Chapter 22 – Tight Road

We reach the pine fork before the two sets of boots do.

The shed is half a roof and three walls of warped board, set back from the track where a cart could hide without inventing a story. Mira stops us short of the clearing and whistles once – two notes, not a tune anyone would hum for fun.

A dark jacket answers from the shed door. Hair pinned flat. The contact from the laundry court. She looks at my bandage, then at Mira, then past us into the trees as if counting shadows.

"You're late," she says. "And you're loud for people who were supposed to take the long cut."

"Marks got interrupted," Mira says. "We had to cut wider. Is she here?"

"She's inside, awake, and asking questions I don't answer." The contact tips her chin at me. "Keep that mouth the wage length. She's already decided what she thinks of it."

The shed smells like dry pine and old oil. Suzumori sits on a crate with a blanket over her shoulders that is not the quiet-floor blanket. She looks smaller in daylight and somehow harder. Her eyes find my scraped voice before they find my face.

"Saeki," she says. "You brought him."

Mira is already looking past her at the track. "He opened the door. Paper wouldn't have. We can fight about whether that was smart when we aren't standing in a shed the hill can see."

"I'm fighting about it now." Suzumori's gaze does not leave my mouth. "I told him in that room to be careful where he points it. Looking at the blood on his wrist, careful didn't take."

I stay by the wall. My shoulder throbs in time with my pulse. I do not offer

her a name. She does not ask for one.

"Who's behind us?" the contact asks Mira.

"Gray suit on the hill road yesterday afternoon. Pairs. And two people on the service path at dusk who weren't wearing gray-green." Mira says it flat. "They took the open pine stretch. We came around."

Suzumori's mouth tightens. "Scraped-voice hunt, or a boy who knows the shape?"

"Both, if we're unlucky." Mira crouches and redraws the fork in dust on the shed floor – track, road, a third line south toward scrub. "We don't sleep here. Truck's gone. Next billet is the farm lean-to past the ridge cut."

"No." The contact says it before the dust settles. "Split it. I take her south through the scrub tonight – two women and a cart story, nobody's hunting that. You two are the description. You draw the road north, shed whoever follows, and we meet past the fork in three days."

"Three days is three more nights of pairs learning the fringe," Mira says. "And she doesn't have three days of scrub in her legs, whatever she's told you."

"I can hear both of you," Suzumori says.

"Then settle it," the contact says. "It's your neck."

Suzumori looks at me – at the bandage, at the mouth she has already made up her mind about – long enough that I understand the argument is not about routes. It is about whether the latch travels with her or away from her.

"I stay with the loud one," she says finally. "If the wrong people find two women and a cart, a story saves nobody. A door might save somebody." She pulls the blanket tighter. "And I walk. I have been sitting in a clean room long enough."

The contact takes losing the way professionals take it – one breath, then the next problem. "Lean-to, then. You ride if you have to," she tells Suzumori. "He walks."

We move before the light gets kind.

The contact takes point with a sack that looks like market work. Mira stays with Suzumori. I take the rear because the rear is where mouths get used when something comes up from behind, and Mira would rather see my face when the hunger starts than hear it happen at her back.

The inland track after the fork is narrower. Pine gives way to mixed scrub – broom, a few stubborn plum trees gone wild, stone walls that used to mean somebody's field. Once we hear a motor on the open road and freeze until it passes. Once a dog barks from a farm.

Suzumori talks while she walks. Not loud. Not soft enough to ignore.

"You pointed him at a latch," she says to Mira. "Paper would have failed. I know. That does not make a boy's throat a tool you spend without asking what it costs him later."

"I asked," Mira says. "He chose."

"He chose angry." Suzumori glances back at me. "Anger opens doors clean. It also opens the wrong ones."

I could tell her about Jun. About a rifle under a man's own jaw. I do not. She has not earned those names, and I am out of the habit of offering them.

"I can hear you deciding not to answer," Suzumori says. "Good. Keep deciding that when someone asks you for a shortcut."

Mira's jaw works once. "We're not having that argument on an open track."

"I'm not naming what he is." Suzumori's stick of wood shifts in her hair as she ducks a branch. "I'm telling you that two loud mouths in one generation is a problem people like your gray suit will solve by putting both of them in the same locked room. I would rather not watch you help him do it."

Two mouths like that in one world. She said it under the linen, and she is saying the shape of it again now. I do not ask. The questions I do not understand stay behind my teeth.

The lean-to sits against a stone wall on the far side of the ridge cut.

It is empty when we arrive, which Mira treats as good news and the contact treats as a question. Inside: straw, a water jug, a folded tarp. Outside: a view of the open pine road for anyone willing to crawl to the wall's broken

end.

The contact crawls. She comes back with dust on her chin.

"Pairs on the road," she says. "Not sweeping. Asking. I saw a clipboard."

"Asking what?" Mira says.

"Directions to a boy whose voice sounds hurt. They have the hospital story now – door, empty room, clerk who cries when you make him repeat it." The contact looks at me. "Your face is becoming a description."

The answer comes up ready – send them back to the hill, make them forget the scraped voice – and I stop it the same way I stopped it on the fringe: jaw locked, nothing under the ordinary air. Mira watches my mouth and nods once, small, like she saw how close I came.

Suzumori sits on the straw. "How long do we have?"

"Until someone smart connects the chalk marks to this wall," Mira says. "Or until the two from the service path walk into the same questions and point inland for free."

"They won't point," I say.

The contact looks over. Mira doesn't. She is suddenly very still, the way she gets when I am about to make a problem into a person.

"You sound sure," she says.

"I am. The tall one will lie to a clipboard and walk. The other one will keep asking shopkeepers and clerks until somebody tells him which way we went. They won't sit down in an office and draw a map for free – but they also won't turn around and go home. They'll stay on the marks."

"So, worse," the contact says.

"That's why we don't leave them marks," Mira says. She draws a line through the fork in the dust with her boot. "Dawn. South scrub. You go ahead and warn the next hand. We stay off the open road."

Suzumori watches me over the water jug. "You sound like you know those two."

"I know the type," I say, and drink before anyone asks which type.

Night hardens.

The contact leaves with the tarp rolled under one arm and a promise to whistle from the scrub line before first light if the next billet is clean. Mira takes first watch at the wall break. Suzumori sleeps like someone who has practiced sleeping in rooms that were not hers.

I do not sleep. My shoulder has found a new way to hurt. Every time the wind moves the pines I hear boots that are not there. Once they are there – real, two pairs, on the open road below the ridge – and Mira's hand finds my ankle in the dark and squeezes until they pass.

Voices carry up the cut, thin as wire.

"–hospital service path. Wet prints. Two, maybe three."

"Scraped voice?"

"Clerk said he never saw faces. Captain says heat. The gray suit says mouths."

A third voice, quieter, unused to shouting: "Anyone ask at Minato?"

"Tomorrow. He wants the bars that feed hands. Tonight he wants the pine road walked twice."

They move on. Mira's grip eases.

"Listener," she whispers. "He's tying your well story to the quiet floors. We are out of Takamatsu's patience."

"Haru–"

This time I say the half-name. Mira does not pretend she misheard.

"If he's on that road," she says, "he's walking into the same questions those pairs are asking. That is not a reason to go find him."

"I wasn't going to go find him."

"You were going to stand up." She is right. My legs had already decided. "Sit. Dawn is six hours. You can hate me for all six, but you still sit."

Suzumori's eyes are open in the dark. She does not speak. She does not need to. The dread she named under the linen is in the lean-to with us now – not as a lecture, as a fact about how many people are hunting the same scraped voice from different directions.

First light comes wrong.

The contact's whistle does not come from the scrub line. It comes from lower, toward the open road, short and cut off. Mira is on her feet before the echo dies. She pulls me to the wall break.

Below, on the pine road where the ridge cut spills gravel, three gray-greens have stopped a cart. The contact's dark jacket is among them – hands out, talking fast. Beside the cart, two civilians who are not civilians enough: a tall boy with his shoulders set wrong for surrender, and a shorter one who stands like the road owes him an argument.

I know the shorter one's stance before I know his face. Ordinary voice. Ordinary hands. The unfinished sentence living in his mouth whether he has said it yet or not.

Haruki.

The tall one has the tongue-click shape from the path – body half a step ahead of the boy he is walking with. A gray-green reaches for Haruki's sleeve. The tall one knocks the hand away. The cart horse startles. Someone shouts for them to kneel.

"Riku—" Haruki says, sharp, and the tall one answers by moving, so the name sticks whether I want it or not.

Mira's fingers dig into my arm hard enough to bruise.

"We go south," she says. "Now. Through the scrub. We do not go down there."

Suzumori is already beside us, blanket discarded. "If you leave him to that road, boy, you will spend the rest of your anger inventing a cleaner version of this morning."

"I'm not leaving him," I say, and the truth of it shocks me more than the lie would have. "I'm not walking into a clipboard either."

On the road Riku takes a swing at the nearest gray-green. It connects. The second soldier brings a rifle butt around; Riku catches it on his forearm and swears loud enough to carry. Haruki's voice rises – not scraped, not weighted the way mine weights, but the kind of careful talk that makes people pause when they should not pause. One gray-green's grip loosens. The third one's does not.

Mira looks at me. Really looks – the pier look, the tide-chart look, the look that asks me to choose before the world chooses for me.

“If you go down there,” she says, “that rifle finishes its swing before you finish a hello. So either you do something, or we watch. I’m not choosing it for you.”

Suzumori’s hand finds the wall. “Decide, boy. Standing here is also a choice.”

Below us Haruki turns his head as if he heard something on the ridge. For half a breath his face is aimed at our wall, at the lean-to, at me – not seeing, not missing. Just hunting the shape he walked a city to find.

I stand up into the open enough that if he looks harder he will find more than a shape.

Mira swears. Suzumori does not.

On the road a gray-green raises the rifle properly this time, not for a butt-stroke – for the shot that ends arguments. Riku moves to put himself in front of Haruki. Haruki’s mouth is already forming a word.

I go down the ridge cut with my mouth already open.

Chapter 23 – Go Home

I hit the pine road running.

The cart is still crooked in the ditch – one wheel sunk, horse stamping, three gray-greens. The contact is on her knees by the horse's head. Riku has his body between Haruki and the nearest rifle, left arm already wrong from the butt-stroke. The rifle that was swinging toward them turns toward me instead when my boots hit gravel.

Mira comes down hard behind me. Suzumori swears from higher up and keeps coming anyway. The contact's breath catches when she sees my face.

"Kaito—" Haruki says.

My name almost stops me. For half a second I am stupid enough to look at him instead of the gun.

The gray-green with the rifle sees a tall boy, scraped voice, bloody bandage – enough of the hospital story to smile wrong.

"On the ground," he says. "All of you. Scraped voice last."

Riku does not get on the ground. He steps into the soldier – shoulder into the barrel, left hand on the sling, right fist short into the gut. The rifle fires into dirt. The horse screams and rears. The contact rolls clear of the hooves.

The second rifle swings toward Riku's back.

I am close enough.

"Drop the rifle. Both hands on your head. Kneel."

It lands. The weight leaves my throat hard enough that the road tips. The second soldier's eyes empty; the rifle hits gravel; he kneels with his hands laced like a child at a shrine. Blood finds my upper lip.

The first soldier is still fighting Riku – my command was for the one with the barrel aimed, not the one already in a clinch. Riku drives him into the

cart wheel. The clipboard man scrambles for a sidearm he is too slow to clear. Mira kicks his wrist and the gun skitters under the cart. She does not pick it up. She puts her boot on his shoulder and keeps him down.

"Don't kill him," she tells Riku, sharp. "We need the road empty, not famous."

Riku's answer is a grin with a crooked tooth and another short punch that ends the argument without ending the man. The gray-green slides down the wheel and stays there, breathing, not getting up.

Haruki has not moved except to catch my eyes and hold them.

The kneeling soldier stays down with empty eyes and his hands still laced. I wipe my nose on my wrist and keep moving.

"Up the cut," Mira says. "Now. That rifle went off – the hill will come looking."

Suzumori is already halfway down, stick of wood crooked in her hair, eyes on my mouth like it is a latched door she refuses to praise.

"Boy," she says. "They heard the gun. They will hear what your mouth did next if we stand here."

"I know."

Haruki steps around Riku. Close enough that I can see the dust on his shoes – Haiga dust, city dust, the kind of dust that means he walked farther than he should have on a sentence I never let him finish.

"Kaito," he says again. Full. Careful. The voice that makes people quiet when he does not mean to. "I need you to hear me."

"We don't have time for speeches," Mira says.

"Then he talks while we walk," Riku says. He is already pulling the contact up, already watching the east stretch of road. "Or we stand here until the next pair arrives and I get to be clever with a third rifle. Pick."

Mira looks at me. I look at Haruki. The unfinished thing between us is louder than the horse still stamping in the ditch.

"West," I say. "Off the road. Talk if you have to. Keep up."

We take the scrub south of the pine road, parallel to the inland track, far enough that a motor would have to invent a reason to follow. Mira leads with Suzumori. The contact and Riku take turns watching behind. Haruki walks at my shoulder like he has a right to the space, and the worst part is that my body still makes room for him before my anger can stop it.

He does not waste the first hundred meters on small talk. He has been composing this since a gateway. I can see it in the way his hands keep almost lifting and then dropping.

"At the gate," he says. "I started to say it wasn't your fault. I stopped because I'd just watched a man die on the end of your sentence, and I wouldn't give you a lie." He swallows. Dust in his throat, or the old honesty. "I've walked every road between that gate and this one meaning to finish it when it was true enough to say."

I keep walking. Roots. Wet scrub. My shoulder singing.

"It wasn't your fault," Haruki says. Six syllables. The ones he owed me under a vending-machine light outside Kōgetsu. "Not the hand. Not Ryn. Not the roof. You told a soldier to let go of a girl and the world broke wrong around the words. That is not the same as choosing what happened to her." His voice stays level. "I should have said it long before now. I am saying it, and I am not asking you to pretend the road didn't happen. I am asking you to stop running like the only clean thing left is your mouth."

The words are true. They do not change what I am going to do next.

"You walked all that way for six syllables," I say.

"I walked all that way because you left with my sleeve still in your hand." He almost smiles and fails. "And because nobody else is coming to fix any of this. I figured that out in Takamatsu before I found your shape on a hospital story. If the world is this broken, I am not spending the rest of it one day behind you."

Riku, ahead, clicks his tongue once. "Pretty. Also we have company if we keep making speeches at walking speed."

Mira has stopped at a break in the scrub where the inland track shows through. She points east – dust on the pine road, small as insects from here. Pairs. Moving west. Not running yet.

"They heard the shot," she says. "They will send more."

Suzumori's hand finds my sleeve – not Mira's habit, a different grip, older. "Say what you came to say to him, boy from the clean rooms. Then decide if you are going to keep opening things, or stop. I will not decide it for you."

Haruki faces me fully. The scrub smells like crushed broom. Somewhere a dog barks at the wrong century.

"Come back with me," he says. "Not to Kōgetsu. There is no Kōgetsu. Back to something that isn't this – Mira steering, your mouth as the whole plan. We find another way. We invent one if we have to. Just stop. Let me walk beside you while we still both remember how."

It is a good speech. It is the speech I wanted in the dark outside Kōgetsu, and in the gateway, and in every ditch between Kuroishi and the stationery shop window. It is not enough.

Because the pairs on the road are closing, and my mouth already knows the clean sentence that gets us out, and Haruki's careful voice will not make three gray-greens forget a rifle shot.

"You don't get to finish my road with a sentence," I say. "Even a true one."

Haruki's face does something small and broken. "Then what do I get?"

"You get to go home."

I do not mean Nagihama. I do not mean Sugi's door. I mean off this scrub, off Mira's fork, off the hunt that ends with the Listener taking mouths. I mean away from me before I use him the way I used a clerk and a soldier and a kneeling man on gravel.

He hears the ordinary meaning first. Then he hears the weight gathering under it – I see it in his eyes, the same recognition he had for a door that opened because a mouth asked.

"Kaito—don't!"

Mira's hand is on my back. Not stopping me. Steadying the body that is about to pay.

Riku starts forward. "Hey—"

The pairs' voices carry from the pine road, closer – questions about a scraped voice, about the hospital path. The contact goes still.

I look at Haruki – careful hands, the face that would not lie to me even when a lie would have been kinder – and I put the weight under the only exit I can still close.

“Stop following me. Go home.”

Copper. Hard. The scrub goes gray at the edges. My knees want the ground and find Mira’s shoulder instead.

Haruki’s face empties – and then something in him fights it, a resistance I have never watched from the outside. I do not get to see which one wins. The weight has already left my throat. Blood is already on my lip.

“Kaito–” Mira says.

Riku grabs for Haruki’s arm. Haruki’s feet are already turning toward the east, toward Takamatsu, toward whatever home means when a scraped voice defines it for him. His mouth opens around my name again and nothing comes out that has force in it.

Suzumori makes a sound like a door latch failing.

I do not watch him take the first steps. I let Mira pull me west into thicker scrub, away from the pine road, away from the pairs, away from the boy who walked a country to close six syllables and got two sentences back instead.

Behind us Riku swears once – ordinary, furious – and his boots go east after Haruki. The contact stays on Mira’s heel. Suzumori comes west with us, stick of wood crooked in her hair, eyes on the road we left like she expects the gray suit to step out of it.

Needles scrape my bandage. Mira does not tell me I did the right thing. She does not tell me I did the wrong one. She puts my arm over her shoulders and keeps me moving west until the pine road’s voices thin to nothing.

“Keep walking,” she says.

I keep walking.

Chapter 24 – East Against the Word

My feet are walking east and I did not ask them to.

That is the only honest way to say it. The pine road runs downhill out of the scrub toward the far smudge of Takamatsu, and my body takes it at a good traveling pace – arms swinging, breath even, a boy with somewhere to be. Inside the boy, I am telling my knees to stop. They don't answer. The two sentences sit behind my eyes where he left them, not loud, not cruel, just load-bearing. Stop following me. Go home.

Riku keeps pace beside me and says nothing. He has blood dried at his hairline and he carries his left forearm tucked against his ribs where the rifle butt caught it. Every few hundred meters he looks over at me – not scared. Working something out.

"So," he says at last. "Are we going to talk about the part where a soldier put his hands on his head and knelt in the road because your friend told him to?"

"You saw it?"

"I saw a lot of things this morning. I'm choosing which one to start with." He steps over a fallen branch without breaking stride. "A grown man with a rifle knelt like it was gym class. Then your friend aimed two sentences at you, and your face went somewhere else, and now you're marching toward the city we just committed a crime outside of, at a pace I'd call cheerful. So talk to me, Aoyama, or I stop walking next to whatever this is."

"He's not my cousin," I say, because we should bury the oldest lie first.

"I worked that out around the second rifle." He doesn't slow. "Keep going."

"I don't have a name for what he does." That is true, and I hold onto it, because the true parts are the only footing I have. "When he puts weight under his voice, people do what the words say. I've seen it three times now – a drying yard in Nagihama, a shrine yard, this morning. I don't know the rules

of it. I don't think he fully knows them either. And this morning he put that weight under go home and pointed it at me, and my legs have been someone else's ever since."

Riku is quiet for ten steps. When he speaks again his voice has lost the crooked-tooth angle it keeps for the world.

"Where do your legs think home is? Exactly."

I've been avoiding the question for an hour, because I already know, and knowing is worse. Kōgetsu is a name on an exclusion map. Sugi's house holds Kaito's grief, not mine. The road doesn't count. Which leaves one door with a rope curtain and one back room that smells of dry rice, where a woman ladles oden at boys who worked, and my body – my stupid, honest body – decided that is where a home goes.

"Minato," I say.

Riku stops walking. I don't. That's the point. He has to jog to get back to my shoulder.

"No," he says. "No, you are not taking a pine-road assault through Machi's curtain. Every pair in that city is going to be shaking bars and bath houses for two boys within a day, and you want to hand her a reason to lose more than a stool."

"I don't want any of this. My feet aren't asking me."

"Then we make them ask." He gets in front of me and plants his good hand flat on my chest. My legs keep going. He gives ground, boots skidding on the grit, swearing with great fluency, and then he stops trying to be a wall and becomes a hook instead – arm around my shoulder, hip turned in, and we both go down into the dry ditch in a tangle of elbows.

My body gets up. It isn't angry. That is the worst part – no fury in it, just an errand. Riku hangs off my arm with all his weight, heels dragging furrows.

"Fight it," he says through his teeth. "Whatever it is, it's your body and his sentence. Take it back."

I fight it. There is nothing to grab. It is like arguing with the current when you are already swimming – the road pulls, the pull is patient, and every time I stop one leg the other has already voted. I get a fistful of dead grass

at the ditch lip and hold on and shake, and my legs walk against the anchor of my own arm until something in my shoulder burns.

"Talk," Riku pants. "You're the talker. Talk."

So I talk – not to him. To the sentence.

"He said home." My voice comes out low and cracked and I let it. "Kōgetsu is gone. There's tape where my street was. Nagihama was never mine – I slept in a shed and owed a woman vegetables. The bar is Machi's, and the back room came with wash-up duty, and if I bring soldiers through her curtain it stops being anyone's home at all." The grass tears. I grab a root instead. "He said go home like it was an address. It isn't an address. It was him. It was a roof and a girl and him, and two of the three are gone, and the third one just–"

Something lets go.

Not like a rope cut. Like a rope that has been hauling on a ring in a wall, and the wall quietly admits there is no ring, there never was, and all that force sits down in the mud at once. My legs stop. All of me stops. I fold onto the ditch grass with my ears ringing and my shirt soaked through and my hands shaking like I have carried something heavy up a long flight of stairs, and Riku sits half on top of me, breathing hard, not letting go of my arm yet.

"You stopped," he says.

"I stopped."

He rolls off me and lies in the ditch looking at the sky, cradling the bad forearm. "Good. Because I have maybe one more of those in me, and then you were going to drag us both into Station Plaza by the ankles."

We lie there while my breath comes back. A truck goes by up on the road – civilian, fish crates – and neither of us moves until it's gone.

"The other sentence," Riku says, eyes still on the sky. "Stop following me. Is that one still in there?"

I try it the way you'd press a bruise – careful, just enough to feel if it still hurts. Stop following me. West is where he went. If I stand up right now and start walking after him, I don't know whether my legs will do it or lock the way they did for home.

"I don't know," I say. "It didn't fray with the first one. It's simpler. It

has him in it, and he isn't gone the way home is."

"So if you turn west right now and try to walk after him, either you can or your legs go on strike again, and we find out which in front of whoever's watching the roads." He sits up, spits grit, and looks at me properly. "That's an experiment for somewhere with fewer rifles."

"Riku." My voice is steadier than I feel. "You could go alone. You're a scrap hauler who got robbed on the road. Next to me, with that rifle bruise, you're an accomplice."

He looks at me for a long second. Then he clicks his tongue, once, and it means what it usually means.

"You still owe me breakfast for a week," he says. "You think I'm letting you disappear owing me food?" He stands, hauls me up by the collar with his good arm, and steadies me with one finger on my chest until I stop swaying – the same as the first day, on a different road. "We go north of the road, cross-country, and we argue about west when your legs are yours for a full hour. Walk, Aoyama. Slowly, this time. Like a person."

We don't get the hour.

The pine road meets the inland road at a crossing with a dry shrine and a concrete water tank, and the crossing has grown a checkpoint since yesterday – one canvas truck, cones, four gray-greens, and a folding table that means somebody intends to stay all day. We see it from the treeline. There is no way around that doesn't mean open field in both directions, and we are two boys who look exactly like two boys avoiding a checkpoint.

"Through it," Riku says grimly. "Fast is guilty. Bored is invisible."

"Let me do the talking."

"That sentence has started to worry me."

The corporal at the table is maybe thirty, with a farmer's neck and a clipboard he writes on slowly, like the pen is expensive. He takes the seasonal-work story the way a man takes weak tea – no objection, no pleasure. I keep my shoulders down and my voice ordinary and answer only what is asked. Where from: the coast, burned out, like everyone. Where to: wherever there's

work that feeds. Papers—

"Papers," he says.

"We were robbed outside Ishibashi in the spring." True, and I give it to him plainly, with the tiredness it deserves. "Three men and a pipe. They took the transit chit and the money. Since then we work for people who don't need paper, and we were hoping to register properly once we—"

And it is working. I can feel it working, the way I could feel it work on gates and clerks all the way down this country — his pen lifts, his shoulders come down half a degree, the day is long and there is a version of the next minute where he waves us through to keep his line moving. The pen hovers over the release column.

Then he catches himself.

I watch it happen. He doesn't know what he is catching — there is nothing to catch, just a polite boy and a tired morning — but some part of him notices that he was about to do something easy, and the noticing offends him. His neck goes red. The pen comes back down like a boot.

"Everyone's boring today," he says, to himself more than to me, and his voice has gone flat and personal. "Whole road full of boring boys, the one morning command has us out here over an assault." He looks up, and now he is actually looking. "Two boys, they told us. One tall one who fights."

"Lot of tall boys on the coast road," Riku says. Easy. Too easy.

"Roll your sleeve up."

The bruise on Riku's forearm has come up purple and yellow through the morning, and it has a shape. Anyone who has done the drills knows the shape. The corporal looks at it the way a man looks at a winning ticket he almost threw away.

"Rifle stock," he says. "Fresh." And then, over his shoulder, not loud, which is somehow worse: "Sergeant. These two."

Riku's mouth opens with something that would have made things worse, and I step on his foot with everything I have.

They are not gentle and they are not cruel. That frightens me more than either would have. They take belts and laces, they pat us down with the

boredom of men who do this in their sleep, and nobody asks a single question about this morning – not who knelt, not who shouted, nothing. The corporal writes. A private wires a paper tag to each of our jackets with a number on it and no line for a name.

"You'll be reviewed," the corporal says, already looking past us at the next body on his road. "Processing will sort what you are."

"Sort us where?" I ask, because a real question is the only tool they haven't taken.

He shrugs. "Inland. There's a facility. You'll eat better than you've been eating, by the look of you." He signs something and tears it and keeps both halves, which tells me more about where we are going than the word facility does.

They put us up into the canvas truck with a bench down each side. There is one other passenger – a gray-stubbed man in a seed-company cap who doesn't look at us, holding his own tag in both hands like it might be exchanged for something later.

Riku settles onto the bench across from me, careful of the arm. Through the open tailgate I watch the checkpoint shrink – cones, shrine, water tank – until a bend takes it. This morning my legs wanted east. The truck is going the other way.

"Hey." He says it quietly, under the engine, and waits until I look at him. "Back in the ditch. Your legs were yours at the end. Whatever pit they're driving us to – remember whose legs they are."

The soldier riding the tailgate leans in and flicks Riku's tag with one finger, friendly as a schoolteacher.

"Don't lose the number," he says. "Boys who lose their number get counted the hard way."

Chapter 25 – Soft Lobby

The truck drives most of the day and picks up four more tags on the way.

A woman who argued with a requisition officer. Two brothers off a farm that couldn't prove it was theirs anymore. A boy of maybe thirteen who cries for the first hour with his whole face and then stops all at once, which is worse. Nobody in the truck talks much. The seed-cap man sleeps sitting up, or does a very good impression of a man who can.

Late afternoon, the canvas goes bright, then shadowed, then bright again – tree line, cut, tree line – and then the truck slows for a gate and I get my first look at where we are going through the gap above the tailgate.

It doesn't look like a prison. It looks like a school that won an award – three stories of pale concrete and long windows set in mown grass, with a flagpole and a paved forecourt and planted saplings still tied to their stakes. Then the truck turns and the rest of it comes into view: the double fence you don't see from the road, the wire's slow curve inward at the top, and a low windowless wing running back from the main building like the handle on a pan.

A signboard faces the gate, white on official blue: SHIZUHARA CIVIL PROTECTION AND RELOCATION CENTER.

"Relocation," Riku reads, flat. "That's a lot of fence for a travel agency."

The lobby is glass and floor wax.

They walk the seven of us in through doors that open by themselves, into a space with the proportions of a bank – high ceiling, a long counter, recycled air that smells of disinfectant with something boiled underneath it. Behind the counter, clerks in civilian gray. Above them, a mezzanine office with glass walls, so whoever works up there can see the whole lobby without standing up.

A man is waiting for us in the middle of the floor, and I take him for an administrator until I see the soldiers' posture change around him.

He is fifty-something and built like a headmaster, in uniform but soft-shouldered, reading glasses pushed up into gray hair. The tape on his chest says HABU. He waits until we are lined up – not barked into line; guided, one hand on a shoulder here and there, the way you seat guests – and then he speaks in a voice pitched for a smaller room, so that everyone leans in a little to hear him. I understand within one sentence that the leaning-in is the point.

"Good evening. I'm Colonel Habu. This building is my responsibility, which means that as of an hour ago, so are you." He looks down the line, and his eyes are attentive and unhurried, and they stop on each face just long enough to be felt. "You've had a frightening day. Some of you are angry, and I'd like to say that's fair. The road has been unkind and the paperwork has been worse. Here is what I can offer: a bed, hot food, a doctor if you need one, and a process. The process is slow, and I won't insult you by pretending otherwise, but it does end, and it ends better for people who let it work." A small smile, self-deprecating, real-looking. "Rules are posted in every corridor. There are only four. You'll find none of them are cruel."

The crying boy – the thirteen-year-old – has started again, quietly. Habu notices before the guards do. He crosses to him, crouches to the boy's height, and speaks too low for me to hear, and whatever he says makes the kid nod and scrub his face with his sleeve. Habu straightens, rests a hand briefly on the boy's head, and turns to the intake counter.

"He hasn't eaten since morning," he tells the clerk, in exactly the voice he used for the rest of it. "Add him to inventory before dinner, please, so he eats under his own number."

The clerk types. Habu said inventory the same way he said hot food – soft, practical, like a boy is a number you add so dinner can find him. The bed and the doctor and the four polite rules are still in the room. That word is what they are for.

Riku has gone very still beside me. He heard it too.

Processing takes the rest of the evening, one of us at a time, in a row of

small rooms off the lobby.

Fingers on a glass plate. A photograph face-on and side-on. Height, weight, a doctor with cold hands who looks at Riku's forearm for a long moment, writes something, and wraps it properly for the first time since the pine road – which Riku accepts with the specific bad grace of a man being done a favor by a building he intends to hate.

Then the booth.

It is the size of a bus-stop shelter, padded inside like a recording studio, with a stool and a microphone and a card taped at eye level. The technician is a young woman who has said her instructions so many times the words have worn smooth.

"Sit. Face the microphone. State your family name, given name, and district of registration, then read the sentence on the card in your normal speaking voice. Don't whisper, don't shout, don't rush."

The card says: I understand the rules of this facility and I agree to cooperate with its staff.

I look at the microphone, and the microphone looks back, and a thing I have no name for turns over slowly in my stomach. Every desk on this road wanted my papers. This is the first one that wants my voice – wants it kept, wants it on file, the way Sato kept stamps. I think of a booth like this one somewhere with Kaito on the stool, and the thought is so bad I have to put it down before it shows on my face.

"Is there a reason it's recorded?" I ask. Normal, curious, nothing leaning on it.

"Voice is harder to fake than paper." She doesn't look up from her list. "Read the card, please."

I read the card in the flattest, most ordinary voice I own – the one for gates and clerks, with nothing under it, nothing leaning on anyone. The machine draws my sentence as a small green mountain range on its screen, thinks about it, and files it away. No light goes red. Nobody comes running. The technician is already looking at her list for the next name.

The not-happening should feel like relief. Instead it walks out of the booth with me: somewhere in this building is a machine that listens to sentences for

a living, and someone taught it what to listen for.

At the forms desk, a tired clerk works down a checklist with Riku while I wait my turn on the bench.

"Prior civil service?" the clerk asks. "Corps registration, defense auxiliary – you're the right age band for the volunteer program."

"No," Riku says.

One word, and I have heard Riku say no a hundred ways – mocking, cheerful, weaponized. This is none of them. It is flat and closed like a shutter coming down, and the clerk glances up at it, and even he, at the end of a long shift, notices there is a room behind the word that nobody is invited into. He marks the box and moves on. Riku's jaw stays set for three more questions.

I don't ask. The road taught me that much – he'll sell it when he's ready.

They walk us to C wing after dinner, down a corridor with a painted line on the floor, and on the way we cross the building's other life.

A door opens somewhere ahead and a line of kids comes through the junction at right angles to us – twenty of them, maybe, thirteen to seventeen, in clean clothes with cloth armbands, walking two by two behind a guard the way a school class walks behind a teacher. They look fed. They look bright – that is the word my head reaches for and I don't like it. A girl near the front waves at us, actually waves, and calls out that dinner is curry on Thursdays, and their guard smiles at her indulgently and tells her to keep the line.

They pass out of sight down their corridor. Ours keeps going.

"Volunteers," says the guard walking us, in answer to nobody. "A and B block. Good kids. Behave and the review board notices, that's all I'll say." He says it warmly, the way you repeat something you have decided to believe.

Riku looks straight ahead at nothing. His jaw is set the same way it was at the forms desk.

C wing is bunks in bays of eight, a wash room that smells of chlorine over rust, and a wall where the four rules are posted exactly as promised. None of them are cruel. All of them are about lines, counts, and doors.

We have been in the bay ten minutes when the mayor arrives.

He is mid-twenties or so, with hair somehow still pomaded in a building that confiscates belts, and he introduces himself as Ōhashi before anyone asks – first to Riku, who ignores him, then to me, who doesn't, which he takes as a lifelong friendship being founded.

"Aoyama, was it? Good bay, this one. I had them move a snorer out last month – I know the day-shift corporal, we have an understanding." He produces a school notebook, fat with pencil, and taps it. "Intake numbers, bunk assignments, who's due at review. I keep track of everybody in C. Somebody has to. Buildings like this, the paper forgets people, but I don't forget people." He says it loudly enough for the nearest three bays to benefit from knowing it.

It costs me two questions and a respectful silence to learn the shape of him: he has been here five months, he is owed favors by half of C wing and collects them in public, and under the vanity he is genuinely useful – he knows which guard trades cigarettes for quiet, which clerk loses forms on purpose out of spite, and what day the review board actually sits, as opposed to the day the corridor rules say it does.

"And the east wing?" I ask it the boring way, the way I'd ask about bus schedules – half attention, folding my blanket while I talk.

"East wing's specials. War paperwork, flagged cases. Different food, different guards – the guards down there don't chat." He lowers his voice to the register of a man giving away stock for free and enjoying it. "They keep the count separate too. I've seen the wall board at the junction when they change shifts. C is forty-one, you two make forty-three. A and B together run about two hundred. East wing never has a number on the board. Just a letter." He frowns, for the first time looking his age instead of like a mayor. "Which is strange, when you think about it, because the whole building runs on numbers. I asked a corporal once and got corridor duty for a week."

He stops. Straightens his hair. Looks like a man who just heard himself talk too much to a stranger.

Lights go to half at the second bell. Somewhere beyond the wash-room wall, a door the size of a garage opens – I feel it in the floor more than hear it – and an engine idles in and settles. Late for deliveries. The kitchen is on the

other side of the building; Ōhashi's tour covered that too.

I lie on a bunk that smells of other people's summers and listen. The engine idles a long time. Then gates, then gears, then gone – heavier leaving than it came, or I am imagining that, lying in the dark with a wired-on number where my name should be.

"Ōhashi," I say quietly, across the bay. He isn't asleep either. Vanity sleeps badly in buildings with wall boards. "The night trucks. Where do they go?"

There is a long pause, and when he answers, for the first time all evening he doesn't sound like the mayor of anything.

"I don't sell that one," he says. "Go to sleep."

Chapter 26 – Volunteers

Morning in C wing starts with a bell that does not care who slept.

They put us on corridor detail before breakfast – mop buckets, a strip of waxed floor from the bay doors to the junction where the painted line splits toward A and B. The day-shift corporal is a woman with a clipboard and a voice that has already decided we are late. She wants the floor dry before the A-block line comes through. She wants quiet. She wants her name kept off any complaint about wet tile.

"You drip on my junction, you polish it again," she says. "You talk while you work, you polish it again. Clear?"

"Clear," I say.

Riku takes the mop without answering. His wrapped forearm is stiff; he switches hands when she isn't looking. Ōhashi appears halfway through the strip with his notebook open, counting heads as if the mop water were a meeting he convened.

"Forty-three still," he announces, loud enough for the corporal. "Nobody wandered overnight. Good bay, Aoyama. I told you."

The corporal does not thank him. She marks something and walks the junction. Ōhashi looks pleased anyway.

I put my head down and push wax. The recycled air tastes like boiled cabbage and bleach. Somewhere past the junction a line of kids laughs – real laugh, not the careful kind – and a guard tells them to keep moving, fondly, the way you tell a class not to run.

Riku's mop slows for half a second. Then he starts again.

Breakfast is rice and something gray that claims to be fish. We eat in a hall with A and B on one side and C on the other, a painted stripe down the middle

nobody crosses without a reason. The armband kids sit brighter than the food. Clean sleeves. Cloth bands with neat stitches. A boy about fourteen argues cheerfully with his neighbor about Thursday curry and whether the review board likes people who smile.

"Good kids," a kitchen guard says to nobody in particular, wiping a tray. "You C lot could learn. Behave, get noticed, get options."

Riku sets his chopsticks down hard enough that the tray jumps. He picks them up again before anyone writes it down as a problem. I watch his jaw do the same thing it did at the forms desk and in the corridor last night. I don't ask across the table. The hall is full of ears.

Ōhashi slides onto the bench beside me with a cup of tea he somehow has and we do not.

"Don't stare at A-block," he says, cheerful. "Makes the guards think you're ambitious. Ambition in C gets you moved to a bay with snorers. Trust me."

"I'm not ambitious."

"Good. Ambition is for people with armbands." He taps the notebook. "I keep C honest. You keep mopping. Everybody stays counted."

"The truck last night," I say, quiet. "You still don't sell that?"

His smile thins. "I still don't. Drink your water, Aoyama. Tea is for friends with seniority."

After breakfast they send three of us – me, Riku, and a seed-cap man from the intake truck – to the service court behind the kitchen to haul empty crates to a loading bay that smells like old ice and diesel. The bay door is shut. Daylight. No night truck. Just a clerk with a stamp and a boy from B-block stacking trays with an armband and a smile that never quite turns off.

"You C?" the B-boy asks me, not unkind. "First week?"

"Second day."

"Stick the corridor work. Review board likes clean floors. My cousin got noticed that way – he's on kitchen now. Hot food twice." He says it like a tip you pay forward. "Volunteers get first pick of the soft jobs. You should put your name in if they open the list."

Riku is behind me with a crate. He goes still – the kind of still that means he heard a word he hates.

“We’re not on that list,” I say.

“Yet,” the boy says, and goes back to stacking.

The clerk stamps our work chit and tells us to bring the next load faster. I use the quiet voice on him – shoulders down, ordinary, the tone that makes people pause when they should not pause – and ask if the bay opens at night for deliveries.

He almost answers. His mouth starts the shape of a yes. Then he blinks, looks at his stamp, and says, “Kitchen schedule isn’t your business. Move the crates.”

It almost worked. My stomach goes cold the way it did in the booth.

Riku watches me sideways as we walk back with empty hands. He does not ask what I tried. He clicks his tongue once, short, and keeps walking.

They give C-wing an hour in the yard after the midday count – a rectangle of mown grass inside the inner fence, and the blank wall of the east wing with nothing looking back. A and B come out in a different slot; we overlap for ten minutes at the gate while they come in and we head for the door.

Armbands. Laughing. A girl waves again, the same one from last night. Her guard smiles.

Riku stops walking.

Not dramatic. Just stopped, in the middle of the line, so the boy behind him bumps his shoulder and swears. A yard guard starts toward us. I put a hand on Riku’s sleeve.

“Move,” I say. “Later.”

He moves. Inside, in the wash room where the chlorine covers most talk, he runs water over his hands longer than hands need and stares at the drain.

“Those bands,” he says. Not looking at me. “We had those.”

“Your town?”

“Ridge town – smaller than Kuroishi.” He shuts the water off, then keeps

talking like he already regrets starting. "When the quota hit, they pulled kids into civil-defense and sewed bands on us. Called it volunteer so they didn't have to write our names down. We walked the perimeter on asset sweeps. Neighbor kids on the line – a runner won't hurt a neighbor's kid. That was what they sold us. They put rifles in our hands that month."

I wait. After the yard, he can't keep it shut.

"A boy ran my stretch," Riku says. "He was fourteen. Somebody had flagged him for being too close to an asset. A soldier shouted to stop him and I fired." He dries his hands on his shirt, rough. "Later they decided the flag didn't hold. One afternoon of theirs. He doesn't get any more afternoons."

He does not say the boy's name. I do not ask for it.

"That's why you said no at the forms desk," I say.

He looks at me then, crooked tooth not showing. "They don't chase volunteers who fold the band and walk. You were never here – that was the other line. Now this place puts the bands on kids and calls them good, feeds them curry talk, and tells C to learn from it." He laughs once, no humor. "I'm not learning. And if some clerk opens a volunteer list under my number, I am going to make a problem, and you are standing too close to be an accident." He tips his chin at the door. "You wanted to know. Now you know. Come on – corporal wants the junction dry before A-block afternoon."

Afternoon puts us back on the junction.

We are on the second wax pass when a man in civilian gray from the mezzanine – not Habu; younger, with a tablet – stops our corporal and points at Riku's wrap, then at me, then at the tablet.

"C intake from the pine-road scoop," he says. "Age band fits the volunteer expansion. Colonel wants soft moves where possible – offer the track before review. Kitchen and yard open slots." He looks at Riku with the polite interest of someone filling a form. "Nakahara. You declined prior service at intake. That was a forms answer. This is a real offer. A-block has bunks. Hot food. The review board sees volunteers first."

Riku's hands are on the mop. The knuckles go white.

"No," he says.

Same flat shutter as the forms desk. The mezzanine man raises his eyebrows.

"You haven't heard the terms?"

"I heard volunteer," Riku says. "That's the whole term."

The corporal shifts her weight. She wants her floor finished. She also wants her name off this. The mezzanine man looks at me.

"Aoyama. You're younger. Same offer. Your friend can stay in C if he's attached to the mop."

I feel the careful voice rising – the one that almost opened the bay clerk. I stop it before it leaves my mouth. This man already listens too easily.

"We'll stay in C," I say, flat, nothing under it. "We're not looking for a track."

"That's a short-sighted answer." He marks the tablet anyway. "Refusal noted. Refusals get reviewed same as acceptances – just slower, and with fewer friends in the kitchen." He glances at Riku's forearm wrap. "And Nakahara – next time a yard guard tells you to keep the line moving, you keep it moving. Standing still in a volunteer gate looks like a statement."

He leaves. The corporal exhales through her nose.

"Finish the strip," she says. "Both of you. And if either of you makes me interesting to the mezzanine again, you polish until second bell."

We finish the strip. Wax. Quiet. Riku does not speak until we are back in the bay with the four polite rules on the wall.

Ōhashi is there with the notebook open, frowning at a page.

"Problem," he says, without his mayor voice. "Midday count on the junction board said C forty-two. I have forty-three names. Someone is wrong, and it isn't me."

"Who's missing on their side?" I ask.

"They don't list names on the board. Just the number." He taps the pencil hard enough to dent the paper. "If their number drops and mine doesn't, either a clerk can't add, or somebody walked a body through a door that doesn't show on C's sheet." He looks at me, then at Riku, then shuts the notebook. "I don't

sell trucks. I sell counts. And today their count is short one."

Riku sits on his bunk and unwraps the end of the bandage to check the bruise. Easier to look at than the board.

"They're counting wrong," he says. "Or they're counting something else."

Outside the wash-room wall, far off, a bay door rolls – daylight this time, a delivery that belongs on a schedule. Still, my shoulders go tight until the engine starts and men shout about ice, ordinary and loud.

Ōhashi stands, hair already being corrected with his palm.

"Tomorrow's morning count," he says. "I'm walking the junction when they write it. Aoyama, you want to be useful, you come. Bring the quiet one if he can keep his feet moving when the armbands go past."

"I'll come," I say.

Riku lies back and puts his good arm over his eyes.

"I'll come," he says to the underside of his elbow. "If anybody offers me a band again, I'm going to need a witness that I said no the boring way."

Chapter 27 – Count

We walk the junction at first bell, before the wax crew, because Ōhashi wants to see the board when the numbers go up wet.

The wall board hangs where the painted lines cross – A left, B right, C back the way we came, and a blank strip toward the east wing with no arrow anyone bothers to repaint. A guard with a tablet stands under it, stylus tapping, while a second guard reads off a clipboard in a bored rhythm. Forty-one. Forty-two. He stops, frowns, starts over.

Ōhashi has his notebook open against his forearm. Riku stands half a step behind me, feet planted, eyes on the east strip as if it might grow a number if he stares hard enough.

“C,” the clipboard guard says. “Forty-two.”

“Write forty-two,” the tablet guard answers, and lifts the marker.

“Forty-three,” says a voice from the east-side corridor.

Not loud. Not polite. The kind of correction you give when the wrong total offends you personally.

A girl steps into the junction light before either guard has turned all the way. Seventeen or eighteen, taller than most of the A-block kids, short practical dark hair, war-issue shirt worn like she picked it. A pale scar runs across the knuckles of her left hand when she reaches for the tablet – not hidden, not shown off. She takes it out of the guard’s hand the way you take a ladle from someone burning soup, taps twice, and finishes the tally herself.

“C is forty-three,” she says. “You skipped the late intake from the pine road – two tags, one bay. They’re on the night sheet. A is ninety-six, not ninety-four; you missed the kitchen runners coming back through B.” She holds the tablet so both guards can see the screen. “East wing stays a letter. Don’t invent a number for it because the column looks lonely.”

The tablet guard’s mouth opens. Closes. The clipboard guard laughs once,

short, like he has lost this argument before.

"Serizawa," he says. "You're supposed to be on the east side of the line."

"I am on the east side of the line." She tips her chin at the blank strip. "Your board is on my way to breakfast. If you hang bad counts in the road, I fix them. That's not a hobby. Bad counts move people."

She writes C-43 on the board in a hand that does not shake, sets the marker in the tray, and only then looks at the three of us from C as if we were furniture that had started talking.

Ōhashi recovers first. His mayor smile comes back on a delay.

"I had forty-three," he says, tapping his notebook. "I've been saying—"

"I don't care what you've been saying," she says. "I care what the board shows when the shift changes." She glances at Riku's wrap, then at my tag. "Pine-road scoop. You're the ones the mezzanine tried to band yesterday."

"How do you know that?" Riku says.

"Corridor duty has ears. Also the mezzanine man complains in a voice built for glass offices." She almost smiles. It is not soft. "I'm Serizawa Mei. You can keep standing in the junction looking grateful, or you can move before this becomes a meeting."

The tablet guard clears his throat. "Serizawa. Back to east. Now. And next time you touch my tablet I write you up."

"Write carefully," Mei says. "Your nines look like fours."

She is already walking. The east corridor takes her.

Ōhashi wants to follow her with thanks. Riku wants to go back to the bay. I want someone who cares about wrong numbers to explain why east is only a letter.

"I'm going to be late for mop," I tell the corporal when she finds us still at the junction. I use the ordinary voice – not the one that almost opened the bay clerk. "We were checking the count. It's fixed."

She looks at the board, sees C-43, and decides we are less interesting than wet tile. "Junction. Now. Serizawa isn't your friend."

"Understood."

We wax. Ōhashi narrates his own correctness for twenty meters and then remembers he has a day-shift corporal to flatter elsewhere. That leaves me and Riku with a stretch of floor and the sound of A-block lining up somewhere we can't see.

"She's not a volunteer," Riku says, quiet, pushing wax.

"She's from the east wing."

"Different clothes. Different mouth. Volunteers don't correct guards in public – not the ones who still flinch." He glances at the east strip as we pass it. "I don't like her. I like that she hates a wrong number. Wrong numbers are how bands get sewn."

"You don't know that."

"I know enough." He puts his head down. "If you chase her for truck stories, do it without me smiling. I have a refusal on a tablet already."

They put C on supply-run to the east junction after midday – not into the wing, just to the painted stop line with a cart of boiled towels and soap. A guard who does not chat checks our tags, takes the cart handle, and tells us to wait. Waiting means looking at a door with a letter on it and no window.

Mei comes out through that door with two empty crates and a list, stops when she sees us, and sighs like we are a chore she did not schedule.

"You're the grateful ones," she says. "Still here."

"We brought towels," I say.

"I can see towels." She dumps the crates on our cart without asking and holds out the list. "Sign that you handed them across the line. If you write the wrong bay I'll walk them back to you myself, and you'll redo the corridor."

I sign. Riku does not. He looks at her face.

"You always steal tablets," he asks, "or only in the morning?"

"I don't steal. I finish." She tips the list at him. "You're the one who said no to the band. Corridor said the quiet boy said no too. That's two

refusals. Mezzanine notices pairs."

"Good," Riku says.

"It isn't good. It's visible." She looks at me. "You. The one who asked a bay clerk about night deliveries yesterday until he almost answered. Don't do that at this door. East guards don't do almost. They write."

My stomach goes cold. "Who told you that?"

"The clerk has a mouth when he's off the stamp. He thought it was funny." She is not laughing. "I fix counts so people don't get moved for ghost numbers. I don't fix boys who lean on strangers for truck routes. What do you want from me that towels don't cover?"

I keep the careful voice out of it. "The board. East is a letter. Night trucks leave from somewhere. Ōhashi won't say where. I want to know if the short count yesterday was a clerk error or a door."

Mei studies me for a long second. Riku shifts his weight – not leaving, not helping.

"Yesterday's short count was a clerk error," she says. "I checked the night sheet. Your two tags were late-posted. Nobody walked out of C." She pauses. "That isn't the same as nobody walking out of the building."

"The trucks," I say.

"I don't sell that one either." Same flat no as Ōhashi, sharper. "Ask me about counts. Ask me about which guard can't add. Ask me why A-block smiles on Thursdays. Don't ask me for bay doors on a towel run."

"Then what do you want?" Riku says, blunt. "You corrected the board in front of us. That wasn't free."

Mei almost looks amused. "I want you to stop making the junction interesting. Every time C refuses a band and then loiters under the board, someone upstairs adds a note, and notes are how people leave this building without anyone asking where." She nods at the letter-door. "I live on the other side of that. When C makes a mess, they clamp my side down, and I lose track of who still has a bed."

"So we owe you boring," I say.

"You owe me a clean board and your feet on your side of the line." She takes

the signed list back. "If the morning count is wrong again, I'll be there. If you bring me a wrong count on purpose to get a conversation, I'll give you corridor duty and I won't make it a joke."

"Serizawa," the silent guard says from the door.

"Coming." She picks up one empty crate as if she still needs a reason to turn. Then, over her shoulder, not quite looking at us: "Pine-road boys. If the mezzanine offers the band again, say no the same way twice. Different nos read like a negotiation."

She goes. The letter-door shuts. The guard points us back toward C with the cart.

Ōhashi intercepts us at the C turn, notebook already open.

"Well?" he says. "Did the east girl admit I was right?"

"She fixed the board," I say. "She said yesterday was a late post, not a missing body."

He brightens, then catches himself and smooths his hair. "Of course it was a late post. I don't miss bodies." He lowers his voice. "She's Serizawa. East. War paper. Don't make her a project, Aoyama. East projects end with fewer friends and the same trucks."

"I'm not making a project."

"You're making a face like a project." He taps the notebook. "Morning count tomorrow. I'm there. You're there if you can be dull. Bring Nakahara if he promises not to stop walking when the armbands pass."

Riku clicks his tongue once.

"I'll walk," he says. "I'm not waving at her."

"Nobody asked you to wave," Ōhashi says, and sails off toward a corporal who might still be flattered.

In the bay, Riku sits on his bunk and rewraps the forearm without asking for help. I sit across from him.

"She'll be at the board again tomorrow," he says.

"So will I."

He ties the wrap off with his teeth and his good hand. "Fine. If she starts offering bands, I'm out of the junction. I'll sit through a count. I'm not putting one on."

"She didn't offer."

"Not this morning." He lies back. "Give them a day."

Second bell. Lights halfway down. Far off, past the wash-room wall, a bay door rolls and an engine settles into idle – night schedule this time, not ice shouting. I listen until the gears take it away. Heavier leaving, or the same trick my ears played the first night.

Riku's voice comes out of the dim, dry.

"If the board goes short again," he says, "and she isn't there to call it a clerk error – we don't take Ōhashi's notebook for it. We check the bunks. See who's gone."

"Alright."

"Sleep, Aoyama. First bell doesn't wait."

Chapter 28 – Bunks

First bell. We are at the junction before the wax water is warm.

Ōhashi has the notebook open against his forearm the way other people hold a shield. Riku stands half a step behind me, feet planted, eyes on the east strip. The blank letter waits. Mei does not walk out of it.

The tablet guard lifts his marker. The clipboard guard reads in the same bored rhythm as yesterday.

"C," he says. "Forty-two."

Ōhashi's pencil stops.

"Write forty-two," the tablet guard answers, and writes it. Wet black. No correction from the east corridor. No Serizawa taking the tablet out of anyone's hand. A-block gets ninety-six. B gets its number. East stays a letter because nobody invents one for it today, and nobody is here to stop them if they tried.

"That's wrong," Ōhashi says, too loud for a junction with ears. "I have forty-three. I checked at lights. I—"

"Board says forty-two," the tablet guard says, not looking at him. "If your notebook wants a fight, take it to the corporal. Move."

Riku does not look at me. He does not have to. Last night's deal sits between us without words: if the board goes short and she isn't here, we do not take the notebook for it. We check the bunks.

"Ōhashi," I say. "Bay. Now."

He wants to argue with the marker. Vanity always wants the public win. Then he sees our faces and shuts the notebook on his thumb like a man closing a door on his own fingers.

"Fine. Fine. We'll prove it. I don't miss bodies."

C-wing smells like chlorine and sleep and the gray fish from yesterday. Eight bunks to a bay. Ours is the third along the wash-room wall. Men sit up as we come through – the day-shift corporal's whistle has already started the corridor line, and half the bay is still pulling on shirts.

"Stay," Ōhashi says, mayor voice cracking. "Nobody leave until I say. I am counting."

He walks the aisle with the notebook open. Name. Bunk. Face. The seed-cap man from the crate run is not on his mattress. The blanket is folded the way Habu's polite rules like blankets folded. The tag hook above the pillow is empty. The space under the bunk where he kept his cracked plastic cup is empty too.

Ōhashi's pencil finds the line and stops.

"Katō," he says. Quiet now. "Katō Hiroshi. Intake from the pine road same truck as you two. Bay three. He was here at second bell. I saw him. He asked me for a cigarette and I told him Tuesday."

Riku crouches and puts his good hand on the mattress as if the bed might still be warm. It isn't.

"He's gone," Riku says.

"Transfer," someone from the next bunk offers, helpful the way people are helpful when they want the counting to stop. "Review board pulls overnight sometimes. Kitchen said–"

"Kitchen doesn't pull people," Ōhashi snaps. Then he hears himself and smooths his hair with a palm that shakes. "I don't miss bodies. The board is wrong. He is on a detail. He is in the wash room. He–"

We check the wash room. Two sinks. One clogged drain. No Katō. We check the corridor strip. The corporal's line is already moving toward breakfast. No seed cap. No cracked cup. No man who complained about crate weight and then laughed at his own complaining.

The day-shift corporal finds us standing in the bay like we have invented a new way to be late.

"Junction," she says. "Now. Or I put all three of you on polish until second bell."

"Katō Hiroshi," Ōhashi says. He holds the notebook out like evidence in a play. "Bay three. Board says forty-two. I have him written. Where is he?"

She looks at the empty bunk. She looks at the notebook. She looks at us the way she looks at wet tile – a problem with a procedure attached.

"Overnight move," she says. "Review track. You don't get a speech about it, Ōhashi. C doesn't get speeches. He was due. They took him. Board is right. Your notebook is behind."

"Due for what?" I ask. Ordinary voice. Shoulders down. Nothing under it. Mei's warning sits in my teeth: east guards write; bay clerks gossip; do not lean.

"Due for review," she says, and the word has the same warm shine the kitchen guard puts on volunteer. "Behave, get noticed, get options. Some options happen at night. You want to argue with the board, argue with Habu's office. You want to mop, mop. Empty bunks don't wait for feelings."

Riku's jaw does the forms-desk thing. He does not speak. If he speaks, the word volunteer will come out, and the junction will hear it.

Ōhashi opens his mouth. Closes it. For the first time since the lobby, he looks like a man who has been here five months and just learned the building can forget a name he refused to forget.

"Write him gone, then," he says, and his voice is small. "If you're going to be right, be right in my book too."

"I don't write your book," the corporal says. "Junction. All of you."

Breakfast is the same rice and the same gray claim of fish. Katō's tray space on our bench stays open until a boy from bay five sits in it without asking. Ōhashi does not eat. He draws a line through a page and keeps staring at the line as if it might apologize.

"Review track," he mutters once, not to us. "They don't pull review at night. Review sits on Thursdays. I know which day. I know."

"Eat," Riku says.

"I don't want—"

"Eat anyway. Empty stomachs make loud mistakes."

Ōhashi eats two bites and stops. Across the painted stripe, A-block laughs about Thursday curry. An armband girl waves at nobody in particular.

I keep my eyes on my chopsticks. The careful voice wants to stand up and ask the room where overnight moves go. I leave it sitting. Mei already knows I almost opened a clerk. I am not giving the hall another story.

Corridor wax. The corporal puts us on the strip that faces the east blank as if she wants us to look at the letter while we work. Riku pushes water. I push water. Ōhashi does not appear with tea. Vanity is somewhere rewriting a page that used to make him feel necessary.

Midmorning, a mezzanine man in civilian gray – not the band-offer one; older, thinner – walks the junction with a tablet and stops long enough to glance at our tags. He does not offer a band. He marks something and leaves. Visible, Mei said. Pairs get noticed. Being noticed without a band is still being noticed.

"Don't look at him," Riku says.

"I wasn't."

"You were about to ask him something with your face." He does not grin. "Keep the face boring. We already have one empty bunk."

Mei finds us at the east supply line after midday, not at the morning board.

They send C with the towel cart again. Same painted stop. Same letter-door with no window. Same silent guard. Mei comes through with a crate of boiled cloth and a mouth already set for an argument she has been having somewhere else.

"You're late," she says, before we can speak. "East held me for a recount on the war sheet. Your junction wrote forty-two without me. I heard it from a runner who can't add."

"Katō Hiroshi," I say. "Bay three. Empty bunk. Corporal called it an overnight review move."

Mei sets the crate down harder than cloth needs.

"Show me the board number when you get back," she says. "If C is forty-two on the wall and forty-two in the bay, the wall isn't lying today." She looks at Riku. "You checked beds?"

"We checked," Riku says.

"Good." Not praise. Confirmation. "Don't check again in front of the corporal. She writes boys who invent missing people, and then those boys get a review of their own."

"He isn't invented," Ōhashi says. He has appeared at the C turn with the notebook shut tight under his arm, hair wrong for the first time. "I had him. Pine-road intake. Seed cap. He owed me a cigarette joke on Tuesday."

Mei studies Ōhashi the way she studies bad tallies – as a thing that will move people if left alone.

"Then stop saying his name in the junction," she says. "Say it in your bay if you have to. Public names make public problems, and public problems on my side of the line get people pulled for recounts they do not come back from." She tips the list at me. "Sign for the towels. And listen carefully, pine-road: I told you yesterday that a clerk error is not the same as nobody walking out of the building. Today somebody walked. That does not mean you get to lean on bay doors and clerks for a map. It means you keep your feet on your side and your mouth ordinary."

"Where do overnight review moves go?" I ask.

She almost answers. I see the shape of it – not kindness, irritation at a stupid question with a real hole under it. Then the silent guard shifts his weight, and Mei's eyes flick to him, and the almost dies.

"I don't sell routes," she says. "I sell clean boards. Your board is clean now. Your bay is short one. Those can both be true." She takes the signed list. "If you chase Katō through the service court in daylight, you will get corridor duty and I will not help you out of it. If you are going to be stupid, be stupid when fewer people are watching."

Riku clicks his tongue once.

"That's not a no," he says.

"It isn't a map either," Mei says. "Move the cart. East is done looking at you for today."

She goes. The letter-door shuts. The silent guard points us back toward C.

Ōhashi walks beside me for ten meters without the mayor voice.

"Tuesday," he says. "He was going to laugh at the cigarette. I don't – I don't lose Tuesdays."

"We know," I say.

"I keep track of everybody in C." He opens the notebook, looks at the struck line, and closes it again. "Somebody has to. If the board can be right while my book is wrong, then the board is counting a different building than the one I sleep in."

Riku glances at him, then at me.

"Second bell," Riku says. "We listen again. And if the bay door opens, we don't ask a clerk where the truck goes. We look."

Ōhashi swallows. The part of him that runs this corridor wants to forbid it. The part that got struck off the Tuesday list wants something else.

"If you get caught," he says, "I never heard this. If you don't get caught – you tell me if you see him. I am not rewriting Tuesday for a story."

"Alright," I say.

We finish the corridor strip. Wax. Quiet. The afternoon count keeps C at forty-two on the wall. Katō's bunk stays empty. Nobody invents him back into the number. Somewhere past the junction an armband line laughs, and a guard tells them fondly not to run.

Second bell is still an hour out when the outer lights slam on.

Not the soft lobby strips. The hard white ones on the west fence – the ones that stay dark unless someone upstairs decides the wire needs to be seen. They throw a hard square of glare across the junction floor through the high window. Boots hit the painted line at a run. A corporal goes past with a rifle up, not a clipboard. He does not look at us. He looks at the west doors like they owe him an answer.

"Perimeter," someone shouts from the mezzanine stair. "West fence. No C in the service court. East locks now."

Ōhashi's notebook is already open. His pencil hangs over the page and does nothing useful.

"That isn't a night truck," Riku says. "Night trucks don't put rifles in the junction."

"I know."

Mei comes through the letter-door before the silent guard can finish locking it. She has no towel cart. Her hands are white on the frame.

"Pine-road," she says, fast, for us and not for the junction. "Do not go to the bay. Do not stand under the board inventing reasons. East is locking because the west wire has company, and when the wire has company every empty bunk becomes a story they write wrong." She looks once at Ōhashi's open notebook. "Keep his name in the bay. Not in the corridor."

"Who is on the fence?" I ask.

"If I knew a name worth saying, I still wouldn't say it with a rifle in the hall." The silent guard's hand finds her shoulder. She shakes it off once, then lets him have it. "Stay on your side of the line. Do not give them a reason to walk anyone else out of C while the fence is lit – you already have one empty bunk they can write any story on."

"Katō isn't—" Riku starts.

"I know what Katō isn't," Mei says. "I also know what a doubled perimeter does to review schedules. Keep his name out of the junction. Do not give them a second problem while they are looking for a first."

The letter-door shuts. The lock turns. Through the high window the west lights stay hard and white. Another pair of boots runs the junction. Somewhere outside a motor turns over that is not the canvas-truck idle we have been listening for – too light, too close to the fence line, cut off like someone killed the engine on purpose.

Ōhashi shuts the notebook, then opens it again to the C list. His hair is wrong. For once he does not fix it.

"Bay is closed," Riku says. "Fence is someone else's fight. So what—"

"So we use their eyes being west," Ōhashi cuts in. He taps the notebook hard enough that the pencil jumps. "Every corporal in this hall is looking at the wire. Nobody is watching who still has a mattress. We check every bunk in C against my book before upstairs invents another review and calls it tidy." He looks at me, then at Riku. "You two know bay three. I take one through four. You take five through eight. Wake them. Match names. If anyone is gone besides Katō, I want it in pencil before a guard writes it in marker."

"And if a corporal comes back mid-count?" Riku asks.

"Then we were doing a hold check like good inventory," Ōhashi says, and there is no mayor smile in it. "I am tired of learning my bay is short from a wall. Move."

We move.

Bay three first – our own. Seven heads. Katō's hook still holds his seed-company cap. His cup is still under the bunk. Nobody took the small things a review move usually packs. Riku swears once under his breath and marks nothing; there is nothing to mark except the empty mattress.

"He didn't pack," I say.

"I know," Riku says. "Wake the next bay."

Five has eight. Six has eight, one of them arguing until Ōhashi's voice from the corridor shuts him up. Seven has seven and a boy who tries to claim the eighth bunk is on kitchen detail; we walk him to the wash-room door and find the eighth asleep behind it with a towel over his face. Ōhashi writes the correction without looking pleased. Eight is full.

We meet back at the junction under the high window. The west glare is still on. A second set of floodlights has kicked farther along the wire. The mezzanine voice comes soft through the stairwell:

"All blocks hold. Inventory stays put until the west is clear."

Ōhashi holds the open notebook between us. One struck line. Forty-two living names. No second gap.

"C is short one," he says. "Only Katō. Cap and cup still here. That is not a man who walked to a review with a bag." He closes the book. "I cannot take

this to the board while they have rifles in the hall. I can keep it until morning, and if the wall tries to call forty-one, I have paper that says otherwise."

"He left his cap," Riku says. "People who get walked to a real review take their cup. Somebody moved him, or he walked himself toward the noise on the west side. Either way I'm not waiting in bay three for a corporal to explain it tomorrow."

"Mei told us to stay off the bay," I say.

"I'm not going to open the bay door." The motor turns over once more outside – short, close, then dead. Riku looks at the bright window, then at me. "There's a stair by the kitchen that looks down on the service court. We used it when we hauled towels. From up there we can see if a truck is loading, or if the guards are shooting at the fence. That's all I want – eyes on it. Then we come back."

"And if they catch us in the west corridor?"

"Then we say Ōhashi sent us to check the kitchen hold, which is almost true." He glances at Ōhashi. "You going to deny that if they ask?"

Ōhashi's mouth opens, then shuts. He shoves the notebook under his arm.

"If you get caught, you got lost on a hold check," he says. "If you see Katō, you come tell me before you tell a corporal. I am staying in bay three. Somebody has to be here when they count heads again."

"Alright," I say.

Riku is already moving toward the west corridor the corporals just emptied. Bad arm tucked in. Good hand empty.

"Ordinary faces," he says without looking back. "Don't touch any door we can't explain. We look, and we leave."

We take the west corridor at a walk we keep slow and even. The floodlight glare gets brighter with every turn. Behind us Ōhashi stays under the junction board with his pencil and his list. Ahead, the kitchen stair smells like boiled fish and cold air from a door that should be shut.

Riku hits the first step.

"Come on, Aoyama," he says. "Before someone remembers we belong in C."

I go up after him.

Chapter 29 – Breach Window

We kill the truck engine in the ditch short of the west fence and sit in the dark until the floodlights tell us whether anyone saw the last hundred meters.

They did not. Not yet. The lights are still dark on this stretch. Mira has her hand on my wrist the way she does when she wants the mouth shut before it starts. Suzumori is in the back seat with the contact, stick of wood crooked in her hair, eyes on the pale concrete block that does not look like a prison from the road.

"Shizuhara," Mira says. Low. "Civil Protection and Relocation. That is the cover on the gate sign. Inside it is where they put people who saw the wrong sweep, or carried the wrong flag, or knew a name somebody upstairs did not want walking around – volunteers, irregulars, and the ones they keep in the letter-wing." She does not look at me when she says the next part. "Including at least one person my road will not leave in there."

"You said extract," I say. "You did not say a building with a double fence and floodlights."

"I said a clean extract. The fence is why it has to be clean." She tips her chin at the dark wire. "We use the west service road and come in at the loading bay behind the kitchen wing. East wing holds the specials – that is the target. We do not walk the lobby. We do not invent a story for a colonel. We cut the outer wire where the contact marked, we take the service door the night clerk leaves unlatched for crate runs, and we are gone before the second count notices a gap."

Suzumori makes a dry sound in the back.

"And if the latch isn't open?"

"Then we leave," Mira says. "That is the whole point of clean. No loud mouth on the first door. No rifles in a corridor full of kids. You open one door if paper fails. One. Then we move."

I watch the fence. My shoulder still pulls when I turn too far. Haruki is east of us somewhere with Riku, or he is not, and I do not get to know which from a ditch.

"Why this building?" I ask. "Why not wait for a transfer truck the way you did with Suzumori?"

"Because the transfer trucks from here do not go somewhere we can reach." Mira's voice stays level. "The contact has been counting night loads for three weeks. People leave. The review board stamps it tidy. Nobody comes back to argue the stamp. If we wait for a soft transfer, we are waiting for a story they already wrote."

"So we steal their inventory before they finish the paperwork," the contact says from the back, not joking hard enough to make it funny.

Mira does not correct the word. That is worse than if she had.

"We take one person out of east," she says. "Maybe two if the second is already at the door. We do not clear a wing. We do not make a speech. Kaito – if I say abort, you abort. If a kid walks into the hall, you do not use your mouth to make the kid useful. Clear?"

"Clear," I say.

Suzumori leans forward until I have to look at her.

"Boy," she says. "You put weight on a friend the last time a road got loud. Do not put weight on a building full of children because a door is slow. That mouth cuts both ways. I am still saying it."

"I heard you on the pine road."

"Hearing me once is not the same as doing it when it gets loud." She sits back. "Go. Or do not. Do not half-go and then invent a reason to finish what Mira told you not to start."

Mira opens her door. The night air smells like cut grass. She looks at me once – not begging, not soft. Checking whether I am going to be a problem before we reach the wire.

"Service ditch," she says. "If I stop, you stop. If I run, you run. We are not here to prove anything about your throat."

"Then what am I here for?"

"The one door paper will not open," she says. "Same as the quiet floors. After that you are a pair of hands and a scraped voice we keep quiet. Walk."

The outer wire is farther from the road than it looked from the ditch.

We go on foot through scrub that has been cut back in the last month – fresh ends, no cover worth naming. The contact leads. Mira counts under her breath, not numbers for show, just the paces between the marks the contact chalked two nights ago when the patrol was on the east side. Suzumori stays with the truck. Mira would not bring her to the wire, and Suzumori would not stay if she thought the boy needed watching more than the exit did. They settled it without me.

At the cut, the contact produces cutters from under her jacket and works without talking. The wire sings once. Mira flinches at the sound. I keep my hands free and my mouth shut.

"Through," the contact whispers. "Low. The inner fence is another twenty meters. Blind spot under the camera if you stay on the painted drain."

We go. Gravel bites through my boots. The building rises ahead – pale concrete, long windows, a flagpole that looks like a school until you see the inward curve of the wire on top of the second fence. Floodlights on this stretch are still dark. Somewhere east, through the body of the building, a different white glare is already up. Mira notices. Her jaw tightens.

"They lit the far side," she says.

"Not us," the contact says. "Not yet. Keep moving."

The inner fence has a service gate with a padlock that should be serious and is not. The contact has a key that does not belong to her. She does not explain it. Mira does not ask in front of me. The gate opens on a hinge that has been oiled recently. That is either luck or someone inside who still thinks crate runs matter more than rifles.

We cross into the shadow of the kitchen wing. The loading bay door is a black mouth ahead. No canvas truck. No clerk with a stamp. A radio plays something cheerful through a wall.

Mira stops us flat against the concrete.

"Listen," she says.

I listen. Boots on a mezzanine somewhere inside – not the bored walk of a night count. Faster. A voice, soft even through glass and distance, saying something about holding blocks. Another voice answers about the west fence.

About us.

"They saw the truck," I say.

"Or they saw the cut," Mira says. "Or they are jumpy because somebody else is jumpy. It does not change the job. Service latch, east stair, back out the cut. If the bay is hot we abort at the door and we do not argue in the open."

The contact checks her watch by feel.

"Night clerk on the service latch has four minutes in his smoke habit," she says. "After that he comes back and the latch is his again. You want clean, this is the clean window. After this you get loud or you get nothing."

Mira looks at me.

"Door," she says. "If he is there, you ask him to open and forget. If he is not, I open. Either way we are inside in under a minute or we are gone. Ready?"

"Ready."

We move along the wall to the green service door under a dead bulb. The contact was right about the smoke habit – the latch is off, the clerk is a shape at the far corner of the bay with his back to us and a cigarette making a small orange point. Mira's hand finds the handle.

Then the west floodlights slam on.

Hard white paints the bay, the wire, our boots, and the cut we left in the outer fence. The clerk drops his cigarette and turns. Somewhere above us a door bangs. The soft mezzanine voice is not soft anymore when it hits the stairwell speakers.

"West perimeter. Hold all blocks. Inventory stays put."

Mira's plan is still on her face for half a second – abort, ditch, truck. Then the clerk sees us, and his mouth opens around a shout, and the clean window is already dead.

"Open the door," I say, and I put the weight under it before Mira can pull me back. "You never saw us. Face the wall."

Copper hits the back of my nose. The clerk's eyes empty the way the quiet-floor clerk's did. He turns to the wall. His hands hang. The shout dies in his throat without becoming sound.

Mira stares at me hard enough to cut.

"I said if I say abort—"

"You didn't say abort," I say. My voice scrapes. Blood is already starting on my lip. "You told me to get the door open. The lights hit, he saw us, and he was about to bring the whole west side down on our heads. What did you want me to do — wait for him to finish the shout?"

The contact is already through, holding the service door with her shoulder. "Finish this inside. The ditch is lit."

Mira goes through. I follow. The door shuts on the white glare and the bay smells like ice melt and old fish. Behind us the clerk stands facing the wall as ordered. Ahead, a concrete stair goes up into the building that called us inventory over a speaker.

"East wing is two turns past the kitchen junction," the contact says, moving. "Specials door has a letter on the shift board, not a number. Do not stop for A or B. Do not look at the kids if they look at you."

"Kaito." Mira catches my sleeve at the first landing. She keeps her voice down and she does not waste it on the blood. "That was the one door. You do not open the next one because you are angry at lights. You open it because I point at it. Say you heard me."

"I heard you."

"Say you will do it."

I look at her. The scraped voice wants a shorter answer than she is asking for. The building's recycled air sits in my throat with the blood.

"I will open the door you point at," I say. "I will not invent a second job while you are still selling the first one."

She holds my eyes a second longer, then nods once, small, like she heard me and does not fully trust it.

"Then keep your mouth shut until I point," she says. "Move."

The kitchen junction is empty of cooks and full of the wrong kind of quiet.

A line of kids in armbands is frozen against the far wall where a guard told them to hold – thirteen, fourteen, clean clothes, cloth bands on their sleeves. They watch us pass the way people watch a fire in the next building: close enough to feel heat, not close enough to know if they should run. One of them almost lifts a hand. The guard's rifle tip comes up an inch. The hand drops.

Mira does not look at them. The contact does not look at them. I look once and then I do not, because looking turns them into a problem my mouth wants to solve, and Mira already told me what happens if I invent a second job.

We take the east turn. The shift board on the wall has columns in wet marker – A, B, C – and a blank strip with a letter painted where a number should be. East. No count. The contact was not guessing.

Boots hit the west corridor behind us. Not ours.

"Faster," Mira says.

The specials door is a plain door with a card reader and a guard who is not silent so much as bored past speech. He sees Mira first, then me, then the blood on my lip, and his hand goes to the radio on his shoulder.

Mira points at the door.

I do not wait for a cleaner sentence than the one that gets us through.

"Open it. Drop the radio. You forget that we were here."

He opens it. The radio hits the floor. His eyes go empty and stay that way. My nose prickles high up and the edge of the hall goes gray. Mira catches my elbow when my knees tip, and we are through the letter-door into a corridor that smells like disinfectant and old paper, and the contact pulls the door shut on the hold order still rolling through the speakers.

Behind the first glass panel on the right, a girl about seventeen looks up from a tablet as if we are late for an appointment she did not book. Short dark hair. War-issue shirt. She does not scream. She does not smile. She takes in the blood on my mouth and Mira's grip on my arm and the contact's cutters

still in her fist, and her first words are not a greeting.

"You lit the west fence," she says. "Do you have any idea what that does to a night count?"

Mira steadies me against the wall.

"We're here to pull someone out of the east wing," Mira says. "War paperwork hold – not a volunteer. You can yell at us about the fence once we're moving."

The girl stands. The tablet stays in her hand like she does not trust the room without it.

"I am Serizawa Mei," she says. "And you just made every empty bunk in this building into a story Habu will write before morning. If you came to extract someone, you came on the wrong night – or you came as the reason the wrong night started." She looks at me again, at the scraped voice, at the blood still wet on my lip. "Which door did you open to get in here?"

"Service door off the bay, then this one," I say. "Paper wasn't going to do either."

Mei glances at the specials door we came through, then at Mira.

"Then your clean extract is already dirty," she says. "Tell me who you came for before the west corridor finishes counting boots – and tell me whether you plan to leave the rest of us holding still while the speakers call us inventory."

Chapter 30 – Inventory Language

"We came for you," Mira says.

Mei does not blink. The tablet light puts a hard square on her face. Boots are still counting somewhere west of the letter-door – not running yet, not calm either.

"You're Serizawa Mei," Mira says. "You've been in the east wing on a war hold. People I trust have been trying to reach you for three weeks. We cut the fence tonight because the trucks that leave here don't bring anyone back to a place we can find." She tips her chin at me, then at the contact. "We can get you to the service door and out to the ditch. We can't empty the whole building. That was never the plan."

"And the armbands in the kitchen junction?" Mei asks. "The ones the speakers just called inventory. Do they walk with us, or do they stay on the wall looking grateful while you take the one person your friends asked for?"

"They stay," Mira says. Flat. Not cruel – already decided. "We can't put two hundred kids through a lit fence. We can move you."

"Then you didn't come for me," Mei says. "You came for one name you can leave with." Her eyes go to the blood on my lip, then past me to the specials guard still facing the wrong way in the hall with his radio on the floor. "That man isn't sleeping. You told me paper wouldn't open those doors. Fine. Whatever you did, you look like it cost you. How much farther can you walk before somebody has to carry you?"

"Far enough," I say.

"That isn't an answer." She turns the tablet so we can see a shift board pulled up on the screen – A, B, C, and a blank east strip. "A and B are still on hold in the junctions. C is locked to their bays. East is locked because your fence trick made Habu nervous. If I walk out with you right now, upstairs will blame every empty bunk on Remnant, and then they'll shove the volunteers

who smiled at Thursday curry onto a review truck that doesn't come back." She holds my eyes. "I've watched that from the letter side. I'm not leaving so you can feel useful."

Mira's jaw tightens.

"We didn't come here to feel useful. We came because you're next on that truck."

"So are they," Mei says. "Difference is, you only booked one seat. They get armbands and a soft voice calling it care." She lowers the tablet. "If you want me through that door, you look at what this building does when it gets nervous. Not a speech – go look. Then we talk about walking."

The contact shifts her weight. Cutters still in her fist. "West corridor is filling. We do not have a debate hour."

"Then walk while we debate," Mei says. "Kitchen junction. You already passed it. The kids are still there. If you can look at them and still call this a clean pull, I'll go with you and I won't argue once. If you can't – you stop pretending the fence was for me alone."

Mira looks at me. I wipe my lip on my wrist. The blood is already drying.

"Let's have a look at the junction," I say. "We will decide after."

Mira hates it, but she does it anyway.

We go back through the specials door with Mei between us like we already decided she was ours to move.

The hold order is still on the speakers – soft, almost polite, the kind of voice that makes people lean in. All blocks hold. Inventory stays put until the west is clear. The specials guard we clashed with is still facing the wrong way in the hall, radio on the floor, eyes empty. Mei does not look at him. She looks at the wet marker columns on the shift board as we pass – A, B, C, blank east – and her mouth goes thin.

The kitchen junction smells like boiled fish and floor wax and fear sweat.

The armband kids are still against the far wall. Two lines. Cloth bands on their sleeves. Thirteen to seventeen, clean shirts, the bright wrong faces of people who have been told they are lucky. A guard walks the line with a rifle

that is not quite aimed at them and not quite aimed away. He talks the way a teacher talks during a fire drill.

"Stay on the painted line. Do not ask about dinner. Do not ask about the lights. You are being good. Good inventory gets counted first when this is over."

One girl near the front – fourteen, maybe – lifts her hand like she has a question in school. The guard smiles at her, fond, and pushes her wrist back down with two fingers.

"Not now, sweetheart. Hold still."

We cut along the opposite wall. Mira wants us invisible. Mei will not let us be. She slows enough that I have to see the lines – the way the kids' eyes follow my scraped voice and then drop, the way one boy mouths volunteer under his breath like it is a prayer and a boast at the same time.

On the C side of the painted line, past the junction board, two shapes are on the kitchen stair – tags, not armbands, frozen mid-climb as if the floodlight glare caught them doing something stupid. I do not look long enough to make faces. Mira's hand finds my sleeve and pulls. The contact hisses once. We keep moving. The shapes stay shapes.

A speaker crackles above the fish smell. A voice fills the junction without raising itself – warm, unhurried, the kind that makes people lean in to hear.

"Good evening. This is Colonel Habu. The west perimeter event is under control. Thank you for holding so quietly – that helps us keep everyone safe." A pause, warm enough to be real. "A and B blocks, remain on your junction lines. You will be processed for evening review in small groups once the service court is cleared. C block, stay in your bays. East wing, remain sealed. Inventory that cooperates eats warmer food and sleeps in the same bed tomorrow. Inventory that invents stories invents problems. I would rather feed you than explain you to a clipboard. Hold."

So that is Habu. Mei already used the name like everyone here should know it. The voice matches the warmth she was angry about.

The fourteen-year-old on the line nods, like he has promised her something kind.

Mei watches my face while he talks. She does not smile.

"There," she says, quiet, for me and not for the guard. "Same voice that gave a crying boy a dinner number. Same voice that will line these two rows for the bay when the court clears. Are you still calling this a clean night?"

Mira's answer is already forming – abort, ditch, one name, live to fight – and I do not want to hear it yet.

"Where do the review groups go?" I ask Mei.

"Service court. Canvas truck. Out the west gate if the fence is quiet enough." She tips her chin toward a side corridor that smells less like fish and more like diesel. "There is a clerk window above the bay with the night schedule. If you came to open doors, open that one. I want you to read the sheet before you ask me to thank you for saving me."

"And if the sheet says what you think?" Mira asks.

"Then you stop talking about clean," Mei says. "And we decide what dirty is worth."

The side corridor is narrow glass on one side, looking down into the lobby we never walked.

Floodlights from the west throw white across the floor wax below. Clerks at the long counter type without looking up. On the mezzanine – the glass office above the lobby – a man in uniform with reading glasses in his hair stands with a tablet, speaking too softly for us to hear through the glass. Habu. Soft shoulders. Attentive. He points once at the west doors and once at the counter, and a clerk nods like she has been handed a gift.

Beside him, not in uniform, a man in a dark coat stands with his hands empty and his weight easy. He does not hurry. He does not look at Habu's tablet. He watches the lobby like he has already decided what happens next and is only waiting for the clerks to catch up. For half a second his face turns toward the glass corridor – not seeing us, not missing us either – and the calm on him sits wrong against the rifles and the floodlights.

Then a clerk crosses between us and the mezzanine, and when the angle clears, the coat is gone. Only Habu remains, pointing at another column on his screen.

"Kaito," Mira says. "Don't invent faces in the glass. We have a window to crack."

"I wasn't inventing."

"Then forget him. We do not have a second hunt tonight."

Mei is already at the clerk window – a half-door above a short stair, dark, smelling of paper and cold metal. The contact works the latch with a tool that is not a key. It gives. Inside: a stool, a stamp box, a clipboard hung on a nail, and a printed night sheet under a clip.

Mei pulls the sheet and holds it in the corridor light.

I read over her shoulder because she makes space on purpose.

Evening review – A/B volunteer track. Staging: service court. Load: canvas, west gate. Destination: blank. Notation in a clerk's hand: contingency ready if perimeter remains hot. Habu auth.

No poetry. No speech. Just a blank where a town should be, and a soft colonel's name under it.

Mira's breath goes out through her teeth.

"That is a transfer list," she says. "Ugly. Not proof they die."

"The destination is blank," Mei says. "Transfers have towns. This has a gate and a canvas side and a note that says the colonel is ready if the fence stays interesting." She looks at me. "Your fence. Your mouth. Their truck. Still want to pull one girl and call the night finished?"

The contact is watching the stair behind us. "Boots. Two turns back. Decide."

Mira takes my wrist. Not gentle. "We came for her. We still leave with her. You do not get to burn a Remnant extract because a clipboard has a blank line."

"I'm not burning anything," I say. The scraped voice comes out thinner than I want. "I'm saying I heard Habu call those kids inventory like he was doing them a favor, and now the favor has a truck with no town on it. If we walk her out and leave them on that painted line, the night gets to call itself a rescue. I'm not walking out and calling that enough."

Mei folds the night sheet once and keeps it.

"Then you come to the bay with me," she says. "Not through the main court – the upper slit above the loading door. You watch who they line up when Habu says the west is clear enough. After that, if you still want a ditch run, I'll argue less." She glances at Mira. "Or you knock me out and drag me. Your road seems flexible about consent."

Mira's face does something sharp and tired.

"We look," she says. "One look. Then she walks, or I carry her, and you keep your mouth shut until we hit the wire. Clear?"

I look at the blank destination on the folded sheet in Mei's hand. I look at the glass where the coat stood too still. I think of the armband girl with her question pushed back down by two fond fingers.

"Clear," I say. "One look."

Mei is already moving toward the diesel smell, tablet under her arm, night sheet in her fist.

Chapter 31 – The Stove

The upper slit above the loading bay is a maintenance walk with a grated floor and a smell of oil that gets into the teeth.

Mei leads. Mira hates every step and takes it anyway. The contact stays at the turn behind us with the cutters, watching the corridor we just left. Below us the service court is white under the floodlights – concrete, a canvas truck backed to the bay door, two gray-greens with rifles, a clerk with a stamp box, and a folding line of armband kids being walked out of the kitchen junction in groups of ten.

Nobody runs. Nobody cries loud enough to carry. They walk the way you walk when a warm voice has told you cooperation gets you home.

Habu's voice comes through the bay speakers, the same lean-in as before.

"A and B evening review, first group. Thank you for your patience. Step onto the truck when your number is called. Leave cups and personal items with the clerk – you will not need them on the short ride, and we would rather they not get lost." A small laugh, almost shy. "I know the lights are unkind. Hold onto each other if you need to. Inventory that stays calm gets home sooner."

Home. He says it like the word still has a house attached to it – not a truck and a blank line.

The first ten climb onto the truck. A boy still has a cup in his hand; the clerk takes it from him and drops it into a bin without looking at his face. Beside him a girl fusses with her armband so it sits straight on her sleeve, then sits on the bench like she is trying not to take too much space. One of the gray-greens checks names against a list and waves the next kid forward. Nobody asks which town the west gate opens onto.

Mira's fingers dig into the grate rail.

"We've seen it," she says. "Blank destination. Soft voice. Now we go before the second group fills the court. Mei – move."

Mei does not move. She is counting under her breath, matching the truck bench to the night sheet still crumpled in her fist.

"That is thirty," she says. "A-block kitchen runners. Thursday curry kids. They waved at C on the way to dinner two days ago."

"Mei," Mira says. "I am not debating the menu. The west wire is still our exit. Suzumori is still in the ditch. If we stay for the whole show, we die in a building that already knows our faces."

"Then leave," Mei says, without looking at her. "Take him and your clean road and go. I'm staying until I know whether the second group comes back."

Below, the truck's canvas sides flap once. The clerk stamps something. The gray-greens close the tailgate. The engine turns over – the light close motor we heard from the wrong side of the night – and the truck rolls toward the west gate under the floodlights.

It does not go far.

It stops inside the inner fence line, at a low windowless annex I took for a shed from the ditch. The bay door on that annex rolls up. No town road. No open country. Just a concrete mouth and a strip of harsher light, and the armband kids being walked down from the truck into it in the same neat ten.

A sound starts inside that I do not have a clean name for – machinery, fans, something that wants air moved in a hurry. One of the kids stumbles on the ramp. A guard steadies him by the elbow, gentle as Habu's lobby hand on a crying boy's head, and walks him in.

The annex door rolls down.

The court is empty except for the clerk's bin of cups.

I hear Mira say my name. I do not answer. My hands are locked on the grate rail hard enough that the metal bites.

"Kaito." Mira gets in front of me on the grate, close enough that I have to see her face instead of the closed annex. "Listen to me. We came for one pull. The building is doing something worse than we booked for. That does not mean you stand here until they finish. It means we take Mei, we cut back to the wire, and we live long enough to burn this place with people who are not

already inside it.”

“They’re kids,” I say.

“I know they’re kids.” Her voice shakes once and she kills it. “I have been counting dead kids since before I met you. Tonight I can still get one person out of a letter-wing. That is the job you agreed to in the ditch. Say you remember.”

“I remember.” Blood is in my mouth again. “I also remember Habu thanking them for holding still. I remember the blank line. I remember the annex that isn’t a road.” I look past her at Mei. “How many groups?”

“A and B together run about two hundred,” Mei says. Quiet. Precise. The tablet girl, not a speechmaker. “If they keep tens, you are watching the first of twenty. Contingency nights do not leave leftovers for breakfast.”

Mira turns on her.

“You brought us here to watch them die so we would feel guilty enough to stay. You didn’t bring us a route. You brought us a reason we can’t leave.”

“I brought you here because you asked me to walk while they were still inventory on a wall,” Mei says. “Now they are inventory in a shed. If knowing that kills your plan, then you were never extracting anyone. You were stealing one name and leaving the rest.”

The contact’s voice cuts up the stairwell, low and ugly. “Second group is leaving the junction. Also boots on our corridor. We are out of quiet.”

Below, another ten armbands step into the court. Habu’s soft voice thanks them for their patience. A cup hits the bin. The annex door starts up again. One of the kids – tall for fourteen, cloth band crooked – looks up at the grated slit as if he felt eyes on him. For a stupid half-second I think he will shout. He only frowns, confused, and a guard turns his shoulder toward the ramp with the same fond two-finger push I saw in the junction.

“Don’t,” Mira says, because she felt me lean toward the rail. “You look, or you leave. You do not call down to them. You do not make them a reason for rifles to find this walk.”

“I’m looking,” I say.

“Then keep your feet.”

The tall kid goes into the harsher light. The door starts down. The fans pull.

Mira grabs my jacket.

"We go," she says. "Now. You open one door if we hit a guard – one – and then you shut that mouth until the ditch. Mei, you are coming if I have to drag you by the shirt."

Mei looks at me, not at Mira.

"Is that still your plan?" she asks. "One door. One girl. Two hundred blanks."

I watch the second group climb the short ramp into the harsher light. A boy near the back turns his head as if he heard something through the fans, and a guard's hand on his shoulder turns it forward again, kind, firm, finished.

Something in my chest that has been holding since the quiet floors – since the pine road, since go home, since every clean sentence that bought us an exit – lets go in a way that is not relief.

"No," I say.

Mira's grip tightens. "Kaito–"

"No." I pull free. The scraped voice stays quiet; the decision does not need weight under it yet. "You can take her to the ditch. You can call it clean. I am not walking out of a building that just thanked children for lining up into a shed."

"You stay and you die," Mira says. "Or worse – you use that mouth until there is nothing left of you, and I am the one who brought you here to watch it happen."

"Then you shouldn't have pointed me at the door," I say. "You wanted a key. I am done pretending I only open the doors you like."

Mei folds the night sheet smaller and shoves it into her shirt.

"If you stay, I stay," she says. "I can get you into the medical stair above A-block before the third group loads. I cannot stop the annex. I can show you where the speaker wire runs, and where Habu's glass office looks down, and which guards still think this is a school drill." She glances at Mira. "You can drag me. You will lose the boy either way."

Mira looks at me like she is watching a roof edge with a girl on it and no clean sentence left.

"Abort," she tells the contact, rough. "Ditch. Tell Suzumori the extract failed. Do not wait on the wire past first light."

"And you?" the contact asks.

"I stay long enough to keep him from eating the first rifle that points at him." Mira does not look soft when she says it. She looks like someone who has already lost the night she booked and is measuring the next mistake. "After that – I don't know. Move."

The contact goes. Boots from the far corridor get louder. Below us the second ten disappear into the annex. The door rolls down. The fans pull harder.

I wipe my mouth. No blood this time – I haven't used my mouth – and somehow that is worse, because the thing waiting in my throat has nowhere to go yet.

"Medical stair," I tell Mei. "Before the third group."

She nods once and takes the grated walk toward a dark door marked with a red cross stencil, not a letter.

Mira falls in on my left, jaw set, already watching exits.

"You do not open a mouth on a child," she says under the fan noise. "Not to save them. Not to stop them. Not to make this easier to watch. If you break that, I will put you down myself and drag what is left to the ditch. Clear?"

"Clear," I say.

It is not a promise that the night ends clean. It is a promise that the first wrong door I open will not be a fourteen-year-old's eyes.

At the medical stair, Habu's voice comes back through a wall speaker, still thanking, still calling the next ten by number like dinner.

I go down into the building that is shaped on purpose, with Mira's shoulder against mine and Mei's tablet light cutting the dark ahead.

The third group is already forming in the court. The annex door is already rising.

I follow Mei into the stairwell with my mouth shut. Mira's shoulder stays

against mine.

Chapter 32 – Evening Review

The medical stair dumps us onto a corridor that smells like ozone and boiled disinfectant.

Mei takes the left turn without asking if we are ready. Her tablet is dark now – no light to give us away – and she counts doors under her breath the way she counted board numbers in the junction. Mira stays half a step behind my shoulder, listening for boots. Below us, through a slit window that looks down into the service court, the third group of armband kids is already on the canvas truck.

Habu's voice follows us through every speaker we pass.

"Thank you. Stay calm. Leave personal items with the clerk. You will be home sooner than you think."

Home. Still that word.

We hit a locked cross-door between medical and the annex approach. Mei swears once, ordinary, and digs a key card from inside her shirt that does not belong to her.

"War-sheet runners get these for recounts," she says. "Sometimes they forget to take them back." The lock clicks. "Stay low. The purge gallery has a glass strip over the chamber. If you came to look, that is where you look."

"Purge," Mira says.

Mei does not soften it. "That is what the maintenance board calls it. Habu calls it evening review."

The gallery is a narrow walk above a white room.

Through the glass: a concrete floor with drain channels cut in neat lines, still damp, as if it was just hosed. Vents along the far wall, metal mouths the size of dinner plates. A row of hooks for jackets that nobody is using.

The floor is empty. Whatever happened to the first two truckloads, someone already took them out of sight – a low side hatch in the far wall stands open on darkness, and a hose is coiled neat beside it like a kitchen tool.

Ten kids from the court truck are walked in through the bay door – armbands still on, cups already gone. A clerk with a tablet stands at a side door. Two gray-greens frame the vents. Nobody is shouting. Nobody is aiming a rifle at a forehead. It looks like a waiting room until Habu's voice comes through a speaker inside the chamber itself.

"Inventory group three. Face the vents, please. This will only take a moment. Breathe normally. You have been very good tonight."

The kids face the vents. One girl reaches for the boy beside her and takes his hand. A guard nods at that like it is the right answer on a test.

Then the vents open.

Not smoke like a fire. A pale rush that makes the air in the chamber go thick and wrong. The girl with the handhold coughs first. The boy tries to pull his armband up over his mouth. Someone laughs – short, confused – and then the laugh turns into choking. They go down in a messy line, knees first, then hands, then faces toward the drains. The clerk marks something on the tablet without looking up. One gray-green watches the vents. The other watches the door.

It takes less time than a school drill.

When the vents cut off, two men in gray coveralls come through the side hatch with a flat cart. They work without hurry – ankles, wrists, stack, roll – and the bodies go into the dark hatch one after another. A third man follows with the hose and washes the floor until the concrete shines again. The hatch closes. The chamber looks like a waiting room once more.

The clerk speaks into a wall phone, still mild. "Group three clear. Send four."

I hit the glass with both palms before Mira can catch my wrists.

"Kaito–"

"Open it," I say to Mei. "Get me into that room."

"There is no door from the gallery into the chamber," Mei says. Her voice is

flat because flat is what keeps her standing. "The access is through the bay. We have to go back down and around. If you break this glass you get a fall onto concrete and a rifle from below, and they still finish group four."

Below us the bay door rolls. Ten more armbands walk into the clean white room. Habu thanks them for their patience. None of them look at the floor like it means anything. A guard straightens a girl's armband so it sits neat.

"Face the vents, please," Habu says. "You're almost done."

The vents open again.

I run.

The way back down is wrong on purpose – medical cross-corridor, then a stair that should hit the bay and instead dumps into a hold lobby full of gray-greens checking rifles. Mira hauls me into a supply alcove before the first one turns. Mei's card opens a side hatch into a service crawl that smells like dust and mouse shit. We move on hands and knees. Through grated panels I see another ten walk into a clean white room. I see them fall. I see the cart men and the hose before the next line is called. Something in my chest is climbing so hard my teeth ache with it. Mira's hand finds the back of my neck and pins my head off the grate.

"Don't," she breathes.

"They're right there."

"And you're up here. Mouth shut. Crawl."

I crawl. My hands leave sweat on the concrete. Every time Habu thanks the next group, the heat under my ribs turns a notch sharper.

We drop out behind a linen cart near the annex outer door. Boots between us and the chamber. A clerk with a stamp. Habu still thanking. Mei points left – fence corridor, longer loop to purge access.

"Ditch," Mira says. "Now. We have seen enough."

"I'm not going to the ditch."

"Kaito–"

"Left."

Mei takes left without looking at either of us. Mira swears and follows.

Halfway down the fence corridor a pair comes around the corner. Mira pulls me into a doorway. Too late for clean. The nearer gray-green sees my face and lifts his rifle.

The sentence is already in my mouth – drop it, face the wall – as ready as it was for the bay clerk. Mira's eyes cut to my lips. For one ugly second I want the weight more than the room. I want these two on the floor the way the kids are on the drains. That want is new, and it is loud, and it is not about doors anymore.

I do not speak. Not because she asked. Because speaking here still does not put me in that chamber.

Mei flashes the war-sheet card and a lie about east recount that is almost good enough. The older one buys it. The younger one does not like my face. He tips the rifle.

Mira hits him with the fire extinguisher from the wall bracket. Hard. He goes down. The older one starts to shout. Mei kicks the rifle aside and we run before the shout finishes becoming a building-wide problem.

Behind us Habu says, soft as ever, "Group seven, thank you. Face the vents."

"Seven," I say, and my voice comes out wrong – too thin, too hot. "They're on seven and we are still in a hallway."

"Keep running," Mira says.

We make the fence-side loop. Through a high window I get one more slice of the white room – another ten on their knees, a guard straightening a boy's armband so it sits neat while the vents push air. The boy looks up as if he heard something. Then he doesn't.

I hit the glass with my shoulder. Mira hauls me off it before it gives.

"Stop it."

"Get out of my way!"

"You break that and every rifle on this floor finds you before you find a door."

"Then find me a door!"

We stop in a dead stairwell because Mira puts her back to the exit and will not move.

Mei listens at the door. Through the concrete I can still hear the vents, or I am inventing them. My hands are fists. I do not remember making them fists.

"I've had enough!" I say.

Not quiet this time. Not aimed at anyone with weight under it – not yet – but loud enough that Mira's face goes hard.

"You've had enough?" She steps in close, voice low and ugly. "I have been dragging you off glass and grates while they thank kids into a hose room. Do not stand there and tell me you are the only one who is done."

"Then stop blocking the door."

"So you can walk in and die with them? So I can watch you bleed out your mouth until there is nothing left to drag?" Her hand hits the wall beside my head hard enough that Mei flinches. "I brought you here for one girl. You turned it into a war with a soft speaker. I am angry too, Kaito. I am not stupid enough to call that a plan."

"I don't need a plan. I need into that room."

"You need to shut up and think for one second—"

"No." I push past her toward the door. Blood is on my lip from biting it. "Give me the card," I tell Mei. "Take me into that room the short way. I am done looking through glass."

Mei holds my eyes for a second. Whatever she sees there, she does not argue with it.

"We go through the loading bay and the clerk door," she says. "If Habu is still staging groups, we walk into rifles."

"Good," I say.

Mira laughs once, no humor in it. Then she swears and gets out of the doorway.

The loading bay smells like diesel and cold coffee. The canvas truck is gone. The dock is empty except for a tipped bin of cups and a gray-green leaning on

the stamp desk with a cigarette, then looking at his radio like the hard part of the night is already over. Mei's card gets us past him before he decides we matter. The purge door stands open a hand's width for the cleanup crew. The cart men have not come yet.

I push through.

Bodies in armbands cover the concrete in rows that started neat and ended where people crawled. Some still have their bands straight. Some do not. The side hatch stands open on the dark bay beyond, and through it I can see the earlier stacks the hose never had to explain to the next group. Habu is not thanking anyone anymore. A wall speaker clicks once and says, mild as a dinner bell:

"A and B evening review complete. Inventory zero recorded. C block remains on hold. East remains sealed. Thank you for your cooperation."

I stand in the doorway with Mira's breath at my back and Mei's tablet hanging dead in her hand, and there is nobody left in the room to save. The kids who waved at C about curry are either on this floor or already through that hatch.

Mira says my name like a rope.

I do not take it.

Mei's voice breaks on the first try. She gets it out on the second.

"We were too late," she says. "I thought if we cut through medical—" She stops. Looks at the armbands. "Thursday curry. I knew their bunk numbers."

The smoking gray-green in the bay laughs at something on his radio. Somewhere upstairs, Habu asks a clerk for tea.

I walk into the white room far enough to see that none of them are breathing. A girl still has her fingers hooked in a boy's sleeve. The drains make a soft sound like a sink left running. Mira says my name again – not a rope this time, a warning – and then she stops, because whatever she sees on my face is not something she can pull me back from.

My jaw locks. My eyes burn, not from smoke – from holding still on the bodies and refusing to look away. Mei takes a step back without meaning to. Mira's mouth goes flat the way it does when a road turns into a fight. I do not wipe the blood off my lip. I do not make my face kinder for either of

them.

"I watched you walk in," I tell them, quiet, useless, too late. "I watched him thank you. I sat on a grate and let distance win. I let Mira tell me not to open my mouth. I let the next door be soon enough." My throat burns. "It was not soon enough. You are on the floor and he is asking for tea like the night went well."

I turn toward the bay. Toward the wall speaker. Toward the man upstairs who still thinks this building belongs to kindness.

Mira sees it coming. "Kaito—don't—"

I do not keep it in.

"HABU!" The shout hits the white room hard enough that the smoker in the bay drops his cigarette. "I heard you thank them! Come down here and look at what your evening review did!"

Silence for half a second. Then Habu's voice on the speaker — not soft anymore.

"There are intruders in the review chamber. Send two pairs to the bay and the purge door. Hold them there. Do not let them get out."

Boots answer from the dock side. The smoker's radio crackles alive. Mira swears and pulls Mei off the doorframe. We are not leaving through a clean road anymore.

Chapter 33 – Progressive Clearing

The first pair hits the bay before Habu finishes repeating the order.

The smoker already has his rifle up. Two more gray-greens come hard around the empty dock with theirs leveled at the purge door – at me, at the blood on my mouth, at Mira and Mei behind my shoulder. Habu wanted us held. They came to do it.

“Drop it,” I say to the smoker, and I put everything under it. “Kneel. Don’t touch the radio.”

He drops it. He kneels. His eyes go empty the way the quiet-floor soldier’s did. Blood hits my lip hard enough to taste. Mira makes a sound behind me that is not permission.

The nearer of Habu’s pair fires.

I do not have time for a person-sentence. The round is already in the air between his muzzle and my chest. What comes out of me is not aimed at him.

“Stop.”

The bullet stops.

Not in a wall. Not in Mira. In the air, a handspan from my shirt, spinning wrong. For one stupid heartbeat nobody breathes – not me, not Mira, not Mei, not the man who fired. Then the round drops to the concrete and rolls into a drain like an ordinary piece of trash.

The gray-green stares at his rifle like it lied to him. His partner freezes mid-step, still waiting for a clean shot that is not coming.

My knees go. Mira catches me under the arm. Something in my skull has split clean open; blood is running from my nose freely now; my vision goes white at the edges and comes back wrong. I have never paid like this for a word. I did not even point the word at a person.

“What did you–” Mei starts.

"Later," Mira says. She is already hauling me upright. "Kaito. Look at me. Can you stand?"

I stand. The kneeling man is still kneeling. Habu's pair is still staring. On the speaker Habu is sharp now. He wants more men in the bay, the mezzanine locked, and someone who can tell him what just happened down here.

I wipe my face on my sleeve and walk at the shooter. The kids on the drains are still behind my eyes. Habu thanking them is still in my teeth. Sitting these men down is not enough.

"Shoot your partner," I tell him. "Then yourself."

He turns. He fires. The partner goes down hard against the stamp desk. Then he puts the muzzle under his own chin and finishes the sentence. The smoker on his knees does not look up. I put the same weight on him before Mira can reach my sleeve.

"You too. Same."

He does. The bay goes quiet except for the radio still crackling Habu's voice. Mei makes a sound like she swallowed glass. Mira's hand locks on my belt and does not let go.

"That was not a door," she says. "That was—"

"The mezzanine," I say. "Habu is behind that glass – the man who thanked them."

Mei stares at the three bodies like her tablet might still make them into numbers. Then she nods once, sharp, and moves.

We take the kitchen junction first because it is on the way and because the painted lines still hold the ghosts of armband rows.

Two guards are arguing about whether A/B cleanup needs more bags. They turn when they hear us. One raises a rifle. I do not wait for Mira's hand.

"Put the rifle in your mouth," I tell the one with it up. "Pull the trigger."

He does. The second man is still blinking at the body when I put the weight on him.

"Your turn. Bash your head in."

He follows. Blood sheets over my mouth. The junction smells like copper and old curry. Mira swears and hauls me behind the serving counter. Mei grabs one of the dropped rifles like it might bite her. Mira takes the other without asking permission – checks the chamber the way she checked doors on the quiet floors, then keeps it pointed at the floor.

Boots answer the shots from two corridors at once.

"The left corridor goes back into A-block," Mei says. "You'll hit the cleanup crews and whoever is still pretending this is inventory work. The right stair goes up to the lobby glass – that is where Habu sits."

"We go right," I say.

Mira blocks me with her shoulder – hard enough that it hurts.

"You just stopped a bullet and then you made three men kill themselves," she says, low and furious. "I don't know what that costs and neither do you. If you burn yourself out in the first stairwell, Habu writes you down as a vent problem and the rest of this building keeps thanking kids into drains. Pace it."

"Then keep up," I say.

A third guard comes out of the dish room with a pistol already raised. He is young. His hands shake. He sees the bodies and still tries to be brave.

"On the ground," he says. "All of you. Now."

"Why don't you just slit your own throat," I tell him.

He does. Mira takes one step toward the sink like she might be sick, then locks it down, keeps the rifle, and follows me into the lobby stair.

The stairwell fills with gray-greens from above and below.

Geography is simple: concrete steps, metal rail, a landing with a fire door, another landing with a glass panel looking into the dark lobby. Three above. Two below. Rifles up. Someone shouts for us to get on the ground. Mira fires once into the ceiling – warning, not aim – and the shout turns into scramble.

I put weight into the men above first because they have the angle.

"Turn your rifles on each other. Fire until none of you are standing."

The landing becomes a short, ugly noise. Three bodies hit the steps. The ones below fire. Mira shoves me sideways; a round bites the rail where my head was. I put the sentence on them before they can climb.

"Same as the ones above. Now."

They do. Mei kicks the fire door open onto a side corridor and we spill through over spent brass and a man who is still twitching. My ears ring. Blood is in my mouth and in my eyes. The stopped bullet is still sitting in my head like a second skull. I do not try that again. People. Only people. That is enough.

The side corridor runs behind the lobby glass. Through it I see Habu on the mezzanine – soft shoulders, reading glasses in his hair, tea cup in hand – looking down at clerks who have started to understand the gunfire is not a drill. Beside him, for one blink, the dark coat from earlier stands with empty hands and easy weight. Then a clerk runs across the glass and the coat is gone again. Only Habu remains, setting his tea down carefully so it will not spill.

He picks up a handset. His voice fills the building, still soft.

"All units, we have an active disruption on the west stair and kitchen junction. Protect the remaining inventory. C and east stay sealed. Do not invent panic."

Remaining inventory – C and east, the ones he did not finish yet.

I put my palm on the lobby glass hard enough that it should hurt. It does not. Everything hurts somewhere else.

"Open the mezzanine stair," I tell Mei.

"Card only goes so far," she says. "Habu's door is keyed different. You need a person with the right belt or you need to break the glass and climb, and climbing with that much blood on your face is how you die mid-air."

A clerk runs the lobby floor below us with a radio. I smash the side door's window with the rifle butt Mei is not using, lean through, and put the sentence on him before he can finish calling for help.

"Bring Habu's key to this door. Now."

He runs for the mezzanine like the words are the only map he has. Mira

watches him go, jaw locked.

"That is still a person," she says.

"So were they," I say.

The clerk comes back with a keycard and empty eyes. The mezzanine door opens. He stays in the stair like a tool we have not put down yet. Habu is already standing when we enter the glass office – not running, not armed. Soft. Attentive. The tea is still steaming.

"You must be the west fence," he says, as if greeting a late parent at a school play. "I had hoped we could finish the evening without frightening the remaining children. You've made a great deal of noise."

Mira's rifle tip comes up. Mei stays at the door watching the stair.

I walk to his desk. Blood drips on his blotter. He notices and does not flinch.

"You thanked them," I say.

"I did. Fear makes a mess. Calm keeps dignity." He folds his hands. "If you've come to discuss the volunteer track, I should tell you it was already authorized before you cut my wire. Contingency. You were the reason we moved the schedule up, not the reason the track exists."

"Shut your mouth," I say, and the weight under it is not a joke.

His mouth closes. His eyes stay awake – not emptied, not blank. He hears. He understands. He just cannot open his jaw around another soft sentence. For the first time since the lobby speakers started, Habu looks like a man in a glass box.

Boots hit the mezzanine stair – a lot of them. Habu's last call for units has arrived. Mira fires into the doorframe. Mei shouts a count. Through the glass I can see gray-greens flooding the lobby floor, rifles up, shouting for the mezzanine, shouting for the soft man who cannot answer them anymore.

I walk to the glass rail above them. Blood runs freely down my chin and I let it. Mira grabs for my sleeve and misses.

"Kaito–"

I put everything I have left into the lobby.

"Every man with a rifle – turn it on the nearest man in a gray-green coat. Fire until you are the last one standing. Then fire into your own head."

The lobby becomes one long roar. Men with rifles shoot the man beside them, then the man who turns, then themselves when there is nobody left to aim at. Clerks drop behind desks and stay there. A radio keeps shouting for status that will not come. Habu's eyes go wide above his sealed mouth. Mei covers her ears. Mira is screaming my name and I do not hear the shape of it until the last shot echoes and the floor below is still.

So still.

No more boots on the mezzanine stair. No more rifles hunting the glass. Habu's armed shift is down on the lobby tile – his pairs, his kindness with guns. The clerk who fetched the key is still breathing in the stairwell behind us, empty-eyed, useless now that the door is open. I do not finish him. I do not remember to.

My legs go. My hands are shaking and will not stop. The Word takes what it wants after a sentence that size. I hit the glass rail on the way down and Mira catches me before the second fall.

"Stop!" she yells, right against my ear, loud enough that it cuts through the ringing. "Stop it – they're dead, Kaito, they're all dead, you have to stop!"

I try to find another sentence for the next corridor, for medical, for whoever is still breathing in a coat. Mira's arms lock around me hard enough to hurt, face pressed into my bloody shoulder, rifle trapped useless between us.

"Stop," she says again, not a command with weight under it – just Mira, furious and shaking. "I am not watching you empty yourself into a building until there is nothing left of you. You hear me. You stop."

I hear her. The next sentence dies in my throat. Habu sits at his desk with his mouth shut and his tea cooling, staring at the slaughter he ordered into the lobby. Mei is crying without sound at the service door. Below us, nobody moves.

I stop because Mira is holding me and will not let go.

Outside the glass, the corridors toward medical and east are still dark. C is still sealed. The review is over. The men who answered Habu's call are finished.

I do not look for the next rifle.

I let her hold me, blood on both of us.

Chapter 34 – Whole Building

Mira's arms are still locked around me when the ringing in my ears starts to leave room for ordinary sound.

A radio on the lobby floor keeps asking for status that will not come. Habu's tea cup sits on his blotter, untouched. His mouth is still shut. His eyes are awake and fixed on the glass rail as if the bodies below might stand up and ask him for a kind sentence. The clerk who fetched the key sits on the mezzanine stair with empty eyes and a blank face, waiting for an order nobody is giving. Mei is still at the service door behind Habu's chair, one hand on the frame, cheeks wet, not making a sound.

I try to put weight under a new sentence – medical, east, whoever is still breathing in a gray-green coat – and nothing comes. My throat is scraped raw. Blood is drying on my chin and on Mira's sleeve. My legs do not trust the floor.

"Say it," Mira says into my shoulder. Not soft. Not kind. "Say you stopped."

"I stopped."

"Louder."

"I stopped." It costs more than a Word. "There is nothing left in my mouth for them."

She loosens enough that I can breathe, not enough that I can walk past her toward the rail again. Habu's gaze flicks to my face. He understands. He cannot answer. That is worse than if he had begged.

Mei wipes her face on her wrist and turns.

"We have to leave this office," she says. "The west shift is dead. That does not mean the whole building is empty. Medical still has a night desk. East still has a lock. C is still sealed on Habu's last order. If somebody upstairs is watching a different board, they will send people who did not hear the lobby die."

Mira looks at Habu.

"What do we do with him?"

"Leave him," Mei says. "If you shoot him, you make noise for a man who already cannot call for help. If you open his mouth again, you spend what the boy does not have." She crosses to the desk, opens the top drawer Habu's hands were twitching toward earlier, and takes a second keycard on a cloth lanyard. Habu's eyes track her. He does not move. "This opens the letter locks and the C hold doors when the board says sealed. My war-sheet card only gets me recounts. His gets me through."

"That was the job," Mira says. "Get you outside before first light. Suzumori is still waiting on a failed extract, not a tour of every wing this place sealed."

Mei holds the lanyard like it weighs more than plastic.

"Your pull failed the moment A and B went into that annex," she says. "I am not walking west with you while C is locked to their bays and Habu's kindness is still written on the speakers. There are people in that hold who waved at the curry kids two days ago. There are two tags who climb kitchen stairs when they should not. I owe morning counts to a bay that is still breathing. I am not leaving them for a clipboard that thinks inventory zero means the night went well."

Mira's jaw tightens. "I came into this building for you."

"Then you came on the wrong night," Mei says. "Or you came for the right person on a night that turned into something else. I will not be the girl you steal while the rest of the letter-wing and C stay on Habu's hold. Take your boy and go. I am going through that door."

She tips her chin at the service door. Dark stair smell comes up through it – disinfectant, boiled cloth, the medical wing we used as a shortcut when we were still only watching.

I push off the rail. Mira has to catch my belt again and hauls me back a step.

"Kurosawa. Stand still or sit down."

"You can't open C alone," I say. The scraped voice is thin. No weight under it. Just talk. "If there are still rifles on that side—"

"Then I use the card and I move quiet, the way I have moved in this building for months," Mei says. "You just showed me what happens when a mouth decides every guard on the west side is a problem. I do not need that in C. C needs a door and a person who knows which bunks still have names."

Mira steps between us and the service door.

"Mei. Listen to me. Outside there is a contact and an old woman who still thinks keys cut both ways. Inside there is a sealed wing and a building that just watched a boy empty a lobby. If you go alone and the hold is still honest, you die in a corridor that does not care you cried for the curry kids. Come west. We regroup. We come back with people who are not already bleeding out of their mouths."

"No." Mei does not raise her voice. She does not need to. "I watched them thank children into a hose room. I watched you stop him from finishing the rest. That stop does not get those kids back, and it does not unlock C. I am done being Remnant property for one night. I am going to the people I still have numbers for."

Habu makes a sound in his throat that cannot become a word. Mira's rifle tip drifts toward him and then away. She looks at me instead.

"Are you going to Word her into coming with us?"

The sentence is almost there – come with us, leave the door. I look at Mei's wet face and the lanyard in her fist and the dark service stair that leads toward the wing I never walked. The kids on the drains are still behind my eyes. If I put weight on Mei now, I am Habu with a scraped voice.

"No," I say.

Mira swears, ordinary and tired.

"Then say something that is not a command," she tells me. "Because if you stand there mute while she walks into a sealed hold, I am going to remember that too."

I meet Mei's eyes.

"Go," I say. "Don't die for a door. If the hold is still full of living people, get them moving before somebody invents a new review."

Mei nods once. She looks at Mira.

"Tell Suzumori I declined the road. Tell her I am not coming out the wire tonight." She looks at me once more. "And tell your boy – when his mouth comes back, he should use it on men who thank children, not on the ones trying to open their locks."

"I heard you," I say.

She takes Habu's keycard, checks her war-sheet card is still inside her shirt, and pulls the service door wider. Cold air from medical moves the papers on Habu's desk. Habu watches her the way he watched the lobby – attentive, useless, kind only in the shape of his shoulders.

"Mei," Mira says one more time.

Mei does not turn around.

"I am not your extract anymore," she says, and goes down into the dark.

The service door swings shut on her footsteps. For a few seconds I can still hear them on the metal stair. Then the stair takes the sound and I can't hear her anymore, and the glass office is only Habu, the empty-eyed clerk, Mira, and the smell of blood that has started to turn ordinary.

Mira hauls my arm over her shoulder.

"We're leaving," she says. "You said you stopped. That means we walk out while we still can."

"What about Habu?"

"We leave him. I am not spending a round on a man who already cannot talk, and you are not inventing a sentence for him either." She tips the rifle at the clerk on the stair. "Stand up. Walk us to the west service corridor, then sit facing the wall. Do not call anyone. Do not follow."

The clerk stands. He leads like a man carrying a tray. We leave Habu in his glass with his tea cup and his sealed mouth and his view of the lobby he filled with kindness and rifles. He does not get a goodbye. He does not deserve one.

The mezzanine stair is sticky. Below, clerks without guns are still behind desks. One of them is praying under his breath. Another is staring at a dead gray-green like the coat might sit up. Nobody raises a voice at us. Habu's

west guards are still on the tile. The building feels huge and hollow at the same time – whole only because the lights are still on and the speakers are still waiting for a soft man who cannot speak.

We cut through the kitchen junction. The painted lines where armbands stood are empty. The serving counter still has the smell of copper and old curry. Mira does not let me look long. My legs try to fold at the dish-room door; she drags me past it.

"You can hate me for this later," she says. "When you can stand without leaning on me."

"I don't hate you."

"Good. Then keep your feet moving."

The west service corridor is darker than it was when we came in loud. Floodlight glare from the fence still leaks through high windows. Somewhere far behind us a lock clicks – metal on metal, a sealed hold giving way. Mira's head turns toward the sound the same time mine does.

"That's her," I say. "She got Habu's card to work."

I stop. Mira's grip on my belt goes hard.

"Don't," she says.

"She's opening C."

"And you are not going back through a building you already emptied just to watch her do it." She pulls. For a second I do not move. The next sentence tries to rise again – not for rifles this time, for the dark behind us, for the girl with the lanyard, for whoever is waiting on the other side of that lock. Mira puts her forehead against mine hard enough that it hurts. "You told me you stopped. Twice. If you turn around now, that was not stopping. That was a pause."

"All right," I say.

We move.

At the service door where the night clerk used to smoke, the latch is still loose. Outside air hits like cold water – wet grass, diesel, the oil smell of the truck that brought us in. Mira half-carries me over the sill. Behind us Shizuhara keeps its lights on like nothing in the lobby happened. Ahead, the

cut in the fence is a black gap in the glare.

We hit the grass, and I follow where she points.

At the wire I look back once.

Through a high corridor window I can see a strip of the C approach – a painted letter on a door, a card reader blinking from red to waiting green. A small figure with a tablet and a lanyard stands there long enough to press Habu's key to the lock. The door starts to move. I do not see who is on the other side. I do not get faces. Mira's hand finds the back of my neck and turns my head forward before I can invent a reason to stay.

"Eyes front," she says. "We are getting out of here."

Somewhere behind us, in a building that just watched its lobby die, a sealed door is standing open.

Chapter 35 – Unsealed

We never made it to the top of the kitchen stair.

A corporal caught us on the third step with a hold order already in his mouth – C stays in bays, west is not our business, get back before he writes us for inventing a kitchen check. Riku argued once. The corporal lifted his rifle an inch. We walked back to bay three with the floodlight glare still in our eyes and Katō's empty bunk waiting the way it had been waiting since morning.

That was hours ago.

C is locked to itself now. The junction door toward A and B has been carded shut since Habu told everyone to hold. For a while we heard the west side of the building doing something loud – motors, boots, a stretch of gunfire that made the high windows shake. Then the speakers went quiet. Habu did not come back. The corridor went so still I could hear Ōhashi's pencil when he turned a page he had already turned twice.

Bay three sits with its shirts on and its shoes ready. Nobody sleeps. Katō's mattress is still empty. His cap is still on the hook. Ōhashi has the notebook open on his knee.

"Board will call forty-one in the morning if they feel like lying," he says, not for the first time. "I have forty-two living names and one struck. Somebody has to be here when they invent the count."

"Somebody has to be here when they invent the next review," Riku says. His bad arm is tight against his ribs. He has been walking the aisle without stopping for more than a minute at a time. "We sat through the loud part. We are still sitting. If Katō walked into that noise, we are not finding him by polishing bunks."

"Mei told us to stay off the bay," I say.

"Mei is not here," Riku says. "East got sealed with the rest of us. Whatever

she owed us for morning counts, she cannot pay it from behind a locked door.”

“She said she would ask who left if the board went short again,” I say.

“She said a lot of things before the locks closed.” Riku stops at Katō’s bunk, looks at the empty cap hook, and keeps walking. “Talk does not open doors.”

I almost argue. Then the sealed C door at the end of the corridor clicks.

Not a guard’s bored card. The hard sound of a lock that has been red all night going green. Footsteps come fast down the waxed floor – one person, not a squad – and Serizawa Mei pushes into bay three’s doorway with a dark tablet in one hand and a cloth lanyard in the other. There is blood dried in a thin line near her hairline and gray ash on her sleeves that does not look like kitchen soot. She looks like she has been running.

“Get up,” she says. “All of you who can walk. The door to C is open again, and it will not stay that way. Down the medical stair, then the service corridor toward the west fence – most of Habu’s guards on that side are already dead. We are not walking forty people through the lobby. Two minutes. Then I leave with whoever is at the door.”

Ōhashi stands so fast the notebook nearly falls. Men start pulling on shoes. Riku is already halfway to the aisle when Mei lifts the lanyard.

“How did you open that?” I ask, moving with him. “Habu sealed us in.”

“I took his key out of his desk.” She talks while she walks the bay toward the door, not while we stand and listen. “Somebody shut his mouth and left him in his glass office. A and B are not coming back to breakfast. Their evening review was a kill room – gas from the vents, then a hose to wash the floor. They thanked the kids into it in groups of ten. I watched. I was too late to stop it.”

Riku’s step hitches. His good hand finds a bunk rail hard enough that the metal complains, but he does not sit. He keeps going, jaw locked, eyes wet.

“That was the volunteer track,” he says. Voice flat, for me more than for her. “Hot food. The review board sees you first.”

“Yes,” Mei says. “And that track ends in a white room with drains. The curry kids are dead. Habu left C locked and east sealed – that is why any of you are still breathing. If your Katō wore an A or B armband, he is probably dead with

them. If he was C, he is still only a line in that book, and we are not hunting him from inside a bay."

Ōhashi's pencil drops. He does not pick it up. He shoves the notebook under his arm.

"Bay three," he says. "Anyone who can walk without a guard's permission, come with us. Anyone who cannot, hide in the wash-room and do not answer if someone starts calling names. I am not coming back to explain the board."

Six men fall in behind us. Two stay. I do not have time to hate them for it. We hit the bay door and turn into the C corridor toward the junction, Mei in front with Habu's card still in her fist.

"Who cut the west fence?" I ask, keeping pace. "Who started all of this?"

"People from outside," Mei says without slowing. "Not Habu's people, and not the kind who fill out FDC forms. They call themselves Remnant. They break people out of places like this when the board has already decided you belong on a list. Tonight they cut the west fence to take me out of the east wing. I was the person they came for."

"You're with them," Riku says. Not a question. An accusation. He is walking again, bad arm tight, not looking at her face.

"No. I was the one they meant to steal." She does not flinch. "A woman brought wire cutters and a boy with a scraped voice. When he tells someone to do something, they do it. They set off the fence lights. Habu used that as his excuse to wipe A and B. The Remnant people tried to pull me out and failed once the killing started. The boy did not leave with them at first – he went through the west side of the building and killed the guards who came for him. The woman dragged him out before he could keep going. I refused to walk out with them while C was still locked. Habu's key opens the east doors and the C locks. I used it. That is as much as you get."

"So the Remnant started the night that killed the volunteers," Ōhashi says from behind us, breathing hard around the notebook.

"Habu started the kill room," Mei says. "Remnant cut a fence and gave him an excuse he already had written down. If you want the man to blame, he is upstairs in the glass office. His mouth is shut. He is still breathing. I left him that way because I needed his keycard more than I needed a corpse."

My throat goes tight. A boy who tells armed men what to do, and they do it – that sounds like Kaito. I do not say his name yet.

At the junction I catch her sleeve for half a step.

“The boy with the scraped voice,” I say, quiet. “Did you get his name?”

“Kurosawa,” she says. “The woman called him that once when she was dragging him. I did not ask for more. Keep walking.”

The name hits harder than I am ready for. I keep my face ordinary because Ōhashi’s six are right behind us. Riku’s eyes cut to me – he heard.

We keep moving.

A and B’s painted lines are empty – no armbands, no kids arguing about Thursday curry. A tipped cup lies against the B stripe where someone left it when the hold order hit. Riku walks through without looking left or right. One of Ōhashi’s six whispers a name toward the empty B line and then shuts up when Mei’s head turns. Ōhashi counts under his breath anyway, notebook tight under his arm.

Mei leads toward the medical corridor. Behind us C’s door stays open on the men who would not walk. Ahead, the service path is dark and quiet. Somewhere far above us a radio crackles once and dies. Nobody answers it.

At the medical door Mei badges Habu’s card. The reader stays red for a second longer than I like, then goes green. Cold air and disinfectant come up the stair. She holds the door with her hip and waves us through – me, Riku, Ōhashi, the six – and does not look back at C.

“Keep your heads down,” she says. “If a guard asks you anything, give him a boring answer and keep walking. Do not argue. Do not explain.”

“What if they do not take a boring answer?” one of the six asks.

“Then you are already in trouble, and talking more will not help,” Mei says. “Move.”

We go down. Our shoes scrape the metal. Cold air pushes up from below. One of the six stumbles and catches the rail. Mei does not wait for him – she is already on the next landing, Habu’s card out for the door at the bottom.

Riku catches my elbow on the turn, hard enough that I have to look at him.

“That was Kaito,” he says under the fan noise. “Do not tell me it was some

other Kurosawa. I stood on the pine road when he dropped that rifle with his mouth. Same boy. Same mess. What are you going to do when we hit the fence and he is already gone west?"

"I am going to get us out of this building first," I say. "Then I am going to find him. Same as before."

"Same as before almost put us on a volunteer list." His grip loosens. "Fine. Out first. But when we clear the wire, you do not get to go quiet on me again."

Mei badges the lower door. The lock clicks green. Service corridor air hits – oil, wet concrete, the faint stink of the court.

"Clear," she says. "Stay on my back. If I stop, you stop."

She steps through. We follow.

Chapter 36 – On Purpose

The service corridor smells like oil and wet concrete.

Mei does not slow for anyone. Habu's card is still in her fist. Riku keeps my pace. Ōhashi has the notebook under his arm like it might still matter if we hit open air with it. The six from bay three breathe hard behind us and nobody asks for a rest.

We climb a short flight into the service court. Floodlight glare from the west fence leaks over the wall and paints the wet asphalt white. Across the court, the annex approach is wrong – empty armband carts stacked against a hose reel, a white door left ajar, the faint chemical stink that does not belong to kitchens. One of Ōhashi's six swears under his breath. Riku's jaw locks and he keeps walking. He does not look at the carts twice. I do not make him.

"Don't stop," Mei says. "That side is finished. We are not."

The soft service door under the dead bulb is where she points. Habu's card goes into the reader. The light stays red.

Mei tries again. Still red.

"Outer latch," she says. "Different circuit. His desk key was never meant to open the fence side."

A gray-green steps out of the shadow by the truck bay with a rifle already up. He looks young enough to still care about doing the job right. There is blood dried on one sleeve that is not his. He has been alone long enough to hear the lobby die and decide the wire still needs a man on it.

"Back inside," he says. "Hold order. Nobody leaves through this door."

"The hold is over," Mei says. "Habu cannot give you one."

"I did not ask Habu." The rifle tip does not shake. "I asked you to go back inside."

Ōhashi's six freeze. Riku shifts his weight like he is measuring the distance to the barrel and finding it too long. Mei's hand is still on the dead reader. Nobody has a gun that will win this.

I step forward before I can invent a better plan.

"Put the rifle down," I say.

I do not shout. I do not soften it into a request. I put the sentence where it has to land – clean, finished, aimed at him – and for a beat nothing happens except the taste of old metal rising at the back of my throat.

Then his arms drop.

The rifle hits the asphalt with a flat clatter that makes one of the six jump. The guard stares at his empty hands like they belong to somebody else.

"Open that door," I say.

He turns to the latch without arguing. The bar scrapes. Cold night air pushes in from the grass beyond the fence. My nose starts to bleed. I wipe it on my sleeve and keep my feet under me.

"Face the wall," I say, quieter. "Sit down. Do not call anyone. Do not follow us."

He sits with his back to the bay concrete and looks at the wall as if the wall asked first. The bleed thickens. The corridor tips a degree. Riku's good hand finds my elbow hard enough to hurt.

"Same as him," Riku says, low, for me alone. Not a speech. Not a question. Just the fact, put where I cannot pretend I did not hear it. "I can do it too – that is what you just showed me. We will have a talk about this later."

Mei is already through the door. She does not ask what I did. She saw enough.

"Fence cut is left of the glare," she says. "Run."

We run.

Grass soaks my shoes. The floodlights make the cut in the outer wire look like a black mouth. For three strides it feels like escape is a real word again – then a truck engine turns over beyond the ditch, low and heavy, and headlamps swing across the scrub.

A big truck sits on the service track outside the cut. Civilian paint, wrong for Habu's canvas. The cab door is open. A man in a plain dark coat too warm for the night stands by the running board as if he has been waiting for exactly this gap in the wire. His face will not stay put when I look at it. Stillness first, then the rest.

I know that stillness.

Minato. Cold tea. The alley where he asked me who reshapes a crooked world.

He does not say my name. He tips his chin at the open bed.

"In," he says. Pleasant. Unhurried. "All of you who can climb. The building is going to invent a reason to shoot at this fence in about two minutes, and I would rather not be the reason."

Mei stops short. "Who are you?"

"A ride," he says. "Ask better questions when you are not standing in Habu's floodlights."

Riku looks at me. I look at the coat. The alley question is still in my head – reshaped by whom – and I do not have a better answer than I had then. What I have is a bleeding nose, a guard facing a wall, and six men who will die if we stand here arguing with kindness.

"We take it," I say.

We climb.

Someone is already sitting against the far rail when Ōhashi hauls himself up – seed-company cap pushed back, cracked plastic cup hooked on a finger like a joke he never got to finish. Katō Hiroshi. Bay three. The empty mattress. The man who asked Ōhashi for a cigarette and was told Tuesday.

He looks older than the bunk made him. Not a kid who wandered into a review. Twenty, maybe a little more. He meets Ōhashi's stare without flinching.

"Katō," Ōhashi says. The notebook almost slips. "You – your bunk. Your cap was on the hook. We struck you. We thought–"

"I got out earlier," Katō says. Ordinary voice. Tired. "Found this truck when the west side went loud. He said there would be more people coming through the fence cut." He nods once at the coat man, who is already swinging into the cab. "Ask me the rest when we are not sitting under Habu's

floodlights. Sit down before you fall out.”

Ōhashi sits like his knees gave the order. One of the six laughs once, sharp and ugly with relief. Riku does not laugh. He watches Katō the way he watches doors that open too easily, then looks at me, then at the coat through the back window.

“You know him,” Riku says under the engine noise. Not for the truck. For me.

“I talked to him once in Takamatsu,” I say. “He sat through half an evening at Minato without drinking, then asked me what I would do if the world was crooked. I said I did not know. He laughed and walked off with two quiet men in coats. I never got a name.”

“And you are climbing into his truck anyway.”

“He is driving away from Habu’s fence. That is all I have right now.”

Mei pulls the last of Ōhashi’s six in and slaps the rail twice. “Argue about who bought the diesel after we clear the lights,” she says. “If either of you wants out, jump now. I am not stopping once he rolls.”

Nobody jumps. The coat man does not wait for a thank-you. The truck rolls. Grass, then gravel, then the dark strip of road that skirts the floodlight pool. Shizuhara’s west face slides past – glass still lit, speakers still mute, Habu still somewhere upstairs with his mouth shut.

Ōhashi leans toward Katō, notebook still crushed under his arm. “Your cap was on the hook. Your cup was under the bunk. Corporals said review move. I struck your name. Where did you actually go?”

“West,” Katō says. He turns the cup once in his fingers. “When the fence lights came on I left bay three. Sitting there waiting for the next hold order felt like a good way to die. I can tell you where I walked when we stop somewhere safe. Not while Habu’s building still has lights on us.”

“That is not an answer,” Ōhashi says. “I kept forty-two names honest for five months. You do not get to vanish and climb back in with a cup like the board never lied.”

“Then write me back in when we stop,” Katō says. “Or leave the strike. I am not fighting a notebook in a moving truck.”

Ōhashi opens his mouth, shuts it, and holds the notebook tighter.

Mei braces a boot on the rail and looks at me, not at Riku. "At the door. The guard. You told him to put the rifle down and he did. You told him to open the latch and he did. That is the same thing the Remnant boy did on the west side tonight."

"I know," I say.

"Do you." Not a question that wants comfort. "Because if you can do that, Habu's people are going to want you the same way they wanted armbands and east letters. I did not drag C out of a sealed bay so you could get yourselves inventoried again by opening your mouth at every locked door."

Riku clicks his tongue once. "He opened a door we could not open. You can lecture him after we are not bouncing past Habu's floodlights."

"I am not lecturing," Mei says. "I am telling him the bill comes due. Remnant came for me because I was useful on paper. Your friend Kurosawa is useful because people listen when he talks. If you are the same kind of useful, do not pretend you are just a pine-road boy with a nosebleed."

My sleeve is still wet. The bleed has slowed to a sticky smear. "I did not plan it. The rifle was pointed at us. I said what I needed said."

"That is how it starts," Mei says. "Nobody plans the first time. They plan the second."

Riku's shoulder stays hard against mine. "You said out first, then find him," he says, low. "Truck is west. That part matches. Do not invent a reason to climb back over the rail for a boy who already told you to go home."

"I know what he told me."

"Then say what you are going to do when we actually stop," Riku says. "Because if your answer is still chase him until he Words you into marching east again, I want to hear it before I decide whether I am walking with you or punching you in the face and walking without you."

One of Ōhashi's six looks over, then looks away fast. The engine covers most of it. Not enough.

"I am going to get clear of this place," I say. "Then I am going to find him. Not to stand in the road and beg. Not to let him send me home with six syllables that do not even mean a town anymore. I want him to look at me when I tell him I am not leaving."

"And if he tells you to stop following him again?"

"Then I will decide whether I can break that one the way I broke home." I meet Riku's eyes. "I am not asking you to like it. I am asking you not to get off this truck without me."

Riku holds my stare for a long second. Then he knocks his knuckle once against my knee, hard enough to sting. "Fine. I am not getting off without you. But when we stop, you talk to me before you talk to him. No more quiet plans in your head while I am the idiot holding your collar."

"All right."

"Say it like you mean it."

"I will talk to you first," I say. "Before I go after him again."

Mei snorts once under her breath. "If either of you jumps off this truck to chase someone in a ditch, I am not stopping for you. Stealing Habu's key got us out of C. That does not mean I am staying behind to drag you back on."

"Nobody asked you to babysit," Riku says.

"Good. Because I am not." She faces forward again. "Driver takes us west. We get off when he stops somewhere that is not a gun range. After that you can hunt scraped voices until your feet fall off. Until then, sit."

Katō watches the ditch past the rail the way a man watches weather he already dressed for. He does not join the argument. He does not look surprised by any of it.

We clear the first bend. The fence glare falls behind. For a breath the night is only engine and wet air and bodies trying not to bounce out of the bed.

Then headlamps catch a shape in the roadside ditch – two people low in the scrub, one of them tall enough that my stomach drops before I can stop it.

I lean toward the rail.

Riku's hand clamps my wrist. "Do not. You jump and you land under a wheel, or you land in Habu's grass with no truck and no plan. Sit."

"Riku—"

"Sit."

The truck does not stop. We are past them in the time it takes to draw a breath. I see dark hair. A girl's grip on a boy's jacket. A face I have been chasing since the pine road – scraped, blood-dried, looking not at me first but at the cab, at the coat in the glass, then at me.

Kaito.

His eyes catch mine across the open bed and the moving dark. For one stretch of road there is nothing else – not Mei, not Habu, not the Word still sticky on my lip. Just him seeing me, and me seeing him, and the engine carrying us past each other before either of us can make a sound that reaches.

His mouth opens on something I cannot hear. The girl hauls him back into the ditch hard. Then we are gone around the next bend, and Shizuhara is only a white smear behind the trees, and the ditch where he was is already out of sight.

Chapter 37 – Reed City

The truck does not stop for a long time after Shizuhara falls behind us.

Nobody asks the coat man to turn around and go back for Kaito. Riku keeps his hand near my wrist without holding it – he still thinks I might jump off the truck. Mei watches the road and the side streets like she is already planning how we get out of the next bad place. Ōhashi has the notebook open on his knee and has not written a word since Katō told him to wait until we stopped somewhere safe. The six from bay three sleep in pieces, heads knocking the canvas whenever the tires hit a hole.

Katō does not pretend to sleep. When the floodlight glare of Shizuhara is finally gone behind a ridge, he looks at Ōhashi once – acknowledgment that the struck name in the notebook is still waiting.

“When we stop,” Ōhashi says, quiet, “I am putting your name back. Living. If you disappear again, I will write that too.”

“Fair,” Katō says.

The road widens. The dark stops being scrub and starts being outskirts – warehouse roofs, a canal that smells like wet rope instead of fence oil, neon that is not Habu’s white glare. An elevated line runs a ring of light around something big enough that I have to sit up to see the end of it.

Mei leans toward the cab window. “Where is this?”

The coat man’s voice comes back pleasant, unhurried, the same tone he used at the wire. “Ashiro. Reed Road city, if the old maps still bother with poetry. Canal wards, night markets, boarding blocks that do not ask for a relocation number if you pay cash and keep your voice down. Thin gray-green presence this far inland from the line. You can breathe here for a while if you do not make yourselves interesting.”

“How long is a while?” Riku asks.

“Longer than a night on the run,” the coat man says. “Not forever. I am not

selling you a home. I am putting you somewhere that is not Habu's inventory."

The truck takes a ramp down into a ward that is still awake. Lanterns hang over reed-stall alleys. Steam lifts off noodle carts. A canal runs black between concrete banks, and somebody's radio is playing a song too cheerful for the hour. Kids my age – ordinary kids, not armbands – shout across a bridge about a lost bicycle. No floodlights. No soft hold speech. For a second my chest does not know what to do with the noise.

We stop in a loading pocket behind a boarding house with a painted reed on the door. The coat man kills the engine, climbs down, and opens the bed gate like a host, not a jailer.

"Out," he says. "All of you who are staying."

We climb down. My legs have gone stiff. The air smells like canal water and somebody burning incense in a stairwell. Habu's disinfectant is finally out of my nose.

The coat man counts us with his eyes the way he counted at the wire – making sure nobody is still in the bed. Then he takes a folded envelope from inside his coat and holds it out to Mei, not to me.

"Room keys for the third floor. Two rooms. Coin for food and a few days of looking ordinary. The landlady thinks you are warehouse hands who missed a transfer. Do not correct her with a better story."

Mei takes the envelope. She does not thank him yet. "And you?"

"I have other work." He glances at Katō, who has not climbed down. "He rides with me."

Ōhashi steps forward so fast the notebook almost hits the coat man's chest. "No. He is bay three. He is on my book. You do not get to invent another review move in a city I have never seen."

Katō swings his legs over the rail and drops to the asphalt light on his feet. He looks at Ōhashi, then at the rest of us, then at the coat.

"I am not going into those rooms," Katō says. Plain. No joke. "He got me out when the west side went loud. I owe him the ride, not your notebook. Write me living if it helps you sleep. I will not be on the third floor in the morning."

"That is not—" Ōhashi starts.

"It is what is happening," Katō says. He nods at me once, almost friendly. "Keep the pine-road Tuesday joke. I never collected on it."

He climbs back into the bed and sits against the rail the way he was sitting when we found him. The coat man closes the gate without looking like a man who stole anyone.

"Aoyama," he says, and my surname in his mouth still feels like a draft under a door. "Eat. Sleep. Do not follow quiet coats into alleys as a hobby – I already told you that once. This time I mean stay in the ward and be boring."

"You still have not given me a name," I say.

He smiles without showing teeth. "Names are for people who want to be found. Go upstairs."

He gets in the cab. The truck rolls. Katō's seed-cap is the last shape I see against the canvas, and then the loading pocket is only us, the reed door, and a city that does not know Habu's name.

Ōhashi stands with the notebook open and nowhere to put the pencil.

"He was mine," he says. Not loud. Not for the street. "I struck him and I found him and he left again."

"He left on his feet," Mei says. She is already counting the envelope. "That is more than A and B got. Come on. Before the landlady decides warehouse hands do not arrive at this hour."

The boarding house smells like boiled rice and old wood. The landlady is a woman with a scarf and no patience for speeches. She takes one look at our G shirts and the dried blood on my sleeve, sniffs once, and points at the stairs.

"Third floor. Bath is down the hall. If you fight, you leave. If you bring soldiers, you leave. Rent is in the envelope or you leave. Questions?"

"No, ma'am," Riku says, before anyone else can invent one.

Two rooms. Thin mattresses. A window that looks over the canal and the night market lanterns. One of Ōhashi's six sits on the floor and laughs until it turns into something that is not laughter, and nobody tells him to stop. Mei

sets Habu's keycard on the windowsill like she does not know what else to do with a thing that opened doors and cannot open a city.

Riku pulls me into the corner by the window while the others claim mattresses.

"We are off Habu's ground," he says. "That was the first part. Tomorrow, before you go looking for Kurosawa, you talk to me. That was the deal."

"I know."

"Do you." He tips his chin at the canal. "Because I can already see you measuring which bridge he would take if he walked into this ward. Sit on it for one night. Eat something that is not institutional rice. If you run out that door before morning, I am not promising I will catch you gently."

Mei joins us without asking if the corner is private. She has washed her face. The blood line near her hairline is still there.

"I am not your Remnant contact," she says. "I am not your babysitter either. I got you out of C because I owed morning counts and because Habu's kill room was real. In the morning I am finding day work so this envelope lasts. If you two want to hunt a scraped voice through a city this size, you do it without expecting me to hold a map."

"You could leave," I say.

She looks at me for a long second. "I could. I also watched A and B walk into vents while I held a tablet and could not stop it. I am not ready to be alone with that yet. That is not the same as signing up for your chase."

"Fair," Riku says.

I look out at Ashiro – reed stalls, canal light, an elevated train sliding past like the Loop used to in a life that still had a birthday cake on a roof. Kaito is somewhere behind us on a road that does not care we made it here. The coat man is gone with Katō. Habu is still mouthed in a glass office we will never see again if we are lucky.

"We stay," I say. "Tonight. We eat. We sleep. In the morning we talk – you first," I tell Riku, "before I invent a plan that puts our names on a desk again."

Riku clicks his tongue once. "Finally. Soft boy learns a schedule."

Mei snorts, almost a real sound. "Do not call him that where the landlady can hear. She will think we are trouble."

"We are trouble," one of the six says from the mattress, eyes already closing.

"Not tonight," Mei says. "Tonight we are warehouse hands who missed a transfer. Act like it."

We go downstairs and buy noodles from a cart that does not ask for papers. The broth burns my mouth. It is the best thing I have tasted since Minato. Riku eats like someone who has decided hunger is an argument he can win. Mei pays from the envelope and keeps the change counted. Ōhashi sits with the notebook closed for the first time since bay three and watches the canal as if names might float past.

"You are staring at the water like it owes you a headcount," Riku tells him.

"Katō owed me a Tuesday," Ōhashi says. "The board owed me honesty. This city does not owe me anything, and somehow that is worse." He taps the closed notebook once. "In the morning I am going to write the six who came, and the two who stayed in C, and Katō living with a question mark. Then I am going to find out if Ashiro has a stationery shop, because this pencil is a stub."

Mei almost smiles. "That is the most ordinary plan anyone has said all night. Keep it."

One of the six asks if there are gray-greens on the bridges. Mei shakes her head.

"Not the way Habu ran them. Coat man was right about thin presence – I counted one patrol car on the elevated and it was going somewhere else in a hurry. Do not take that as forever. Take it as tonight."

Across the water, lanterns rock on their wires. Somebody laughs too loud. A couple argues about a bicycle. The war app in a stranger's pocket buzzes once and gets ignored, the way I used to ignore it on birthday nights I thought I could keep. An elevated train slides past with its windows full of people going home from shifts that still exist. Nobody in those windows is walking into a vent review. Nobody is waiting for Habu's thank-you voice.

Riku knocks my bowl with a knuckle. "You are somewhere else again."

"I am here," I say. "I am just not used to a place where nobody is inventing

a hold order."

"Then sleep before your brain invents one for you," Riku says. "Morning comes either way."

We carry the empty bowls back toward the reed door. Upstairs, one of the six has claimed the mattress by the wall. Another is washing blood out of a sleeve in the shared bath. Mei has put Habu's keycard on the sill and is folding the envelope smaller so it will not show in her pocket.

Riku checks the latch twice, then looks at me.

"Mattress," he says. "Not the window. If you stand there all night measuring bridges, I am tying your ankle to the bedpost."

"I will sleep," I say.

"Say it like you mean it."

"I will sleep."

I lie down. The canal noise comes through the glass. For a while it is only water and carts and somebody laughing too loud in the market, and that is what I listen to until my eyes finally close.

Chapter 38 – On Your Feet

The taillights are gone before I can make my legs do anything useful.

Mira's hand is still over my jaw. Her forehead is still against mine. The almost-sentence sits unfinished in my mouth – Stop. Get out. Get away from him – with nowhere left to land. Behind us Shizuhara keeps its lights on like the lobby slaughter was a rumor somebody else told. Ahead, the service track is empty mud.

"He had him," I say. Not a question. "The coat from the glass. Habu's mezzanine. He had Haruki in the bed of that truck."

"I saw it." Mira does not let go of my belt. "You are shaking and half empty. If you Word that truck while it is moving, you could kill him with the stop."

"I am not leaving him with–"

"You already did." Her voice is flat with the effort of holding me. "The truck did not ask your permission. Contact is this way. Suzumori is this way. You can hate the coat when you can stand without me."

I walk because she makes me. West along the ditch, away from Habu's white glare, away from the place where Haruki's face was for one breath and then was not. My legs still do not trust the grass. Blood is dried on my chin from the lobby. The vents are still in my head – kids thanking Habu into a white room, the hose between groups, the soft voice on the speakers. I left Habu alive with his mouth shut. I killed his west guards. None of it put Haruki on our side of the wire.

On the ridge above Nagihama, Mira once told me I could grieve on my feet. I am still on my feet. My hands will not close all the way. I start to say his name to nobody and do not finish it. It does not feel like grief anymore. It feels like I still have a sentence left and nowhere to put it.

The contact's truck is where we left it, pulled further into scrub so Habu's

floodlights do not paint it. The contact is under the open hood with a light between her teeth, swearing at a belt. Suzumori sits on the running board with her stick of wood crooked in her hair, eyes on the pale concrete block we failed to steal a girl out of.

Suzumori looks up first.

"You smell like a building that died," she says. Not unkind. Exact. "Where is Mei?"

"Mei is not coming," Mira says. She eases me down against the tire before my knees give out. "She took Habu's key and went back for the kids in C. The west guards are dead. Habu is alive, but he cannot talk – Kaito shut his mouth and left him in the glass. A and B are gone. We got out through the cut in the wire."

The contact spits the light into her palm. "That was not the job."

"The extract failed once they started killing in the annex," Mira says. "You were not inside. Do not talk to me like I forgot the chalk marks."

"We burned cutters and a night window to pull Mei out," the contact says. She looks at me. "You came back without her, and you look like you spent your whole voice on something else. What did you do in there?"

"What Habu's people deserved," I say. The scraped voice is thin. No weight under it. Just talk. "They thanked kids into a kill room. I killed the ones with rifles."

Suzumori's mouth tightens. "You already knew that mouth of yours cuts both ways. Knowing it and emptying a lobby are not the same thing."

"I am not asking you to like it." I tip my head toward the dark road the truck took. "There was a man in a dark coat on Habu's mezzanine while A and B walked into the vents. He watched the whole thing and did nothing. Then he drove past us with Haruki in the truck bed – kids from C, a girl with a lanyard, somebody with a notebook. Haruki looked straight at me. His nose was bleeding."

Mira's hand finds my shoulder. I shake it off.

"That coat has my friend," I say. "And Habu is still breathing in his glass. I am not sitting in this ditch while either of those things stays true."

The contact laughs once, ugly. "You want to chase a truck on ruined legs after you turned Shizuhara into a story every desk east of here will invent a hold order for. Brilliant. Remnant does not run taxi service for boys who cannot finish an extract without writing a massacre."

"Then do not run it for me," I say. "Point me at the road and get out of the way."

Mira steps between us before the contact can answer with a hand.

"Enough," she says. "Both of you. We are not arguing volume in Habu's scrub. Contact – the extract failed. That is on the night, not on a speech. You still owe us a direction that is not back through the wire. Suzumori – if you have a place that is not a Remnant billet with a clipboard of its own, say it. I am not putting him in another inventory while his mouth is like this."

Suzumori taps the running board with one finger, thinking the way she thinks about keys.

"Ashiro," she says.

The contact's head turns. "That is not our drop."

"It is a city," Suzumori says. "Canals, night markets, boarding houses that take cash. Remnant keeps a thin watch there if you keep your head down. People go when the road behind them is burned and they need a few days somewhere that is not writing hold orders about them." She looks at Mira, then at me. "Your aunt's drivers used the inland ring through Ashiro when the coast got too watched. You know the name even if you have never been. After a job like tonight, that is where I would send a boy who still wants to fight – not to heal him. To keep him from walking straight back into Habu's lobby because he cannot think of anywhere else to go."

"Why would Haruki's truck go there?" I ask.

"I do not know that it did," Suzumori says. "I know coats that move people after buildings catch fire often prefer cities that can swallow a story. I know Mira's road has used Ashiro before as a breath. I know if you stand here inventing sentences for a ditch, Habu's second shift will invent you first."

Mira nods once. Slow. "We go to Ashiro."

The contact slams the hood. "I am not driving you into a reed market so he can hunt a coat. Remnant will want answers for Mei, for the cutters, and for

whatever he did to Habu's west side. You take him inland, and that mess follows you."

"Then let it follow," Mira says. "I am not leaving him in this ditch to be the next anomalous line on somebody's sheet. You can come, or you can go tell your table the extract died and the girl stayed. Those are your choices. They are not his."

The contact stares at her. Then she looks at me like I am a broken tool she still has to load.

"I take you to the inland spur," she says. "Not into Ashiro proper. From there you walk or you steal a ride. I am not parking under lanterns with a scraped-voice boy who just made Shizuhara famous. And when the table asks, I tell them Mira chose the loud road again."

"Tell them whatever keeps you breathing," Mira says. "We leave now."

Suzumori stands with a small sound of old joints. She puts her stick of wood back through her hair.

"I am coming," she says. "Not because I like Ashiro. Because somebody on that truck needs a person who has opened bad locks before, and the contact is not going to be that person."

We climb in. The truck bumps off the scrub onto a darker road than Habu's service track. Shizuhara's white smear falls behind the ridge the same way Nagihama's lights once fell away under my boots. Mira sits with her shoulder against mine so I do not tip. Suzumori watches my mouth the way she watched it on the quiet floors – not afraid of blood, afraid of the next sentence.

I do not give her one.

I watch the dark and see Haruki's face in the truck bed, and the coat in the cab glass, and Habu's awake eyes over a sealed mouth, and the armband kids walking into a room that thanked them. The Word offers me clean clauses for all of it. I keep them behind my teeth because Mira is right about distance and trucks, and because if I open my mouth now I am not sure I will stop at one building.

"Ashiro," I say at last, to the window, to anyone who wants it. "I find Haruki. Then the coat. If your city is on the way, fine. If it is not, I will keep walking."

Mira does not tell me I am wrong.

Suzumori makes that dry sound again. "On your feet, then. Just remember – getting there is the easy part. What your mouth does after is the part that gets people killed."

The inland spur is a black strip between reed fields that smell like wet rope. The contact brakes hard enough that my teeth click.

"Out," she says. "End of the ride. I am not parking under Ashiro lanterns with him in the cab."

We get out. She does not wait for thanks. The truck turns back the way we came, and the taillights shrink until there is only reed smell and dark.

Mira pulls the sack onto her shoulder – the same sack she packed days early in Nagihama.

"Talk now," I say. "I have been waiting since the ridge. I am not walking another hour before you answer."

"You are," Mira says. "If I answer you out here, you will want to turn around and fight somebody before we have walls, and Suzumori cannot run. When we stop somewhere that is not a ditch – a shed, a roof, anything with a door – I will answer you. Not before."

"That is not fair."

"It is not. Can you walk or not?"

"I can walk."

Suzumori taps her stick once against the dirt. "West. Before Habu's people come looking."

Mira starts walking. I fall in beside her.

"How far?" I ask.

"A few hours if we do not stop," Mira says. "Do not start the questions until we have a roof. I mean it."

Chapter 39 – What She Packed

We stop because Suzumori's ankle will not take another hour on the spur.

Her boot comes off with a wet sound. She sits with her back to a crate and rolls the sock down slow – not showing off the pain, just letting it be there. Mira finds a strip of clean cloth from the sack and wraps the swelling without asking. I stand opposite the shed door so I can see anyone coming down the canal path.

"You said when we stopped somewhere that was not a ditch," I say. "This is not a ditch. Why did you pack that sack days before the shrine yard in Nagihama? Why did you already know the ridge track? Why does Remnant hand you chalk marks and cutters like you are on a payroll? And why the hell did you walk me into Shizuhara for a girl and let me empty a lobby while you held my belt?"

Mira does not flinch. She sets the water bottle between us and rolls her left sleeve up to the elbow.

The burn on the inside of her forearm is old – pale, tight, skin that healed wrong. She does not hide it. She also does not wave it around.

"When I was fourteen," she says, "Federation people burned a warehouse on the coast where my aunt's drivers stored crates they were not supposed to have. Food. Medicine. Paper that helped people who did not have the right stamps. I was inside counting boxes because my aunt trusted me with numbers. The fire started at the loading doors. I got out because a woman I had never met dragged me through a side hatch and put her coat over my face so I would not breathe the smoke."

She stops. The canal lock drips outside. Suzumori's eyes stay on Mira's arm.

"My aunt did not get out," Mira says. "Two of the drivers did not get out. The woman who pulled me told me her name once, then said names mattered less than getting people out. She was Remnant. She still is. She is the reason I am

not ash in a warehouse the news called an electrical fault.”

Suzumori clicks her tongue. “Okina does not like being thanked in rooms with thin walls. Keep going.”

“Okina,” Mira says. Just the name. “She got me out. She put me with my aunt’s remaining drivers when the coast got too watched for their old routes. Those drivers taught me which gray suits listen instead of stamp, which ridge tracks still take a bicycle, which cities you can hide in for a few days if you keep your head down. That is how I knew about the man in the gray suit before you saw him cover his ears in Nagihama. That is how I had a sack packed. Not magic. Homework. Ugly homework.”

I look at the scar until she rolls the sleeve down.

“So you were always Remnant.”

“I was always a girl who owed a woman her life,” Mira says. “Remnant is the road that woman walks. I walk it because asking nice did not save the people in that warehouse, and the news lie did not either. Habu’s building is the same kind of place – soft voices thanking kids into a kill room. You can make people do what you say when you put weight behind it. I have watched it work. I am not going to pretend that is a party trick while places like that still have the lights on.”

Suzumori leans forward. “Careful, girl. That is starting to sound like you own him.”

“I do not own him,” Mira says. She looks at me, not at Suzumori. “I steered you because you were already going to throw yourself at the next person held over a drop. I would rather that be pointed at the next warehouse instead of at a random fight you cannot win. That is not a leash. If you want to walk away from me in Ashiro, walk. I will not Word you. I cannot.”

“Remnant wanted Mei,” I say. “Not a massacre. The contact made that clear.”

“Remnant wanted a clean extract,” Mira says. “Next time they will want answers – for Mei staying, for the cutters, for what you did in the west. Ashiro is not the end of my road either. Okina has people somewhere who still think I report to them. I am telling you that now so you do not invent a nicer version later.”

Suzumori ties her boot back on with hands that know how to work through

pain. "I am walking with you because a boy with a mouth like yours scares me when he is alone. I have kept packages for people Mira's aunt's road owed. I have sat on quiet floors while men with nice watches decided when I would be transferred east. Your voice is loud even when you whisper, Kurosawa. I will not turn that into a speech tonight. I will tell you this: if Mira uses you only as a hammer, I will say so to her face. If you use yourself only as a hammer, I will say so to yours."

"Two mouths like that in one world," I say, because the phrase has been stuck in my head since the pine road. "You said that once."

"I said I was afraid of the thought," Suzumori says. "Do not turn it into a plan. Not tonight."

Nobody talks for a bit. Outside, something moves on the canal – a night fisherman, maybe, or a patrol that does not care about a broken padlock on a tool shed. My throat still tastes like the lobby. Haruki's face in the truck bed will not leave. I see it every time I blink: blood at his nose, C shirt, the coat man's cab between us.

"You watched me tell him to go home," I say to Mira. "On the pine road. You did not stop me."

"No," she says. "I did not. I thought if he stayed he would die next to you. I may have been wrong. I may have been right in a way that still makes me sick. I am not going to polish it for you."

"And Shizuhara?"

"I came for Mei. You stayed for the kids. I held you when the lobby was done because if you kept going there would be nothing left of you by morning." Her voice stays level. "I am not sorry I held you. I am sorry A and B are dead. Those can both be true."

I want to say something that cuts her. I want to crack Habu's glass from here. I want Haruki in front of me without a truck between us. None of that helps, so I keep my mouth shut.

The vents come back anyway – white room, hose between groups, a girl my age saying thank you like it was a password. Something ugly comes up my throat and I swallow it down. Mira watches my jaw work.

"You are doing that thing," she says. "Where you line up words and do not

say them."

"If I say them, somebody dies," I tell her. "That used to feel like a rule. Now it just feels like the only way I know how to stand still."

"Good," Suzumori says. "Keep your mouth shut until you know who you are pointing it at."

I look at her. "You think I do not know?"

"I think grief makes boys sure of themselves," she says. "I have seen it on the quiet floors. Your mouth is louder than theirs. That does not make you wiser. It only makes the mistakes bigger."

Mira passes me water. I drink because my body needs it, not because anyone offered kindness.

"Why stick with me at all?" I ask her. "If Okina taught you numbers and ridge tracks and chalk marks, why stay next to a boy who just killed a room full of people?"

"Because after Ryn, you were going to keep throwing yourself at the next bad thing until something stopped you," Mira says. "I did not make you that. I only decided I would rather be standing next to you when it happens than hear about it later. That is selfish. I am not pretending it is noble."

"Selfish is honest," Suzumori says. "Noble is what people say later when the bodies are out of sight."

The shed creaks when the wind shifts. My chin still has dried blood on it from Habu's night. I touch the scab and feel how ordinary the skin is underneath – how the lobby did not burn me, only the people in the vents.

"The coat," I say. "Haruki's truck. You think Ashiro?"

"I think cities where a story can get lost," Mira says. "My aunt's drivers used Ashiro when the coast got watched. If that truck is anywhere we can reach on foot, it is more likely under Ashiro lanterns than behind another fence. I do not know that. I will not pretend I do just because your hands are shaking."

"I am not shaking."

"Your hands are," she says.

I look down. She is right. I make fists until the knuckles go white, then

open them because Suzumori is watching and I am tired of being read.

"Ashiro," I say. "We find the coat. We find Haruki. We find the next man who runs a place like Habu's. After that I decide whether your road and mine are still the same."

Mira nods once. "That is fair."

Suzumori finishes with her boot. "Fair changes the minute a city gives you a worse choice. Drink the water. Lie down for an hour. Ashiro is closer than it looks, and neither of you will get there sharper by talking yourselves empty."

"I am not sleeping," I say.

"You are lying down with your eyes closed," she says. "That is what I mean by sleep. Do not argue about words at two in the morning."

Mira almost smiles. It does not reach her eyes. "She is older than both of us. Listen to her anyway."

I lie down on the shed floor with my eyes open. The boards smell like oil and old rope. Suzumori takes the spot by the door. Mira sits against the crate with the sack in her lap, awake the way she is when she still thinks somebody might come down the path.

When the hour is up, Suzumori stands and checks her ankle. Mira repacks the water. We leave without another speech about roads.

By the time the reed thins, Ashiro is lanterns over black water and a bridge with a sleepy clerk who wants two coins or a reason.

Mira pays before I open my mouth.

The clerk waves us through. On the far side, under the first real streetlamp, I stop.

"Where do we start?" I ask. "Boarding houses? Drivers? The coat will not wait for us to be careful."

"Boarding houses that take cash," Mira says. "Drivers who talk when they drink. Not desks. And not your voice on the first man who smells wrong."

Suzumori leans on her stick. "If you Word someone in this market before breakfast, the city will write a hold order with your face on it. Ask with coins and eyes. Save the mouth for when you are sure."

"Haruki first," I say. "Then the coat. Then I decide about your road."

Mira nods once. "Haruki first. That much we agree on."

Chapter 40 – Cash Room

The lanterns over the canal are still burning when we go looking for a roof, but the streets have thinned out enough that our footsteps sound too loud on the stone.

"Haruki first," I say again, because saying it once did not make it feel finished. "So we start asking tomorrow. Tonight we just need a door that locks."

"Tonight we need a door that does not ask for papers," Mira says. "There is a difference and it matters more here than it did in Kuroishi."

Suzumori is limping. Not badly, but enough that she puts a hand on my shoulder every third step without asking, and I let her, because arguing about it would take longer than just being a post for a minute. We follow the canal until the lanterns start hanging over shopfronts instead of water, and Mira reads the hand-painted signs the way she read the checkpoint sergeant back on the coast – not for what they say, for what they don't.

"That one," she says, pointing at a narrow building with a faded blue door and a card in the window that just says ROOMS, no rates, no rules. "Places that post their rules want you filling out a form to go with them."

The woman who answers the door is younger than I expected, maybe thirty, with her hair tied back hard enough to pull at her eyebrows and a ledger already open on the counter like she was doing sums before we knocked. She looks at the three of us – me still wearing yesterday's blood on my collar in the shape of a stain I gave up trying to explain – and does not flinch, does not soften, just taps her pencil twice against the page.

"Two rooms or one," she says. "Third floor, water down the hall, no cooking in the rooms. Cash tonight, cash every morning after. I do not run a tab and I do not remember faces kindly if you skip out owing me."

"One room," Mira says, before I can open my mouth about money. "How much."

The landlady names a number. Mira doesn't argue it down – she just counts coins onto the counter from the fold she has been carrying since Takamatsu, slow enough that the landlady watches her hands instead of our faces, which I think is the point.

"Names," the landlady says, pencil ready.

"Aoki," Mira says. Not the name any of us were born with. "The old woman is my grandmother. The boy is my cousin."

The landlady looks at Suzumori, who does not correct the word old, and then at me, who apparently reads as cousin material with a split lip and dried blood on my jaw. She writes something in the ledger that is probably not even close to Aoki.

"Third floor," she says again. "If you fight, you're out before I ask why. If soldiers come asking, I never saw you. That part is not kindness. That part is bad for my rent roll." She slides a single brass key across the counter. "Bath's cold after nine. Deal with it."

We climb three flights of stairs that smell like somebody's dinner from two nights ago. The room is smaller than the one in Shizuhara's C-wing bunks but it has a door that shuts and a window that looks out over a rooftop instead of a fence, and for a second that is enough.

Suzumori sits on the nearest mattress and starts working her boot off with both hands.

"You are staring at the wallpaper like it insulted you," she tells me.

"I'm not staring at anything." I am. It's just a wall. It doesn't have a fence in it or a truck driving away from it, and I keep checking that fact like it might change if I look too long.

Mira sets the fold down on the windowsill, counts what's left with her thumb, and doesn't share the number out loud, which tells me it isn't a good one.

We go back out because Suzumori's stomach makes a sound loud enough that Mira laughs before she can stop herself – a short, surprised bark of a laugh, gone as fast as it came, like she forgot she still had that in her.

The night market is smaller than the one at the bridge but louder, packed into an alley between two canal walls with strings of paper lanterns overhead and a smell of frying batter that makes my mouth hurt from wanting it. We buy noodles from a cart because it's cheap and fast, and a bar of gray soap from a stall selling nothing but soap and string, and a jug we fill twice at a public tap before Mira decides two jugs is enough water to carry up three flights.

"We need more than soap," Suzumori says, counting the coins Mira has left in her palm without being asked to. "Coats that hide blood stains. Something for my ankle that is not spit and hope."

"We need rent for tomorrow more than we need a new coat," Mira says. "One thing at a time."

"You say that like it's wisdom and not just running out of money."

"It's both," Mira says. "Doesn't make it wrong."

Suzumori makes the dry sound in her throat that isn't quite a laugh. I watch the alley instead of the argument, because watching the alley is a thing my body still knows how to do even when the rest of me feels like a held breath. There's a man near the tea stand in a coat too heavy for the weather, and my shoulders go up before my brain catches why – dark wool, collar turned, the shape of a coat I have spent nights hating without ever seeing the whole face under it.

He turns to pay for his tea. He's sixty if he's a day, jowls, a merchant's soft hands. Not him. Not even close to him.

"Kaito." Mira's voice, low, at my elbow. She saw where I was looking. She doesn't say anything about it – no lecture, no you are doing that thing – she just puts herself half a step between me and the tea stand until my shoulders come back down on their own.

"It wasn't him," I say.

"I know."

"I know I know it wasn't him too. My legs didn't get the memo before my eyes did."

"That's what legs are like," she says. "Eat your noodles before they're cold."

We eat standing at the cart because there's nowhere to sit, and the broth is hot enough to hurt going down, which is the first thing in days that has hurt in a way I don't mind.

While the cart man refills Suzumori's bowl, I try it once – quiet, casual, the way you'd ask about weather. "You get many new faces through here? I'm looking for a cousin. Tall, soft-spoken, would've come in sometime this week."

The ladle doesn't stop moving. "Everyone in this ward is somebody's cousin," the man says, flat, and turns to the next customer, and that's the whole conversation. Mira looks at me sideways over her bowl and doesn't say anything, which is louder than saying it.

Suzumori steals a piece of pork off my bowl without asking and eats it like she's daring me to say something.

"You two fight like you've been doing it for years," I say.

"We have only been in the same room since the quiet floors," Mira says. "That is not nothing. It is also not a lifetime."

"Feels like a lifetime," Suzumori says. "You pack like someone who has been running her whole life. I have been running most of mine. We recognize the walk."

Back in the room, Suzumori soaks her ankle in the second jug of water while Mira sits cross-legged on the mattress counting the fold again, like the number might improve if she asks it politely enough.

"How long does that last us?" I ask.

"Four days if we're careful. Six if we're mean about food." She folds the cloth smaller. "After that we need work. I am not calling Okina for rent money, and I would rather cut off my own hand than beg a desk."

"So we find work."

"So you find work," Suzumori says, not looking up from her ankle. "I am not fast enough to carry crates, and Mira should not be the only one whose face this city learns first. You want to look for your friend without anyone remembering your voice – get a job that keeps your head down and your mouth shut for money instead of for free."

I want to argue that finding Haruki is the whole reason we're here, that every hour spent hauling something for a stranger is an hour the coat's truck gets further away with him in it. I open my mouth to say exactly that, and Mira watches me do it the way she watches everything now – patient, waiting to see if I'll actually say the loud thing or catch it.

I catch it. Mostly because Suzumori's ankle is the size of a fist and neither of them asked me to fix it with my voice, and some small stubborn part of me is glad they didn't ask, because I don't know yet if I'd have said no.

"If I go asking every driver and every boarding house today with my face and my voice, this city writes a report on me by Thursday," I say instead. "Suzumori already said it. Ask with coins and eyes, or get found."

"So?" Mira says.

"So I do it the slow way." Saying it out loud makes it feel more real than deciding it in my head did. "I get work somewhere that pays cash and doesn't ask questions. I ask around while I'm doing it – a name here, a face there, not a manhunt, just ears open. It takes longer. Nobody has a reason to remember my face by the end of the week. And it keeps money coming in so we're not living off your fold until it hits zero."

Suzumori looks at me for a long moment, the kind of look that used to make me want to fill the silence with something clever. I don't, this time.

"That is the first plan out of your mouth since Shizuhara that did not involve breaking something," she says. "Write the date down somewhere. It will not happen twice by accident."

"It's not a promise," I say. "It's just tomorrow's plan."

"Fair," Mira says, and for once she doesn't add anything to it – no steering, no and after that, just the one word standing on its own. She blows out the little oil lamp on the sill, and the room goes down to just the canal light coming grey through the window and the sound of the market below finally starting to quiet.

"Tomorrow," Suzumori says from her mattress, "you find work. I find whoever sells crutches in this city. And somebody in this room is going to ask about your friend before the week is out – quietly, like a person and not a fire alarm. You saw how far the direct ask got you at that cart."

"I said I would," I say.

"Say it again in the morning," she says. "When there's light on it."

"Fine," I say. "In the morning I go looking for whoever's hiring, and I start there. Same plan, sunlight on it, if that's what it takes for you to believe I mean it."

"It is," Suzumori says. "Go to sleep before you say something you'll have to keep."

Chapter 41 – Lantern Paper

The paper shop wants hands before it wants names, which suits me fine.

I find it because a boy my age is standing outside it at dawn shouting into the alley that his uncle needs two backs and doesn't care whose, and I get there first by half a step ahead of a dockworker twice my size. The owner is a narrow man named Endo who talks the entire time he's deciding whether to hire me, which turns out to mean he decides in about four seconds and just keeps talking anyway.

"You're not from here," he says, already turning to lead me inside. "Don't care. You're not from here, you don't owe anybody in this ward a grudge, which means you'll actually move the boxes instead of standing around arguing about whose turn it is. That's rarer than you'd think. Watch the stacks – that one's rice paper, that one's the heavy stock for the frames, and none of it likes rain, which is a problem because half of Ashiro's roof leaks in August."

"What's the rush?" I ask, because the whole floor of the shop is stacked to the rafters with rolled paper and the man behind me is already unloading a second cart.

"The Reed Festival," Endo says, like I'm slow for not knowing. "Two weeks. Every lantern on every bridge in this city needs new paper because last year's is sun-rotted and the fire marshal finally noticed. I have the contract for the east wards. I have three days to fill an order that should take a week, and my nephew has decided this is the month to fall in love and be useless." He shoves a roll of paper into my arms that's heavier than it looks. "Frames go upstairs. Paper goes on the racks by color, not by size, I don't care what your instinct tells you. Two coins an hour, paid tonight, not tomorrow, because I don't trust boys I met at dawn to still be here tomorrow."

"I'll be here tomorrow."

"Everyone says that." He's already turned away, shouting at the cart man. "Upstairs. Go."

The work is the kind my body remembers even when my head doesn't want to – stacking, hauling, the particular ache across the shoulders that comes from carrying something too wide to hold close. It's not the pier and it's not the ice-truck yards from a life that feels like someone else's now, but it's close enough that my hands know what to do without me managing them, and for a few hours that's the whole relief of it. Nobody in the shop asks where I learned to carry a load balanced right. Nobody asks about the fading bruise along my jaw or the way I flinch half a beat too long at a dropped crate downstairs before I place the sound. Endo just keeps talking – about the festival committee, about his nephew's terrible taste in girls, about the fire marshal's cousin who runs the lantern-frame stall and has been overcharging the whole district for six years running – and none of it requires an answer, which is its own kind of mercy.

By noon I've learned three things that have nothing to do with paper: the festival is on the fifteenth, the fireworks go up over the reed pond on the east side because the water throws the light back twice, and half the city treats the whole thing like the only good thing that's happened to Ashiro in a year.

Around midmorning the cart man – a heavyset guy named Tetsu who has clearly worked for Endo long enough to have opinions about him – leans against the doorframe on his break and watches me stack the last of the rice paper.

"You're doing the corners wrong," he says. "Not wrong-wrong. Just slow. Stack from the middle out, not the edge in, or you'll be here till the fifteenth yourself."

I switch the way he shows me and the stack goes twice as fast, which he seems to take as a personal victory.

"Where'd you learn to carry like that?" he asks. "That's not paper-shop carrying. That's dock carrying."

"Pier, up north. Before the line moved."

"Before the line moved" is apparently a phrase everyone in this city understands without needing more of it, because he just nods like I've explained a whole life in four words and goes back to stacking without asking anything else. It's the easiest conversation I've had in weeks, mostly because it isn't really a conversation – just two people agreeing on how to move a

stack of paper without either of us owing the other a story.

"You're quiet for a boy who talks with his shoulders that loud," Endo says, handing me a rice ball wrapped in paper he definitely didn't pay for out of his own pocket. "Eat. You've earned lunch, at least, even if you haven't earned trust yet."

I eat on the loading step with my legs hanging over the canal, and it's the first food since the truck left Shizuhara that I actually taste instead of just swallow – the rice a little too salty, the plum in the middle sharp enough to make my eyes water, ordinary in a way that feels like an accusation and a relief at the same time. Somewhere behind me Endo is arguing with the cart man about the price of glue.

Mira finds me at the end of the shift with Suzumori's borrowed crutch tucked under one arm like she's been carrying it since Shizuhara instead of buying it an hour ago.

"You smell like paste," she says.

"I smell like money," I say, and hold up the coins Endo counted into my palm without shorting a single one, which he made a point of narrating out loud so I'd notice. "Three days of work, maybe more if his nephew stays useless."

"That covers the room through the week." She doesn't smile exactly, but something in her face unclenches a notch, the way it does when a number finally goes the right direction. "Suzumori found a woman selling grilled fish two streets over who does not ask why an old woman needs a crutch. We're eating something that isn't noodles tonight."

The fish stall turns out to be run by a woman with forearms like she's spent thirty years hauling nets, who calls everyone customer instead of a name and clearly could not care less about our story as long as our coins are real. The fish is smoky and a little burnt at the tail and better than anything I remember eating in Kōgetsu, which shouldn't be possible and is anyway. Suzumori eats with the crutch propped against her chair like a spear she's decided to retire for the evening.

"Your boy smells like a paper shop," she tells Mira, around a mouthful.

"He got hired at one," Mira says.

"I noticed the smell before the sentence. It's a strong smell." Suzumori tilts her head at me. "Did you learn anything today besides how to carry a box?"

"The festival's on the fifteenth," I say. "Fireworks over some pond on the east side. The whole city's making paper for it like it's the only thing that matters this year."

"It is the only thing that matters this year," the fish woman says, without looking up from her grill, which makes all three of us go quiet in the way you do when a stranger overhears more of your table than you meant to let out. She flips a fillet with the flat of her knife. "First one since the checkpoints went up on the coast road. Half this city lost someone to the line east. The other half is pretending they didn't so they can still go stand by the water and watch the sky do something pretty for one night. You should go. Boy like you looks like he forgot what pretty looks like."

"Maybe," I say, because it's easier than explaining that I don't know if I'll still be standing anywhere in this city on the fifteenth, hunting a coat and a truck instead of watching fireworks.

"Maybe is a coward's answer," Suzumori says, but there's no real heat in it. "You've been in this city one day and you're already deciding which parts of it you don't get to enjoy. That's not caution. That's just punishing yourself with extra steps."

"I'm not punishing myself."

"You are, a little," Mira says, quieter, not unkind. "You ate lunch today and you're already apologizing for it with your face."

"I didn't apologize for anything."

"You don't have to say it for it to be there," she says, and doesn't push past that, which is somehow worse than if she had.

We walk back with full stomachs, which is a sentence I would not have believed a week ago. Suzumori swings the crutch more than she needs it, testing the rhythm of not favoring the bad ankle, and at one point she overcorrects on a loose cobble and nearly puts herself into a fruit cart, catching the awning pole with one hand and swearing in a way that startles a laugh out of me before I can stop it – short, surprised, gone almost as fast

as it came, the way Mira's laugh went last night. It still counts. My chest still remembers how to do it.

"Laugh at an old woman falling," Suzumori says, straightening with as much dignity as a woman leaning on a stolen crutch can manage. "That's the boy I expected to meet on a pine road with a mouth like his."

"You didn't fall."

"I nearly gave a fruit cart my whole dignity. Same thing." But she's not really annoyed – there's something almost pleased in it, like she'd rather I laughed than flinched.

Back at the boarding house, Endo's paper roll list is still stuffed in my jacket pocket from the afternoon, and when I pull it out to check tomorrow's start time, a second sheet comes out with it – a festival notice, cheap printed paper, the kind Endo said his shop was stocking for every lamppost in the east ward. Reed lanterns pictured along a bridge. A date in block characters. FIFTEENTH NIGHT – LANTERNS ON THE WATER, FIREWORKS OVER THE REED POND, ALL WARDS WELCOME.

Mira takes it out of my hand and reads it twice, the way she reads everything that might matter later.

"Two weeks," she says.

"That's what Endo said."

"That's a lot of city standing in one place on one night." She folds the notice along its crease, careful, like it's worth keeping instead of scrap. "A lot of faces coming out from wherever they've been hiding all year to stand by the same water at the same hour."

"You think he'd be there?" I say. Haruki, I mean, though neither of us says his name out loud, because saying it out loud still feels like it might jinx whatever thin luck got us this far.

"I think a city that empties itself onto one bank of water is either the safest place in Ashiro to look for somebody, or the worst place to be found standing still," Mira says. "I don't know which yet. I know we have two weeks to decide, and paper in my hand that says exactly when we'll need to."

Suzumori looks at the notice over Mira's shoulder, quiet for once, and doesn't say anything about coats or careful mouths. She just taps the printed date once with one finger, the way a person marks something down so they won't have the excuse of forgetting it later.

"Fifteenth," she says. "Write it somewhere that isn't just your head, boy. Heads forget things they're scared of."

I put the notice on the windowsill next to what's left of the envelope, where I'll see it every morning whether I want to or not.

Chapter 42 – Taking Time

Four days into the paper shop and Endo trusts me enough to send me out on deliveries instead of just watching me stack, which is either a promotion or a way to get me out of his hair during the slow hours. Either way, it means I'm carrying a roll of festival lanterns across three wards by midmorning with nobody watching my shoulders for a tell, and it's the closest thing to peace I've had since the truck pulled away from Habu's mezzanine with Haruki's face in the gap of the canvas.

I ask about him anyway. Not loud, not with a description that sounds like a wanted notice – Mira drilled that into me the first night and I haven't forgotten it – just a question dropped sideways into whatever conversation is already happening. A dockworker unloading crates near the ferry stair. A woman selling roasted chestnuts who's worked that corner nine years and knows every face that's ever bought from her twice.

"Group of kids came through maybe a week back," I say to the chestnut woman, like it's idle. "One of them tall, dark hair, might've had a rough voice on him."

"Half this city came through a week back," she says, not unkind, just tired. "Reed Festival brings in every cousin and stranger with a boarding-house cousin. You looking for family?"

"Something like that."

"Ask at the labor board, not me. I sell chestnuts. I don't keep a register." She hands me a paper cone anyway, warm, without charging for it, which might be the nicest thing anyone's done for me all week and also tells me exactly nothing.

It's like that every time. A shrug, a maybe, a lot of tall boys in this city, kid. Nothing that points anywhere. I used to think patience was something other people had because they hadn't lost anything yet. Turns out it's just this – asking the same quiet question forty times and getting forty

different kinds of nothing, and going back the next day to ask again anyway.

Back at the shop, Tetsu is stacking the delivery cart for the afternoon run and gives me the east-ward route without being asked twice, which I've learned means he trusts me not to get lost or steal the cart.

"You're out there asking people things," he says. It's not a question either. "Endo noticed. Says you talk to every stall owner on your route like you're memorizing them."

"Looking for someone," I say. "A friend. Got separated coming into the city."

"Separated." He says the word like he's turning it over for a false bottom. "That's a soft way to put whatever actually happened."

"It's the true way. Just not the whole of it."

Tetsu shrugs, the kind of shrug that means he's decided not to ask twice either. "Ashiro's not as big as it looks from the bridge. People wash up in the same three or four places – the labor board, the ferry stair, the market. Keep asking. Cities like this one eventually run out of ways to hide a person, especially with the festival dragging half of them out into the open at once." He hands me the cart handle. "East ward. Don't let the fire marshal's cousin talk you into a discount on frames. He does that to every new face."

Suzumori's ankle is good enough now that she only leans on the crutch going downstairs, and she's decided this means she's earned the right to come to the market with me and Mira instead of waiting in the room like something that needs minding.

"I am not luggage," she says, when Mira suggests she stay behind while we go for ointment and rice. "I have walked farther than either of you on worse legs. I am coming to look at faces, because four eyes miss less than two, and because I am tired of that window."

"Nobody said luggage," Mira says. "I said rest another day. There's a difference."

"There is no difference when it's the same window and the same wall for the fourth day running." Suzumori is already reaching for her crutch. "I sat

behind shutters for longer than you've been alive, girl, waiting for men in nice watches to decide what happened to me next. I am not doing that again in a room I'm paying rent on. If my ankle gives out, you may say you told me so exactly once."

Mira looks at me like she wants backup and isn't going to get it, because I already know better than to referee this one.

"Fine," she says. "Once."

We go together. The market at midday is packed shoulder to shoulder along the canal rail, stalls selling everything from dried fish to festival string lights, and it's loud in a way that feels almost normal – not FDC-loud, not gunfire-loud, just a hundred people arguing over the price of onions. Mira haggles a wrap of ointment down two coins while Suzumori leans on her crutch and watches the crowd the way she watches everything, unhurried, like she's reading names off it.

That's when the boy goes for her coin purse.

He's quick about it – younger than me, maybe fourteen, already three steps into the crowd with the little cloth pouch in his fist before Suzumori even finishes turning to see what pulled at her belt. I move before I decide to move, which is the whole problem with my body lately; it still thinks like the pier, like the roof, like a place where the fastest answer is always the right one.

"Stop—" comes up in my throat on its own, already shaped, already carrying weight I haven't decided to give it, and copper floods the back of my tongue before the word finishes forming, sharp and metallic and familiar as a bruise. One more syllable and that boy's legs lock wherever he's standing, in the middle of a crowded market, in front of forty strangers who would remember a boy who freezes mid-stride for the rest of their lives.

I swallow it instead. Whole. It goes down like a stone and leaves my throat raw, and I close the last few steps on my own legs and grab the boy by the back of his collar with my actual hand.

He yelps and twists, and I twist him right back until the purse falls out of his fist onto the cobbles, and then I let go, because he's fourteen and skinny and already looking at me like I'm about to do something worse than shout.

"Go," I say. Just that. No weight under it, nothing but a boy telling another boy to get lost. "Before she decides to press it."

He goes. Fast, weaving through legs and stall poles until he's just another back in the crowd, and I stand there with my heart going too hard and my throat raw from the word I swallowed instead of said.

Suzumori picks up her own purse from the cobbles without any drama at all, like this happens to her weekly, which for all I know it does.

"You almost said something," she says. Not a question.

"I didn't."

"I know you didn't. I asked because I watched you decide not to, which is a different thing than not thinking of it at all." She weighs the purse in her palm, checking the coins are still inside. "That is the first time since I've known you that I've watched the word come all the way up your throat and stop before it left your teeth."

"He's a kid," I say. "Stealing a purse. That's not – that's not the kind of thing that needs my voice on it. My hands worked fine."

"Your hands have always worked fine," Mira says, arriving a beat late with the ointment, taking in the scene in one pass the way she does. "That was never the argument."

We eat lunch on the canal steps because none of us wants to carry the ointment and the rice all the way home before the bread goes stale. Suzumori peels a hard-boiled egg with more concentration than the task requires, which is her way of thinking without announcing that she's thinking.

"You could have stopped him with one word from ten feet away," she says eventually. "No running. No grabbing. No collar in your fist. Just a word, and he freezes, and you walk over at your own pace and pick the purse up like nothing in the market ever moved."

"I know."

"Why didn't you?"

I turn the empty paper chestnut cone over in my hands, looking for an answer that isn't just a reflex dressed up as a reason.

"Because I've used that word on things that mattered a lot more than a purse, and it left something in me a little more hollow every single time," I say slowly. "Because if I start using it on a fourteen-year-old with sticky fingers, I don't know where the line moves to next. Because Mira held my jaw shut in a ditch outside Shizuhara so I wouldn't kill a truck full of people, and I don't want to find out what happens to a purse-thief on a day nobody's there to hold anything."

Suzumori doesn't say good boy or anything close to it, which I'm grateful for, because I think I'd have thrown the egg at her.

"Taking your time with a thing like that," she says instead, "is not the same as being slow. People confuse those. A slow boy doesn't notice the word rising. You noticed it and made it wait. That's a different animal entirely, and it took you longer to grow than it should have, and it still isn't finished growing."

"It isn't," I agree. "None of this feels finished."

"No," she says. "It won't, for a while yet."

Mira has gone quiet beside me, turning her own cup in her hands, and when she finally speaks it isn't about the thief or the market or the coin at all.

"You've been asking about him for four days," she says. "Quiet questions. You'll find a thread eventually – this city is not that big, and the festival will pull people toward the same water." She looks at me directly. "So say it plainly. When you find him – what are you going to say?"

I open my mouth. Nothing comes. Not a command. Not even an ordinary sentence.

"I don't know yet," I say.

Mira nods once, like that is an answer she can work with for tonight.

Chapter 43 – Stall Turn

Suzumori wants pickles from a stall two lanes past the fish woman's – the good kind, she says, not the ones that leave your mouth tasting like you bit a fence – and Mira left before I woke up with nothing but a note pinned under the festival notice on the sill: checking something, don't wait on me. So it's just me and a fistful of coins Endo doesn't need back until noon, walking a market I've mostly learned the shape of by now.

Ten days to the fifteenth. Endo's shop has stopped being about rolled paper and started being about frames, which means half the ward smells like glue and cut reed whenever the wind comes off the workshops. I like the smell more than I expected to. It means people are building toward something instead of just surviving whatever's already happened to them.

The lane Suzumori sent me down is narrower than the main strip, more locals than festival lookers, brine barrels lined up under a low tin roof with jars stacked three deep behind them. A man's voice up ahead is arguing with a customer about the price of pickled plum like his whole reputation rides on two coins, which in this city it probably does.

I get in line behind an old woman with a basket and wait, because waiting in lines is one of the smaller, dumber skills this city has taught me – how to just stand somewhere and not need it to move faster.

The stall boy has his back to the lane, both hands deep in a barrel, hauling up a net bag of daikon that's been soaking since dawn by the smell of it. Tall. Dark hair a little longer than it should be for someone doing this kind of work, pushed back off his forehead with a wet hand. Sleeves rolled past the elbow. Forearms that didn't use to look like that – thicker through the wrist, a new white line across one knuckle healed wrong, like he grabbed something sharp and kept working anyway.

"Two coins for the plum, that's it," he says to whoever's ahead of me, not turning around yet. "I don't set the price. I just work here today."

The old woman pays without arguing and moves off. It's my turn.

He turns around.

For one whole second my body doesn't know what to do with what my eyes just gave it. The market keeps making its noise – the plum vendor arguing, a cart wheel sticking on a cobble, gulls fighting over a dropped skewer – and none of it touches me, because Haruki is standing on the other side of a barrel of daikon with his mouth already open on whatever he was about to say to the next customer, and the next customer is me.

His mouth stays open. Nothing comes out of it.

"Haruki." It comes up my throat with weight already stacked behind it before I've decided to give it any, hot and sudden, and copper floods the back of my tongue for half a breath – not a command, nothing shaped enough to land on anyone, just his own name trying to leave my mouth like a shout instead of a word. I swallow it down to something barely louder than the barrel between us. "Haruki."

"Kaito." His voice does the opposite of mine – goes quiet instead of loud, careful instead of hard, the way it always does right before he says something he's thought all the way through. Except I don't think he's thought anything through yet either. His eyes go to my jaw, my hands, the space behind me like he's counting who's close enough to hear, and only then back to my face. "You're—" He stops. Starts again. "You're here."

"I live here." It comes out stupid and I know it's stupid the second it's out, but it's true, and true is apparently all I've got left in me right now.

Behind me somebody clears their throat – a woman with two kids tugging her sleeves, waiting for pickles like the world hasn't just tipped sideways on her side of the lane. Haruki's eyes flick to her and something in his shoulders drops half an inch, deliberate, like he's setting a lid back on a pot before it boils over in front of a stranger.

"What can I get you?" he says. To me. In the voice he'd use for anyone.

"Daikon," I say, because it's the first pickled thing my mouth can find. "And whatever she was buying. The plum."

He weighs it without looking at the scale twice, wraps it in paper already gone translucent with brine, and takes my coins with fingers shaking just

enough that one drops and rolls under the barrel. Neither of us goes for it.

"You're not hurt," I say, low, while he's still bent half toward the dropped coin. It's not the question I mean to ask. It's the one that gets out first.

"Not right now." He straightens. "You?"

"Not right now."

The woman behind me shifts her weight, not patient anymore. Haruki serves her without missing the wrap, without his voice changing at all – daikon, two jars of plum, change counted out loud so she doesn't have to ask twice. I stand there holding my own paper parcel like it's the only reason I'm allowed to still be in this lane, and I watch him be normal at somebody while every other part of him is clearly not.

When she's gone there's a gap – three, four seconds where the next person in line is still deciding what they want – and neither of us wastes it on anything soft.

"Where?" I say. "Just tell me where you are, who you're with, I need–"

"I can't talk here." Fast, flat, his glance going past my shoulder again. "The man who runs this stall went to get more barrels. He'll be back before I finish explaining anything, and I am not having this conversation where six strangers can hear your name."

"So when?"

"Tonight." He wipes his hands on an apron someone lent him, plain gray, two sizes too big, and for a second he just looks at me – really looks, not the scanning-the-lane look, the other one, the one I haven't seen since a truck full of headlights put half a mile of dark road between us. "I close this stall myself tonight. The man's leaving me to lock the barrels and count the till because he trusts me now, which took less time than it should have. Come back after the lanterns go up over the lane – not before, or you'll be standing here with witnesses. I'll be alone by then."

"Alone." I latch onto the word harder than I mean to. "Riku's not going to be standing over your shoulder?"

"Riku knows I'm covering somebody's stall for the hour. He doesn't know who walked up in the line." Something moves behind Haruki's eyes, fast, gone before I can read all of it. "None of them know you're here. I took this

because the warehouse foreman owed the stall man a favor and I said I'd cover so the crates got unloaded on time. It wasn't supposed to turn into anything."

"You didn't tell them where you were going."

"I'm telling you I didn't expect the customer," he says, and there's an edge in it now, thin but real. "I don't plan my whole morning around who might be standing in a pickle line. Do you tell Mira everywhere you walk?"

I don't answer that, because the honest answer is not since about four minutes ago, and saying it out loud feels like handing him something I haven't decided to give yet.

Another customer steps up – a kid, maybe ten, counting coins twice like he's not sure he has enough. Haruki turns to him without missing a beat, patient, gets the order right on the first try. I watch him do the whole ordinary transaction like it costs him nothing, and I read it wrong, the way I read most things about him lately – I decide it means he's fine, that whatever's under the careful voice is small enough to manage between customers.

It isn't. I see it the second the kid walks off – the way Haruki's hand stays flat on the counter a beat too long, like he's using the wood to keep himself standing instead of just resting there.

"You're not fine," I say, before I can stop myself.

"No," he says. Plain. No argument in it. "I'm really not. But I have about four more minutes before that man comes back with his barrels, and I'm not going to spend them falling apart in front of you where anyone walking past can watch it happen. Tonight. That's what I have to give you today."

"Fine." The word comes out harder than it should. "Tonight, when the lanterns go up. This stall."

"This stall," he says. "Don't bring Mira. Don't bring Suzumori, if she's still with you—"

"She is."

"—not because I don't want to see them. Because I don't know what I'm going to say yet, and I would rather say the wrong thing to just you first than say it in front of a room."

That lands somewhere close to the exact thing Mira asked me on the canal

steps a few days back, the question I still don't have an answer for, and hearing it come out of Haruki's mouth instead – I don't know what I'm going to say yet – makes it feel less like a hole in me and more like something we're standing in together for once.

"Okay," I say. "Just me."

Down the lane, a man's voice calls out, already annoyed, already back – "Boy! Barrels don't unload themselves, and neither does my till" – and Haruki's face closes back into the ordinary stall-boy mask so fast I almost don't believe the last few minutes happened at all.

"Go," he says, quiet, not looking at me now, hands already moving to look busy. "Before he sees your face twice in one morning and starts asking who you are."

I go. I make myself walk instead of run, out into the wider lane where nobody's paying attention to a boy with a parcel of pickled daikon, and three turns away my hands start shaking hard enough that I stop and set the parcel down on a low wall, just to breathe.

Back at the room, Suzumori is sitting up on her mattress with her bad ankle propped on a folded blanket, and she takes one look at me before I've even got the door shut.

"You look like you saw a ghost buy vegetables," she says.

"Just tired." I hold out the parcel. "Daikon. And the plum, since it was there."

She unwraps a corner and eats a slice standing on principle, not because she's hungry yet. "Your hands were shaking when you walked in. Was it him? The coat."

It's the easiest door she could have opened for me, and I walk through it before I can talk myself out of it. "Thought I saw him again, by the barrels. Wasn't. Same as the tea stand." The lie sits wrong in my mouth, heavier than the truth would have been, but it's not nothing – I did think my whole life had turned a corner in that lane, just not the corner I'm telling her.

"You keep seeing him in men who are not him," Suzumori says. "That's what a bad debt does. It goes looking for the man who's owed it in every stranger's coat." She studies me a beat longer than I like. "Eat something. You look like

a boy who forgot he has a body.”

I eat because it's easier than arguing. She doesn't ask again, but I catch her watching my hands twice more before I leave for Endo's, and both times I make them still on purpose.

The shop is glue smell and stacked frames all afternoon, and I get two corners wrong badly enough that Tetsu redoes them without comment, which is somehow worse than if he'd said something. “You're somewhere else today,” is all he offers, and doesn't push past it when I say I didn't sleep great. Endo pays me out at dusk without shorting a coin and tells me to be back at dawn. I say I will. Right now the only thing I'm actually planning past tonight is tonight.

Mira comes back to the room after dark, quiet in a way that isn't unusual for her lately – whatever she's been checking, she doesn't hand it over easy, and I've learned not to make her. She eats a little of the pickles Suzumori has been guarding, says the plum's better than the last stall's, and doesn't ask why my leg won't stop bouncing under the table.

When the lanterns along the canal start going up – the first strings catch light through the window, one by one – I stand up and say I'm going to walk for a while.

“Now?” Mira looks up from the coins she's been recounting for the fourth time tonight. “I'll come.”

“I want to be by myself for a bit.” It's not a lie, even if it isn't the whole truth either. “Head's loud. I need the water without anybody talking at me.”

She studies me the way Suzumori did this morning, and for a second I think she's going to argue it, come anyway, plant herself beside me whether I want the company or not. Instead she just nods, once, slow.

“Don't be gone past midnight,” she says. “And don't go looking at every coat you pass. You'll wear yourself out before you find the real one.”

“I won't look at coats,” I say. True enough. “I'll be back.”

She goes back to the coins. I go down the stairs two at a time, past the landlady's dark window, into the lane that smells like canal water and somebody's dinner. The pickle stall is three turns from here.

Chapter 44 – Without Them

I count the till twice because the first count doesn't feel true, and somewhere under the second count I realize I'm stalling – not because the coins are wrong, but because the second I finish, there's nothing left standing between me and the thing I told Riku I wouldn't do without him.

He made me say it out loud, our first morning in this city, before either of us had eaten – sat me down on the boarding house stairs and waited until I said I don't go near Kaito without you standing next to me, then nodded once like a man closing a deal. I said it because I owed him that. That morning, I believed it.

I'm going to break that promise in about four minutes, and the only honest thing I can do about it now is not pretend otherwise while I'm doing it.

The stall man left twenty minutes ago with his barrels and his instructions – lock the till, drop the shutter, leave the key with the noodle cart two stalls down. I've done all of it except the shutter. I leave a gap at the corner wide enough for a boy to duck through sideways, and I sit down on the upturned crate to wait, because standing felt like something I'd have to explain to my own legs.

Kaito ducks through the gap a little after the second string of lanterns catches down the lane. He doesn't say anything at first. He just stands there in the narrow space between the barrels with the lamp light cutting half his face into shadow, and for a second neither of us moves.

Then he crosses the stall toward me, and I feel it before I understand what I'm feeling – some part of my legs deciding, on their own, without asking me, that they are not allowed to close that distance from the other side. It isn't pain. It's more like trying to walk against water that only exists for me. I push through it anyway, standing up off the crate to meet him halfway, and it breaks the way ice breaks under a boot – sudden, then just gone, like it was never load-bearing in the first place.

"You felt something," Kaito says. He's close enough now that I can see the thin scar through his eyebrow catching the lamp. "Your face just did a thing."

"I'm fine." It's not a lie exactly. Whatever that was, it's already over. "I didn't know if I'd be able to walk toward you. After the pine road. I wasn't sure if it was still – holding."

Something goes still in him. "Stop following me. Go home," he says, quiet, like the words themselves might still be armed. "You remember it that clean."

"I remember every word of it that clean." My voice comes out flatter than I mean it to, all the careful going out of it at once. "I remember my feet turning east before I decided anything. I remember walking for an hour thinking about my mother's apartment like it was still standing there waiting, and then somewhere past the second checkpoint I couldn't remember which floor. That's when it broke. Not because I was strong. Because you told a version of me to go somewhere that doesn't exist anymore, and my body didn't have anywhere left to walk to."

Kaito doesn't flinch away from that the way I expect him to. He just stands with it, jaw tight, hands loose at his sides like he's decided not to hide behind moving them for once.

"I didn't have a better sentence," he says. "You were about to die next to me on that road, and the only thing my mouth could reach for fast enough was something that would put miles between you and whatever was coming. I'm not going to tell you I'm sorry I said it. I'm sorry I didn't know a way to save you that didn't take your legs away from you while I did it."

"That's not the same as sorry."

"No," he says. "It's not. It's the truth instead."

I want to be angrier than I am. I spent weeks building the shape of this exact conversation in my head – on the road east with Riku pulling me by the collar, in a bunk in Shizuhara, in a truck bed watching him go past in a ditch with a girl's hand fisted in his jacket – and every version had me saying something that actually cut. Standing here with the real him in front of me, all I've got is the plain fact of it, laid out instead of thrown.

"You don't get to decide what happens to my legs," I say. "Not again. If you ever put weight under a sentence pointed at me again, I want you to at least

look at me while you do it. Not shout it over your shoulder and watch it work from a distance.”

“I looked at you the whole time,” Kaito says. “That’s the part you don’t know. I watched your face go empty and I kept watching it, because turning away would’ve been letting myself pretend I didn’t do it.”

That lands somewhere I didn’t leave room for. I sit back down on the crate because my legs have earned a rest twice in five minutes, and Kaito lowers himself onto a barrel across from me, close enough that our knees almost touch in the narrow gap between the stacks.

“Shizuhara,” I say, because if I don’t say it now I’ll find a reason not to. “I need to know what you did there. Not the version Mei gave us secondhand through a locked door. Yours.”

His hands find each other, thumb working over a knuckle. “How much do you already have?”

“Vents. Gas, then a hose. A and B, all of them, in groups of ten. Habu’s mouth shut and left in his own office, still breathing. Guards on the west fence, dead, however many of them there were.” I make myself keep my voice level saying it, because if I let it shake now I won’t get through the rest. “Riku said your name in the corridor before Mei even told us hers. He said, that was Kaito. Same boy. Same mess. I want you to tell me if he was right.”

“He was right.” No hedge in it. No softening. “I didn’t kill the ones in the vents. I got there after that part was already done – I heard it happening below me and couldn’t reach it in time. What I did was everyone standing between me and Habu once I knew. The guards who came at us. The two who tried to stop us at the medical stair. I stopped being able to count somewhere in the kitchen corridor.”

“And Habu?”

“I left him alive.” His jaw works once. “Ending him would have been for me, not for anyone he already hurt, and Mira wouldn’t let me pretend otherwise. I shut his mouth instead. He’s still up there behind that glass, breathing, unable to give an order to anyone, for as long as that holds.”

“You could have died in there.”

“I know.”

"You could have made me watch you die in there, from a truck bed, going the wrong direction, unable to do a single thing about it." My voice does shake now, and I let it. "That's the part I can't put down. Not the guards. Not even Habu. The idea that the last time I ever saw you could have been through the slats of a truck, and I would have spent the rest of whatever life I've got not knowing if you walked out of that building or not."

Kaito's throat moves. "I saw you too," he says. "In the ditch. I've thought about that stretch of road more than almost anything else since. Half a second, and then you were gone around a bend, and I didn't even get to say your name loud enough for it to reach you."

"I heard you," I say. "I couldn't make out the words over the engine. I saw your mouth start something and then Mira pulled you down before it finished, and I spent the next three days furious that I'd never know what it was."

"I don't remember what I was going to say." He looks almost embarrassed admitting it, which is its own strange comfort – that some things got lost for him too. "Might not have been words at all. Just noise. Your name, maybe, without anything after it."

We sit with that for a second, the lamp hissing low between us, brine and cut daikon thick in the air.

"I'm not the same as I was on the roof," Kaito says eventually. "I've watched what happens in my own hands now, and I don't get to pretend it's still just bad luck and a temper. I need you to know that before we decide anything, because if you're hoping I'll turn back into the version of me from before the truck took Ryn, I'm not going to lie and say that's still in here waiting to come back out."

"I don't want him back," I say, and mean it more than I expected to when the sentence started. "I want to know who you are now. That's different. I've changed too – something happened at that fence I still haven't told Riku the whole shape of, because I don't fully know the shape of it myself yet."

Something sharpens in Kaito's face, quick and gone. "What happened?"

"Not tonight," I say, and it costs me to say it, because I can see he wants it and I'm choosing to keep it anyway. "I'll say it out loud eventually. Just not standing in a stranger's pickle stall with a shutter that isn't even locked."

He doesn't push. He just nods, slow, and for once that doesn't feel like distance between us – it feels like the first honest boundary either of us has drawn since the pine road, the kind that says not never, just not yet instead of never ask again.

"So what happens now?" I say. "You go back to Mira and Suzumori and don't tell them. I go back to Riku and Mei and Ōhashi and don't tell them. We meet in pickle stalls until the festival, and nobody who actually cares about either of us knows we've found each other."

"That's not a plan. That's just delaying the part where somebody gets hurt finding out sideways." Kaito rubs a hand over his jaw, and for a second he looks less like the boy who emptied a lobby and more like the one who used to argue with a teacher over a seating chart. "Riku already knows my name. Mei already knows it. If Mira sees you on a street corner before I've told her myself, that's worse for everybody than doing this the hard way once."

"I made Riku a promise," I say. "I talk to him before I go chasing you again. I already broke half of it just by being here tonight without telling him first."

"Then don't break the rest of it. Tell him tomorrow, first thing, exactly how this happened – you didn't go looking, I walked up in a line. That's true. It's also not going to make him less furious that you didn't run straight to him after."

"No," I say. "It won't."

"So we do it together," Kaito says. "Not just us circling each other in an empty stall like criminals. Everybody. Riku, Mei, Ōhashi. Mira, Suzumori. One room, one night, before the festival turns this whole city into a crowd we could lose each other in for good this time. Say what needs saying where all of it gets heard at once, instead of feeding it out one careful sentence at a time until somebody feels lied to."

It's not a soft idea. I can already see it going wrong – Riku and Mira in one room with weeks of separate roads behind them, Suzumori's opinions about kept things, Mei's flat refusal to be anyone's steady hand – but I can also see the alternative clearly enough to know it's worse: both of us running secret errands to the same pickle stall until someone's patience runs out first.

"They're not going to like each other," I say.

"They don't have to like each other," Kaito says. "They just have to sit in the same room long enough to say the true things instead of the careful ones."

Outside the gap in the shutter, footsteps come down the lane at a pace that isn't a stroll – two sets, unhurried but deliberate. Kaito goes still the way he does now, listening with his whole body instead of just his ears, and I find myself doing the same.

They pass – just two men heading for the noodle cart, voices fading into the market noise beyond the barrels.

"We can't keep doing that every time somebody walks past," I say, quieter now. "Jumping at footsteps in a stall that isn't even ours."

"Then let's not have a reason to jump," Kaito says. "Tomorrow. Tell Riku everything tonight so it's not a fresh wound in the morning. I'll tell Mira the same. We find a place big enough for all of us and small enough that nobody official notices seven people arguing in it."

"This stall at dusk," I say. "Same place. You tell me where when you have a room. I am not handing you our boarding house so you can knock and get Riku's fist before you get a sentence out."

"Fair," he says. "Dusk. Here. If the stall man is back, we talk like customers and walk."

"Tomorrow," I say, because saying it once makes it real in a way that thinking it hasn't managed yet. "I'll bring them wherever you say. You bring yours."

"Tomorrow," Kaito says, and holds out his hand – not for a shake, just open, like he's not sure what to do with it now that the sentence is finished. I take it anyway, because some things don't need a better reason than that.

Down the lane, the noodle cart's steam whistle lets out a short, ordinary shriek, and both of us laugh before either one decides to, startled, the way you laugh at nothing when everything in you has been braced too long for something worse.

"Go home before Mira starts walking the canal looking for you," I say. "I still have to lock this shutter properly, or the stall man's going to notice whose fingerprints are all over his barrels."

"Tomorrow," Kaito says again, backing toward the gap, like repeating it enough times will keep either of us from finding a reason to back out.

"Tomorrow," I say back, and mean it exactly as much as he does.

I drop the shutter and turn the key, and stand a moment in the lane with the market noise washing past. Tomorrow I walk into our room and tell Riku I found Kaito, and met him twice, and never said a word. How do I make that sound like anything except what it is?

Chapter 45 – Same Table

Riku is sitting up on his mattress with his knees against his chest when I get the door shut behind me, which tells me he was already awake, which tells me some part of him knew tonight wasn't going to end the ordinary way.

"You said you were walking off a headache." Not a question. His voice is flat in the dark, careful the way it gets right before it isn't. "That was two hours ago."

"I found him." I don't try to soften it, because softening it now would just be another version of the lie I already told walking out the door. "Kaito. He was standing at the till of a pickle stall three lanes from here, and I've been talking to him since the lanterns went up."

Across the room Mei sits up too. She wasn't asleep either – nobody in this room sleeps light enough to miss a door – and she doesn't say anything yet, just watches me the way she watches a short count on a board, waiting to see where the number lands.

"You went alone." Riku's voice hasn't moved, but something under it has. "After you told me – after Shizuhara, after the pine road, you told me you wouldn't go near him without me standing next to you."

"I know what I said."

"Then say it again so I know you heard yourself."

"I heard myself." My hands are doing the thing they do, smoothing a wrinkle out of my own sleeve that isn't there. "I didn't go looking for him tonight, Riku. I was covering somebody's stall for an hour and he walked up in the line to buy pickled daikon. I didn't choose the moment. I chose what I did after it."

"Which was not to come find me."

"Which was talk to him for five minutes in front of the vendor and then go back tonight, alone, because he asked me to and because I wanted one

conversation with him that wasn't performed for an audience first." I make myself hold his eyes instead of the floor. "That part I chose. You're right to be angry about that part."

Riku doesn't say anything for a moment. Mei is the one who breaks it.

"Is he still in this city?"

"Yes. With Mira and an old woman named Suzumori, in a rented room somewhere in the canal wards. We meet again at the stall at dusk. He'll have a place by then."

"Habu's building," Mei says. Not loud. "He's the reason A and B are all dead. He's the reason I spent a night watching a tablet I couldn't put down because it was the only thing keeping my hands from shaking." She says it the way she reads a bad count out loud – correcting it, not performing grief over it. "I want to hear that from him before I decide what I think about a pickle stall reunion."

"You'll get the chance." I sit down on the floor between the two mattresses because standing feels like something I have to justify. "That's what tonight was actually about. He wants everyone in one room. Tomorrow, or the day after – whenever he finds somewhere. You, Mei, Ōhashi. Mira and Suzumori on his side. Everybody says the true things instead of feeding it to each other one careful sentence at a time until somebody feels lied to."

"His words or yours?"

"His, mostly." I almost smile at that, and hate that I almost do. "He's better at naming what's wrong with a plan than I am lately."

Riku rubs both hands down his face and holds them there a second before dropping them. "You understand what you're asking me to do. Sit in a room with the boy who put a rifle-stock bruise on my shoulder the same morning a checkpoint decided to look twice at us. Be civil about it. For your sake."

"I'm not asking you to be civil. I'm asking you to be honest, in the same room, where he can hear it and answer it instead of it just living in you."

"That's worse," Riku says, but there's no real refusal in it, just the sound of a man deciding to do the harder thing anyway. "Fine. One room. I get to say what I came to say, and nobody in that room gets to tell me it isn't the time."

"Nobody's going to tell you that."

Mei lies back down but keeps her eyes open on the ceiling. "I'll come. Not for him. For Habu, and for whatever he's decided to do with the rest of the people who were in that building." A pause. "And because if I don't hear it now, I'll keep wondering the whole time we're in this city, and wondering is worse than knowing."

At dusk I go back to the pickle stall the way we said, and I bring Riku with me because that was the other half of the deal – no more secret meetings, no more walking into Kaito alone. Mei stays with Ōhashi and the six; she said if the place is real she will come to the room, not stand in a market lane waiting to be introduced like a package.

Kaito is already there, buying nothing, standing where the barrels block the view from the main path. When he sees Riku his shoulders go tight, then he makes himself leave them down.

"Nakahara," Kaito says. His voice is careful in a way I've only heard him use with strangers he's decided not to underestimate. "I owe you a busted shoulder and everything that came after it. I'm not here to fix that in a pickle lane. I'm here to tell you where."

"Where," Riku repeats.

"Paper shop, east ward. Endo's. My boss trusts me enough now to lend me the back room after closing, no questions, as long as nothing gets set on fire near the good stock." A ghost of something almost like a joke moves across his face and doesn't land anywhere. "Tonight, once the lanterns are lit. Bring whoever's coming. I'll bring mine."

Riku looks at me, then at Kaito. "You walk us there. I am not following a scrap of directions into a building your people picked."

"Fine," Kaito says. "I walk you there. Mira and Suzumori will already be inside."

We collect Mei and Ōhashi on the way. The six stay with the landlady, who's fed stranger arrangements than seven kids arguing across town and doesn't ask why. Ōhashi tells the oldest of them where the stationery shop is if anyone needs him urgently, which is Ōhashi's whole way of saying be careful without

saying it.

Endo's shop at night smells like glue and cut reed, rolls of unfinished lantern paper stacked to the rafters on either side, half-built frames leaning in a row like something waiting to be given a shape. One oil lamp on a crate throws just enough light to make everyone's face look older than it is.

Mira is already there when Kaito pushes the storeroom door open, and Suzumori is seated on an upturned crate with her stick across her knees like she's decided this is where she'll be presiding from. Kaito steps aside so the rest of us can file in behind him. Nobody says hello. There isn't a version of hello that fits.

"Sit if you want," Kaito says. "Nobody's going to make anyone stand through this out of manners."

Riku doesn't sit. "The pine road," he says, straight at Kaito, no run-up. "You put a soldier's rifle down like it was nothing, and then you turned around and told my friend to go home in a voice that took his legs out from under him for a mile. I got hit trying to get between the two of you. That bruise is why we walked slower than we should have. Slower is why the checkpoint that morning had time to actually look at us instead of waving us through. Slower is why we both ended up on Habu's intake line."

"I know," Kaito says. He doesn't look away from it. "I've turned that road over a lot of nights since. I'm not going to tell you it would've gone differently if I'd said something kinder. I don't know that it would have. I know I didn't ask what it would do to you before I said it, and that's on me whether the checkpoint finds you slow or fast."

"That's not an apology."

"No," Kaito says. "I'm short on those lately. The truth is what I had."

Riku's jaw works. He sits, finally, on the edge of a paper crate, like the honesty took more out of him than a fight would have.

Mei doesn't wait for a gap. "Shizuhara," she says. "I was there. Vents. Lobby. Habu. Mira said abort. You stayed. I want to know why you stayed – not the schedule. You."

"Because I watched them walk into that shed and I could not make myself leave," Kaito says. "Because walking out felt like agreeing with Habu. Because after Ryn I keep throwing myself at the next bad thing until something stops me. That is not a clean reason. It is the one I had. When it was over I killed every rifle between me and Habu. I did not count them. I am not going to pretend I did."

"You left him alive."

"Mira stopped me." His hand finds Mira's without looking for it, just briefly, and lets go. "I wanted him dead more than I've wanted almost anything. She told me that would be for me, not for anyone he already hurt, and she wasn't wrong, and I hated her for being right for about a day."

"He's still breathing somewhere," Mei says. "Mouthed shut or not, that's a man who knows exactly what happened, sitting in a chair, waiting for whoever finds him to ask the wrong question." She looks at Mira. "Your people left that loose."

"My people didn't leave anything," Mira says, even. "I left it, because the alternative was watching him become someone I didn't recognize over a body that couldn't argue back. I'll live with that choice being wrong before I'll live with the other one."

Suzumori taps her stick once against the crate leg, not sharp, just present. "You are all determined to relitigate a building none of you can go back and fix. Say the useful part instead. What do you do about the coat."

That's the word that turns the room.

"The coat helped us," Ōhashi says, careful, like a man laying a card he's not sure of. "He handed us an envelope with rent money in it and dropped us in this city without asking anything back. Katō rode off with him on his own two legs. Whatever he is, on our side of it he looked like a man clearing a debt."

"On my side of it," Kaito says, and his voice goes flatter, "he stood on a mezzanine and watched children walk into a gassed room and didn't move, and then he loaded my best friend into the back of a truck without asking either of us if that was all right, and drove off into the dark like he'd bought something. I don't care how kind the envelope was. A man doesn't get credit for the rescue if he was close enough to stop the thing he rescued you from."

"I don't know what he saw on that mezzanine," I say. "I was not there for that part. You were. I know what he did once he had us on the truck – he got us out of the wire and into Ashiro. That kept six people and me and Riku and Mei and Ōhashi off Habu's next board. Both of those things can be true at once."

"Convenient, that the same man is a savior on your morning and a bystander on mine."

"Maybe he's both," I say. "I don't like that answer either. It's the only one that fits what we've each actually seen."

Nobody has a better one. The lamp hisses. Somewhere out past the shutters a cart wheel sticks on a cobble and somebody swears at it, ordinary and far away.

"We are not going to solve that man tonight," Suzumori says, into the quiet that follows. "We are not going to solve Habu, or the pine road, or which of you gets to keep the worse guilt. You have all been carrying this since separate roads met a truck, and carrying it together in one storeroom for an hour has not made any of it lighter. It has only made it louder, in stereo, which I could have told you before we started."

"So what were we supposed to do?" Riku says. "Sit quiet and let it fester?"

"No. You were supposed to say it once, out loud, where the other side could hear it land – which you have now done." Suzumori looks around the room, slow, like she's counting faces the way Sato once counted stamps. "Now you are supposed to do the harder thing, which is decide you are not going to fill every hour left in this city arguing about who bled worse."

Mira reaches into her jacket and sets a folded sheet of paper on the crate between the lamp and Suzumori's knee – cheap printed paper, a picture of reed lanterns on a bridge, block characters gone soft at the fold from being carried too long.

"The fifteenth," she says. "Fireworks over the reed pond. All wards welcome. That notice has been sitting on our windowsill for days like a joke we hadn't decided whether to laugh at."

"You want a festival," Mei says, and it isn't quite a question, and it isn't quite mockery either.

"I want one night where nobody in this room has to be careful," Kaito says. "Not pine road, not vents, not the coat – just lanterns and food that costs coins instead of a story, and everybody standing by the same water at the same hour like it's normal, because it's the closest thing to normal any of us are going to get handed for free."

"We don't get nights off," Riku says, but it comes out tired instead of hard, which is its own kind of answer.

"No," Kaito says. "We're taking one anyway."

Ōhashi looks down at his notebook, at the page he hasn't written on all evening, and for once doesn't reach for the pencil. "I'd like that written down as the first plan tonight nobody had to argue into existence."

"Fifteenth," Suzumori says, tapping the paper once with one finger. "All of you. In one place, for one evening, doing nothing more dangerous than watching the sky do something pretty."

"All of us," I say, looking at Riku, then at Mei, then at Kaito last, because some agreements need the person who started this to say it plainly before it's real. "The fifteenth. We go."

"We go," Kaito says.

Riku looks like he wants to argue purely on principle, and doesn't. "Fine. But if anyone so much as raises a voice near that pond, I'm dragging both of you home by the collar, and I don't care whose legs decide to fight me on it."

"Fair," Kaito says, and for the first time all night, something in his face almost settles.

Chapter 46 – Pond Night

The fifteenth shows up faster than it has any right to, the way every deadline in this city seems to once you've agreed to enjoy the one at the end of it.

We spend the morning acting like warehouse hands who have the day off – Riku arguing with the landlady about whether festival nights count against rent credit, Mei washing her hair in the shared bath like she is preparing for an inspection, Ōhashi deciding the notebook is coming whether anyone likes it or not. I buy a cheap plain yukata from a stall two lanes down, cotton the color of weak tea, because showing up in the same shirt I've worn all week would look like I hadn't decided to actually come. Riku finds a plain dark jacket instead of his work coat, which on him counts as festival dress. Mei borrows something from a neighbor girl on the second floor and pushes the sleeves up out of habit even though there's nothing left to carry.

Last night, on the stair outside Endo's, I asked where we should meet. Kaito rubbed the back of his neck like he still expected someone to cancel.

"The bridge by the reed pond," he said. "Dusk. If you're late I'm eating without you."

"Don't eat without us," I said. "Riku will start a fight with the corn cart."

"Then don't be late."

We aren't. For a few minutes it's just the four of us and the crowd thickening around the lanterns, and nobody quite knows how to stand after last night – not angry anymore, just careful, like the wrong joke might put the bruise back.

Then Kaito comes across the bridge with Mira and Suzumori.

He's in dark blue cotton that doesn't try to be anything. Mira is in pale green that isn't new but has clearly been kept somewhere careful for exactly this kind of night. Suzumori has traded her stick for a shorter cane and a

clean gray wrap she wouldn't let anyone else pay for. For a second nobody quite knows how to stand near each other either. Then Riku opens his mouth.

"You clean up like somebody who's never held a crate," he tells Kaito, by way of a greeting that isn't quite a greeting.

"You clean up like somebody who lost a fight with an iron," Kaito says back, and something that's been tight in Riku's face since the storeroom finally lets go, half an inch.

The bridge crowd thickens as we cross into the ward proper – lanterns strung two and three deep over every lane, paper Kaito himself might have stacked at Endo's counter a week ago, red and white and pale green swinging in a wind that smells like fry oil and canal water and somebody's incense stick burning too close to a stall of dried squid. A man with a drum the size of a barrel is warming up two streets over, and every few seconds the crowd answers him with a laugh that has nothing to do with the joke, just the noise of people glad to be standing where they're standing.

"I forgot cities did this," Mei says, mostly to herself, watching a pair of kids race paper boats down the canal's edge with actual coins riding on the outcome. "Just – this. For no reason except the date on a calendar."

"There's a reason," Suzumori says. "It's the first one since the checkpoints went up on the coast road. Half this crowd lost somebody east. The rest came anyway." She doesn't say it like a lecture. She says it like a woman confirming a fact she already knew before she agreed to come.

We eat standing at a cart selling grilled corn brushed with something sweet and a little burnt, because Kaito insists, because apparently there's a version of him that gets loud and cheerful about corn on a stick when nobody's life is currently on fire, and it's strange and good to watch. Ōhashi buys a paper cone of roasted chestnuts and gives half of it to Mei without being asked, the way he's been doing small unannounced things for her since Shizuhara, and she takes it without comment, which from Mei is the whole thank-you.

"You are going to get grease on that notebook," Riku tells him.

"I have survived worse threats to this notebook than a chestnut," Ōhashi says, and licks his thumb clean before turning the page anyway, just in case.

A ring-toss stall catches Riku's eye two stalls further down – bottles lined up on a warped board, a hand-painted sign promising a paper fan for three rings and a whole candied apple for five – and he plants himself in front of it before anyone can talk him out of it.

"I used to be good at this," he announces, to nobody who asked.

"You used to be good at everything, according to you," Mei says.

He isn't good at it. His first ring skips off the nearest bottle and bounces into the crowd, his second goes wide enough that the stall owner has to duck, and by the third Kaito's laughing hard enough that he has to lean on the counter, which draws a look from the owner that says he'd rather Kaito not lean on anything he hasn't paid for.

"Let the expert try," Kaito says, and pays for three rings of his own before Riku's finished protesting that there's no such thing as an expert at this game. He lands one clean, misses the second wide, and the third catches a bottle dead center and knocks it clean off the board, which gets him nothing but a shrug from the stall owner and a groan from the rest of us, because apparently knocking the bottle over doesn't count if the ring doesn't stay on.

"That's a rigged game," Kaito says, delighted anyway.

"Every game at every festival has been rigged since before either of us was born," Suzumori says, not even looking up from the folding stool she's found herself. "The rigging is the point. You are meant to lose cheerfully and buy a fan on your way out regardless."

Mei steps up next, pays for three rings without any speech about it, and lands two out of three clean around the bottle necks, calm as she counts a junction board, and holds her hand out to the stall owner for the promised fan like the outcome was never in doubt.

"How?" Riku says, betrayed.

"I watch things fall for a living," Mei says, already fanning herself with her prize. "Turns out that's useful for more than counting kids."

She gives the fan to Suzumori without being asked, the same unannounced way Ōhashi gave her the chestnuts, and Suzumori accepts it with a small nod that's as close to delighted as I've seen her get, snapping it open and fanning herself with the exaggerated dignity of a woman who has decided, tonight, to

let herself be spoiled a little.

We find a spot on the grass bank above the reed pond an hour before the fireworks are due, because Suzumori refuses to stand for an hour on principle and everyone else is happy to sit rather than argue with her about it. The water's gone gold and pink with the last of the light, thick with paper lanterns already floating out from the near bank, little unsteady flames bobbing between the reeds like a low constellation that drifts instead of holding still.

Kaito lies back with his hands behind his head and looks, for one unguarded stretch, exactly like a boy who used to argue with a teacher over a seating chart and nothing worse than that.

"I keep waiting for someone to tell us to move," he says.

"Nobody's going to tell us to move," I say. "That's the whole point of tonight."

"I know that's the point. Knowing it and believing it in my legs are two different things." He turns his head toward me without lifting it off the grass. "You look like an actual person in that yukata. It's unsettling."

"You look like you're about to fall asleep in public."

"I might. Mira, wake me up if the sky does anything before I do."

"You'll wake up on your own," Mira says, not looking up from the lantern she's writing something small on with a borrowed brush, the ink still wet at the tip. "You always do the second something's about to matter."

Riku and Mei have gotten into an argument about whether the drummer two streets over is any good, which somehow turns into Riku doing an impression of the man's face mid-solo, which somehow gets Mei laughing hard enough that she has to put the chestnuts down before she drops them. It isn't a big laugh. It's short, and a little surprised at itself, and gone almost as soon as it lands – but I watch Ōhashi watching her do it, and I watch him decide not to say anything about it, which is its own kind of gift.

Suzumori sends her own lantern out onto the water without ceremony, just leans forward on her cane and lets the current take it, watching it join the

little drifting field of light without a word about what she wrote on it, if she wrote anything at all. Mira sends hers after. Kaito doesn't buy one, and nobody makes him explain why, and I don't ask either, because some silences are a kindness and this is one of them.

For a while nobody says anything that needs saying. The drum two streets over settles into something slower. A vendor somewhere is arguing happily with a customer about the price of a candied plum. Somebody's little sister runs past us shrieking about a lost shoe, and her father catches her by the collar without breaking stride, laughing the whole time, and it's such an ordinary thing to see – a kid, a shoe, a laughing father – that my chest does something complicated it hasn't done in weeks.

"This is nice," Mei says, quiet, mostly to the water. "I am glad we decided to do this."

Down by the pond's edge, someone shouts that the fireworks crew is testing the first fuse, and half the crowd on the bank turns to look. For one more breath it's just a warm evening and seven people who finally got to sit still together without anybody hurting.

The first firework cracks open white above the reeds, and everyone on the bank tips their face up at once, waiting on the next one.

Chapter 47 – Above the Water

The second firework is still opening when every phone on the bank screams.

It stacks fast – not the ordinary tower ping people ignore at markets, the hard two-tone nobody can uninstall, the same sound that ate Kōgetsu's birthday night. Every pocket, every bag, lighting up white at once. People laugh for a second, the way a crowd laughs when it thinks the system glitched for a joke. Then they read the text.

ANOMALOUS MATERIEL – ASHIRO REED POND – CIVIL SHELTER IN PLACE – AWAIT FDC DIRECTION

I look up because looking at the phone does not help.

Above the water, past the last firework bloom, something is shaping itself out of the dark the same way it did over the Loop the night Ryn died. White, and wrong, and not in a hurry.

Then it doesn't just open. It tears, and for three heartbeats the pond isn't there at all.

There's a field instead – trampled grass under a sky I don't have a word for, banners down in the mud, something the size of a house lying dead in the dirt with an arrow the length of a mast still standing out of its throat. A man stands over the wreck of it wearing a crown that doesn't catch any light, and he is speaking – not to anyone I can see, one long sentence aimed straight up at the sky, and the sky is listening. Clouds unknot overhead. The dead thing's leg twitches, like the sentence is trying to walk it home.

Someone else is screaming at him to stop. A second man, younger, half his face gone to blood – but he is not speaking a sentence of his own. His hands are out in front of him, two fingers twitching the way you'd correct a line of type, and the king's sentence is still in the air when something in it changes. Same shape. Same length. One word that is not the word the king said. The sky is still listening. It listens to the wrong version.

Then the sky answers, and it answers wrong, and the whole field goes white the way a photograph burns through from the back.

Then it's the pond again, and I'm on my hands and knees in cold mud, chest heaving like I ran here.

Kaito's already moving. Not steady – up wrong, one hand braced on his knee – but up, and he's got a fist in my jacket before I've found my own feet.

"Up," he says. His voice comes out thin. "We have to go. Now."

"What did we just--"

"I don't know. Go."

We push into a crowd already pushing the other way. Festival clothes, kids with candy still stuck to their fingers, a man who drops a paper fan and doesn't stop for it. On the far bank a loudhailer starts up, calm and even, the same soft tone Habu used putting kids into lines. Gray-green shapes are already at the bridge mouths. Not a cordon yet. Close to one.

Riku's got Ōhashi's sleeve. Mei's face has gone the blank kind of careful. Suzumori's stick hits the mud hard, keeping pace she shouldn't be able to keep.

That's when I see him.

Plain dark coat, too warm for the night. He isn't running. He isn't even looking at the sky. He's looking at us. Half a step behind him, a gray-green with major's tabs on his collar is already watching us too – short black hair cut flat to the scalp, face built for orders, the kind of stillness that doesn't wait for permission. Katō stands beside the major in the same uniform, clean, no seed-cap, nothing left of bay three.

Suzumori's hand locks on my wrist before I decide anything for myself. Something crosses her face I have never seen sit there before – not her usual dry look. Real fear. She looks at me, then at Kaito, voice gone thin. "Is that the coat? The one you meant? Is that him?"

"Yes," Kaito says, already half a step in front of me.

"He stood in Habu's glass and watched while that building killed those kids," Mira says. Fast, hard, no room in it for argument.

Suzumori's grip doesn't loosen. "He is not a friend, Haruki! He is--"

"Commander Kuroda! We have a problem – both of them, right here on the bank!"

The major yells it straight across the water. Kuroda doesn't flinch at the title. He just keeps walking toward us, and when he smiles it isn't the host smile from Minato and it isn't patience. It's quieter than that. Worse.

"That's not a problem, that's faith. Aoyama, Kurosawa." He says both names like he's been saving them. "Do you know how long I have waited for this moment?"

Kaito's hand is a fist at his side. "Say what?"

"I know exactly who you are. Both of you – and not just your names. I have known what you can do since before that night on the roof. But you two have no idea what the extent of your true power is."

"You don't," I say, and my own voice doesn't sound steady to me. "You're FDC. You're–"

"I am the reason you're both still breathing." Not loud yet. Certain. "The truck out of Shizuhara. The alley behind Minato. Every quiet door that opened when you needed it – that was me. I built the road under your feet and let you believe you were walking it yourselves."

Kaito's face has gone somewhere I don't have a name for. "You've been using us."

"Yes." Undisguised. Proud of it.

Riku's fist is already in my sleeve. "Haruki. We're leaving. Now."

"Don't stand there and feed him your anger," Mira says, hard, to Kaito more than to me. "He wants an audience. Don't give him one."

Kaito doesn't move. Ash is starting to fall again, fine and gray. Around him it drifts wrong – slower, like the air forgot which way down is.

"I have planned this from the start," Kuroda goes on, and now his voice does climb, enough that gray-greens by the cordon turn their heads. "I rode the Loop with you that night. I turned my phone toward you so you would see the file – both of you, already named – before you ever climbed those stairs. I only needed to be sure I had the right boys. My men were on that building because I put them there. The radio order came from me. I told them both of

you were flagged, that alive was the entire point, and that they were to cover their ears."

"You put them on the roof," Mira says. "You—"

"I was not trying to kill the girl," Kuroda says over her. "She was cheap trash standing in the way. Your friend was too weak to move a hand without breaking the girl attached to it. That is when I understood what you two actually needed. Not careful handling. Despair. So I put you on a road that would keep feeding you just that, until your powers had no choice but to wake up hungry."

"You organized that," Kaito says. His voice has gone thin and wrong.

"I organized all of it," Kuroda says. Kindly, which is worse.

Riku hauls my sleeve hard enough to tear the seam. Mira has Kaito's jacket; he isn't feeling her hand. Around us the crowd is breaking – someone falls in the mud, a kid screams for a parent who doesn't answer, gray-greens at the bridge mouth pushing people back with rifle butts. The bank is getting smaller. Ide already has a hand up for a weapons call.

Kaito takes one step toward Kuroda. That is all Ide needs.

"Weapons up!"

Three gray-greens bring rifles onto a seventeen-year-old's chest. Hands not steady. Festival light on the barrels.

"Good idea Major, Fire!" Kuroda yells. He doesn't look away from Kaito once.

"Commander—" Ide starts.

"I said fire."

The first shot cracks. Then the second. Then the third – three muzzles bright at once, the bank lighting up like a second set of fireworks aimed at one boy.

Kaito's mouth opens before the sound finishes.

"Stop!"

The Word hits the air like a wall going up, and every bullet in flight stops dead. Three rounds hang between the gray-greens and Kaito's chest – spinning in place, smoking, close enough that I could count the rifling marks if the

light were kinder – and the men who fired them are locked mid-recoil, shoulders jammed, fingers still crushed on triggers that no longer mean anything. Lanterns along the bank blow sideways and the reed water goes flat. For a full breath the whole east bank is silent.

Kaito's knees go soft. He locks them. Gray sits at the edges of his eyes for a second and then clears.

"Drop your weapons. Kneel."

They do. Rifles hit wet ground hard enough to splash. The three who fired go down first, then the next pair along the cordon, foreheads in the festival dirt like the Word put them there, and the hanging bullets finally drop.

Someone in the crowd screams. Ide is shouting for a second line and not getting one. Riku has me two steps back; I am fighting him for the third. Kaito does not wait for any of it. He walks through the dropped rifles, through the smoke still hanging where the rounds stopped, straight at Kuroda until there is almost no mud left between them.

Kuroda laughs once – short, pleased.

There is nothing left in Kaito's face that belongs to a festival. Just like at Shizuhara.

"You're a monster," Kaito says. Full. Loud. Aimed at Kuroda's face. "You don't care what happens to anyone. You just think of them as toys."

The gray-greens are still where he put them – guns in the mud, knees in the dirt. Kuroda is the only one left standing close enough to hit. Kaito turns on him the same way he turned on the rifles. Kuroda's mouth moves – small, almost nothing – and what the bank hears out of Kaito's throat is:

"Stand!"

The men who knelt shove themselves upright. A man who had his forehead in the dirt comes up blinking, empty hands open. Kuroda does not kneel. He does not even bend. He stays on his feet in the mud.

Kaito stares at him. At the men standing when they should still be down. At his own mouth. Blood runs from his nose over his upper lip. His face looks scared in a way I have not seen on him before.

"That's not what I said." His voice breaks on it. "I said kneel. I said

kneel.”

Nobody answers him. Nobody else heard anything different. Above the pond the white wound flashes once, bright enough that half the bank flinches.

“Kneel—” he tries again, thinner, and the bank hears stand a second time. Another pair of boots scrapes up. He looks at Kuroda like he cannot make the two versions fit.

Kuroda laughs under his breath, pleased.

“Rewrite,” he says. “I rewrote it.” He taps his own mouth once, not a cast, just a point. “I finish your sentence with mine before it lands. Quiet. No second voice for anyone else to hear. Same shape. Same order. Different landing. You keep saying the word you meant. Everyone else hears the one I rewrite it with.”

Kaito’s hands are shaking. “You—”

“You said I don’t care for people, but that is a lie,” Kuroda says. He tips his chin at the white still hanging over the pond. “I did care. The ones I cared for are gone. Not dead. Erased. Replaced by this faulty world – trains, ration lines, this festival, boys who think love is a plan.”

“Then stop talking and let them leave,” Riku says.

“Before any of this, the world was larger,” Kuroda continues, as if Riku did not speak. “A sky that answered when a king spoke to it. Beasts bigger than most of these buildings. Until a king tried to use his voice to change that world, and I put myself in front of the sentence to save the people I loved, and I rewrote it by accident. Only one word changed. The whole speech went wrong. What you are standing in is the failed reality that mistake made. It should not exist. The real world is still out there. It needs to be reshaped back to what it was.”

His eyes find mine across the mud.

“In the alley behind that bar, Aoyama, I asked you who would reshape the world. You said you didn’t know yet.” He waits half a beat. “So I will ask it this way. Are you going to be the one who decides which world is real?”

My mouth opens. The true answer is still that I do not know, and I cannot make myself give him that out loud. The silence after his question stretches long enough that the crowd noise comes back in – someone crying near the

bridge, a gray-green swearing over a stuck bolt – and Riku hears the gap for what it is.

“What kind of stupid question is that?” he shouts, raw, over all of it. “These are real people. They’re alive. They’re standing right here–”

“I can see them,” Kuroda says. “They are not real the way you two are. I will spend them if I have to.” He turns back to me. “You and Kurosawa are the ones who matter here. Your anger is what makes the power grow.”

Behind him a boy barely older than us has a rifle out of the mud again. Barrel half-raised. Hands shaking. The ones who knelt have not all stayed down.

Kaito does not wait for the next sentence. He turns on that boy the same way he turned on the rifles – one clean order, pointed through the gray-green at Kuroda’s chest.

“Shoot him!”

Kuroda’s mouth moves. Small. Almost nothing.

What the bank hears out of Kaito’s throat is:

“Shoot her!”

The muzzle swings off Kuroda and finds Mira. She is three steps behind Kaito’s shoulder with her hand still out for his sleeve. Riku lunges. He is a half-step late. The round hits her high in the side and knocks her clean off her feet. She goes down in the festival dirt hard, both hands already at the wound, blood coming too fast between her fingers. Mei screams once. Suzumori’s stick hits the mud as she drops beside her.

“Mira–” Kaito’s voice breaks on her name. His face empties, then fills with something worse than the roof. He knows what he aimed at. He knows what left his mouth for the rest of us.

I am already moving. Riku gets there first and presses down where the blood is worst. Mira’s eyes are open. She is trying to say something and only gets air. Her face is the wrong color under the lantern light.

Kaito turns on Kuroda. I look at Mira’s blood on Riku’s hands, then at Kuroda still standing in the mud, pleased until he isn’t. The same hollow from the night Ryn fell hits both of us at once – except this time she is still

breathing wrong in the dirt in front of us.

Kaito's mouth opens.

Mine opens with it.

We do not look at each other. The same word leaves both our throats at the same time, aimed at Kuroda:

"Die!"

Weight leaves me so hard my knees almost go. Beside me Kaito's nose floods red again. The Word hits the air doubled – two mouths, one sentence – and for the first time tonight Kuroda's face changes. The pleased look breaks. Fear gets through. Real fear. His mouth starts moving for a rewrite and finds too much sentence already in the air, too heavy, too late.

The white wound over the pond tears open.

Mei has already torn free of the mud. She is three steps from Kaito, arm out, fingers open, shouting his name like she can haul him sideways out of his own voice. She is still moving when the tear finishes opening.

Heat without a flame. A shove from nowhere flattens the reed water. The east end of the bridge lifts and then is gone. Buildings beyond it go pale, then blank, then gone – a whole slice of Ashiro wiped out in one pass. People scream. The screams cut short under a rain of grit that used to be walls. Kuroda is in the middle of that light when it takes him. Ide too – the major who yelled the rank – gone from the mud where he stood. Kaito is still on his feet when the light reaches him. Mei's hand is still reaching. When the shove hits the bank I go down with everyone else.

When the grit thins enough to see through, the white is gone from the sky. Ordinary dark. Ordinary cold.

What is left of the east bank does not look like a festival anymore. Lantern paper burns in black scraps on the mud. The bridge ends in a chewed stump over empty air. Beyond it, where shops and houses should still be, there is a pale gap – streets that stop mid-block, rooms opened to the night with their furniture already dust. Festival ash and building ash fall together. Sirens start somewhere west, late. Strangers kneel in the dirt with paper stuck to their knees, staring at a skyline that ends where it should not.

Katō is still on the bank, on his hands in the mud. Ōhashi's pencil is still

in his fingers. The notebook is not.

"Kaito?" I call. My voice cracks. "Mei- Kaito!"

No answer. The place where they stood is empty mud. No coats. No bodies. Kuroda is gone too. Ide with him. Four people missing from ground that still holds everyone else's footprints.

Riku turns a full circle, scanning the bank, the chewed bridge, the pale gap where the shops were. "They're not here. I don't see them."

"The girl," Suzumori says. She is already kneeling beside Mira. "Help me with the girl first. Then we look."

I crawl to Mira.

Riku puts both hands on her side. They are red to the wrists. Mira's eyes are half-shut. Her chest rises once and almost does not come back. There is too much blood under her.

"Mira." My hands shake as I pull her into my lap. "Mira, look at me. Please."

"Stay with us," Riku says. He presses harder. "Come on. Stay."

She does not answer. Her face is the wrong color under what is left of the lantern light. I have seen this before. On a roof. On a pier. I start crying and cannot stop it.

I put my forehead to hers. I do not have a careful voice left. I am crying too hard to keep it quiet.

"You're not dead. You can't be dead - wake up, Mira!"

Weight leaves me hard enough that my arms almost fail. I hold her tighter. My vision goes gray at the edges.

For a breath nothing happens.

Then the blood under my hands slows. Her chest finds a rhythm again. Color comes back into her mouth.

Riku jerks like he has been hit. "What-" He almost lifts his hands off her side, stares at the wound, then presses down again harder. "Haruki. What did you just do?"

Suzumori's stick clatters in the mud. "That hole was killing her. I have

seen that kind of bleeding. She should not—”

Mira’s fingers twitch on my sleeve.

Her eyes open.

She sucks in a raw gasp and stares up at me, alive.

Ōhashi makes a sound that is not a word. Katō has stopped staring at Kuroda’s empty place; he is staring at us instead.

“She’s breathing,” Riku says, half to Suzumori, half to himself. “She was dying. I felt it. She was dying.”

I laugh once, broken, and look past her at the empty mud where Kaito was.

“Kaito,” I say again. Quieter. “Mei.”

Still nothing. Riku follows my eyes, then looks back down at Mira’s side as if he can hold both problems at once and knows he cannot.

“We get her up,” he says. His voice is still shaky. “Then we search the bank. Every meter. I’m not leaving them as a blank spot on the ground.”

Suzumori nods once, eyes still on Mira’s side. “Agreed. Alive first. Missing second. And later, boy – you explain that.”

Mira’s hand tightens on my sleeve.

“Kaito,” she whispers. “Where is he?”

And yet again, I don’t have an answer.

End of Book One

The King's Word – 王の言霊